

February 2025

Results from Qualitative Testing of the Annual Social and Economic Supplement of the Current Population Survey: Round 1 Cognitive Interviews to Prepare for Web-based Administration

Prepared for:

U.S. Census Bureau
Center for Behavioral Science Methods
Suitland, MD

Prepared by:

RTI International
3040 E. Cornwallis Road
Research Triangle Park, NC 27709

Research Support Services
906 Ridge Avenue,
Evanston, IL 60202



Call Order 011: Cognitive Interviews for ASEC Health Insurance, Medical Out of Pocket Expenses, Moving, Earned Income, Income Sources, and Poverty

Round 1 Briefing Report

February 2025

The U.S. Census Bureau has reviewed this data product to ensure appropriate access, use, and disclosure avoidance protection of the confidential source data used to produce this product (Disclosure Review Board (DRB) approval number: CBDRB-FY25-SEHSD003-055).

Contents

Section	Page
1. Executive Summary	1-1
2. Introduction	2-1
3. Cognitive Methodology	3-1
3.1 Methodology	3-1
3.2 Protocol	3-1
3.3 Interviews.....	3-2
3.4 Analysis	3-3
4. Participant Recruitment	4-1
4.1 Implementation of Recruitment Advertising	4-2
4.1.1 Participant Selection Strategy	4-2
4.1.2 ASEC cognitive interview recruitment outcomes	4-3
4.2 Health Insurance Participants	4-3
4.3 Income Participants.....	4-5
5. Question by Question Results – Health Insurance	5-1
5.1 Health Insurance Questions.....	5-1
5.2 Maximum Out of Pocket (MOOP) Questions	5-41
5.3 Migration Questions.....	5-55
6. Question by Question Results – Income	6-1
6.1 Employment Questions	6-1
6.2 Income Questions	6-30
6.2.1 Earned Income	6-30
6.2.2 Income Sources	6-40
6.2.3 Income Amounts.....	6-93
6.3 Poverty Questions	6-116
6.3.1 Housing	6-116
6.3.2 Food Assistance	6-120
6.3.3 School Meals	6-127
6.3.4 Non-Cash Benefits.....	6-133

6.3.5	Child Care	6-139
6.3.6	Child Support.....	6-151
7.	Overall Recommendations	7-1
7.1	Income	7-1
7.1.1	Introduction with instructions	7-1
7.1.2	Allowing estimates	7-1
7.1.3	Section introductions / Transition statements	7-2
7.1.4	Additional definitions	7-2
7.1.5	Reordering of questions	7-2
7.1.6	Overall summary screen	7-3
7.1.7	Validations / Confirmations.....	7-4
7.1.8	Respondent burden and reducing breakoffs	7-4
7.1.9	Recommendation for format of grids.....	7-6
7.1.10	Programming of instrument for the second round of cognitive interviews	7-6
7.1.11	Information sharing from government	7-6
7.2	Health Insurance.....	7-7
7.2.1	Health insurance	7-7
7.2.2	Medical out of pocket expenses.....	7-7
7.2.3	Migration.....	7-7
8.	Conclusions	8-1
Appendices		
A.	Recruitment Screener	A-1
B.	Participant Recruitment Materials	B-1
C.	Cognitive Interview Participant Consent Form	C-1
D.	Health Insurance, Out of Pocket Expenses, and Migration Cognitive Protocol	D-1
E.	Income with Employment and Poverty: Cognitive Protocol	E-1
F.	Programming Issues from Income and Health Insurance	F-1
G.	Recommended Question Order	G-1

Exhibits

Number	Page
4-1. Primary Participant Characteristics for Health Insurance Interviews	4-3
4-2. Secondary Characteristics for Health Insurance Interviews	4-4
4-3. Primary Participant Characteristics for Income Interviews	4-5
4-4. Secondary Participant Characteristics for Income Interviews.....	4-6
6-1. Number of Don't Knows by Question for Self and Proxy Reports	6-95
6-2. Number of Estimated Answers by Question.....	6-97
6-3. Need for Records by Question.....	6-98
7-1. Abbreviated Question Order Changes Listed by Topic.....	7-3

[This page intentionally left blank]

1. Executive Summary

This report details the results of 60 cognitive interviews which were conducted during the first round of cognitive testing for the Annual Social and Economic Supplement (ASEC). The cognitive interviews tested the ASEC instrument which includes questions about health insurance coverage, medical out of pocket expenses, moving, earned income, income sources and amounts, poverty, and child care. The instrument and tests were divided into two sections, broadly categorized as the “health insurance” and “income” sections. Health insurance includes the medical out of pocket expenses and moving questions. Income includes the remaining sections.

Interviews were conducted by RTI International (RTI) and Research Support Services (RSS). Findings and recommendations from the cognitive interviews will be used to revise the questions for the second round of cognitive testing to take place in the Spring of 2025.

Cognitive testing consists of one-on-one in-person interviews to assess a questionnaire in terms of general comprehension, clarity of question and response wording, effectiveness of skip logic, and visual aids. Census Bureau provided two separate and distinct cognitive protocols: one for health insurance and one for income. Both protocols included the full set of questions tested in each interview, concurrent probes on most questions, designation of the motivation for testing the question, and the desired output to be reported for each. Interviews were designed to take no more than 90-minutes.

The Census Bureau programmed each questionnaire in Qualtrics to facilitate virtual interviewing. All interviews were conducted remotely and were recorded by interviewers. Following each interview, participants were provided with a \$40 Visa digital gift card as a token of appreciation for completing the interview.

Participants were recruited and selected based on pre-established targets/quotas. All efforts were made to reach these targets while providing an even distribution among demographic characteristics such as sex, age, education, race/ethnicity, and household composition, among other criteria.

The RTI and RSS team used a systematic approach to analyze the cognitive interview data and address the research questions. Each team coded data with a combined approach of coding in the raw data, as well as developing iterative codes for questions with significant feedback. Once the data were organized and coded, the teams wrote up their findings in a standardized format, including question-level responses from participants, key findings, a summary, and recommendations for questions that performed poorly. These provided the basis of this report.

There were several overall recommendations that came from the research which included the following:

Health Insurance Module

- Questions in the **Health insurance section** need to be reviewed for how best to address the issue of respondents who are covered by insurance of a non-household member, in particular young adults not living at home and covered until age 26 under their parents' insurance. Participants with unrelated household members also found it difficult and sometimes impossible to proxy report for their roommates.
- **Medical out of pocket expenses** that ask for a dollar amount of expenses includes a field to enter the amount, but also allowed for text entries. Those who entered text entries were treated as having answered the question with a value, and therefore skipped out of the follow up questions offering ranges for non-respondents. It is recommended to either not allow text responses or route respondents in a similar fashion as nonresponders.
- **Migration questions** asking the 1-year and the 10-year time frame use the structure "x year(s) ago, that is, September 1, 2014/2024." The date was provided as a fixed date, not as it related to the interview date. In addition, all but one participant focused on the month and year or the number of years, or both, but not on the specific date. For these reasons it is recommended to restructure the time frames as "1/10 year(s) ago, that is, <CURRENT MONTH>, <1/10 YEARS AGO>."

Income Module

- **Include instructions within the Introduction.** The prenotification letter should describe the survey and the data we are collecting so participants can be prepared. In addition, the introduction of the survey would be a prime location to explain that some financial records would be helpful to have during completion of the survey.
- **Allowing estimates.** If SMEs believe that an estimate is acceptable, that instruction could be included in the introduction as well. Alternatively, the instruction could be included as a soft check prompt if respondents try to go to the next question without responding. We may also consider including this instruction on certain questions that are more likely to need to be estimated, such as income from interest-earning accounts.
- **Section introductions / Transition statements.** As respondents progress through various income and finance topics, it can be somewhat confusing or disorienting as to the content being covered. It is highly recommended to include a short instruction or transition statement at the beginning of new sections. These transitions could be included on the same screen as the question text.
- **Additional definitions.** Several questions may benefit from the addition of definitions of key terms to ensure respondents are consistently presented the same information. Adding definitions may also be helpful for proxy reports, in which respondents may not know the term themselves, but seeing a definition could help them remember and report for someone else in their household.
- **Overall summary screen.** During cognitive testing, it was evident that some participants responded to several questions while thinking of the same source of income or account. In essence, this led to "double-counting." One consideration to help aid respondents would be to include an overall summary screen which would allow participants to review each of the accounts that they noted to ensure they did not double-count items. Moreover, this screen might help respondents to determine that an income source was not listed.

- **Validations / Confirmations.** Another approach to increase data quality and reliability would be to include various validations and confirmations. This can be done through the inclusion of programming logic around key questions that may contribute to respondents providing duplicate information. We would not recommend consistency logic to be included on all questions, but the survey would benefit from inclusion on some items, where respondents are likely to get confused or double report. A standard message could appear on specific questions confirming with respondents that this information was not already reported on a previous question.
- **Respondent burden and reducing breakoffs.** It was clear during cognitive testing that respondent burden associated with answering many of the questions is quite high. Knowledge is not available or would require review of financial documents. While some participants will take the time to report accurately, others will either provide an estimate, leave the question blank, or breakoff entirely. To mitigate these concerns, we suggest the following:
 - Consider removing questions that pose the highest respondent burden and lowest data quality (See Section 6.2.2 for further details).
 - Consider allowing a “Don’t know” response option for a few key questions, where “don’t know” could improve respondent experience and provide more complete data (See Section 6.2 for further details).
 - Consider allowing response ranges.
 - Consider providing additional context to tie previous questions together.
 - Consider additional features to improve reporting such as including labels outside of the response boxes and adding a “\$” when looking for a monetary value.
 - Ensuring consistency throughout the questionnaire by placing the reference year at the beginning of the question.

Finally, there were many challenges in conducting cognitive testing during the first round of testing as the questionnaire is quite long at 90 minutes. One issue that contributed to challenges in collecting data was due to programming errors. We were unable to assess the performance of several questions due to incorrect or broken skip logic and problems with fills. We assume that these will be corrected during the second round of interviews to fully assess the questions.

[This page intentionally left blank]

2. Introduction

The Current Population Survey (CPS) is an important source of data on U.S. employment and unemployment. Collected within the CPS is the Annual Social and Economic Supplement (ASEC). The ASEC collects data on income sources, health insurance, and participation in various economic support programs. ASEC data also supports the creation of the Supplemental Poverty Measure and are thus critically important to a broad array of data users.

To support development of new questions on health insurance and income/public assistance topics for the ASEC supplement, RTI International and Research Support Services (RSS), conducted 60 one-on-one cognitive interviews in each of two rounds of cognitive testing. Interviews were split (i.e., 30 each) across two topic ASEC topic areas—health insurance and income. The purpose of the first round of cognitive interviews was to learn more about how participants interpret and respond to the questions and response options, identify possible issues that may hinder a respondent’s ability to respond, and to gather feedback that can be used to revise the questions.

This report details the cognitive methodology, including the description of the target population and participant eligibility criteria and interviewing procedures, participant recruitment and screening, question findings and recommendations, and overall recommendations for the Health Insurance and Income modules. Findings and recommendations from the cognitive interviews will be used to revise the questions for the second round of cognitive testing to take place in the Spring of 2025.

[This page intentionally left blank]

3. Cognitive Methodology

This section provides an overview of the interviewing methodology used during ASEC health insurance and income cognitive interview data collection. Specifically, this section provides details about cognitive methodology, as well as the protocols and procedures that were used during interviews.

3.1 Methodology

The cognitive testing consisted of (virtual) one-on-one in-person interviews to assess the questionnaire in terms of general comprehension, clarity of question and response wording, effectiveness of skip logic, and visual aids. The goal was to gain an understanding of how well the questions work when administered to a sample of the survey's target population. The interviews followed a protocol with pre-scripted probes, administered after most questions. Cognitive interviewers also used spontaneous probes to gain a better understanding of questions. Cognitive interviewing was used to:

- Learn about the respondents' thought processes while answering the questions;
- Measure the response process, including comprehension, retrieval, judgement, and response;
- Observe non-verbal, human reactions;
- Test navigation of the instrument;
- Assess the potential for measurement error in survey items;
- Examine potentially big or complex issues; and
- Gauge opinions on the survey as a whole.

3.2 Protocol

Census Bureau developed two separate and distinct protocols that focused on each of the two topic areas being explored in this study: one for health insurance (**Appendix D**) and one for income (**Appendix E**). RTI/RSS provided input and reviewed each protocol. Both protocols included the full set of questions included in each interview, along with concurrent probes on a subset of questions. Due to the large number of questions included in each interview, scripted probes were only utilized on a subset of questions to maintain the required 90-minute timing for the interview. Interviewers were instructed and trained to collect spontaneous feedback on other questions as needed.

Census Bureau programmed the protocols in Qualtrics to facilitate virtual interviewing. However, there were some identified issues with the programming when interviews started (see **Appendix F** for the list of programming issues, both those known before interviewing started and those discovered during interviewing). During the interview, the desired protocol was to provide a web survey link to participants to review the ASEC topic-specific questions (i.e., health insurance or income). Participants were then asked to respond to

questions while sharing their screen. In most cases this was the approach, however, as a back-up, the interviewer could display the web instrument containing ASEC questions on screen and ask participants to respond while entering responses for them.

3.3 Interviews

All interviews were conducted remotely using Microsoft Teams within Census Bureau's secure Virtual Desktop Interface (VDI) environment or using a Census Bureau issued laptop. With permission from participants, interviewers recorded all sessions using handheld audio recording device. Interviews were also recorded using SnagIt software, which records both audio and video. Recordings were saved to the designated deliverable folder in the Census Bureau file share location. At the end of the interview, interviewers offered participants a \$40 Visa digital gift card code via email as a thank you for their time. Following each interview, interviewers or note takers completed the appropriate case summary template for the topic area (i.e., health insurance or income).

Although the two protocols and respondent-facing instruments differed, each interview was conducted in the following sequence to standardize implementation:

- Interviewers explained the purpose of the study.
- Confirmed participant had reviewed and signed the online consent form to participate in the study and be audio/video recorded (**Appendix C**).
- Started audio recording using an external audio recorder and SnagIt software.
- Re-confirmed verbal consent to participate and be recorded once recording has started.
- Shared the respondent-facing instrument and asked participants to answer ASEC questions shown on screen.
- Administered probes to ASEC questions.
- Concluded the interview and sent the participant the incentive.
- Saved the recording within the Census Bureau's secure network environment in the designated file share folder.
- Completed the interview summary and saved it in the designated file share folder no more than 5 business days following each interview.

Before conducting cognitive interviews, all RTI/RSS interviewers were trained by Census Bureau on protocols for each topic area (i.e., health insurance; income) and other key procedures, including Title 13 requirements. Because each topic area used different protocols, two interviewer training sessions were held: one that focused on the health insurance protocol and one that focused on the income protocol. Due to the length and complexity of the interviews, all interviewers also completed a recorded practice interview before beginning interviews with participants. This practice interview was reviewed by RTI's lead researcher, and feedback was provided to interviewers directly to prepare them for the main interviews.

3.4 Analysis

The RTI and RSS team used a systematic process to analyze the cognitive interview data and address the research questions. The case summaries were recorded in Excel to provide a thorough data set for analysis, with participants presented in each row and interview probes presented in each column. Both teams coded data with a combined approach of coding in the raw data, as well as developing iterative codes for questions with significant feedback. Once the data were organized and coded, the teams wrote up their findings in a standardized format, including responses from participants, key findings, a summary, and provided recommendations for questions that performed poorly. For the Income section, RTI also developed substantial overall recommendations based on trends across questions, as well as suggestions for question order.

[This page intentionally left blank]

4. Participant Recruitment

This section provides an overview of participant recruitment used to screen and select participants for the ASEC health insurance and income cognitive interviews. Specifically, this section includes an overview of recruitment strategies and targets and presents participant characteristics for each topic area. The RTI/RSS team recruited participants for the first round of ASEC cognitive interviews from September through November 2024. The concurrent recruitment for these two testing tasks began by leveraging the participant recruitment for the CPS usability testing conducted from June through August 2024. First, the RTI/RSS team identified 115 prospective participants who were selected based on their eligibility for the CPS usability testing but were left uncontacted for solicitation. The team planned an email outreach campaign, inviting them to complete the ASEC online screener to determine their eligibility for ASEC cognitive interviews based on their demographics and current employment status.

Following the outreach campaign with the previously screened individuals, the RTI/RSS team identified multiple metropolitan areas across all four Census regions (i.e., Northeast, Midwest, South, West) that have relatively large and diverse populations for a potential larger proportion of residents who met the recruitment criteria of both subprojects. The RTI/RSS team then posted online recruitment advertisements in the selected metropolitan areas, releasing advertisements on a rolling basis to maintain a steady stream of prospective recruits for screening and scheduling. RTI/RSS team also conducted word-of-mouth outreach with the staff's personal networks specifically screening for individuals with the rarer primary characteristics that seemed to fall behind after approximately 8 weeks of data collection. The additional effort helped improved our recruitment outcome with those who live with unrelated individuals and those who received income from unemployment benefits or worker comp.

The Census Bureau programmed a web-based eligibility screening in Qualtrics. The RTI/RSS team also provided a toll-free telephone line dedicated to recruitment purposes. The web link of the screening instrument and the toll-free phone number were presented in the online advertisements (see **Appendix A**).

During the data collection period, the RTI/RSS team provided the Census Bureau with a weekly recruitment and interviewing progress update report, reflecting results to date. The weekly report sought to present the diversity of interview participants with respect to recruitment goals and needed sub-characteristics. The results of ASEC cognitive interview recruitment presented in **Sections 4.3** and **4.4** of this report reflect the final recruitment outcomes.

4.1 Implementation of Recruitment Advertising

The RTI/RSS team began the participant recruitment by launching the email outreach campaign to contact those previously recruited through Craigslist posts and screened but not contacted in September 2024.

For the main online recruitment strategy, the RTI/RSS team used Craigslist as the primary venue for recruitment advertising. Craigslist is one of the best-known online bulletin boards and provides the most comprehensive coverage of metropolitan areas in the United States. To leverage Craigslist's broad reach, RTI/RSS did not use targeted advertisements that focused on specific characteristics and used a customized general advertisement instead (see **Appendix B** for recruitment materials and advertisement text).

The RTI/RSS team posted the general recruitment advertisement on Craigslist under the "jobs/et cetera" sections for ten metropolitan areas across all four Census regions (further details below) over the entire duration of data collection. At the same time, the RTI/RSS staff reached out their personal networks to solicit participation from those who may fit our recruitment criteria, and also asked their personal contacts to refer the participant recruitment screener word-of-mouth to others who might be eligible in their broader social circles.

The first round of monthly paid advertising started September 2023, and expired November 2024. RTI/RSS team recorded screening responses for more than 650 prospective participants from the first round of advertising.

4.1.1 Participant Selection Strategy

To facilitate efficient screening review and participant selection across subprojects, the RTI/RSS team created two spreadsheets. First, the team created a main intake sheet to import the screening responses from Qualtrics. The main intake sheet was used to determine eligibility for the first round of the ASEC cognitive testing. Interested participants were reviewed to ensure they met the main eligibility criteria (e.g., Age 18+ and met one or more of the recruitment criteria outlined in the exhibits).

Within the main intake spreadsheet, the RTI/RSS team employed a two-step review strategy to determine subproject assignment and participant selection priority. The spreadsheet first calculated and presented the number of eligible respondent characteristics. Participant screening responses were reviewed to determine whether they fit within one or more of the quotas which were established. Next, we reviewed all prospective participants on the intake sheet, focusing on contact information self-reports and the IP addresses in the paradata for de-duplicated entries from the same individuals and excluding ineligible entries from foreign IP addresses. After reviewing and cleaning the tentative assignments, the records of eligible recruits were exported to each of the two subproject-specific recruitment tracking sheets (i.e., ASEC Income or ASEC Health Insurance). The lead recruiter reviewed the participants to ensure fulfillment of key quotas and selected participants for the RTI/RSS recruiter to contact.

During data collection, RTI/RSS team processed and reviewed the screening data at least once a week to select eligible participants for an interview. After a batch of screening data were reviewed and released to recruiters, about 1 week would elapse before new assignments would be made to allow recruiters sufficient time to contact their existing assignments. Once recruiters contacted participants, they scheduled an interview for each of the interviewers, sending a confirmation email with all the information needed to take part in the interview. At that point, the interviewer took over the case, sending reminders and communicating with the participant, as needed.

4.1.2 ASEC cognitive interview recruitment outcomes

The RSS team completed 30 cognitive interviews for the health insurance module while the RTI team completed 30 interviews for the income module. Across both efforts, RTI/RSS selected and contacted an additional 88 eligible participants; 58 participants did not respond to our invitation, 6 participants refused during recruitment and 14 of them did not show up for their scheduled interview. Another 10 decided to withdraw their participation after they were scheduled for an interview.

4.2 Health Insurance Participants

Exhibit 4-1 details the distribution of the completed interviews with the primary recruitment criteria for the topic of health insurance for the ASEC cognitive interviews. It includes required targets such as participants under the age of 65, participants who are not the policyholder for their insurance, those who do not have access to regular care, those who have had at least one life event in the past year (marriage, divorce, children, new job), those who have performed nonstandard or seasonal work, and those who enrolled in Medicaid or other plans for people with low incomes. **Exhibit 4-2** presents the soft targets of other demographic characteristics such as sex, age, education, race/ethnicity, household composition, and geography of the health insurance cognitive interview participants.

Exhibit 4-1. Primary Participant Characteristics for Health Insurance Interviews

Primary Criteria		
Characteristic	Completed	Goal
Under 65	30	30
Policy holder: No	8	At least 5
Access to care: No	7	At least 5
Life event: At least one	20	At least 5
Spell of unemployment	13	At least 5
Nonstandard work	15	At least 5
Medicaid	10	At least 5

Household Composition		
Characteristic	Completed	Goal
Lives with at least one other person (Primary criteria)	26	At least 21
Lives with unrelated individuals	6	At least 6
Lives with immediate family	15	At least 9
Lives with extended family	10	At least 5
Lives with children	10	At least 5

Exhibit 4-2. Secondary Characteristics for Health Insurance Interviews

Characteristic	Completed	Goal
<i>Sex</i>	-	-
Male	12	At least 10
<i>Race/Ethnicity</i>	-	-
Non-white non-Hispanic	8	At least 5
Hispanic	8	At least 5
<i>Geography</i>		
Northeast	5	At least 5
Midwest	12	At least 5
West	6	At least 5
South	7	At least 5
<i>Education</i>	-	-
Less than college degree	14	At least 10
College graduate	11	At least 5
Post-graduate	5	At least 4
<i>Age</i>	-	-
18–35	13	At least 5
36–50	10	At least 5
51–64	7	At least 5
<i>Unlikely to respond online/screened in by phone</i>	2	At least 2

4.3 Income Participants

Exhibit 4-3 details the distribution of the completed ASEC cognitive interviews with the primary recruitment criteria for the topic of income. It includes the required recruitment targets of participants who received income from retirement or pensions, those who received income from unemployment benefits or workers compensation, those who received income from interests and dividends, those who are self-employed, participants with a second job or side hustle and those that participate in a social assistance program.

Exhibit 4-4 further presents the soft targets of other demographic characteristics such as sex, age, education, race/ethnicity, household composition, and geography of the participants of the income cognitive interviews.

Exhibit 4-3. Primary Participant Characteristics for Income Interviews

Primary Criteria		
Characteristic	Completed	Goal
Retirement/pensions	10	At least 10
Unemployment/workers comp	4	At least 4
Interest and dividends	14	At least 5
Self-employment	7	At least 5
Second job/side hustle	9	At least 3
Program participation	6	At least 5
Household Composition		
Characteristic	Completed	Goal
Lives with at least one other person (Primary criteria)	22	At least 21
Lives with unrelated individuals	5	At least 6
Lives with immediate family	16	At least 14
Lives with children 13 or younger (Primary criteria)	8	At least 7

Exhibit 4-4. Secondary Participant Characteristics for Income Interviews

Characteristic	Completed	Goal
<i>Sex</i>	-	-
Male	13	At least 12
<i>Race/Ethnicity</i>	-	-
Non-white non-Hispanic	10	At least 5
Hispanic	2	At least 5
<i>Geography</i>	-	-
Northeast	6	At least 5
Midwest	9	At least 5
West	9	At least 5
South	6	At least 5
<i>Education</i>	-	-
Less than college degree	11	At least 10
College graduate	12	At least 5
Post-graduate	7	At least 5
<i>Age</i>	-	-
18–35	7	At least 5
36–50	9	At least 5
51–64	5	At least 5
65+	9	At least 12
<i>Unlikely to respond online/screened in by phone</i>	9	At least 6

5. Question by Question Results – Health Insurance

This section presents results and recommendations, where appropriate, for ASEC Health Insurance questions. Findings in this section are presented by topic, with findings from the cognitive interviews listed first followed by recommendations. Each question is formatted with the following elements:

- **Research question** provided by Census Bureau with the goals of testing each question, as well as background about changes made to the question.
- **Question text and response options** that were shown to the participants during cognitive interviewing.
- **n**, representing the total number of participants who were exposed to the question, and thus could provide feedback.
- **Responses** provided by participants during the interview.
- **Findings** detailing the answers to key research questions provided by Census Bureau.
- **Summary** with an overall summary of the findings, especially for questions that included significant findings.
- **Recommendations** for question changes, when appropriate.

The goal of cognitive interviewing is to collect qualitative feedback from participants about their response process when providing an answer to each question. We have included a report of the responses to each question (i.e., the quantitative data) to provide context for the findings. This response data comes from a combination of the Qualtrics data entered by either the participant or the interviewer, and the response recorded in the notes during the interview. Participants are not required to provide an answer, and thus the total sample who saw the question (“n”) may differ from the total number of responses.

5.1 Health Insurance Questions

Question 1

Research Question: We ask this question before getting into insurance type because it identifies the uninsured early in the instrument.
Q1. Did you have health insurance at any point between January and December 2023? ▪ Yes ▪ No
n = 30

Findings:

What does “health insurance” mean to respondents?

- Some participants (n=9) defined health insurance as their financial means to healthcare because it provides them access to doctor appointments, prescription medications, and hospital trips.

- "Yeah so, to me that means that I had the ability to go see the doctor or dentist or optometrist and have the majority of my cost covered with just like a copay that I had to pay. That gave me the ability to seek out medical help as needed." [P2367]
- Five participants [P2256, P2446, P2633, P2743, P2975] explicitly mentioned health insurance being a financial safeguard.
 - "It [health insurance] means that I am paying someone so when I get sick I don't have exorbitant medical bills" [P2256]
 - "To me insurance is the assurance that I will have some kind of medical care and that I don't have to worry about how I will have to pay for that." [P2446]
- Some (n=11) defined health insurance as a third-party coverage system in which the government, employer, or person paid for a service which helped finance healthcare needs.
 - "Any insurance that I might have for medical expenses provided either by the employer or other institution." [P2273]
 - "Either Medicare, Medicaid, or private health insurance, or some sort of employer." When the interviewer asked for clarification, the participant said, "Maybe I don't know the jargon. Where someone pays a monthly premium to cover, I guess, maintenance healthcare and." (*sic*) [P2507]

Are respondents thinking about public coverage?

- Many participants (n=18) said that they considered Medicare and Medicaid when answering the question, although very few expanded on their consideration.
- Some participants (n=8) noted that they did not consider government programs like Medicare and Medicaid when answering the question.
 - "No I was just thinking because I still work and it didn't [specify] what type of insurance. It just said did I have health insurance between that time." [P2263]
 - "Well since it was just asking me, I didn't really have to think about types, I just know that I have health insurance." [P2265]
 - "Between January and December 2023, I had healthcare through my employer so that's what I thought of." [P2707]

Are the instructions necessary?

- Some participants' responses (n=10) reflected that they considered the timeframe.
 - One participant noted that they had different types of health insurance coverage during the timeframe, ""Yeah it was last year, which I, I had insurance last year... I had a job up until, until the first quarter and I had insurance until the end of March and then I had transition insurance in April, so I was almost covered almost entirely last year." [P2975]
- Two participants [P2633, P2782] said they did not consider the timeframe in their response, and another two [P2260, P2684] said the timeframe instruction was irrelevant because they had health insurance their entire life.

Participants seemed confident in their answers and did not struggle to understand the question. Participants generally defined health insurance as a means to healthcare access

and third-party payment. Many participants thought about public coverage options, although not all considered them. The reference period was acknowledged by some participants, but others did not find it relevant because they had health insurance for extended periods. The question accurately captured insured and uninsured participants early in the instrument.

Recommendations:

No recommendations. The question was easily understood by participants.

Question 2

Research Question: HIGH PRIORITY. This is a new question that is a lot less wordy than the standard ACS laundry list. For the ISR mode, we would like this to be “expandable” for respondents who want additional information before answering.

Q2. Between January and December 2023, were you covered by any of the following types of health insurance? Do not include plans that cover only dental, drug, or vision.

- Private health insurance
- Medicare
- Medicaid or other government program
- Veterans health care (enrolled for VA)
- TRICARE or other military health care
- Indian Health Service
- Something else
- Not sure

The second and third options will be EXPANDABLE to:

2. Medicare

- Medicare Part A (hospital care)
- Medicare Part B (outpatient care)
- Medicare Advantage

3. Medicaid or other government program

- Medicaid
- [^CAIDNAME]
- Children’s Health Insurance Program
- Other government health program for people with low income or disability

n = 27

Findings:

Do the headers “Private health insurance” and “Medicaid or other government program” make sense?

- Many participants (n=14) defined private health insurance as employer-provided coverage.
 - “I think of employee, through your job, through your employer or your spouse’s health insurance through a job.” [P2647]
 - “Private health insurance is like health insurance that you get through like a job. So it’s like it’s a private company.” [P2428]

- Some (n=8) also mentioned that private health insurance could be something a person pays for separate from their employer and the government.
 - "To me it's either something offered by an employer or just basically you choosing your own health insurance at your own cost at your own, you know expense or whatever. So, that to me that's what I think private health insurances." [P2941]
 - "I take that to mean that its insurance coverage that I am paying for myself. So I am paying the full premiums so there is no subsidization by an employer or by the government." [P2344]
- All participants reported that they understood the "Medicaid or other government program" header, although some provided alternative descriptions for those who qualified for the programs.
 - P2268 stated that Medicaid and other government assistance would come from having served a military term, being a pensioned worker, or being underaged.
 - P2640 and P2941 both mentioned that these programs are for low-income individuals.

Do the submenus for Medicare and Medicaid work (should they include more information)?

- Despite participants not being able to select specific Medicaid programs from the submenu, those who saw it thought the options were clear and made sense.
- Some participants might have benefitted from seeing the submenus immediately rather than upon selection of the Medicare and Medicaid response option.

Do we need any other wording?

- Four participants [P2263, P2254, P2263, P2707] questioned whether their employer-sponsored health insurance should be categorized as Private or Something Else.
 - "For me when I think about private insurance, I think about marketplace insurance where you can select what you want. I know sometimes when it comes to employer insurance it will usually say employer-sponsored insurance so that's why I was confused [as to what to select] but I just clicked private health insurance." ... "So I clicked on that [Private] because I feel like maybe employer-sponsored insurance might be included since it's something that is through the employer. I thought about putting "Something else" but I felt like that might be something that is outside of all of these choices...I felt like private health insurance was the best one." [P2254]
 - Before selecting a response, one participant asked, "So, when it says 'private health insurance' does it mean that I get it on my own or is, would private be also what I got through my employer? That's what I'm wondering, would it be 'something else'?" They later explained, "I wasn't sure if through my work was considered private since I did not get it on my own, I got it through my employer, so I didn't know if that was private or not." [P2707]
 - P2904 said they would have liked to have an option, "Maybe like 'through an employer,' so, I'm just saying, like those are one of those common answers and are not even listed here."
- The four participants [P2263, P2254, P2263, P2707] who responded, "Not sure," to this question all selected "A job" when asked how they got the insurance they

have (See Question 4). These four participants could have ostensibly selected “Private health insurance” instead.

Do people read and understand the instructions (about drug, vision, etc.)?

- Most participants (n=19) noted that they read the instructions, although many did not comment on the impact they had on their answer.
- Three participants [P2538, P2647, P2260] did not read the instructions, one of whom [P2647] noted that it was helpful to consider after the interviewer pointed them out.
- Three participants [P2279, P2507, P2589] noted that they were uncertain about whether dental, vision, and drug were included in their health insurance plans.
- One participant [P2707] stated that the instructions did not impact their response at all.

Participants generally understood this question and were able to easily answer it. Most recognized “private health insurance” as employer-provided insurance, however some participants questioned whether their employee insurance would be considered private or under “something else.” The submenus for Medicaid and Medicare options were generally well received, although they were not interactive, which led to some confusion. Some observations suggest that the submenus for Medicaid and Medicare would have been more effective in confirming a participant’s decision had they been shown immediately rather than appearing upon selection.

Recommendations:

Consider testing additional information for the “Private Health Insurance” response option. For example:

- | |
|---|
| <ol style="list-style-type: none">1. Private Health Insurance<ul style="list-style-type: none">▪ A plan provided through an employer or union▪ A plan purchased by an individual from an insurance company |
|---|

This may help clarify participants’ understanding of what “private health insurance” means and whether it applies to them.

We suggest testing a version in which the submenus for Medicare and Medicaid are shown in full rather than expanding upon response selection. This may help participants make a clear decision and avoid hiding key information.

Question 2a

Research Question: HIGH PRIORITY. This is a new question restricted to the “Private health insurance” responses for Q2.

Q2a. How did you get your private health insurance? Mark all that apply.

- Current job (yours or another family member)
- Former job (yours or another family member)
- Union or professional association
- Directly from an insurance company
- Broker
- State or Federal Marketplace
- Healthcare.gov
- [^State-Specific Portal Name]

n = 14

Findings:

Does the response “Directly from an insurance company” make sense?

- Most participants (n=10) found that the response option made sense and defined the option as a transaction between an individual and an insurance company rather than a third-party (e.g., an employer) facilitating the transaction.
 - “Yeah, there’s, I know that there’s insurance companies that you wouldn’t have to go through an employer, you can go directly to them. So, pick through the plans that are available and then make those selections based on what’s best for your situation as far as, you know, the cost of those benefits and whether it’s assured cost that sometimes weighs heavily, heavier on the insurance company or heavier on the individual.” [P2905]
 - “Well that I would initiate coverage myself. I would contact [an] insurance company and say, I want to purchase a health insurance plan for myself or my family. I would initiate that.” [P2640]
- One participant [P2254] was unsure about what “directly from an insurance company” meant.
 - “I feel like it’s a little bit confusing...I am assuming it’s [referring to] marketplace insurance and there’s already an answer listed for that, so I don’t know what [directly from an insurance company] means exactly.” [P2254]
- Another participant [P2718] mentioned that the response option was clear to them, although they did not have previous knowledge of such a thing.
 - “I didn’t know you could buy insurance directly from an insurance company.” This participant clarified that the response option made sense to them, though. [P2718]

Does the overlap in “State or Federal Marketplace,” “Healthcare.gov,” and/or the state-specific portal name confuse people?

- Some participants (n=7) noted that the terms were essentially referring to the same type of government coverage, although many of them were unclear about the terms themselves.
 - “Yeah, I guess I don’t really know enough about it, so it might be a little confusing because they all do seem like they are related to getting insurance from the state government. So, I’m not sure.” [P2265]
 - “I would group them together, it’s all through federal health care. I have never received that kind of healthcare, so I don’t really know.” [P2279]
 - “I think they’re, in essence, the same thing. Healthcare.gov and this, whether it’s tied to the state or on the federal level, it seems like the same programs available.” P continued, “I thought it was redundant but there might be more options on the state level that varies from states to state.” [P2905]
 - “I’m a little confused because some of them seem so similar... It’s almost acting like it’s three different things and it’s making me overthink it.” This participant selected all three response options. [P2260]
- Four participants [P2254, P2640, P2648, P2975] felt that the terms could refer to different programs, particularly distinguishing between federal and state level coverage.
 - “The only thing that I think might--the state or federal marketplace the state is separate from the federal. When I think of federal marketplace, healthcare.gov, the human insurance marketplace, healthcare.gov [*sic*] I am thinking of Obamacare. But the state, my specific state in OH that might be a completely different entity. I’m not sure.” [P2640]

This question was generally well received, but there was some confusion among participants when defining the response option “directly from an insurance company.” Some considered that their insurance was sourced directly from a company, despite acquiring it through an employer. Some of those who saw the question found the “State or Federal Marketplace,” “Healthcare.gov,” and/or the state-specific portal name response options redundant, but some acknowledged the importance of distinguishing the programs.

Recommendations:

To clarify the difference between the “directly from an insurance company” and “current job/former job” response options, consider testing verbiage that implies that an individual person independently purchased the insurance (i.e., NOT acquired through an employer). Consider testing a combined response option for the public coverage options or implementing a similar expandable dropdown when “State or Federal Marketplace” is selected.

Q2a. How did you get your private health insurance? Mark all that apply.

- Current job (yours or another family member)
- Former job (yours or another family member)
- Union or professional association
- Purchased directly from an insurance company by you or another family member
- Broker
- State or Federal Marketplace, Healthcare.gov, or [^State-Specific Portal Name]

Question 3

Research Question: For respondents recorded as uninsured, we need to confirm the information is correct – in a way that does not sound like we are doubting them.

Q3. Did you have health insurance for even a short time in 2023?

- Yes
- No

n = 3

Findings:**Is this question redundant/annoying?**

- All participants who saw this question [P2250, P2633, P2942] found the question redundant, but two [P2633, P2942] specifically noted that it was not annoying to answer.
 - “It seems like the exact same question before, yes. It doesn’t bother me, though.” [P2633]

This question confirmed that the information regarding insurance status was correct. The question was overall easy for participants to answer and did not seem redundant.

Recommendations:

No recommendations. The question was easily understood by participants.

Question 4

Research Question: This is the start of the funnel. It’s an attempt to get more specific responses before sending people to the write-in option (i.e., Q6.3). For R who skip the question, we use the fill “that was not listed,” because R might not like the suggestion that they are “not sure.”

Q4. How did you get your health insurance [that you’re not sure how to report/ that was not listed]? Mark all that apply.

- A job
- The government
- Some other way
- I’m not sure

n = 4

Findings:**Were there any problems with this question?**

- One participant [P2904] noted that they would have preferred the word “employer” instead of “a job” for the response option.

This question successfully funneled and confirmed participants who reported having insurance they were unsure of how to report. It was easy for participants to understand and answer.

Recommendations:

No recommendations. The question was easily understood by participants.

Question 5.1

Research Question: Funnel question designed to get response and avoid write in.
Q5.1. Was that insurance tied to military service? ▪ Yes ▪ No
<i>n</i> = 5

Findings:

There were no notable findings for this question.

Recommendations:

No recommendations. This question was easily understood by participants.

Question 5.2

Research Question: Funnel question designed to get response and avoid write in.
Q5.2. Who provided that insurance? ▪ TRICARE ▪ CHAMPVA ▪ Veterans Administration (VA) Care ▪ Other
<i>n</i> = 0

Findings:

No participants received this question.

Recommendations:

No recommendations at this time.

Question 6.1

Research Question: Funnel question designed to get response and avoid write in.
Q6.1. Was that insurance through a job with the federal, state, or local government? ▪ Yes ▪ No
<i>n</i> = 0

Findings:

No participants received this question.

Recommendations:

No recommendations at this time.

Question 6.2

Research Question: Funnel question designed to get response and avoid write in.
Q6.2. Who provided that insurance? ▪ Medicaid or Medical Assistance ▪ Children’s Health Insurance Program (CHIP) ▪ Medicare ▪ Military ▪ Indian Health Service ▪ Other
<i>n = 0</i>

Findings:

No participants received this question.

Recommendations:

No recommendations at this time.

Question 6.3

Research Question: This is a high priority. In addition to providing the write-in option, we want to add “decoy,” out-of-scope insurance categories that often show up in write-ins (e.g., “church”). The motivation is to reduce write ins that would only end up being categorized as uninsurance.
Q6.3. What kind of health insurance did [you/they] have? ▪ Church ▪ Charity care ▪ HealthShare ▪ Other [write in]
<i>n = 0</i>

Findings:

No participants received this question.

Recommendations:

No recommendations at this time.

Question 7.1

Research Question: This is a funnel question designed to help the R avoid a write in.
Q7.1. How did you get this insurance? ▪ Former employer ▪ Union or professional association ▪ Indian Health Service ▪ Student insurance ▪ Parent or spouse's plan ▪ Purchased
n = 0

Findings:

No participants received this question.

Recommendations:

No recommendations at this time.

Question 7.2

Research Question: This is a funnel question designed to help the R avoid a write in.
Q7.2. How did they get this insurance? ▪ Job ▪ Purchased ▪ Some other way ▪ Don't know
n = 0

Findings:

No participants received this question.

Recommendations:

No recommendations at this time.

Question 7.3

Research Question: This is a funnel question designed to help the R avoid a write in.
Q7.3. Was that insurance through healthcare.gov [or state exchange portal names]? ▪ Yes ▪ No ▪ Don't know
n = 0

Findings:

No participants received this question.

Recommendations:

No recommendations at this time.

Question 11

Research Question: We need to collect information about coverage spells.
Q11. How long did you have [^health insurance type] in 2023? ▪ All year ▪ Part of the year ▪ I did not have [^health insurance type] in 2023
<i>n</i> = 27

Findings:**Were there any problems with the question?**

- Two participants [P2507, P2904] changed their initial responses to the question.
 - P2507 initially selected "Part of the year" but upon advancing to Q15 (Were you uninsured for part of 2023?), struggled and returned to Q11 to change their response to "All year." P described that they changed their HMO within Medicaid in June but maintained coverage through the rest of the year.
 - P2904 initially answered "All year," but then answered "Yes" to Q15 (Were you uninsured for part of 2023?). P then updated their response to "Part of the year." P noted that they weren't thinking about the period they were uninsured the first time they read the question.
- One participant [P2647] thought the display of the question number (e.g., "Q-11") preceding the question text was confusing.
- One participant [P2905] revisited the difference between "private health insurance" and insurance "directly from an insurance company" during their think aloud. They figured that private health insurance indicated a relationship between the employer and insurance company.
 - "I guess, as I think about it ... some people might consider 'private health insurance' as health insurance that's provided by an employer. But maybe the true definition of 'private health insurance' is, is insurance that you acquire by working directly with an insurance company. My initial thought process is private health insurance is, could be tied to an employer or by any individual going directly to an insurance company." When asked for further clarification, "Well initially I would just assume it was tied to a relationship directly with the insurance company or through the employer so I would say I had it all year." [P2905]

This question was understood by most participants and accurately captured insurance coverage spells. Participants were able to change their responses if needed, and others were able to reason their answers logically based on the question text.

Recommendations:

No recommendations. The question was easily understood by participants.

Question 12

Research Question: We need to ask about additional coverages.
Q12. Have you recorded all the insurance type(s) you had last year? Do not include plans that cover only dental, drug, or vision.
▪ Yes ▪ No
<i>n</i> = 6

Findings:**Were there any problems with the question?**

- One participant [P2446] found the word “record” confusing and wondered if the question was asking whether they, “kept record of the insurance itself or all of the time I’ve had to utilize the Medicaid.”

Did they read and follow instructions about dental/drug/vision?

- Five participants who saw the question [P2344, P2446, , P2904, P2905, P2975] seemed to follow the instructions, although none explicitly commented on them.
- One participant [P2507] mentioned that the word “only” could be italicized to clarify that we are asking about standalone plans rather than supplemental dental, drug, and vision insurance.
 - “I don’t think so, but the word ‘only’ makes me think that even if it did, in addition to other standard Medicaid, it’s probably not, yeah, it would still be included, that’s my intuition. But I don’t know. ... I could see people maybe browsing over it just because it’s, yeah, if you italicized it, maybe that would help. I don’t know. [P2507]

This question seemed to be well understood and easy for participants to report additional coverages.

Recommendations:

The question was easily understood by most participants however, we recommend testing the word “reported” instead of “recorded” to improve comprehension:

Q12. Have you reported all the insurance type(s) you had last year? Do not include plans that cover only dental, drug, or vision.
▪ Yes ▪ No

Question 13

Research Question: We need to collect data about other forms of insurance coverage.

Q13. What other health insurance(s) did you have in 2023? Mark all that apply.

- Private health insurance
- Medicare
- Medicaid or other government program
- Veterans health care (enrolled for VA)
- TRICARE or other military health care
- Indian Health Service
- Other: [Write in]

The second and third options will be EXPANDABLE to:

Medicare – 2

- Medicare Part A (hospital care)
- Medicare Part B (outpatient care)
- Medicare Advantage

Medicaid or other government program – 3

- Medicaid
- [^CAIDNAME]
- Children’s Health Insurance Program
- Other government health program for people with low income or disability

n = 1

Findings:

- One participant [P2344] selected Other and wrote in “Ending coverage through a previous job.” They explained that they did not consider this coverage as private health insurance because they only had it for one month during 2023.

This question seemed to capture another type of insurance this participant had during 2023, although it is unclear whether it was an accurate response given that it was employer-provided. Otherwise, it seems like this question was well understood.

Recommendations:

As recommended in Question 2, consider testing a similar feature for the “Private Health Insurance” response option. For example, the first option could be expandable when selected:

1. Private Health Insurance

- A plan provided through an employer or union
- A plan purchased by an individual from an insurance company

This may help clarify participants’ understanding of what “private health insurance” means and whether it applies to them.

Question 13A

Research Question: HIGH PRIORITY. This is a new follow-up question restricted to the “Private health insurance” responses for Q2 and Q13.

Q13a. How did you get your private health insurance?

- Current job (yours or another family member)
- Former job (yours or another family member)
- Union or professional association
- Directly from an insurance company
- Broker
- State or Federal Marketplace
- Healthcare.gov
- [^State-Specific Portal Name]

***n* = 0**

Findings:

No participants received this question.

Recommendations:

See Questions 2a recommendations.

Question 14

Research Question: This is high priority. It’s a new question. We need information on coverage spells.

Q14. How long did you have [^health insurance type/this other health insurance] in 2023?

- All year
- Part of the year

***n* = 1**

Findings:

There were no notable findings for this question.

Recommendations:

No recommendations at this time.

Question 15

Research Question: For people with multiple forms of insurance coverage but none of which were reported as being held “all year,” we need to clarify whether there was any period of uninsurance.

Q15. Were you uninsured for part of 2023?

- Yes
- No

***n* = 7**

Findings:**Do we need to say, “without insurance”?**

- Two participants [P2446, P2904] noted that they were indifferent regarding the use of “uninsured” versus “without insurance”.
 - “Either or is fine. It's just a verbiage, but it still means the same thing.” [P2904]
- Two participants [P2263, P2707] preferred the word “uninsured,” but both noted that the terms meant the same thing to them.
 - “I’m just used to seeing ‘uninsured’ so I, that, better for me.” [P2707]
- Two participants [P2344, P2095] preferred “without insurance.”
 - P2344 suggested updating the verbiage to, “without health insurance” to further specify the question.

Overall, this question was well understood, despite some disagreements about the text used to convey periods of uninsurance. Comprehension of “without insurance” and “uninsured” are synonymous.

Recommendations:

No recommendations; the term “uninsured” is concise and synonymous with “without insurance.” The question was easily understood by participants.

Question 17

Research Question: We need to know who in the household is the insurance policyholder. The concept of “policyholder” is tricky for respondents.

Q17. Whose name was your [^health insurance type] policy in? (who was the policyholder?)

R’s name	-
Spouse	-
AdultChild1	-
AdultChild2	-
Other1	-
OtherOutsideHH	-

n = 13

Findings:**Did they understand “whose name was your [^health insurance type] policy in?” or “who was the policyholder”?**

- Three participants [P2254, P2265, P2538] thought the term “policyholder” was clearer than “whose name was your policy in.”
 - “I feel like when it says policyholder that makes more sense. It’s saying who is the main person. Like if I had my insurance through my parents the main subscriber would be me [but the policyholder] would be my parents.” [P2254]

- "I guess it's a little confusing because if I just saw 'whose name was it in?' I might think 'oh, it's in my name.' I'm listed as someone on our insurance plan. But then when it, when it specifies 'who is the policyholder?' I assume it's trying to clarify the same question. And then I would say 'oh, that's, I'm not the policyholder.'" [P2265]
- Four participants [P2279, P2718, P2748, P2975] preferred "whose name is it in?"
 - "The policyholder makes it seem like, who does the policy apply to?" ... "I can clearly see on my card that it's my father's name on the card." [P2279]
 - "'Whose name is it in' is more clear to me. 'Policyholder' could mean my employer." [P2718]
 - "Then I like the first one with the '[whose name was the] private health insurance policy in' because that reminds me that we're still focusing on the health insurance and not something else." [P2748]
- One participant [P2598] thought the terms were synonymous but noted that "whose name is the policy in" was a clearer way to ask the question.
- Three participants [P2260, P2265, P2975] interpreted the terms as referring to different people.
 - "It seems like it's a little bit different kind of. Like it could be seen in the same way, but you have like the policyholder like through an employer like I was under a certain age and it was under my mom's name or something I would say she was the policy holder but then 'who's name is it in?' I might think well I have a health insurance card that has my name on it, so I think it almost feels like it could be two [different] questions." [P2260]
 - "To me, policyholder means like the person who gets it through their workplace, which is my mom. I do have insurance in my name, but I believe she's the policyholder. It's a little confusing." [P2265]
- One participant [P2265] also noted that the policyholder for their private insurance did not live in the same household, so they reported themselves as the policyholder even though they knew they were not.
 - "Oh ok, this is interesting because none of these are the right answer for me. My insurance policy is in the name of my mom, who I don't live with so." [P2265]
- Two participants [P2640, P2975] thought the term "policyholder" referred to the insurance company providing the plan, rather than an individual.
 - "...Once you bring up private insurance policy, then [I'm] going to think Blue Cross Blue Shield [or] something like that. So yeah, the policyholder, or maybe [inaudible], so 'who's the primary policyholder of the health insurance?' would be clear to me." [P2975]
 - "Well, I don't understand the word policyholder, I thought the policy holder was the insurance company. I could be wrong on that. So, if I am correct on that then it's talking about two different questions." When asked to clarify by the interviewer, "Well mainly the first part 'whose name was your private health insurance policy in—it was in my husband's name and then the 'who was the policy holder' the first thought that popped into my mind was well the policy holder is my husband's employer, but I could be wrong on that." [P2640]
- One participant audibly reminded themselves of the reference period, emphasizing that it was not included in the question text.

- After reading the question, “I’m assuming 2023.” [P2589]

This question yielded mixed responses. Most participants understood “whose name is the policy in?” and “who is the policyholder” as asking the same thing. However, there were some participants who interpreted the former as asking about who was covered by the policy and the latter as the person who acquired or owned the insurance policy. It was also discovered that non-household members were unable to be selected as policyholders, which presented an issue for participants.

Note that the response option “OtherOutsideHH” was not displayed on the programmed version of the survey.

Recommendations:

Given the confusion about the terms used and the importance of identifying the policyholder, consider testing the word “policyholder” with a definition of the term. This definition could be expandable so as not to overcrowd the question page.

Q17. Who was the policyholder for your [^health insurance type]?

The policyholder is the person who purchases or owns an insurance policy (through an employer, union, or other insurance provider).

R’s name	-
Spouse	-
AdultChild1	-
AdultChild2	-
Other1	-
OtherOutsideHH	-

Question 18

Research Question: We need to know whether the R’s employer contributes to the premium payment. “Premium” is a tricky word/concept.

Q18. Did [your or Person in Q17’s] employer or union help pay for the health insurance?

- Yes
- No

n = 14

Findings:

Do they know we’re asking about their premiums?

- Six participants [P2254, P2640, P2648, P2741, P2905, P2975] explicitly mentioned premiums when asked about their interpretation of this question.
 - “For the, the insurance premium, the monthly premium. Or yearly premium, however you’re charged for your health insurance. Because I’m sure that some, I’m sure that some people, you know, that they, it pays for all of their insurance, but it doesn’t pay for all of mine, I still have to pay a portion every month.” [P2741]

- Five participants [P2589, P2260, P2265, P2279, P2718] did not explicitly mention premiums, but noted aspects of health insurance that can be associated with employer contributions.
 - “Maybe it also means like health insurance, certain benefits that they are covering. I think it can catch a lot. I would think it even means that they just give you a couple of benefits and pay for some of it.” [P2260]
 - “Usually a certain number of, a certain list of things that includes like checkups and certain doctors’ visits. So many not like dental or not certain types of procedures that are more elected.” [P2265]

Are people able to answer this if they are not the policyholder?

- Three non-policyholder participants [P2256, P2279, P2640] had some difficulty answering this question.
 - “I guess I don’t fully know. I know we got this kind of healthcare through his job so I assume that they help pay for it in some way.” [P2279]

This question was generally easy for participants to answer, although the clarity of the question asking about premiums is questionable. This question was particularly difficult for non-policyholders.

Recommendations:

To clarify that this question is asking about monthly premiums, consider rephrasing the question as follows:

Q18. Did [your or Person in Q17’s] employer or union help pay the premium or monthly cost of the health insurance?

- Yes
- No

Question 18a

Research Question: We need to know whether the R’s employer contributes to the premium payment. “Premium” is a tricky word/concept.

Q18a. Did [your or Person in Q17’s] employer or union pay for all or part of the cost of the insurance?

- All
- Part

n = 8

Findings:

Do they know we’re asking about their premiums?

- Four participants [P2718, P2743, P2905, P2975] mentioned premium or monthly payment contributions from employers.
- Two participants [P2538, P2589] specifically mentioned deductions (or lack thereof) from their paychecks to infer that their employer pays for part or all of the health insurance.

- One non-policyholder participant [P2279] indicated that they understood the meaning of the question, but was unsure about the information itself. They mentioned that they assumed “Yes” to the previous question about employer contributions, but was unsure if the employer paid for all or part of the insurance. This participant did not provide an answer to the question.
- One participant [P2256] was confused by this question and thought it read too similarly to the previous question.

Most participants seem to have understood that this question asked about the premium payments, although there was some confusion for non-policyholders. Generally, this question was understood as intended.

Recommendations:

No recommendations. This question was easily understood by participants.

Question 18b

Research Question: We need to know whether the R received a subsidy or tax credit to reduce the cost of insurance.
Q18a. Did [you/Person in Q17] receive a tax credit or subsidy based on family income to help pay for the insurance?
▪ Yes ▪ No
n = 13

Findings:

Do they know what subsidies and tax credits are?

- Some participants (n=8) described subsidies and tax credits as income-based qualifications to receive help paying for health insurance costs.
 - “If we were possibly in a lower income bracket there could be some program out there such as a tax credit or subsidy probably initiated by either the state or federal government that would help costs.” [P2640]
 - “Well subsidy would be based on, you know, maybe like on a sliding income. You know, if you make a certain amount of money, like they pay for a portion of your insurance premium.” [P2743]
- Three participants [P2256, P2265, P2279] mentioned government assistance with health insurance costs, although not based on income qualifications.
 - “I assume it means you get some money back when you’re paying your taxes. Or you have to pay fewer taxes essentially that, and that money can go towards insurance. ... I think subsidy means that the government is essentially giving you some money and maybe making something cheaper for you. So I assume like the government would be providing money to help pay for the insurance.” [P2265]
- One participant [P2905] found this question confusing because they defined tax credits and subsidies based on opposite income qualifications.

- “Is it [a tax credit or subsidy] the same amount? I would think it differs. I think that the, the subsidy may be based on your annual income ... and so, when it’s, when it’s questioned as ‘received a tax credit or subsidy,’ it seems to me like it’s two different scenarios, yeah. ... That the government would provide the tax credit to the individual that may be in a higher income bracket and a subsidy would be someone in a lower tax bracket.” [P2905]
- One participant [P2975] noted that the lack of defined timeframe is confusing.
 - “It says ‘did you receive,’ it doesn’t give me a timeframe. I know we keep talking about 2023, and if that’s the case, you should put in parentheses ‘for 2023’ ...” [P2975]
- One participant [P2260] noted that they had heard the terms before but did not know what they meant.
 - “I just know I haven’t—I don’t know all the things like the tax and the subsidy I know nothing else helped me pay for the insurance and I fully covered [it]. So, in my mind right away I know no even if I don’t know exactly what that entails, I know I didn’t have that assistance.” [P2260]

This question yielded mixed interpretations of what tax credits and subsidies are. Some participants mentioned income-based government financial assistance, but not all agreed on that definition. There was some confusion regarding the reference period for this question.

Recommendations:

Consider testing a version of the question with explicit definitions of tax credit and subsidy and adding a timeframe reference. These definitions could be expandable so as not to overcrowd the question page.

Q18a. In [timeframe reference], did [you/Person in Q17] receive a tax credit or subsidy based on family income to help pay for the insurance?

A tax credit is a tax reduction that helps eligible individuals and families cover the premiums for their health insurance.

A subsidy is health coverage that is available at reduced or no cost for people with incomes below certain levels.

- Yes
- No

Question 19a

Research Question: HIGH PRIORITY. This is a new question. It’s a filter to the household roster.

Q19a. Did anyone else in your household also have [health insurance type] in 2023?

- Yes
- No

n = 27

Findings:

Does this question capture both situations where the second person is on the R's insurance and where the second person has their own policy of the same insurance type?

- Fourteen participants said they were thinking about the type of insurance rather than specific policies.
 - "Yeah, I guess, I was thinking about it in that particular timeframe. It was private insurance that I would carry and, the children's mother had, she was part of what some of the government programs available." [P2905]
- Participants with unrelated household members struggled to answer the question confidently.
 - "So, this one, I guess, is a little confusing because it, I haven't totally defined what my household is. I'm assume they're looking in my household as the people I wrote down, my roommates that I live with. But there's also my household as in like my parents, who are paying for the, or whose employers, are paying for the insurance. And I don't necessarily know the health insurance details of the roommates I live with. So, I'm just going to say 'No' because it's, I don't really know." [P2265]
- Two participants [P2263, P2279] thought about the question at the policy level.
 - "I was thinking it was saying that did anybody that lived here had my insurance at my job." [P2263]
- Three participants [P2428, P2743, P2260] mentioned both the insurance type and policy level in their descriptions of the question.
 - "I was thinking about with my insurance provider because even though there's multiple of us on that policy, everyone else is dependent so no one else had like a separate insurance plan." [P2743]
 - "Okay, so regarding this question, my children have it and my husband he has a private... He has it through his job. So, for this question you've got to be a little bit more specific because sometimes people in the household, they have other health insurance." [P2428]
- Two participants [P2707, P2904] received this question even though they were single member households.

Many participants found this question easy to answer. However, several participants considered insurance types rather than individual insurance policies, but fewer participants thought strictly on the policy level. Very few participants thought of both scenarios, and some found it confusing.

Recommendations:

Given that both scenarios should be collected, consider testing a split version of the question to target both situations.

Q19a.1. Was anyone else in your household on [^your or Q17 policyholder's] insurance policy in 2023?

- Yes
- No

Q19a.2. Did anyone else in your household have their own policy with [insurance type] in 2023?

- Yes
- No

Question 20

Research Question: This is a high priority. We need to collect proxy reports of health insurance for all household members.

Q20. Which people in your household had [health insurance type] in 2023? Mark all that apply.

Spouse	-
Child1	-
Child2	-
Child3	-
Other1	-
Other2	-

n = 10

Findings:

No additional findings from this question.

Recommendations:

No recommendations at this time.

Question 21

Research Question: This is a high priority. We need to collect proxy reports of spells of health insurance for all household members.

Q21. How long did [^Person] have [insurance type] in 2023?

Person	All year	Part year
Spouse	-	-
Child1	-	-
Child2	-	-
Child3	-	-

n = 10

Findings:**Were there any problems with the question?**

- Two participants [P2428, P2518] expressed slight uncertainty about their responses for their infant children, noting that the children were technically insured for part of the year, but for their entire lives. P2158 misread the question to ask about the year 2020, which is when their child was born. Regardless, both P2428 and P2518 selected "Part year" for their infant children.
- One participant [P2647] also noted semantic uncertainty.
 - "No. The, the second part, when it says 'part year,' yes. That part could be confusing to some people. Do they mean half of the year or what do they mean exactly 'part year'?" P2647]

Did they struggle with the grid format?

- One participant [P2589] mentioned that the labels could be emphasized by bolding or increasing the font size for clarity.
 - "It took me a second to realize the columns were labeled. For a moment I thought this is just a list of names" [P2589]

Are the column headings clear?

- Three participants [P2273, P2538, P2728] found the column headings clear.
- One participant [P2718] thought the headings were clear but would have preferred the verbiage "all of the year" instead of "all year."

Overall comprehension of this question was clear and easy for participants to answer. There were some recommendations to emphasize the column headings, but these did not seem to hinder participants' responses.

Recommendations:

Consider testing a version of the grid with emphasized column headings.

Question 22

Research Question: We need to collect information on any additional coverages.
Q22. Besides {list insurances that were asked about}, was anyone in your household covered by any other type of health insurance in 2023?
▪ Yes ▪ No
n = 24

Findings:**Are there any problems with the question?**

- A known programming error caused two single-person households [P2707, P2904] to see this question, which caused annoyance.

- “It's kind of redundant. It's kind of going back to the previous question. So, it's just asking again.” [P2904]
- One participant [P2344] found it odd to have “other insurance type” listed, although they were able to answer the question.
- One participant [P2518] was unclear about who this question was asking about.

Do we need to list all the insurances?

- Four participants [P2279, P2344, P2446, P2743] did not need to see the full list of insurance types again in this question and noted that they could recall the types of insurance from previous questions.
- Three participants [P2589, P2648, P2975] found that listing the previously reported insurance types was helpful in this question because they wouldn't have to recall what they previously reported.
- Two participants [P2263, P2518] would have preferred to see the entire list of insurance types again.
 - “Yeah, because when you said ‘besides the following health insurances’ and I thought it would have maybe named some names out. But it didn't drop down the whole other insurance type. I would've thought it might've would have [sic] put the type of insurance.” [P2263]
- Some participants (n=9) only had one insurance type listed and did not express issue with the format of the question.

This question was generally well received and answered easily. Most participants did not need to see the full list of insurance types to answer, with some recalling the different types and others noting that it would have been annoying to see the full list again.

Recommendations:

No recommendations. This question was easily understood by most participants, although some of those living with unrelated household members struggled to answer.

Question 22a

Research Question: We need to collect information on any additional coverages.

Q22a. Which people in your household were covered by some other type of health insurance? Mark all that apply.

Spouse	-
Child1	-
Child2	-
Child3	-
Other1	-
Other2	-

n = 10

Findings

Is it necessary to mention 2023 in the question?

- Five participants [P2256, P2265, P2367, P2428, P2518] said they considered the same timeframe from previous questions.
 - “Yeah I assume it’s still talking about that same time period. The January to December 2023.” [P2265]
- One participant [P2648] said they considered the present when answering the question.

This question was overall easy for participants to answer and they maintained the reference period from previous questions.

Recommendations:

No recommendations. This question was easily understood by participants.

Question 22d

Research Question: We need to know who in the household is the insurance policyholder. The concept of “policyholder” is tricky for respondents.

Q22d. Whose name was [Person in 20]’s [^health insurance type] policy in? (who was the policyholder?)

R’s name	-
Spouse	-
AdultChild1	-
AdultChild2	-
Other1	-
OtherOutsideHH	-

n = 5

Findings:

Are there any problems with this question?

- One participant [P2589] who lived with unrelated household members was unable to accurately proxy report for their household member because the policyholder would have been a non-household member. The participant selected the household member as the policyholder but would have preferred to skip the question if they could.

No further findings from this question.

Recommendations:

As recommended in Question 17 and given the confusion about the terms used and the importance of identifying the policyholder, consider testing the word “policyholder” with a definition of the term. This definition could be expandable or placed in a linked glossary so as not to overcrowd the question page.

Q22d. Whose name was [Person in 20]’s [^health insurance type] policy in? (who was the policyholder?)

R’s name	-
Spouse	-
AdultChild1	-
AdultChild2	-
Other1	-
OtherOutsideHH	-

Question 22e

Research Question: We need to know whether the employer contributes to the premium payment. “Premium” is a tricky word/concept.

Q22e. Did [Person in Q22d’s] employer or union help pay for the health insurance?

- Yes
- No

n = 5

Findings:

Do they know we’re asking about their premiums?

- One participant [P2538] was unclear whether this question was about private health insurance or other types that employers might contribute to.
- One participant’s [P2589] understanding of this question changed since answering it for their own coverage.
 - They assumed in the previous iteration of this question that “help pay for” referred to, “the company buys insurance and then the employees pay their own individual portion. But now I’m wondering if it means that they actually provide assistance paying for your portion” [P2589]

Are people able to answer this if they are not the policyholder?

- Two participants [P2254, P2260] expressed uncertainty when proxy reporting for household members.
 - P2260 noted that they would have preferred to have a “don’t know” option for this question.

This question presented uncertainty for proxy reporters, particularly in households with unrelated members. Otherwise, there were no additional findings from Q18.

Recommendations:

No recommendations.

Research Question: We need to know whether the employer contributes to the premium payment. “Premium” is a tricky word/concept.

Q22f. Did [Person in Q22d’s] employer or union help pay for the health insurance?

- All
- Part

n = 2

Findings:

Are there any problems with this question?

- One participant [P2538] notes that they are not completely certain of their proxy reporting for their household member.

Do they know we're asking about their premiums?

- One participant [P2718] maintains that they are answering about health insurance premium payments.

This question was well understood, although it was difficult for a proxy reporter. No further findings from Q18a.

Recommendations:

No recommendations.

Question 22g

Research Question: We need to know whether the employer contributes to the premium payment. "Premium" is a tricky word/concept.

Q22g. Did [Person in Q22d] receive a tax credit or subsidy based on family income to help pay for the insurance?

- Yes
- No

n = 4

Findings:

No additional findings from this question beyond those from Q18b.

Recommendations:

As recommended in Question 18b, consider testing a version of the question with explicit definitions of tax credit and subsidy and adding a timeframe reference. These definitions could be expandable so as not to overcrowd the question page.

Q22g. Did [Person in Q22d] receive a tax credit or subsidy based on family income to help pay for the insurance?

A tax credit is a tax reduction that helps eligible individuals and families cover the premiums for their health insurance.

A subsidy is health coverage that is available at reduced or no cost for people with incomes below certain levels.

- Yes
- No

Question 22b

Research Question: High priority. This is a new question. We need to catch proxy reports of no insurance
Q22b. Was [Person] uninsured at any point in 2023?
▪ Yes ▪ No
n = 14

Findings:**Do people understand “uninsured?”**

- Five participants [P2260, P2446, P2640, P2718, P294] noted that the term “uninsured” and “without insurance” meant the same thing.
 - “Either the health insurance was cancelled or interrupted and there was a period of time that we had zero health insurance.” [P2640]
- One participant [P2743] preferred the term “uninsured.”
- One participant [P2518] preferred the term “without health insurance.”
- One participant [P2279] noted a redundancy in the question.
 - “If [household member] was uninsured I would be uninsured too because we are under the same plan” [P2279]
- One participant [P2367] lived with unrelated household members and was unsure when proxy answering. The P would have preferred an “I don’t know” response, but chose to leave the question blank.

Participants generally understood “without insurance” and “uninsured” to mean the same thing. No additional findings from Q15.

Recommendations:

See Question 15 recommendations. No further recommendations.

Question 22c

Research Question: High priority. This is a new question. We need to collect information on any spells of uninsurance in the proxy reports.
Q22f. How long was [Person] uninsured in 2023?
▪ All year ▪ Part of the year
n = 5

Findings:**Do people understand “uninsured?”**

No additional findings.

Can people proxy report for this question?

- One participant [P2718] noted that they were uncertain of their response and would have preferred to have a “don’t know” response option.
 - “Oh, yeah, that [a ‘don’t know option] would be helpful because they are asking for other people in your household.” [P2718]

There were some issues with proxy reporting in this question, but it was otherwise generally understood. No additional findings.

Recommendations:

No recommendations.

Question 23

Research Question: We need to collect proxy reports of multiple coverages.

Q23. What [“other” if coming from Q22a but NOT Q22b or Q22c] health insurance(s) did [Person] have in 2023? Mark all that apply.

- Private health insurance
- Medicare
- Medicaid or other government program
- Veterans health care (enrolled for VA)
- TRICARE or other military health care
- Indian Health Service

The second and third options will be EXPANDABLE to:

Medicare – 2

- Medicare Part A (hospital care)
- Medicare Part B (outpatient care)
- Medicare Advantage

Medicaid or other government program – 3

- Medicaid
- [^CAIDNAME]
- Children’s Health Insurance Program
- Other government health program for people with low income or disability

n = 9

Findings:**Are there any problems with this question?**

- One participant [P2260] notes that their interpretation of the response options has changed since seeing the question the first time.
 - “Oh wait. I kind of feel thrown off and I realize like ‘oh no did I mess up?’ because for some reason my mind went to. When I saw private HI I was thinking either through healthcare.gov or also just like getting it directly through the insurance company. I don’t know why but I kind of overlooked, it went over my head, that this could be through employer. I think usually I am

used to seeing like ‘through employer’ like that word associated with it. So I wasn’t even thinking about that...I think maybe it would have been a little more helpful to have an employer differentiated it.” [P2260]

- Two participants [P2265, P2684] expressed uncertainty in their proxy reporting.
 - “It’s good to have an ‘other’ option just in case you need to write something in to make it a little more accurate.” Note this participant entered “I don’t know” when they selected “Other insurance type” [P2265]
- Two participants struggled to proxy report on this question. They noted that the “other” option was helpful because they could write in that they were not sure.

Recommendations:

No recommendations. This question was easily understood by participants.

Question 23a

Research Question: This is a new question. We added it because we simplified the laundry list of insurance types so that there’s only one choice for private health insurance. This new question is a follow up for the private insurance holders to find out how they got it.

Q23a. How did [^Person] get their private health insurance? Mark all that apply.

- Current job (theirs or another family member)
- Former job (theirs or another family member)
- Union or professional association
- Directly from an insurance company
- Broker
- State or Federal Marketplace
- Healthcare.gov
- [^State-Specific Portal Name]

n = 4

Findings:

Does the response “directly from an insurance company” make sense?

- One participant [P2367] understood “directly from an insurance company” as insurance acquired from someplace other than an employer.
 - “You would access health insurance directly and not through your job.” [P2367]

Does the overlap in “State or Federal Marketplace,” “Healthcare.gov,” and/or the state-specific portal name confuse people?

- One participant [P2518] mentioned that there likely are differences among these programs, but they are unsure about the details.
 - “I think there’s distinctions between them however I have absolutely no idea what those are.” [P2518]

What if someone hit “private” earlier by mistake – what do they do/choose?

No findings.

Are there any problems with this question?

- One participant [P2428] thought that the words “former job” in reference to a past job could be confusing and suggested using the phrase “previous job” instead.
 - “Okay so ‘former job’ is job previously [sic]. So I feel like that, with that, when they say ‘former’ people are going to think, ‘job now.’ So I feel like the wording should be different for that question. Instead of ‘former’ put ‘previously.’”

This question was generally well understood. There are no additional findings beyond those in Question 2a.

Recommendations:

See Question 2a. No further recommendations.

Research Question: We need to collect proxy information on coverage spells.
Q24. How long did [^Person] have [^health insurance type] in 2023? ▪ All year ▪ Part of the year
n = 7

Findings:**Are there any problems with this question?**

- One participant [P2684] noted that they were uncertain proxy reporting for an unrelated household member.
 - “Unfortunately, I am not related to this person, who I live with, so I don’t have the luxury of having all of her information on board.” [P2684]
- One participant [P2256], who is not the policyholder, felt more confident proxy reporting for their household member who is the policyholder than they did for themselves.

This question was generally well understood, although there were some mixed opinions from proxy reporters.

Recommendations:

No recommendations. This question was easily understood by participants.

Question 25

Research Question: For people with multiple forms of insurance coverage but none of which were reported as being held “all year,” we need to clarify whether there was any period of uninsurance
Q25. Was [^Person] uninsured for part of 2023? ▪ Yes ▪ No
n = 14

Findings:**Do we need to say, “without insurance?”**

No additional findings.

Are there any problems with this question?

- One participant [P2256] found the question somewhat redundant and felt like they had already answered this question.

This question was generally well understood, although one participant felt that they had already answered this question.

Recommendations:

No recommendations. This question was easily understood by participants.

Question 25a

Research Question: We need to know who in the household is the insurance policyholder. The concept of “policyholder” is tricky for respondents.

Q22d. Whose name was [Person in Q22a]’s [^health insurance type] policy in? (who was the policyholder?)

R’s name	-
Spouse	-
AdultChild1	-
AdultChild2	-
Other1	-
OtherOutsideHH	-

***n* = 4**

Findings:**Are there any problems with this question?**

- One participant [P2518] had two household members with the same name but used the context of the question to answer.

Do they prefer “whose name was the policy in?” or “who was the policyholder?” better?

- Two participants [P2367, P2518] preferred “whose name was the policy in?”
 - P2367 noted that the two questions mean the same thing but that the word “policyholder” would not be widely understood.

This question was generally well understood. There were no additional findings.

Recommendations:

See Question 17 recommendations. No further recommendations.

Question 25b

Research Question: We need to know whether the employer contributes to the premium payment. "Premium" is a tricky word/concept.
Q25b. Did [Person in Q25a's] employer or union help pay for the health insurance? ▪ Yes ▪ No
n = 4

Findings:**Do they know we're asking about their premiums?**

No additional findings.

Are people able to answer this if they are not the policyholder?

- Three participants [P2260, P2367, P2518] expressed uncertainty in proxy reporting for household members.
 - "Because I'm assuming, I know they don't fully cover everything there's additional expenses [household member] has." [P2260]
 - "I would guess yes, because typically employers pay a part of it." [P2367]

This question was generally well understood, although there was some uncertainty among proxy reporters. No further findings beyond Question 18.

Recommendations:

See Question 18 recommendations. No additional recommendations.

Question 25c

Research Question: We need to know whether the employer contributes to the premium payment. "Premium" is a tricky word/concept.
Q25c. Did [Person in Q25a's] employer or union pay all or part of the cost of the insurance? ▪ All ▪ Part
n = 4

Findings:**Are there any problems with this question?**

- Three participants [P2260, P2367, P2518] expressed uncertainty when proxy reporting and all figured that it was more likely that the employer paid for part of the health insurance.
 - "I don't know quite how to answer that because I know that she has like health insurance benefits, but I know also there's certain things that I believe she's had to pay out of pocket. I'm sure they don't pay for all of it so I guess I would say as far as I know I think part of it, but yeah, I kind of wish there was a not sure answer for this." [P2260]

- “It was easy to say part because no one covers the whole insurance” [P2367]

Do they know we’re asking about their premiums?

- One participant [P2260] noted that it was unclear that the question was about premiums.
 - “No that’s [asking about premiums is] not clear. I don’t know I wasn’t sure exactly what this entailed.” [P2260]

This question was generally understood, although those who proxy reported were uncertain about their responses. No further findings beyond Question 18a.

Recommendations:

No recommendations.

Question 25d

Research Question: We need to know whether the R received a subsidy or tax credit to reduce the cost of insurance.
Q25d. Did [Person in Q25a] receive a tax credit or subsidy based on family income to help pay for the insurance? ▪ Yes ▪ No
n = 4

Findings:

Do they know what subsidies and tax credits are?

- One participant [P2518] noted that they did not know what tax credits or subsidies were.

No additional findings beyond those in Question 18b.

Recommendations:

See Question 18b. No further recommendations.

Question 27

Research Question: HIGH PRIORITY. This is a new question. This is a follow up with respondents who said they were uninsured for all of previous year. In combination with the next question, Q27a, it helps identify which household members had insurance.
Q27. Was anyone else in your household uninsured for all of 2023? ▪ Yes ▪ No
n = 3

Findings:

No additional findings beyond Question 15.

This question was generally well understood.

Recommendations:

No recommendations. This question was easily understood by participants.

Question 27a

Research Question: HIGH PRIORITY. This is a new question. This is a follow up with respondents who said they were uninsured for all of previous year. It asks for proxy reports of uninsurance by other household members and is followed by questions on insurance.

Q27a. Which other people in your household were uninsured for all of 2023? Mark all that apply.

Spouse	-
Child1	-
Child2	-
Child3	-
Other1	-
Other2	-

***n* = 1**

Findings:

No notable findings. This question was well understood.

Recommendations:

No recommendations. This question was easily understood by participants.

Question 28

Research Question: High priority. This is a new question that is a lot less wordy than the standard ACS laundry list. For the ISR mode, we would like this to be “expandable” for respondents who want additional information before answering.

Q28. What health insurance(s) did [^Person] have in 2023? Mark all that apply.

- Private health insurance
- Medicare
- Medicaid or other government program
- Veterans health care (enrolled for VA)
- TRICARE or other military health care
- Indian Health Service

The second and third options will be EXPANDABLE to:

Medicare – 2

- Medicare Part A (hospital care)
- Medicare Part B (outpatient care)
- Medicare Advantage

Medicaid or other government program – 3

- Medicaid
- [^CAIDNAME]
- Children’s Health Insurance Program
- Other government health program for people with low income or disability

Other:

[Write in]

***n* = 2**

Findings:

No additional findings beyond those in Question 2.

Recommendations:

See Question 2 recommendations. No additional recommendations.

Question 29

Research Question: HIGH PRIORITY. This is a completely new question restricted to the “Private health insurance” responses for Q2.

Q29. How did [^Person] get this private health insurance? Mark all that apply.

- Current job (theirs or another family member)
- Former job (theirs or another family member)
- Union or professional association
- Directly from an insurance company
- Broker
- State or Federal Marketplace
- Healthcare.gov
- [^State-Specific Portal Name]

n = 1

Findings:**Does the response “directly from an insurance company” make sense?**

- One participant [P2250] noted that their self-employed household member could fall under the categories of “directly from an insurance company” and “current job.”
 - “Oh, um, see that’s not clear because I’m thinking ‘current job’ could be if somebody’s self-employed. That, that would qualify under ‘current job’ ... not just because you work for someone else. I feel like that would also fall under that. But then, ‘directly from an insurance company’ is probably whether you work for someone else or not, you can buy your own. You choose to buy your own. So, I feel like she could fall under either one.” [P2250]

Does the overlap in “State or Federal Marketplace,” “Healthcare.gov,” and/or the state-specific portal name confuse people?

- One participant [P2250] noted that these looked like different names for the same program.
 - “They look like different names for the same thing. At least I know, where I live, I’ve seen, I’ve gone to the website of New York State of Health and so, they all kind of seem, to me, the same thing at least in New York. ... They also say that the ‘Federal or State Marketplace is like the New York State of Health is considered one of those.” [P2250]

What if someone hit “private” in Q2 by mistake?

No findings.

This proxy response brought up the question of self-employed respondents and whether they would qualify to select “current job” and “directly through an insurance company.” Otherwise, this participant was able to answer the question.

Recommendations:

See Question 2a recommendations. No further recommendations.

Question 30

Research Question: We need to know whether someone had any spells of uninsurance even if they are reported to have a type of coverage.
Q30. How long did [^Person] have [^insurance type] in 2023? ▪ All year ▪ Part of the year
<i>n</i> = 2

Findings:

No additional findings. This question was generally well understood.

Recommendations:

No recommendations. This question was easily understood by participants.

Question 31

Research Question: We need to know whether someone had any spells of uninsurance even if they are reported to have a type of coverage.
Q31. Was [Person] uninsured for part of 2023? ▪ Yes ▪ No
<i>n</i> = 1

Findings:

No additional findings. This question was generally well understood.

Recommendations:

No recommendations. This question was easily understood by participants.

Question 31a

Research Question: We need to know who in the household is the insurance policyholder. The concept of “policyholder” is tricky for respondents.

Q31a. Whose name was [Person in Q27a]’s [^health insurance type] policy in? (who was the policyholder?)

R’s name	-
Spouse	-
AdultChild1	-
AdultChild2	-
Other1	-
OtherOutsideHH	-

***n* = 2**

Findings:**Do they prefer “whose name is the policy in?” or “who is the policyholder?”**

- One participant [P2250] notes that they prefer the term “policyholder.”
 - “‘Who is the policyholder’ is more direct, I feel like it saves a lot more time.” [P2250]

No additional findings beyond Question 17.

Recommendations:

See Question 17 recommendations. No further recommendations.

Question 31b

Research Question: We need to know who whether the R’s employer contributes to the premium payment. “Premium” is a tricky word/concept.

Q31b. Did [Person in Q31a’s] employer or union help pay for the health insurance?

- Yes
- No

***n* = 2**

Findings:**Do people know we’re talking about their premiums?**

- One participant [P2250] mentioned costs related to health insurance, but not premiums explicitly.
 - “From when I used to have health insurance with a company that I was working for, it’s that, you know, they cover a lot but they don’t cover everything, so I feel like that’s what’s implied with this. ... You know, there’s copays for medications, there’s, it could be copay for a visit if you don’t have a personal wellness account, like that’s what they used to call it at my employer like HSA card or something that covers whatever they, the insurance doesn’t cover.” [P2250]

Are people able to answer this if they are not the policyholder?

- One participant [P2250] indicated that although their interpretation of the question was correct, the wording did not was not ideal for self-employed individuals.
 - “I’m going to say no because [household member] is self-employed, so, [household member] is, [household member] is [their] own employer but I feel like here they mean like a company like not a, not a person. ... So, I’m going to put ‘no’ here because [household member]’s not employed by anyone but [themselves], and I don’t believe this is what they mean here. I don’t believe ... they are implying self-employed.” [P2250]

This question was well understood, although the participant brought up the point that the language did not encompass self-employed individuals.

Recommendations:

No recommendations. This question was easily understood by participants.

Question 31c

Research Question: We need to know whether the R’s employer contributes to the premium payment. “Premium” is a tricky word/concept.
Q31c. Did [Person in Q31a’s] employer or union pay all or part of the cost of the insurance? ▪ All ▪ Part
n = 0

Findings:

No participants received this question.

Recommendations:

No recommendations at this time.

Question 31d

Research Question: We need to know whether the R received a subsidy or tax credit to reduce the cost of insurance.
Q31d. Did [Person in Q31a] receive a tax credit or subsidy based on family income to help pay for the insurance? ▪ Yes ▪ No
n = 2

Findings:**Do they know what subsidies and tax credits are?**

- One participant [P2250] described government help paying for health insurance based on an individual's income bracket but was unsure of the exact definition of a subsidy.
 - "Like some type of help from the government. Given where she falls in her income bracket to pay for her health insurance. ... Like when she's doing her taxes. You know, like if anything comes up when she's filing her taxes. If there's a little break for her at the end of the year, filing year." [P2250]

There were no additional findings beyond those in Question 18b.

Recommendation:

See Question 18b recommendations. No further recommendations.

5.2 Maximum Out of Pocket (MOOP) Questions*Question 32*

Research Question: This question is trying to get information on how much people are paying for their health insurance.

Q32. In 2023, how much did you pay for all health insurance premiums covering yourself or others in the household?

Include comprehensive plans and supplemental plans such as vision and dental insurance. Do not include any Medicare deductions from Social Security, Social Security Disability/ Social Security and Social Security Disability.

\$ _____

***n* = 24**

Findings:**Response distribution:**

- Ten of the 19 participants answered \$0 and nine provided a non-zero amount.
- Five participants received the question but provided no answer. Two of them [P2265 and P2279] did not know the amount as they are covered under their parents' insurance and parents live elsewhere. Two said they would have to check paperwork to answer [P2640 and P2905]. The fifth thought the question asked for annual payment and they only knew monthly. [P2260]

Where did participants stop reading the question?

- Most participants (n=18) appeared or confirmed to have read everything.
- One participant only scanned the instructions. [P2279]
- Five participants that stopped before reading the question and instructions in full stopped at varied places:
 - Two read up to "premiums" [P2265 and P2268]
 - One read up to "household" [P2589]

- One read up to “Medicare” [P2260]
- One read up to “yourself or others” but claimed they read the instructions [P2344]

Do the answers provided follow the instructions?

- About half of those who answered this question (n=13) provided an answer that followed the instructions.
 - NOTE: Judging from the second probe after this one, the intent of the question appears to be to collect the monthly premium amounts. However, the question does not say so, nor does it record the time period for the amount provided. One participant explicitly provided the annual amount [P2743]. Another participant provided a biweekly amount [P2256]. These two answers can be considered incorrect, but the participants had no clear instructions to follow regarding the time frame.
- Five other participants did not follow the instructions in different ways.
 - One participant [P2268] who answered \$0 (has Medicaid) thought they were being asked about out-of-pocket expenses, of which they had none.
 - Another participant [P2507] also thought it included any out-of-pocket expenses such as prescription medicines, but returned later to the question and corrected their answer after seeing Q33.
 - Another participant [P2260] answered correctly but did not interpret the instructions as intended. They thought they were being asked to include their roommate’s premiums and to provide a total household figure.
 - A participant [P2446] was thinking of hospital visits in addition to premiums.
 - The fifth participant [P2684] reported their out-of-pocket expenses and not their premiums.

Did the participants understand the instructions?

- Of the 19 participants that answered Q32, one who had answered Don’t know (parents outside of household paid for her HI) was not asked this probe. [P2265]
- Most participants (n=16) appeared to understand the instructions, including one person [P2344] who felt most other persons would not understand terms such as “comprehensive plans.”
- Two participants [P2446 and P2260] did not appear to understand the instructions, with one thinking of hospital visits in addition to premiums, and another misunderstanding the instructions and thinking they may need to include roommate’s HI expenses in this figure as well, respectively.
- Two participants were confused about the phrasing “covering yourself or others in the household.” They were not sure if the question was about themselves alone, themselves paying for everyone’s coverage, or for everyone covered under their plan. One [P2260] wondered if they should also include their roommate’s premium. Another said, “Is this for me, I paid for my insurance with my employer. Or is this for my household?” [P2589]
- Other participants were not sure if the reporting period for the premium total was month or year. ([P2254]: “For this total are they meaning from year to year for the total amount that I paid or from month to month?”) [P2344] did not know if this question meant for her to respond based on an annual or yearly figure.

Because she had two different plans during the year she also found it difficult to report the amount because the premium amounts were different.

What would make it easier for participants to know that we are looking for how much you pay monthly to have coverage?

- Only two participants answered mentioning specifically that they were giving the monthly amount [P2254 and P2975]. Otherwise, participants gave amounts without stating the periodicity.
 - Note: We would recommend mentioning in the question that you are asking for the monthly premium.

If they have employer sponsored insurance, is the value provided before or after any contribution from their employer?

- Of 13 participants that answered Q18 (Did employer or union help pay for the health insurance?) only 4 received this probe with 7 accidentally skipped. Two others were not probed because they did not know anything about the employer-paid insurance someone else covers them under.
- One participant [P2256] provided the portion that comes out of her boyfriend's paycheck, i.e. after employer contribution.
- Three other participants [P2344, P2589, P2718] reported the amount after employer contribution.

If someone responds zero, was it actually zero or was there a specific reason why they said zero?

- Of the 10 participants answering \$0, almost all (n=9) were covered under Medicaid
- The remaining participant explained that they did not have to pay anything for their 2023 health coverage because they were living in the U.K. where health care is free via the National Health Service.

Recommendations:

We recommend specifying in the question if the intent is to collect the total amount paid in the year for premiums for all in the household, not just the monthly premiums. Also to clarify if the question wants to collect only the amount paid by the respondent alone for all in the household, and whether it should include roommates.

Question 33

Research Question: This is just to induce someone to give a response if they didn't know previously.

Q33. If you don't know the exact amount, please estimate. In 2023, how much did you pay for all health insurance premiums covering yourself or others in the household?

- \$0 to \$999 – 1
- \$1,000 to \$2,999 – 2
- \$3,000 and above – 3

n = 3

Findings

Providing an answer

- Three participants received Q33 and selected a range.
- Two others who had not provided an answer to Q32 but had entered a textual response (P2279: "I'm not sure"; P2265: "Not sure – Paid by parent"), were not routed to Q33.

Did participants keep in mind from the previous question what to include and not include when answering?

- Two of the participants would have liked to see the instruction here again, "to avoid overlooking something" [P2260], "...I think it'd be helpful to list them again." [P2905]
- There was no evidence, however, of their forgetting what to include/exclude. The third one was clear in that they were not forgetting the instructions: "Yes, I included my husband's health insurance premium and dental. We didn't have any vision or hearing." [P2640]

Did participants have any trouble with the ranges?

- The ranges themselves created no difficulties.

How did participants arrive at their answer?

- The participants multiplied the amount they pay biweekly or monthly to get to an annual figure.
 - One simply took out a calculator to figure the response. [P2640]
 - One multiplied and selected an annual range consistent with the monthly amount they had mentioned. [P2260]
 - The third one had difficulty doing the math from biweekly to annual and appeared to get the numbers wrong. [P2905]

Recommendation:

We recommend changing the routing of participants who give a textual response in Q32, so they get asked Q33 rather than skipped out.

Question 34

Research Question: NA
Q34. Choose the range that represents how much you paid for health insurance premiums in 2023. ▪ \$0 to \$199 ▪ \$100 and \$499 ▪ \$500 to \$999
n = 0

Findings:

None of the 30 participants received this question.

Recommendations:

No recommendations at this time.

Question 35

Research Question: This question is trying to get information on larger non-premium expenditures. The type of expenditure is really not all that important; just that we are getting these types of items.

Q35. In 2023, how much was paid out-of-pocket for your own medical care?

Include:

- copays for doctor and dentist visits
- diagnostic tests
- prescription medicine
- glasses and contacts
- and medical supplies

Include any amount paid out-of-pocket on your behalf by anyone in this household.

\$ _____

n = 30

Findings:

Providing a response

- Participants answered by giving a global estimate or by building up to a number adding specific expenses as they mentioned them.
 - Three participants did not give an answer.
 - One of them who had received Q33 earlier, immediately asked for range options. [P2640]
 - Another answered “Not sure” [P2279]
 - The third one left it blank [P2260]

Did participants read the entire question?

- Most participants (n=23) read the entire question and instructions.
- The 7 who stopped before reading it entirely stopped in different places:
 - Two read up to “prescription medicine” [P2265] [P2975]
 - One read up to “out of pocket” [P2684]
 - One read up to “glasses and contacts” [P2268]
 - One read up to “diagnostics” [P2250]
 - One read entire question but skimmed the instructions [P2904]
 - One skipped over the “include” items [P2260]

Did participants find the categories of what to include confusing?

- Twenty nine participants were probed on this
- A majority of participants (n=17) found nothing confusing in the “include” categories

- One participant was overwhelmed by seeing so many categories and only included prescriptions [P2344]
- The rest wondered what “medical supplies” includes, and in particular wondered if it includes over-the-counter medicines.
 - “Medical supplies, what does that include? Is that when I went to the doctor and they gave me a sling and I had to pay for the sling? Or is when I go buy Tylenol because I take Tylenol almost every day...” [P2589]
 - “... if I had to purchase a walker, a cane, something that our prescription coverage wouldn’t cover like for instance. I had to use some special medicated soap I had some surgery. That was out of pocket. I don’t know maybe it even includes things like Tylenol.” [P2640]
 - “...if I am buying things, from like CVS, like Advil or Band-Aids, I’m not typically including that in my medical expenses budget. That is kind of more like a household item I guess. When I’m thinking about my medical care I’m thinking more about my copays, if I had a surgery, or if I was seeing a therapist for a while, things like that.” [P2718]
 - “Do I count all the money I spent on weed so I could get a good night sleep and function well at work the next day. Where is the line of what is medical supplies and what is not?” [P2589]
- A couple of participants wondered what is covered under “diagnostic tests”.
 - “...also like diagnostic tests, do they mean like an MRI or like a lab test?” [P2256]
 - “I would think the diagnostic test I would say would be like an x-ray or MRI. So, is that what that means?” [P2640]

Did the ‘on behalf’ instruction matter or was ignored? Was it taken into consideration when responding?

- 28 participants were probed on this and 17 participants understood the instruction as intended:
 - “‘On your behalf’ is helpful because it’s appointments and supplies that you needed but someone else could pay for.” [P2265]
 - “Did anybody else pay anything that I couldn’t cover. Or did anybody else in the household or my family or daughter or mother, did they help me.” [P2263]
- Even among those who understood it well, it did not always matter for their response because of their household composition:
 - A participant [P2904] understood the instructions but, in his case, there is no one who would pay his medical expenses.
 - Another participant lived alone so this was not relevant. [P2707]
- 2 participants mentioned keeping track of expenses through their HSA or FSA card but that could work in opposite ways for keeping track of something paid on their behalf:
 - For one participant if someone else paid for something for them they would not keep track of it because it would not show up in their HSA card [P2684]
 - For the other it would be the opposite: “We use the, the FSA card all the time so I think if I logged into there I would probably get the amount pretty easily.

And since everybody has the same, or is paid with the same card, it would all be in one spot.” [P2743]

- For five participants, the meaning of “on behalf” was not clear or incorrect. While one of them [P2518] simply could not explain what the instruction meant, the others had unusual interpretations:
 - “Originally I was just thinking, besides myself and I was thinking about others in the household. But now that I’m looking at it, it is confusing because I was thinking, I wasn’t thinking about an outside. Is that what they meant by outside? Anybody else ... that could be confusing, because I know I was.” [P2647]
 - Another participant [P2260] was not sure if it meant she was paying for others in HH or if they were paying for her. After rereading multiple times they said the wording was confusing.
 - A participant took this to mean as another way of saying out of pocket for herself. [P2446]
 - The fifth participant had a hard time understanding this probe. When probed about the meaning, this person mentioned they had no copays. [P2367]
- Finally, one participant [P2684] found the instruction as contradicting what was stated earlier. They said that the first sentence asks about how much the participant paid out of pocket while the last sentence asks if others are paying.

Would participants’ answer be the same if the question was simplified to “How much was paid out of pocket for your medical care? Include copays, prescription medicine, etc.”?

- Nine participants felt their answer would be the same with the simplified wording.
 - However, one of them felt that others may forget expenses if not provided the list, particularly if they have a lot of testing or need lots of medical care, they could have a harder time recalling all the types of expenses with the simplified version of the question. [P2718]
 - Another one recommended starting with the inclusions before asking the question itself. “I think it’s better if you put the question on the bottom versus the top. Because once you answer, answer the question, I just want to answer it. And I ignore everything else. But if you put ‘including de-de-de-de-de-de-de-de, including the amount..., how much was paid out of pocket?’ that’s clearer. But you put it first, I ignore everything else.” [P2975]
- Eight participants preferred the current wording as they thought the simplified version may make them forget to include something.
 - One of them felt that the alternate wording runs the risk of people thinking the examples are instead an exhaustive list: “Maybe if you add “all expenses” too or something. Maybe people could interpret include co-pay just only specifically for that and they’ll just write them out just for that. So maybe if you add some kind of wording that includes all expenses, not just only that. But those are just examples.” [P2904]

What additional or other wording would help participants recall small medical spending?

- Eight participants felt no other wording was needed

- Among those Participants receiving this probe did not necessarily focus on 'small' medical spending but on items they may otherwise forget.
 - Two mentioned mental health services [P2718 and P2250]
 - Two others mentioned adding 'over-the-counter medications' [P2273 and P2256]
 - Two more suggested adding medical equipment such as "blood pressure cuffs or waistbands for pregnancy" [P2428] and "braces, boots, etc." [P2518]
 - Two thought a global reference such as "include all expenses" [P2904] or "additional expenses" [P2647]
 - One participant who uses cannabis for pain management suggested adding a reference to include this as well. [P2589]

Did participants answering \$0 to this question verify they had no expenses and did they consider something to report but decide against it?

- One participant initially reported \$0 but during probing they realized they had missed a co-pay and changed their answer to \$20. [P2250]
- 6 other participants had answered \$0 as follows:
 - One simply confirmed no OOP expenses. [P2941]
 - Two considered an expense but decided not to include it:
 - A participant began to consider prescriptions but then remembered the question was asking about 2023 so they said they had nothing to report because they had not had any OOP expenses in that year. [P2273]
 - A participant considered a dentist payment made on their behalf but decided against it, although the reasons were not probed. [P2633]
 - One participant does not pay OOP because of Medicaid coverage: "So yeah, I'll put zero because when you have Husky you don't know how much you're getting charged...The state covers the cost. " [P2428]
 - Two others had no medical expenses at all in the year of reference:
 - "I have not had anything. I have not been to the doctor or the dentist...and I need to get my eyes checked. I don't know how much that would cost, but I plan on paying OOP since Medicaid is just for my health but I haven't had to pay for anything." [P2518]
 - "Because I never have paid anything like I never, never paid for nothing, for no medical, no glasses, nothing like that. [PROBE: No prescription medicines?] Nothing, nothing. No, not at all like if I have a headache or whatever I get Tylenol and stuff but like, I never had a main... a main injury of work or anything to end up in the hospital or not even in the house. I never caught COVID since the first day in the United States. I never caught that. Um, what else? I mean, I haven't, I haven't at all. I haven't been to the doctor at all. It's been years." [P2942]

Recommendations:

The version of this question as tested did not raise issues for being too long or having too much detail and several participants appreciated the include categories. The major confusion was with "medical supplies" as it was too vague a term for participants. However, since this question seemed to pick up expenses some respondents would have given later in

Q.38 and there was little overlap between the two with minimal double reporting, we recommend keeping as is.

Question 36

Research Question: This question is trying to get information on larger non-premium expenditures. The type of expenditure is really not all that important; just that we are getting these types of items.

Q36. If you don't know the exact amount, please estimate.

In 2023, how much was paid out-of-pocket for [^your OWN/Person from Q20's/Person from Q23's/Person from Q28's] medical care, not including premiums?

Include:

- copays for doctor and dentist visits
- diagnostic tests
- prescription medicine
- glasses and contacts
- and medical supplies

Include any amount paid out-of-pocket on [your/Person from Q20's/Person from Q23's/Person from Q28's] behalf by anyone in this household.

n = 2

Findings:

Providing a response

- Three participants should have been asked this question, as they provided no answer to Q35. However, one of them [P2279] who provided a textual answer in Q35 was not shown this screen, while the two others who had left Q35 blank were routed to this screen.
- Both participants selected a range without raising any issues. [P2260 and P2640]

Where did participants stop reading the question?

- One participant [P2260] read the question in full.
- For the other participant [P2640] there was no probe or observation.

How did you participants feel being asked this question?

- Only one participant [P2260] was asked this probe and said they felt overwhelmed and a little confused because there were no examples. The participant liked that there were ranges and felt selecting the middle range was the safest choice.

Are the categories of what to include confusing?

- The participant who was asked this said that they would have liked to see more examples for each of the categories. [P2260]
- Does the "on behalf of" instruction matter? Did the participants ignore this? (if not) Did they factor it into their answer?
- Neither of the two participants was asked this probe.

Would participants answer the same if the question was simplified to “How much was paid out of pocket for your medical care? Include copays, prescription medicine, etc.”.

- Neither of the two participants was asked this probe.
- What additional or other wording would help participants recall small medical spending?
- The one participant who was asked this would have liked to see examples for categories, in particular for “medical supplies.”

Recommendations:

No recommendations at this time.

Question 37

Research Question: To obtain a range from Rs who can't report an exact value.
Q37. Choose the range that represents how much [^you/Person from Q20/Person from Q23/Person from Q28] paid for [^your own/their] medical care not including premiums in 2023.
<i>n = 0</i>

Findings:

No one was administered this question.

Question 38

Research Question: We have recently learned that this question is meant to capture small medical expenses. therefore, this question is trying to prompt people to remember those trips to CVS where they were picking small things up
Q38. In 2023, how much was paid out-of-pocket for [^your/ Person from Q20's/Person from Q23's/Person from Q28's] non-prescription healthcare products? Include spending on items like vitamins, allergy and cold medicine, and anything else not yet reported.
<i>n = 30</i>

Findings:

Providing a response

- All but three participants provided an amount.
 - One of the three was the participant that saw ranges after not answering Q32 and asked for them at Q35 and here.
 - The other two participants who did not venture a figure, saying they just could not figure an amount:
 - A participant read through the three examples offered, felt overwhelmed, and said they did not know. [P2344]
 - “If I was going to guess I would say \$50 but I have no clue.” [P2718]

How did participants arrive at their answer?

- Participants followed different strategies to come up with a number to report. Some simply gave a global amount for the year as a guesstimate.
 - In one case, the interviewer noted that the participant considered the year and thought about smaller medical expenses, then gave a global amount. [P2254]
 - Another participant recalled that they use a lot of vitamins, also have bought cold medicine and Tylenol, pink eye medicine, ointments. They were not sure they could remember all the things they has bought, but guessed the amount would be about \$400-\$500. [P2367]
 - “Wow I can give you a, a, an estimate, like a rough estimate... I would say at least, on non-prescription healthcare products, is that like Mucinex, Advil, or just like over the counter products?... Oh, I would say at least two hundred and fifty to three hundred dollars... I would say, I would round it off in the, I would say like two hundred and eighty dollars.” [P2633]
- Other participants tried to itemize their expenses on-the-fly
 - “Okay what vitamins did I get. I’m always stocking up on cold medicine. How often was I sick—how often was somebody else in my household sick that I was buying for. I don’t even know how to answer this because it’s hard to remember, how much did I even pay for cold medicine. This is hard.” [P2344]
 - “Because I take vitamins, multivitamins for women, and I have cold medicine. You know, like the Alka-Seltzer Plus you know, anything with cold cough, Robitussin. And that I pay out of pocket, over the counter, mostly over the counter medication and vitamins, I pay myself out of pocket.” [P2647]

Did the examples in this question help participants think about smaller medical expenses?

- For some participants, the examples were definitely helpful, and allergy and cold medicine seemed particularly helpful to jog participants’ memories.
 - “Yeah it did. Maybe the word ‘over the counter’ would help some people, I don’t know. I kind of assumed that, I guess.” [P2507]
 - “...anything that I would need that I didn’t have to go to a doctor for...something I could get at the store.” [P2254]
 - “So yeah, definitely having like vitamins, allergy, cold medicines are little things that you know you may just go get once in a while or, you know, run to Walgreens and grab. Definitely having that, you know, makes you think about all the money you spend on it.” [P2743]
- In fact, some participants may only have been thinking of the specific examples provided.
 - For instance, one participant calculated strictly allergy, vitamin costs, and cold medicine costs and relied on the examples given and did not think of anything else. [P2782]
 - “Because the specific examples is making me think only include those. So, you have to read it very carefully. And if you don’t read it carefully, people might interpret it as, they’ll just write them out just for vitamins, allergies, and cold medicine. And if those don’t apply, they might write a zero...” [P2904] This participant suggested adding the phrase “all expenses”.

- In another case, an interviewer observed: "The participant calculated strictly allergy, vitamin costs, and cold medicine costs and relied on the examples given and did not think of anything else." [P2782]
- For some participants, however, there were still questions about expenses they were unsure should be reported here:
 - "...I'm not sure if like contact lens care products would be considered medical or not." [P2273]
 - The examples did help but also made a participant wonder if this includes menstrual products or toothpaste or anything that is related to taking care of your health: "It made me think about money that I would only spend on pills, liquid medicines that I would buy at the pharmacy, that are over the counter." [P2279]
 - "With this type of wording...nonprescription healthcare products can be so many different things, but what if you broke your leg? Aren't technically you're prescribed crutches?...More specific detailed examples that will help give the interviewer the best insight...bandages are no Rx, topical creams are non Rx, is my contact solution considered non-Rx even though my contacts are Rx? You know what? As silly as this sounds, what about my tampons and pads? Those are non-Rx but those are a healthcare product." [P2446]

Additional possible response error detected

- One participant thought the question was asking about non-medical expenses and provided her annual food expenses of \$25,000. "That's all my food. I'm curious if you're focusing on things like that." [P2268]
- Another participant thought the question meant to include the entire household. They realized their misinterpretation when they had to answer the same question for another household member in Q35_notR. [P2279]
- Another participant noticed this is the question where they should have included Tylenol and cannabis expenses, rather than in the medical supplies category in the previous question. [P2589]

Were some of these expenses already reported in the previous questions?

- Twenty-four participants answered this probe, and among them most did not report duplicate expenses, that is, expenses they had previously reported under Q35. They had clear in their mind that the questions were asking about different types of expenses.
 - "No, none other. Because I consider those two things very different." [P2250]
 - "If I'm being honest some of them aren't, because I didn't think of them. I was thinking more doctors' appointments, medicines, like provider based rather than personal health." [P2684]
- Two participants likely included in this response amounts they had reported previously in Q35:
 - One participant said if she had seen this question before, she would not have reported her "random medical supplies" in Q35. [P2718]
 - Another participant who had reported taking Vitamin D in Q35 she reported vitamins again in Q38, which they may have double reported. [P2782]

Recommendations:

We recommend highlighting the term “non-prescription healthcare products.” In addition, asking annual costs for what could be a long time before the question is asked may run into more memory issues. Consider testing asking for the past 12 months. Since previous questions asked about the household and this one does not, it may be useful mentioning in an introduction.

Question 39

Research Question: Aim is to induce DK responses to provide an answer.
Q39. If you don't know the exact amount, please estimate. How much was paid out-of-pocket for [your/ Person's] non-prescription healthcare products.
n = 3

Findings:

- Three participants were asked this question, as they had not provided an answer to Q38.
- All three were able to select a range, and all selected the lowest range.

The instructions don't appear again. Did you follow what to include when answering?

- All three participants said they did remember and follow the instructions.
 - One participant said she did remember the other examples in the previous question but thought it would have been helpful to restate them. [P2344]
 - Another participant summarized it: “Well, non---medical expenses that aren't covered by prescription anything that we couldn't give our medical card for payment.” [P2640]
 - The third participant indicated they were thinking about the previous question categories. [P2718]

How did you arrive at an answer for this question?

- Two of the participants were probed on this.
 - “Well thinking back over the year. My husband had to purchase... he had hernia surgery so he had some out of pocket expenses at the pharmacy or stuff that the surgeon and doctor say he needed which were not covered. Same with me, I had hip replacement surgery back in August, I had to buy a special cleansing soap. It was pretty expensive. It was 25 dollars for a little bottle. I couldn't pay for it with my insurance. I'm thinking of he goes through cold medicine kind of a lot and allergy medicine and that's kind of an all-year expense. Like every couple of months maybe month or month and a half he'll ask me to get some.” The interviewer probed about the timeframe the participant was considering and it turned out they were talking about 2024.” [P2640]

- The other participant simply felt that the lowest range they selected is a large range and they could not imagine spending more than \$999 in those expenses. [P2718]

Were some of these expenses already reported in the previous questions?

- The interviewer noted for P2640 that the medicated soap they included in Q39 had already been included in the answer to Q35.

Recommendations:

No recommendations at this time.

Question 40

Research Question: Aim is to get more precise answer for those in lowest range in q39.
Q40. Choose the range that represents how much [^you/Person from Q20/Person from Q23/Person from Q28] paid for other medical spending in 2023.
n = 3

Findings:

Did participants understand that this question is to further refine their response?

Did they find it annoying? Difficult to answer?

- Three participants received this question and two answered it:
 - One participant had no idea what “other medical spending” means, because it seemed like it was asking about something completely different than Q39. This person thought the wording needed to be the same so they could understand this question is referring to the previous one. [P2344]
 - Another participant reacted initially by saying they did not know what they meant by other medical expenses. It was not clear to them that question was asking about the same things as in Q39 but trying to narrow the range. “Well, I--we’ve already covered the last several questions back, the different categories of medical spending: insured, uninsured, covered by prescription, not covered and out of pocket. Is this a brand-new question? Is this a new category or is it just recapping?” They selected a range one the interviewer explained this was meant to refine their answer. [P2640]
- The third participant left the question unanswered.
 - “I am not sure what other spending is. With having all the other things we already covered like health insurance, medical expenses, smaller medical expenses, now I don’t know what medical spending is.” The participant could not think of anything else she spent money on related to medical care. She indicated that this question felt like a separate question from the one that she answered right before. She mentioned that each of the questions about health insurance, copays, smaller medical expenses felt that they are asking for a different type of expenses and not a drill down from Q38 as this one. [P2718]

Recommendations:

No recommendations at this time.

5.3 Migration Questions

Question 1A

Research Question: Are respondents correctly reporting based on the moving question reference period – meaning whether they were living at this residence exactly one year ago - rather than going by the current calendar year or misunderstanding the reference period in some other way? How much clarification do we need within the question itself, and what information (if anything) would be best-suited to “help text” (e.g., hover-over information box)?

Q1A. Were you living at [Current Address- just street add.] one year ago, on September 1, 2023?

- Yes
- No

n = 30

Findings:

How many respondents reported difficulty with this question? If any, why?

- One participant [P2904] reported that the question was difficult to answer. This participant did not enter their address in the beginning of the survey, so the question wording did not make sense.
 - “Yeah, so if you didn't explain it to me, this question would have thrown me off. So, this question wouldn't make sense. So, if you didn't explain it to me.” [P2904]
- Some participants (n=9) noted that the question was not difficult to answer because they had lived at the reported address for several years. Many of these participants did not consider the reference period when answering the question.
- One participant [P2268] entered their permanent mailing address but mentioned that they were unsure if they were physically living at the address a year ago as they had been residing in a vehicle for the past year.
- One participant [P2279] clarified that they were reporting based on the address of their family’s home despite her residing in a college dorm for roughly half of the year.

How many misunderstood the reference period?

- Two participants [P2344, P2446] found the reference period slightly confusing because the question asked specifically about September 1st, 2023, but they were interviewed in October, 2024.
 - “I mentally put myself where was I a year ago. It’s October right now [and it’s asking about September] ...I very much tried to gear it towards the date more than where was I ‘last year.’” [P2446]

If they misunderstood the reference period, what did they think it was referring to, and how could it be made clearer to them?

- Three participants [P2279, P2782, P2904] recalled the month and year that they had moved, but not the specific date.
 - P2904 noted that the exact date was unnecessary and too specific. This participant would have preferred the month and year as the reference period.

- One participant [P2975] interpreted thought having both “one year ago” and the specific date in the question was confusing. They may have preferred to see just one or the other.
 - “[I considered] Both, which confused me so, so, ‘were you living at this address one year ago?’ I’m like, ‘yes.’ Then it says, ‘on September first 2023,’ then I have to think a second time. Like was that [one] year ago? Yes.” [P2975]

Is anything desired in a separate help text section?

- No findings.
- This question was understood by most participants, although there were some who were confused about the reference period. Interviews occurred from September through October 2024, so most of the confusion stemmed from the mismatch of the specified date (September 1st, 2023) and “one year ago” language. Many participants had been residents at their reported addresses for well over one year, so they disregarded the specified date and only paid attention to the “one year ago” text. Some participants also noted that the month and year would be enough for the reference period.

Recommendations:

See Question 1B recommendations.

Question 2A

Research Question: N/A (Here, we establish if the respondent’s prior residence was in the United States. For respondents who lived in the U.S., we ask follow-up questions on their state and county of residence.)

Q2A. Were you living in the United States (within the 50 states and the District of Columbia) one year ago, on September 1, 2023?

- Yes
- No

***n* = 3**

Findings:

Did the definition of United States make sense?

- One participant [P2538] was unclear about what the District of Columbia referred to but otherwise thought that the definition was fine.
- Two participants [P2782, P2905] thought that the definition was missing US territories.
 - “Yeah, that’s how I’d [*sic*]. Puerto Rico is part of, is a, it’s a part of the United States so I guess that would be the only other, the only thing I’d think is technically missing here.”
- The participants were able to answer the question, although there was some confusion about what the “District of Columbia” referred to. A couple of participants also noted that US territories were missing from the definition.

Recommendations:

See Question 2B recommendations.

Question 3A

Research Question: N/A (Here, we establish if the respondent's prior residence was in the United States. For respondents who lived in the U.S., we ask follow-up questions on their state and county of residence.)

Q3A. What state did you live in one year ago, on September 1, 2023?

- | | | |
|------------------------|------------------|------------------|
| ▪ Alabama | ▪ Kentucky | ▪ North Dakota |
| ▪ Alaska | ▪ Louisiana | ▪ Ohio |
| ▪ Arizona | ▪ Maine | ▪ Oklahoma |
| ▪ Arkansas | ▪ Maryland | ▪ Oregon |
| ▪ California | ▪ Massachusetts | ▪ Pennsylvania |
| ▪ Colorado | ▪ Michigan | ▪ Rhode Island |
| ▪ Connecticut | ▪ Minnesota | ▪ South Carolina |
| ▪ Delaware | ▪ Mississippi | ▪ South Dakota |
| ▪ District of Columbia | ▪ Missouri | ▪ Tennessee |
| ▪ Florida | ▪ Montana | ▪ Texas |
| ▪ Georgia | ▪ Nebraska | ▪ Utah |
| ▪ Hawaii | ▪ Nevada | ▪ Vermont |
| ▪ Idaho | ▪ New Hampshire | ▪ Virginia |
| ▪ Illinois | ▪ New Jersey | ▪ Washington |
| ▪ Indiana | ▪ New Mexico | ▪ West Virginia |
| ▪ Iowa | ▪ New York | ▪ Wisconsin |
| ▪ Kansas | ▪ North Carolina | ▪ Wyoming |

***n* = 2**

Findings:

Participants did not seem to struggle with this question and were able to select the state from the dropdown menu.

Recommendations:

No recommendations. This question was easily understood by participants.

Question 4A

Research Question: Here, we are trying to identify respondents' ability to recall and accurately report their county of residence 1 year ago. Our intention here is to have branching logic so that only the counties within the state reported in the prior question are listed. The companion file "MIGCOU County List" lists all county options for each non-DC state option.

Q4A. What county in [State] did you live in one year ago, on September 1, 2023?

[Refer to "MIGCOU County List" (accompanying spreadsheet)]

Response selection format: Searchable dropdown list

***n* = 2**

Findings:

Do respondents know what county they lived in one year ago?

- Both participants [P2782, P2905] noted that they did not have difficulty recalling which county they lived in one year ago.
 - P2782 noted that both city and county were equally easy to recall.
 - P2905 did not have an issue remembering the county they lived in one year ago but said that reporting the city was easier.

How confident are they in their response?

- Both participants [P2782, P2905] seemed confident in their response.

Could any changes to the question improve their understanding of it?

- No findings.

Did the provided list make it easier to report the county that the respondent lived in last year?

- One participant [P2782] noted that the county they reside in is occasionally omitted from lists, as was the case in this dropdown list. This participant selected a nearby county instead and felt that the answer sufficed.
- This question was easy for participants to answer. They recalled the county they lived in and did not struggle to use the dropdown list to select their response.

Recommendations:

No recommendations. This question was easily understood by participants.

Question 5A

Research Question: If respondents are unable to recall and accurately report the county that they lived in one year ago, we intend to ask a follow-up question to see if they remember their city or town one year ago. In cognitive testing, our goal is to assess respondents' ability to accurately recall and report this information. Alongside this, we are curious if respondents have an easier time recalling the city/town as opposed to the county that they lived in one year ago.

Q5A. What city or town in [State] did you live in one year ago, on September 1, 2023?

[Respondent self-reports via write-in.]

Response selection format: Fill-in response

***n* = 2**

Findings:

Are respondents able and willing to report the city or town they lived in one year ago? If not, why?

- Both participants [P2782, P2905] were able and willing to report the city or town they lived in one year ago.

Did they find this question clear? Straightforward?

- Both participants [P2782, P2905] seemed to find the question clear and straightforward.

Would a searchable dropdown list of city/town names (i.e., places) have made it easier to answer?

- No findings, but P2782 and P2905 did not seem to have an issue with the text input.
- This question was understood and easy to answer for participants. They recalled the city or town they lived in and did not express discomfort in reporting the information. They did not seem to struggle with the textbox to enter their responses.

Recommendations:

- No recommendations. This question was easily understood by participants.

Question 6A

Research Question: Because this question is changing in meaningful (and, we hope, meaningfully improved) ways, we have several questions on which cognitive testing could shed light.

- We want to confirm that these categories are clearly articulated (i.e., respondents understand what sorts of reasons fall under each category), mutually exclusive (i.e., any one reason fits into at most one category), and sufficiently complete (i.e., all or almost all reasons fit into an existing, non-Other category).
- Ideally, respondents will be able to identify a main reason for move from the provided categories as easily as possible; to this end, we want to probe about question difficulty and ask if respondents can identify any changes that would make the question easier to answer.
- About how long are respondents taking to determine their response? (If relatively long, they question may be more burdensome than we intended.)
- The examples associated with each category are meant to facilitate the identification of the appropriate category for main reason for move. We want to assess whether they are serving this purpose, as well as if any additional examples are warranted.
- We also want to confirm that the Other category is not used when the respondent's specific reason for move in fact could fall under an existing non-Other category; if this happens, we seek insights into why the relevant non-Other category was not selected, with an eye to clarifying the relevant category or categories.

Q6A. What was the main reason for your most recent move, to [current street address]?

[Displayed information when folded:]

1. Family
2. Nonfamily relationship
3. Work
4. Education or training
5. Housing or neighborhood hardship
6. Better-suited housing or neighborhood
7. Health
8. Natural disaster
9. Better-suited climate or region
10. Legal or institutional

11. Other

12. Not my decision

[Displayed information when unfolded:]

- Family
 - Examples: birth of a child; to help parent; divorced; death in family
- Nonfamily relationship
 - Examples: to be with unmarried partner; wanted to live with friend; conflict with roommate
- Work
 - Examples: shorter commute; starting new job; unemployed; armed forces; retired
- Education or training
 - Examples: college; trade school; unpaid internship; desirable public school district
- Housing or neighborhood hardship
 - Examples: unaffordable housing costs; foreclosure; eviction; landlord negligence – such as refusal to provide repairs, pest or mold control, or heating; neighborhood safety concerns; homelessness
- Better-suited housing or neighborhood
 - Examples: found less expensive housing; desirable neighborhood; wanted to own home; down-sized; amenities such as garage, pool, or yard
- Health
 - Examples: needed home without stairs; aging; injury; illness; assisted living; exited rehabilitation
- Natural disaster
 - Examples: hurricane or tornado damage; flooding; wildfire risk
- Better-suited climate or region
 - Examples: less cold or rainy; wanted to live in a city; wanted to live in the Southwest; closer to the mountains
- Legal or institutional
 - Examples: re-entry from prison; foster care; requirements of parole; probation ended
- Other
 - Any reason that does not fit into one of the categories above
- Not my decision
 - Someone else made the decision to move for me/the household

***n* = 3**

Findings:

How many respondents reported difficulty with this question?

- One participant [P2518] reported difficulty with this question. Before their most recent move, the participant was living in temporary housing while waiting for transfer from the United Kingdom to their current address. They ultimately chose “Other” for their main reason to move.

How many respondents found the examples useful in guiding their selection?

- Two participants [P2538, P2905] found the examples helpful.

- P2538 noted that the examples in “Housing or neighborhood hardship” were helpful in guiding their selection because it described their exact reason for moving.
- P2905 reviewed the examples after entering their response, but retrospectively noted that the descriptions aligned with their personal reasoning for the move.

How many respondents, if any, had difficulty understanding the categories? If any, which categories did they find difficult to understand, and why?

- No findings.

How many respondents selected Other? If any, what their reason for their move was, and whether this reason could ostensibly fall under any of the existing categories.

- Two participants [P2538, P2905] selected “Other” as their main reason for their move.
 - P2538 mentioned that a motivating factor for their move was their spouse’s work but chose “Other” because their previous housing situation was temporary lodging.
 - P2905 chose “Other” and cited the cost of their previous neighborhood as too high. After they made their selection, the interviewer prompted them to click on other categories, at which point the participant noted “housing or neighborhood hardship” or “better-suited housing” may have been a better fit for their reason.

How many respondents reported feeling overwhelmed by the amount of text on the page? Are there any improvements they suggested for this issue?

- None of the participants reported feeling overwhelmed.

Once the respondent realized that the categories unfolded, did they select additional categories to see the extra help info?

- P2905 clicked on additional categories per the interviewer’s instructions and then on their own volition. They explained that it would be helpful if the examples were displayed or if there were instructions to click on the categories to see examples.
- This question was understood by participants, although some had issues answering the question. Two participants selected the “Other” option without clicking on the categories, therefore they did not see the examples and felt that none captured their main reason for moving. Once instructed by the interviewer to review the examples from the categories, participants noted that the example text was helpful and couple help guide their selections.

Recommendations:

See Question 6B recommendations.

Question 7A

Research Question: Are respondents interested in providing up to two additional reasons for move? Do respondents feel that the follow-up question is framed in a straightforward manner?

Q7A. What were the other reasons, if any, for your most recent move?

[Displayed information when folded:]

1. Family
2. Nonfamily relationship
3. Work
4. Education or training
5. Housing or neighborhood hardship
6. Better-suited housing or neighborhood
7. Health
8. Natural disaster
9. Better-suited climate or region
10. Legal or institutional
11. Other
12. None

[Displayed information when unfolded:]

- **Family**
 - Examples: birth of a child; to help parent; divorced; death in family
- **Nonfamily relationship**
 - Examples: to be with unmarried partner; wanted to live with friend; conflict with roommate
- **Work**
 - Examples: shorter commute; starting new job; unemployed; armed forces; retired
- **Education or training**
 - Examples: college; trade school; unpaid internship; desirable public school district
- **Housing or neighborhood hardship**
 - Examples: unaffordable housing costs; foreclosure; eviction; landlord negligence – such as refusal to provide repairs, pest or mold control, or heating; neighborhood safety concerns; homelessness
- **Better-suited housing or neighborhood**
 - Examples: found less expensive housing; desirable neighborhood; wanted to own home; down-sized; amenities such as garage, pool, or yard
- **Health**
 - Examples: needed home without stairs; aging; injury; illness; assisted living; exited rehabilitation
- **Natural disaster**
 - Examples: hurricane or tornado damage; flooding; wildfire risk
- **Better-suited climate or region**
 - Examples: less cold or rainy; wanted to live in a city; wanted to live in the Southwest; closer to the mountains
- **Legal or institutional**
 - Examples: re-entry from prison; foster care; requirements of parole; probation ended
- **Other**
 - Any reason that does not fit into one of the categories above
- **None**
 - Any additional reasons for moving

n = 3

Findings:

Each combination of main and additional reasons selected.

- P2538 selected “Other” for their main reason and “Other” for their additional reason.

How many respondents reported difficulty with this question?

- P2538 found that the response categories did not encompass their situation of moving for a spouse’s job.

Did respondents have trouble coming up with a 2nd and 3rd reason for moving?

- No findings.

Is only one reason sufficient? Was the limit of 3 reasons a problem? Did they want to select more?

- No findings.

If mentioned other reasons, did you feel that there were significant factors or very minor?

- P2538 noted that their reason for moving was significant because it was for their spouse’s job.

How many respondents found the additional reasons for move question useful for more accurately describing their move or for making it easier to answer the reason for move question over all?

- Two participants [P2782, P2905] were able to describe their reasons for moving more accurately with the additional reasons.
 - P2782 mentioned that they moved because the cost of their previous residence was too high. They selected “Housing or neighborhood hardship” as their main choice, and “Better-suited housing or neighborhood” for the additional reason. They noted both of these reasons were equally important.
 - After the interviewer prompted P2905 to click on the response categories and read the examples, they noted that “Housing or neighborhood hardship” would be an accurate description for the reason they moved.

If any reported “Other”, what was their reason for their move, and could this reason ostensibly fall under any of the existing categories?

- P2538 selected “Other” for their additional response but described the same logic for their selection of “Other” for their main reason. They noted that they moved for their spouse’s job, so this could have ostensibly fallen under Family and/or Work. The participant did not click on either or read the examples that would have unfolded.

Would the respondents have preferred to receive the question in another format?

- No findings.

Was the R answering for themselves, personally, or the household?

- P2538 answered for themselves personally despite the entire household partaking in the move.
- This question was well received and generally understood. The participants felt that it gave them an opportunity to describe their other reason(s) for moving more accurately.

Recommendations:

See Question 7B recommendations.

Question 8A

Research Question: The broader research purpose for this question is to be able to identify a subsample for which we know Residence A, Residence B, and the reason for move from Residence A to Residence B. Since multiple moves can occur within the period of a year and certainly ten years, residence one/ten year(s) ago will not always be the prior residence.

Q8A. Other than your move to [Current address – just street], did you move another time between September 1, 2023 and today?

- Yes
- No

n = 3

Findings:

Were there any problems with this question?

- P2538 noted that the reference period was unclear, as they initially interpreted it as asking about one year ago. They suggested asking, "Between September 1st, 2023, and today, did you live anywhere else other than [address]?" instead.
- This question was well understood, although one participant noted that the reference period was unclear.

Recommendations:

See Question 8B recommendations.

Question 9A

Research Question: The purpose of this question is to identify an eligible HH member about whom the interviewer can loop through the questions again (to improve the sample size and increase the amount of feedback the migration team receives).

Q9A. There (are/is) (number) other (people/person) in this household who is/are at least 1 year old. Which of these people, if any, lived with you one year ago, on September 1, 2023?

[ALL OTHER HOUSEHOLDERS]

n = 25

Findings

How many respondents reported difficulty with this question? If any, why?

- Three participants [P2647, P2782, P2942] reported some confusion regarding the “at least 1 year old” language.
 - “No, I understood it [the question]. It’s, let me see, let me look at it again. Probably when it says ‘who are at least one year old,’ that part I probably didn’t understand that. Did they mean like age or?” [P2647]
 - P2782 initially interpreted the question as asking those in the household who were at least one year old.

How many misunderstood the reference period?

- P2975 reiterated the inconsistency between having “one year ago” and “September 1st, 2023” in the same question because they were technically 14 months apart from September 1st during the time of interview.
 - “Again like that’s kind of confusing. I think just putting September first 2023 is good. When say a year ago it’s actually more than a year ago now. It’s the fourteen months...” [P2975]

If they misunderstood the reference period, what did they think it was referring to, and how could it be made clearer to them?

- No additional findings.

Is anything desired in a separate help text section?

- No findings.
- This question was well understood by most participants, although some struggled with the language of “at least 1 year old” when describing other household members. There was no additional confusion about the reference period beyond what was found in Question 1A.

Recommendations:

See Question 9B recommendations.

Question 6A_i

Research Question: N/A
Q6A_i. What was [name selected in 9A]’s main reason for their most recent move, to [current address – street only]? [Displayed information when folded:] 1. Family 2. Nonfamily relationship 3. Work 4. Education or training 5. Housing or neighborhood hardship 6. Better-suited housing or neighborhood 7. Health 8. Natural disaster

9. Better-suited climate or region
10. Legal or institutional
11. Other
12. None

[Displayed information when unfolded:]

- **Family**
 - Examples: birth of a child; to help parent; divorced; death in family
- **Nonfamily relationship**
 - Examples: to be with unmarried partner; wanted to live with friend; conflict with roommate
- **Work**
 - Examples: shorter commute; starting new job; unemployed; armed forces; retired
- **Education or training**
 - Examples: college; trade school; unpaid internship; desirable public school district
- **Housing or neighborhood hardship**
 - Examples: unaffordable housing costs; foreclosure; eviction; landlord negligence – such as refusal to provide repairs, pest or mold control, or heating; neighborhood safety concerns; homelessness
- **Better-suited housing or neighborhood**
 - Examples: found less expensive housing; desirable neighborhood; wanted to own home; down-sized; amenities such as garage, pool, or yard
- **Health**
 - Examples: needed home without stairs; aging; injury; illness; assisted living; exited rehabilitation
- **Natural disaster**
 - Examples: hurricane or tornado damage; flooding; wildfire risk
- **Better-suited climate or region**
 - Examples: less cold or rainy; wanted to live in a city; wanted to live in the Southwest; closer to the mountains
- **Legal or institutional**
 - Examples: re-entry from prison; foster care; requirements of parole; probation ended
- **Other**
 - Any reason that does not fit into one of the categories above
- **Not their decision**
 - Someone else made the decision to move for them/ the household

***n* = 3**

Findings:

Note that only 3 participants received this question due to programmed skip patterns for this question. Participants who answered “no” to Q1A answered Q6A_i-Q8A_i about the household member selected in Q9A. This was purposeful so that we could compare whether participants reported the same personal reasons for moving (Q6A-Q8A) as the household members’ reasons for moving (Q6A_i-Q8A_i).

How often does the R give the same answer for themselves and the 2nd person?

- None of the participants chose the same main reason for themselves and the 2nd person.
- This question was well understood by participants. None of the participants chose the same main reason for themselves and the household member.

Recommendations:

See Question 6B_i recommendations. We may want to consider changing the skip patterns for this question in the second round of cognitive interviewing to gather more feedback.

Question 7A_i

Research Question: N/A
Q7A_i. What were the other reasons, if any, for [person number <i>i</i> from COHABITANT LIST]’s most recent move? [Displayed information when folded:] 1. Family 2. Nonfamily relationship 3. Work 4. Education or training 5. Housing or neighborhood hardship 6. Better-suited housing or neighborhood 7. Health 8. Natural disaster 9. Better-suited climate or region 10. Legal or institutional 11. Other 12. None [Displayed information when unfolded:] ▪ Family – Examples: birth of a child; to help parent; divorced; death in family ▪ Nonfamily relationship – Examples: to be with unmarried partner; wanted to live with friend; conflict with roommate ▪ Work – Examples: shorter commute; starting new job; unemployed; armed forces; retired ▪ Education or training – Examples: college; trade school; unpaid internship; desirable public school district ▪ Housing or neighborhood hardship – Examples: unaffordable housing costs; foreclosure; eviction; landlord negligence – such as refusal to provide repairs, pest or mold control, or heating; neighborhood safety concerns; homelessness ▪ Better-suited housing or neighborhood – Examples: found less expensive housing; desirable neighborhood; wanted to own home; down-sized; amenities such as garage, pool, or yard

- Health
 - Examples: needed home without stairs; aging; injury; illness; assisted living; exited rehabilitation
- Natural disaster
 - Examples: hurricane or tornado damage; flooding; wildfire risk
- Better-suited climate or region
 - Examples: less cold or rainy; wanted to live in a city; wanted to live in the Southwest; closer to the mountains
- Legal or institutional
 - Examples: re-entry from prison; foster care; requirements of parole; probation ended
- Other
 - Any reason that does not fit into one of the categories above
- None
 - No additional reasons for moving

***n* = 3**

Findings:

Do they feel confident reporting for other people in the household?

- P2538 notes that their household member's additional reason for moving was probably the same as their own, and therefore sounded confident in their response.

If mentioned other reasons, did they feel that there were significant factors or very minor?

- P2538 maintained that these were significant factors.

Anything they would suggest to improve this question?

- No findings
- This question was well understood by the participants. They sounded confident in their ability to proxy report for household members.

Recommendation:

See Question 7B_i recommendations.

Question 8A_i

Research Question: The broader research purpose for this question is to be able to identify a subsample for which we know Residence A, Residence B, and the reason for move from Residence A to Residence B. Since multiple moves can occur within the period of a year and certainly ten years, residence one/ten year(s) ago will not always be the prior residence.

Q8A_i. Other than [name]'s move to [Current address – just street], did they move another time between September 1, 2023 and today?

- Yes
- No

***n* = 3**

Findings:**Did you have any difficulty with this question? If so, why?**

- No findings

Is there any language that would have been useful to make it clearer?

- No findings
- This question was well understood. There were no additional findings beyond those from Question 8A.

Recommendations:

See Question 8B_i recommendations.

Question 1A-L

Research Question: Are respondents correctly reporting based on the moving question reference period – meaning whether they were living at this residence exactly one year ago - rather than going by the current calendar year or misunderstanding the reference period in some other way? How much clarification do we need within the question itself, and what information (if anything) would be best-suited to “help text” (e.g., hover-over information box)?

Q1A-L. Was [name] living at [Current Address] one year ago, on September 1, 2023?

- Yes
- No

***n* = 0**

Findings:

- No participants received this question.

Recommendations:

No recommendations at this time.

Question 2A-L

Research Question: Where did this other HH member live one year ago? (Here, we establish if the respondent’s prior residence was in the United States. For respondents who lived in the U.S., we ask follow-up questions on their state and county of residence.)

Q2A-L. Was [name] living at [Current Address] one year ago, on September 1, 2023?

- Yes
- No

***n* = 0**

Findings:

- No participants received this question.

Recommendations:

No recommendations at this time.

Question 3A-L

Research Question: N/A		
Q3A-L. What state did [name] live in one year ago, on September 1, 2023?		
▪ Alabama ▪ Alaska ▪ Arizona ▪ Arkansas ▪ California ▪ Colorado ▪ Connecticut ▪ Delaware ▪ District of Columbia ▪ Florida ▪ Georgia ▪ Hawaii ▪ Idaho ▪ Illinois ▪ Indiana ▪ Iowa ▪ Kansas	▪ Kentucky ▪ Louisiana ▪ Maine ▪ Maryland ▪ Massachusetts ▪ Michigan ▪ Minnesota ▪ Mississippi ▪ Missouri ▪ Montana ▪ Nebraska ▪ Nevada ▪ New Hampshire ▪ New Jersey ▪ New Mexico ▪ New York ▪ North Carolina	▪ North Dakota ▪ Ohio ▪ Oklahoma ▪ Oregon ▪ Pennsylvania ▪ Rhode Island ▪ South Carolina ▪ South Dakota ▪ Tennessee ▪ Texas ▪ Utah ▪ Vermont ▪ Virginia ▪ Washington ▪ West Virginia ▪ Wisconsin ▪ Wyoming
n = 0		

Findings:

No participants received this question.

Recommendations:

No recommendations at this time.

Question 4A-L

Research Question: Here, we are trying to identify respondents' ability to recall and accurately report their county of residence 1 year ago. Our intention here is to have branching logic so that only the counties within the state reported in the prior question are listed. The companion file "MIGCOU County List" lists all county options for each non-DC state option.
Q4A-L. What county in [State] did [name] live in one year ago, on September 1, 2023? [Refer to "MIGCOU County List" (accompanying spreadsheet)]
n = 0

Findings:

- No participants received this question.

Recommendations:

No recommendations at this time.

Question 5A-L

Research Question: If respondents are unable to recall and accurately report the county that they lived in one year ago, we intend to ask a follow-up question to see if they remember their city or town one year ago. In cognitive testing, our goal is to assess respondents' ability to accurately recall and report this information. Alongside this, we are curious if respondents have an easier time recalling the city/town as opposed to the county that they lived in one year ago.

Q5A-L. What city or town in [State] did [name] live in one year ago, on September 1, 2023?
[Respondent self-reports via write-in.]

***n* = 0**

Findings:

- No participants received this question.

Recommendations:

No recommendations at this time.

Question 6A-L

Research Question: Because this question is changing in meaning (and, we hope, meaningfully improved) ways, we have several questions on which cognitive testing could shed light.

- We want to confirm that these categories are clearly articulated (i.e., respondents understand what sorts of reasons fall under each category), mutually exclusive (i.e., any one reason fits into at most one category), and sufficiently complete (i.e., all or almost all reasons fit into an existing, non-Other category).
- Ideally, respondents will be able to identify a main reason for move from the provided categories as easily as possible; to this end, we want to probe about question difficulty and ask if respondents can identify any changes that would make the question easier to answer.
- About how long are respondents taking to determine their response? (If relatively long, they question may be more burdensome than we intended.)
- The examples associated with each category are meant to facilitate the identification of the appropriate category for main reason for move. We want to assess whether they are serving this purpose, as well as if any additional examples are warranted.

We also want to confirm that the Other category is not used when the respondent's specific reason for move in fact could fall under an existing non-Other category; if this happens, we seek insights into why the relevant non-Other category was not selected, with an eye to clarifying the relevant category or categories.

Q6A-L. What was the main reason for [name]'s most recent move to [current street address, same one we've been using]?

[Displayed information when folded:]

1. Family
2. Nonfamily relationship
3. Work
4. Education or training
5. Housing or neighborhood hardship
6. Better-suited housing or neighborhood
7. Health
8. Natural disaster

9. Better-suited climate or region
10. Legal or institutional
11. Other
12. Note their decision

[Displayed information when unfolded:]

- Family
 - Examples: birth of a child; to help parent; divorced; death in family
- Nonfamily relationship
 - Examples: to be with unmarried partner; wanted to live with friend; conflict with roommate
- Work
 - Examples: shorter commute; starting new job; unemployed; armed forces; retired
- Education or training
 - Examples: college; trade school; unpaid internship; desirable public school district
- Housing or neighborhood hardship
 - Examples: unaffordable housing costs; foreclosure; eviction; landlord negligence – such as refusal to provide repairs, pest or mold control, or heating; neighborhood safety concerns; homelessness
- Better-suited housing or neighborhood
 - Examples: found less expensive housing; desirable neighborhood; wanted to own home; down-sized; amenities such as garage, pool, or yard
- Health
 - Examples: needed home without stairs; aging; injury; illness; assisted living; exited rehabilitation
- Natural disaster
 - Examples: hurricane or tornado damage; flooding; wildfire risk
- Better-suited climate or region
 - Examples: less cold or rainy; wanted to live in a city; wanted to live in the Southwest; closer to the mountains
- Legal or institutional
 - Examples: re-entry from prison; foster care; requirements of parole; probation ended
- Other
 - Any reason that does not fit into one of the categories above
- Not their decision
 - Someone else made the decision to move for them/the household

n = 0

Findings:

- No participants received this question.

Recommendations:

No recommendations at this time.

Question 7A-L

Research Question: Because this question is changing in meaning (and, we hope, meaningfully improved) ways, we have several questions on which cognitive testing could shed light.

- We want to confirm that these categories are clearly articulated (i.e., respondents understand what sorts of reasons fall under each category), mutually exclusive (i.e., any one reason fits into at most one category), and sufficiently complete (i.e., all or almost all reasons fit into an existing, non-Other category).
- Ideally, respondents will be able to identify a main reason for move from the provided categories as easily as possible; to this end, we want to probe about question difficulty and ask if respondents can identify any changes that would make the question easier to answer.
- About how long are respondents taking to determine their response? (If relatively long, they question may be more burdensome than we intended.)
- The examples associated with each category are meant to facilitate the identification of the appropriate category for main reason for move. We want to assess whether they are serving this purpose, as well as if any additional examples are warranted.

We also want to confirm that the Other category is not used when the respondent's specific reason for move in fact could fall under an existing non-Other category; if this happens, we seek insights into why the relevant non-Other category was not selected, with an eye to clarifying the relevant category or categories.

Q7A-L. What were the other reasons, if any, for [name]'s most recent move?

[Displayed information when folded:]

1. Family
2. Nonfamily relationship
3. Work
4. Education or training
5. Housing or neighborhood hardship
6. Better-suited housing or neighborhood
7. Health
8. Natural disaster
9. Better-suited climate or region
10. Legal or institutional
11. Other
12. None

[Displayed information when unfolded:]

- Family
 - Examples: birth of a child; to help parent; divorced; death in family
- Nonfamily relationship
 - Examples: to be with unmarried partner; wanted to live with friend; conflict with roommate
- Work
 - Examples: shorter commute; starting new job; unemployed; armed forces; retired
- Education or training
 - Examples: college; trade school; unpaid internship; desirable public school district
- Housing or neighborhood hardship
 - Examples: unaffordable housing costs; foreclosure; eviction; landlord negligence – such as refusal to provide repairs, pest or mold control, or heating; neighborhood safety concerns; homelessness

▪ Better-suited housing or neighborhood – Examples: found less expensive housing; desirable neighborhood; wanted to own home; down-sized; amenities such as garage, pool, or yard ▪ Health – Examples: needed home without stairs; aging; injury; illness; assisted living; exited rehabilitation ▪ Natural disaster – Examples: hurricane or tornado damage; flooding; wildfire risk ▪ Better-suited climate or region – Examples: less cold or rainy; wanted to live in a city; wanted to live in the Southwest; closer to the mountains ▪ Legal or institutional – Examples: re-entry from prison; foster care; requirements of parole; probation ended ▪ Other – Any reason that does not fit into one of the categories above ▪ None – No additional reason for moving
<i>n</i> = 0

Findings:

- No participants received this question.

Recommendations:

No recommendations at this time.

Question 8A-L

Research Question: Where did this other HH member live one year ago? (Here, we establish if the respondent's prior residence was in the United States. For respondents who lived in the U.S., we ask follow-up questions on their state and county of residence.)
Q8A-L. Was [name] living at [Current Address] one year ago, on September 1, 2023? 1. Yes 2. No
<i>n</i> = 0

Findings:

- No participants received this question.

Recommendations:

No recommendations at this time.

Question 1B

Research Question: To get enough responses from movers during cognitive testing, we want to ask participants who moved within the past 10 years about where they lived 10 years ago and their most recent reason for moving. The research purposes of this question are otherwise analogous to 1A.

Q1B. Were you living at [Current Address- just street] ten years ago, on September 1, 2014?

- Yes
- No

***n* = 27**

Findings**Did participants have any difficulty with this question? If so, why?**

- Participants had no serious difficulties answering this question. In fact, they said so unequivocally.
 - “No, I remember easily.” [P2633]
 - Another participant said it was super easy because she has only been at her current address for the past two years. [P2718]
 - Answering about P2, a participant said it was easy because she knew they have lived together for twelve years. [P2256]
- While still not finding difficulty, three participants needed to jog their memory.
 - “Oh, now I have to think!” [P2367]
 - Another participant used several important events as references, she recalled they moved after her 5th grade graduation, and this helped her recall the date of the move. [P2279]
 - The third person first selected Yes, but right away corrected her answer as she realized they had a break living at the address: “The address where I live currently is a home that we own but we did live elsewhere sometime from 2010 to 2016 and then we moved back to this address.” [P2273]

When answering this question, did you consider the date provided or just focus on “ten years ago”?

- Nine participants focused on the year 2014. One of them [P2279] explained that she was too young back then to focus on the specific date as a way to remember.
- Five said they paid attention to both the date and the number of years ago.
 - One of them, however, felt the specific date was not helpful: “This one, ‘were you living at [P’s address] ten years ago’ and 2014, that makes it very clear question. But when you add September first, it’s not clear. Ten years and 2014 is good.” [P2975]
- Thirteen others focused on “ten years ago.”

Recommendations:

Consider asking about 10 years ago, that is [CURRENT MONTH], [10 YEARS AGO].

Question 2B

Research Question: N/A
Q2B. Were you living in the United States (within the 50 states and the District of Columbia) ten years ago, on September 1, 2014? ▪ Yes ▪ No
n = 21

Findings

Participants answered about themselves without difficulties.

- The 21 participants that were asked this question were able to respond about themselves as well as for one household member.
- Given the definition of United States used in the question, all participants answered as intended.
- The one participant who said No, was living in Puerto Rico 10 years before. They said that their definition of US is different. He could not articulate it but said it was different for Puerto Rico. Presumably, without the definition offered, this person would have answered Yes, that he was living in the U.S. in 2014.

Participants were also asked this question as proxy for others in the household.

- No one reported someone living outside the U.S.
- Two were not sure of their answer, and both said Yes, with one suggesting adding a Don't Know option. [P2265]. The other participant added, "I would assume, but I don't know. I'll say yes since she has never mentioned being outside the United States" [P2367].

Are the participants' definitions of the United States the same as the one in parentheses? Is the definition needed?

- Six participants felt the definition provided matched their understanding, but they did not agree on whether a definition is necessary. Two did not say if the definition was needed [P2743, P2941]. And one felt it was ok to provide it [P2260]. Three others found it unnecessary because it matches their understanding [P2507, P2518]. One explained that if the question intended to include or reference US territories then they would need this information, but in this case they did not. [P2279]
- Other participants demonstrated, through their own definitions, that they did not cover the same areas as the question specified.
 - Five participants [P2718, P2684, felt the definition was needed because their own definition includes U.S. territories and here they were excluded.
 - The mention of the District of Columbia confused some participants who did not know that the DC in "Washington DC" stands for "District of Columbia." In fact, some appeared to be thinking of the country Colombia instead.
 - A participant reacted to "District of Columbia" saying "See I always thought, I never really thought about it. Are they part of the United States or no?" The interviewer probed about what the participant thinks of when they hear "District of Columbia". "I think of south of the border, or the border. I think of, yeah." [P2647]

- “I didn’t know the District of Columbia was a part of the United States, that’s something new to me, but yes.” [P2633]
- Others thought that the District of Columbia is included in the 50 states.
 - “I never, I mean, I don’t know why District of Columbia would be very like, specified. I might be a bit ignorant but I ... ever to like, think about that, so I disregarded it. It’s just not something that I have to think about really or consider as part of the 50 United States on a regular basis.” [P2250]
 - Another participant [P2428] said “District of Columbia” was unnecessary when specifying 50 states as it was already there.

Recommendations:

The definition of United States is necessary to limit the scope to the 50 states and the District of Columbia, as several participants would otherwise include Puerto Rico and the other US territories. We recommend testing the definition reformulated as “within the 50 states and Washington, DC.”

Question 3B/4B

Research Question: Do participants know what county they lived in ten years ago? How confident are they in their response? Could any changes to the question improve their understanding of it? Did the provided list make it easier to report the county that the participant lived in last year?

Q3B. In which state and county did you live in ten years ago, on September 1, 2014? (Enter R's response)

***n* = 13**

Findings

- Participants showed no difficulties recalling the state in which they lived 10 years earlier. This was true when answering about themselves as well as when answering about another household member that did not cohabitate with them 10 years prior.
- About as many participants could report the county name as those who could not. This did not necessarily appear as a recall issue, since no one said they did not remember but rather that they did not know.
- The same distribution persisted when reporting about a household member on county name.

Recommendations:

See recommendations for Q5B.

Question 5B

Research Question: To assess respondents’ ability to accurately recall and report this information. Do respondents have an easier time recalling the city/town as opposed to the county that they lived in one year ago.

Q5B. What city or town in [State] did [reference person name] live in ten years ago, on September 1, 2014? (Enter R's response)

***n* = 19**

Findings:

- All participants that received this question were able to provide the city or town in which they lived ten years earlier.
- Eighteen participants were asked about another household member, and this question worked equally well in most cases. There were two exceptions. One participant was not sure and guessed [P2446], while the other proposed adding a Not sure option:
 - "I'm pretty sure it was [CITY], but this is something that I feel like a lot of people might not know. Even if they were living with family, it's hard to know exactly where someone was exactly 10 years ago. There should definitely be an 'I'm not sure' option." [P2265]

Did participants have difficulty recalling this information?

- Fourteen participants said they had no difficulty.
- Two others reported needing to give it some thought:
 - "Slightly yes, a little bit. Because you don't think about, you know, where were you ten years ago? So yeah I had to think about it, yeah." [P2647]
 - Another participant had to think back about when they graduated to be able to recall the city within the county reported. [P2446]
- Two participants had difficulty finding on the menu what they were looking for:
 - "But [CITY NAME] wasn't where I thought it was going to be. It was all the way at the very end... Yeah it was a pull-down menu and it lets you scroll and when I got down to where [COUNTY WITH SAME NAME] was, I guess I thought (it was) [CITY], because it was in alphabetic order... but instead it goes all the way past W and then it comes back to [CITY]." [P2743]
 - A participant had no idea what the county was at all that she lived in and guessed the name before seeing Don't know. They said they wished Don't know was listed at the top. [2344]

Did participants feel uneasy about reporting this information?

- Fifteen participants said they were not uneasy providing this information.
- Two others made comments that suggested slight discomfort:
 - "Not so much. I think if anything it's like currently, but I feel trusting of the US Census Bureau...there's always hesitation with sharing personal information." The participant added that their concern would be higher if they were asked to share their current address. [P2260]
 - "Just a big question in my head, 'why are they asking this?'" [P2250]

Which was easier to report – county or city?

- Among the 19 participants that answered question 5B, ten found it easier to report the City and State, while for eight others it was just as easy to answer city/state or county.
- There was one single participant who preferred to answer county. For this person [P2446], since they had moved frequently across towns within the county, it was easier to remember the county without giving much thought to the specific date.

Recommendations:

Since a vast majority of participants preferred reporting the city/town and state over county, or found either one just as easy, we recommend asking only about city/town and state.

*Question 6B***Research Questions:**

- We want to confirm that these categories are clearly articulated (i.e., participants understand what sorts of reasons fall under each category), mutually exclusive (i.e., any one reason fits into at most one category), and sufficiently complete (i.e., all or almost all reasons fit into an existing, non-Other category).
- Ideally, participants will be able to identify a main reason for move from the provided categories as easily as possible; to this end, we want to probe about question difficulty and ask if participants can identify any changes that would make the question easier to answer.
- About how long are participants taking to determine their response? (If relatively long, they question may be more burdensome than we intended.)
- The examples associated with each category are meant to facilitate the identification of the appropriate category for main reason for move. We want to assess whether they are serving this purpose, as well as if any additional examples are warranted.
- We also want to confirm that the Other category is not used when the participant's specific reason for move in fact could fall under an existing non-Other category; if this happens, we seek insights into why the relevant non-Other category was not selected, with an eye to clarifying the relevant category or categories.

Q6B. What was the main reason for [name]'s most recent move to [current street address]? (Enter R's response)

***n* = 21**

Findings**Providing a response**

- In selecting a response, three of the 21 participants showed some hesitation.
 - Two participants first chose "housing or neighborhood hardship" but upon reading the explanations they realized it was not a good fit. They changed to "Better-suited housing or neighborhood." [P2428; P2647]
 - Another participant read through 'Health' aloud, then chose 'Better-suited housing'. Then read the description and explained that their current apartment was slightly nicer than their previous residence, noting that it is quieter and has more yard space. [P2250]

Did the participant read all of the options, or only the start of the list?

- Fourteen participants read the list in full.
- The remaining seven looked through the list and either stopped when they found the reason they wanted to select or scrolled looking for a specific reason until they found it.

Did you have difficulty with the question? Tell me more about that.

- One participant was too young at the time of the move and was not sure of her parents' reasons. [P2279]
- For another participant, there was some confusion because for a moment they thought of the 1-year ago move instead of the 10-year move. [P2718]
- Thirteen of the 21 participants found no difficulty answering the question.
- Despite not finding it difficult to choose a response, for two of the 13 this was a sensitive question:
 - "It's not so much about being honest with the surveyor; it's about being honest with yourself so I am going to have to click on neighborhood hardship because I became homeless." [P2446]
 - "To be honest with you when I lived in the house in [CITY]... my name was not on it...I've never owned a house because I just can't afford it...We had to come and stay here because we can't afford anything." [P2518]
- Five participants [P2344; P2250; P2273; P2589; P2260; P2647] had difficulty selecting among possible choices. One simply did not know how to classify the most important reason and would have wanted to select more than one. [P2344]
 - "I mean, I was between... 'better suited housing or neighborhood' and in a way this here, 'housing or neighborhood hardship' so let's see what it says because I didn't open it. ... "I'm going to say it's a little bit of both. Our previous landlord was negligent too. So yeah. Safety concerns, we had concerns in the building of people just breaking in and stuff like that so it was a little bit of both. But I felt that 'better suited housing' was a better, better worded for me because we were, we were looking for something that was slightly better than what we were having before." [P2250]
 - "Sort of, the reason that we moved back was due to a foreclosure but also that was as a result of health just my ... husband had actually gotten into a very bad motorcycle accident and so that's kind of what progressed to the foreclosure. So it's sort of, you know, I sort of could have answered either in my mind." [P2273]
- One participant [P2647] did not find the list of options detailed enough: "...It wasn't detailed enough for me." For this participant the term 'better suited housing' made it confusing: "Yes. I got the neighborhood part, but yeah, the better-suited-housing, that part, what do they mean exactly?"
- Finally, two participants mentioned that it would have helped to see the additional information about each option before clicking on each.
 - "The only thing it was difficult because I didn't know that once you click it gives examples. Maybe if you didn't have to click on the subcategory, maybe if it gave the examples right off the bat it would be a lot easier." [P2941]
 - A second participant would have liked to see examples with the question instead of having to click on the responses to get the examples to come up. [P2428]

Was your most recent move from the county/city you just provided to your current address? If not, what move did you think about when answering?

- All participants were thinking about their most recent move without exceptions.

Were you thinking about your personal reasons for moving or reasons applicable to the household as a whole?

- Nineteen participants answered this probe.
- Eleven participants provided an answer for their household as a whole, including two who said they were thinking both.
 - One initially spoke about the household reasons for moving but later focused on his own reasons. For him the reasons were financial and also it was closer to where he wanted to live, and how he wants to live his life. [P2589]
 - The other one was thinking about personal reasons, but her reasons are also applicable to the whole household. [P2684]
- Eight others were thinking of personal reasons only, but this number includes three participants [P2268, P2507, and 2904] in single-person households.

Did the reasons fit easily into one of the response options? If not, was it that they did not fit any category? Or did they fit more than one?

- For 16 participants, their reasons fit easily into one of the response options.
- For five others that was not the case.
 - One participant was a child when the move took place. Although she wanted to select Family, the examples did not fit her situation. She was age 10 and as she put it, "I am moving where my parents say, I don't have a say in that." [P2279]
 - Three others felt their reasons fell into more than one category. [P2273, P2260, and P2344]
 - The fifth participant did not initially choose 'better-suited housing or neighborhood': "It didn't jump out exactly what I was looking for. It wasn't, it wasn't detailed enough for me." This person felt that the term 'better suited housing' made it confusing: "Yes. I got the neighborhood part, but yeah, the better-suited-housing, that part, what do they mean exactly?" [P2647]

Did the additional information about each option help?

- Fourteen participants found the additional information, the examples that appeared when selecting an option, helpful.
 - Some (P2446, P2260, P2647, and P2684) found it helpful as confirmation that their choice fit their reason.
 - Two others found it helpful to know they should look for other reasons as the examples suggested this was not the right choice for them. (P2254 and P2941)
- Two others did not find the examples helpful. One simply because their choice was clear and did not need examples [P2265]. For the other, it appeared that the examples only made finding a category harder; this was the person who moved as a 10-year old and any answer she selected as possible gave examples that did not fit. She eventually realized there would not be one that fit her. [P2279]
- Four participants mentioned that it would have helped to see the additional information about each option before clicking on each.

- "The only thing it was difficult because I didn't know that once you click it gives examples. Maybe if you didn't have to click on the subcategory, maybe if it gave the examples right off the bat it would be a lot easier." [P2941]
- A second participant would have liked to see examples with the question instead of having to click on the responses to get the examples to come up. [P2428]
- "I guess I'm not used to seeing examples once you select an answer..." [P2904]
- Another participant thought the examples were helpful but wished they had been available without having to click on them first. [P2260]

The options are sometimes about the place you left and sometimes about the new residence. Did you notice this? Was it confusing?

- For the most part, participants did not notice this, and among the few who noticed, it was not found to be confusing.

How do you feel about the number of response options?

- Thirteen participants felt the number of response options was good, some more enthusiastically than others.
 - "I think it's fine." [P2904]
 - "I think it makes sense. It pretty much covers everything. Like some people might just move because they wanted to, but I think that would be covered under like 'better suited'. And there's also, like there's an 'other' option. So yeah, I think it covers everything." [P2265]
 - "I thought there was a good amount. You know, you, I mean, people move for different reasons. You know, sometimes you get a job in another state or you know, on the other side of the country. Stuff happens, you know, we have flooding here so I could definitely see natural disaster. I think of hurricanes and stuff so yeah, definitely a, a good amount of things here." [P2743]
 - "It's enough option to be relatively comprehensive, but not too many options to be incredibly overwhelming. It's a little overwhelming, but it's not like ... it seems like a necessary amount of overwhelming." [P2589]
- Three other participants felt the list was too long.
 - One participant felt that it was too long and wanted to write-in a reason and wanted to pick more than one reason. [P2344]
 - Another one felt there were too many response options and was overwhelmed by this question and the options. [P2428]
 - The third one had an interesting perspective: "I mean it was fine for me, I guess, I suppose if I were taking this, you know, kind of for free, totally on my own time, it would maybe seem like a few, like a lot. And some of them are a little inclusive like Natural Disaster could kind of fit into Housing or Neighborhood Hardship. So yeah, I don't know, but it seems fine." [P2507]

Why did respondents select “Other” or “Not my decision”?

- Only one participant chose this response. This participant had selected “Family.”
 - “My parents chose to move, and I followed them because rent is free here. But the reason they chose to move ... My most recent move is because of family.” [P2589]

Q6B.i and Q6B.L

- For household members who did not live with the participant ten years earlier, no additional issues were found.
- For household members who were living with the participant ten years earlier, participants were asked if they felt they had to give a different reason than what they answered for themselves in the same question. Not one of them gave a different reason.

Recommendations:

We recommend looking for a way to show examples for reasons for moving without needing to click on them.

See Q7B regarding question format.

Question 7B

Research Question: Are respondents interested in providing up to two additional reasons for move? Do respondents feel that the follow-up question is framed in a straightforward manner?
Q7B. What were the other reasons, if any, for your most recent move?
n = 22

Was it easy to come up with additional reasons? If yes, did you want to report more reasons?

- For 16 participants, it was not difficult coming up with additional reasons.
- The five participants who had trouble selecting just one answer in Q6B wanted to report more reasons here. The rest were content selecting a main reason in the previous question.

Were the reasons you came up with important or minor?

- While not considering the reason(s) provided in this question as necessarily “major,” seven participants defined them as “important.”
- Three participants said their responses in Q7B were minor. (P2250, P2265, and P2589)

Would you prefer to provide the other reasons another way?

- One participant suggested a “check all” format as in Q7B, but used to ask a single question instead of 6B and 7B. [P2344]
- Three others also wanted the questions combined but proposed a ranking format, with up to top three reasons. [P2743, P2718, and P2265]

(IF SELECTED OTHER) PROBE: Please tell me more about that

- Only one participant selected Other and explained: "I was thinking of, like something like. We moved in 2021, when Covid was kind of like getting just slightly less intense. That could have been added too, because I feel like a lot of people also moved in that time period ... that was also a determining factor for us. But like, 'we're going through all of this, and the landlord is still not fixing this.' You know, you know stuff like that. So it was like, it was more than one thing, but, you know, Covid could have added, just because." [P2250]

(IF THE RESPONDENT CHOSE THE SAME ANSWER AS IN THE PREVIOUS QUESTION) PROBE: Please tell me more about that—are these 2 separate reasons that fall into the same category? Or the same reason that you are repeating?

- Five participants selected the same response choice as they had picked in Q6.
- Four said they did so because it was their only reason for the move.
 - "I don't know but in my head, I guess I kind of immediately associate, if I don't click anything, it might say 'oh, this, you need to put something,' so I just kind of assumed." [P2507]
 - For another participant, they picked the same reason again because the response options were multiple choice, and they could select more than one. [P2589]
 - Another participant confirmed as well that there were no other reasons or aspects of the same reason. [P2633]
 - One more provided the same answer as the main reason because there were no other reasons for his move. He said that he was only focused on the main reason. He did not look at the other options and did not see that the option of 'none' was available. [P2904]
 - The fifth participant was thinking of another reason under the same 'Family' category: "The only other reason I can think of is because of, well, that was my family home and familiarity with the neighborhood... I mean, but basically like I said, I live there, that's my family home. So, I know the neighbors still, you know, I mean, so I would still say family I would still say family, but yeah...and I also help my parents as well." [P2941]

Recommendations:

- Consider combining Q6B and Q7B into a single question with up to three choices, ranked.
- Same recommendation as in Q6B regarding showing examples without having to click on them.

Question 8B

Research Question: The broader research purpose for this question is to be able to identify a subsample for which we know Residence A, Residence B, and the reason for move from Residence A to Residence B. Since multiple moves can occur within the period of a year and certainly ten years, residence one/ten year(s) ago will not always be the prior residence.

Q8B: Other than your move to [Current address – just street], did you move another time between September 1, 2014 and today?

***n* = 0**

Findings:

- This question was not shown to any participant.

Recommendations:

- No recommendations at this time.

Question 9B

Research Question: The purpose of this question is to identify an eligible HH member about whom the interviewer can loop through the questions again (to improve the sample size and increase the amount of feedback the migration team receives).

Q9B: Listed below are the other members of your household who are at least 10 years old. Which of these people, if any, lived with you ten years ago, on September 1, 2014?

***n* = 21**

Findings**Did participants have any difficulty with this question?**

- Fourteen participants found no difficulty whatsoever.
- Four others hoped they could select a “None” option:
 - P knew she did not live with any of her current roommates ten years ago but there is no option to select “none” [P2260]
 - P would have benefitted from a “none of the above” response. P said it felt wrong to move on without selecting anything. [P2344]
 - No difficulty but would have like a “None of the above” option. [P2446]
 - None of listed HH members lived with R 10 YA and P was unsure if she should just click next since there was no “none of the above” option. [P2518]
- One participant had a different difficulty, a question comprehension problem: “I had to look at ‘who are at least ten years old.’” [Interviewer: Did you understand that?] “A little bit. Do that means they younger than ten years old?” [P2647]

Did participants consider the date provided or just focus on “ten years ago” when answering this question?

- A few participants that received this probe in Q1B were not probed here again.
- Six focused on 10 years

- Five focused on both
- Five focused on the date, or at least the year. One reported focusing on the full date to figure if their 10-year old child had been born yet.

Was it difficult to decide if someone was living with the participants, if they usually or sometimes lived somewhere else?

- Only one participant was probed on this and he did report a recall issue. "This is hard to remember. I don't believe we were living together at the time. I believe I was already moved in with somebody that I was in a relationship with. So, I'm not going to choose because I'm not a hundred percent sure." [P2250]

Recommendations:

Because the question is asking about something that may have happened "10 years ago," it may be clearer to add "age" to the minimum age, as in:

Listed below are the other members of your household who are age 10 or older. Which of these people, if any, lived with you ten years ago, on September 1, 2014?

Also, we recommend testing this question with an option to select "None".

As in previous questions asking about "ten years ago, on September 1, 2014," we recommend asking it as "ten years ago, on [CURRENT MONTH], [YEAR 10 YEARS AGO]."

6. Question by Question Results – Income

This section presents results and recommendations, where appropriate, for ASEC Income questions. Findings in this section are presented by topic, with findings from the cognitive interviews listed first followed by recommendations. Each question is formatted with the following elements:

- **Research question** provided by Census Bureau with the goals of testing each question, as well as background about changes made to the question.
- **Question text and response options** that were shown to the participants during cognitive interviewing.
- **n**, representing the total number of participants who were exposed to the question, and thus could provide feedback.
- **Responses** provided by participants during the interview.
- **Findings** detailing the answers to key research questions provided by Census Bureau.
- **Summary** with an overall summary of the findings, especially for questions that included significant findings.
- **Recommendations** for question changes, when appropriate.

The goal of cognitive interviewing is to collect qualitative feedback from participants about their response process when providing an answer to each question. We have included a report of the responses to each question (i.e., the quantitative data) to provide context for the findings. This response data comes from a combination of the Qualtrics data entered by either the participant or the interviewer, and the response recorded in the notes during the interview. Participants are not required to provide an answer, and thus the total sample who saw the question (“n”) may differ from the total number of responses.

6.1 Employment Questions

Question 29a

Research Question: Does revising question impact respondent’s understanding? What do respondents consider as “work”? Does adding the phrase, “even if for one day” capture additional work?
Q29a. Did you do any work for pay or profit at any time during 2023, even for one day? ▪ Yes ▪ No
n = 30

Findings:

Would respondents answer differently or think of different kinds of work if the question asked about a “job or business” instead of “work”?

- Of the 30 participants that received this question, many felt that there was a difference in how they would interpret the question if they thought about work as opposed to a job.
- Several participants (n=10) would answer differently if the question asked about a “job or business” instead of work. They explained that work would also encompass things like charity work you don’t get paid for, work that you do not get a W-2 for, odd jobs or “gig” work (n=4).
 - Reflecting on how adding “job or business” would narrow their understand of the question, one participant (P2245) explained, “Yeah, I would think that would really narrow what they’re asking... Because you’d think that you’d have to be employed, there’d be like a W-2, you get paid by somebody else, you know, direct deposit.”
 - Another participant (P2709) added, “Yes it would. It would make it feel like that would be a more regular position. This is a more on-off gig type work.”

Did respondents include work in 2023 that they did not get a paycheck for, such as managing a rental property or sell something online?

- Three participants (P2245, P2303, P2595) included work that they did not get a paycheck for when answering this question.
- One participant (Pp2464) thought of “freelance” work such as doing the cognitive interview, focus groups, and odd jobs such as this as “work.”
 - One participant (P2245) explained, “I do sell things sometimes online that isn’t furniture, un... I would include that as well. I have a friend that does, like, babysitting before the bus comes and after the bus drops them off. I would think that, you know, it would include her work because she does get paid for it. So, I think this is very, like, it’s a wide berth of what could be included in this question.”

Did any respondents not include short-term work when answering the question?

- [Participants were not asked directly about short-term work]
- Participants had a narrower interpretation of “job or business” as opposed to “work.” They interpreted the term “work” as including odd jobs or “gig” work in addition to standard W-2 job roles. This could also include making money from informal economy jobs (e.g. babysitting) and freelance work such as participation in a focus group. If the question were to ask about a “job or business”, participants thought the question was only asking about regular/formal types of job where they received a W-2.

Recommendations:

Depending on the intention of this question, consider whether to change the wording. For example, if only W-2 jobs should be considered, then changing to “job or business” may be more appropriate. Regardless, the question might benefit from inclusion of some examples to ensure respondents are interpreting the question in a standard way.

Question 29b

Research Question: Removed help text about military reserves and national guard work. Is this help text necessary or not?
Q29b. Did (you/^name) do any temporary, part-time, or seasonal work, even for one day during 2023?
▪ Yes ▪ No
n = 5

Findings:

[If applicable] Did the respondent include any Military Reserves or National Guard work. If yes, Probe: Explain the work you did in 2023.

- Only five participants received this question, so findings were minimal.
- This was not applicable to the one participant that answered “Yes” to this question.

All, probe: Anything else? Unpaid? Any self-employment or work for a home-based business? Military service?)

- One participant (P2464) explained that she thought of something that she had published, however, she does not get paid for this. She assumed the question is asking about work for pay.

Overall, there were not enough participants that received this question to assess whether the removal of the help text impacted how participants understood and responded to the question.

Recommendations:

While twelve participants received this question, only one participant responded “Yes.” We recommend recruiting a few “temporary, part-time, or seasonal workers” and retesting this during the second round of cognitive testing. Specifically, identifying participants that are in the military reserve or national guard would be ideal.

Question 30

Research Question: No changes made. We want to make sure respondents understand the terminology in this question.
Q30. Did (you/^name) spend any time trying to find a job or on layoff during 2023?
▪ Yes ▪ No
n = 4

Findings:

How did respondents interpret 'on layoff', were they confused by this term? (Note: on layoff is different than laid off. On layoff means they will be called back to work).

- Only four participants received this question but did not seem to be confused by the term 'on layoff.'
- Participants considered 'laid off' as being permanent, such as losing your job or that you're unemployed. One participant (P2351) contrasted 'on layoff' with 'laid off' explaining that 'on layoff' is temporary, while "laid off" is more permanent.
 - One participant (P3022) explained, "...say he was working, and then he got laid off from his job, or he was unemployed, if he was trying to go back to work, he would be trying to find a job, so that time, then the answer would have been yes."
 - Another participant (P2261) added, "I wouldn't say confusing, but 'On layoff' you can still look for work when you're on layoff, so... I don't think 'On layoff' is a reason to not look for work."
 - One participant (P2710) felt that it is awkward and suggested two separate questions, suggesting, "Did you spend any time trying to find a job/ and/ did you spend any time on layoff?"

While only 4 participants received this question, they seemed to understand what was being asked and understood the term 'on layoff.'

Recommendations:

While participants did not seem to be confused by the term 'on layoff', the question seems to be asking about two different things, that is, it is double barreled. Double barreled questions pose a higher respondent burden and can lead to more misreporting than questions about a single topic. People could be 'on layoff' and not looking for a job. It is unclear whether the analytic value of this question is to determine how many people are looking for a job, are on layoff, or both.

Consider separating the question into two questions:

Q30. During 2023, did (you/^name) spend any time...	Yes	No
...trying to find a job?	0	0
...on layoff?	0	0

Question 31

Research Question: For this question, we want to test the layout and wording of the response option, in particular whether any additional help text is needed noting that there are 52 weeks in a year. How does knowing or not knowing that there are 52 weeks in a year affect their ability to provide an answer for this question.

Q31. How many weeks in total were (you/they) looking for work or on layoff in 2023?

_____ weeks
☐ all weeks in 2023
<i>n</i> = 0

Findings:

How well do respondents remember / count the number of weeks looking for work? How did respondents come up with their answer (thought process)?

Do they know a year has 52 weeks? If they used the check box, why did they select that rather than put in 52 weeks?

- No participants received this question.

Recommendations:

While no participants received this question, the initial concern was whether participants know if there are 52 weeks in a year. Consider changing the checkbox to:

- ☐ all 52 weeks in 2023

This should address the concern.

Question 32

Research Question: Changed response options.
Q32. What was the main reason (you/ ^name) did not work in 2023? ▪ Temporary injury, illness, or other health concern ▪ Chronic health condition or disability ▪ Retired ▪ Pregnancy or childbirth ▪ Taking care of children or others ▪ Going to school ▪ Unable to find work ▪ On layoff ▪ Not interested in working ▪ Some other reason
<i>n</i> = 11

Findings:

How did respondents decide which response option to choose? What did they think about the response options? Are any of them unclear or confusing?

- Most participants (n=8) were retired and felt it was easy to find the category that applied to them as they saw it right away. One participant (P2710) explained that they were retired but also could consider “Not interested in working.”

- One participant (P2709) explained, "Well not interested in working for pay, I guess. But again, it's an unusual situation, but mainly it's because he's retired." Another participant (P2734) who was also retired, explained, "I just knew nothing else would fit...as soon as I saw it."
- A participant (P2332) was looking for a category for "Disability" and was going to select "Temporary injury, illness, or other health concern." However, this respondent then saw the category for "Chronic health condition or disability" realizing that is the one she wanted.
- While most participants felt the response options were clear and not confusing, one participant (P2261) felt the category, "On layoff", did not fit the question, explaining, "I wouldn't say confusing, but 'On layoff' you can still look for work when you're on layoff, so... I don't think 'On layoff' is a reason to not look for work."

How did they decide on "main" reason if multiple reason applied? If "Some other reason": Probe on possible reasons.

- While one participant (P2710) wanted to select more than one option, they were able to identify the *main* reason for not working. As they said, "Is there only one? I would just say retired."

If choose temporary illness, probe for what this was (and if it lingered most of the year).

- No participants selected this response category.
- Most participants that received this question were retired. They found this question easy to answer. A few participants thought of multiple responses that could apply but ultimately decided on the most salient response.

Recommendations:

The question performed well. One small recommendation would be to underline or bold the words 'main reason' to help respondents focus on the most important reason for why they did not look for work.

Consider the revision:

Q32. What was the **main reason** (you/^(name) did not work in 2023?

- Temporary injury, illness, or other health concern
- Chronic health condition or disability
- Retired
- Pregnancy or childbirth
- Taking care of children or others
- Going to school
- Unable to find work
- On layoff
- Not interested in working
- Some other reason

Question 33

Research Question: Changed response method, do respondents need help text indicating number of weeks in a year.

Q33. During 2023, how many weeks did (you/^name) do any work, even for a few hours? Include paid vacation and sick leave as work.

_____ weeks

[] all weeks in 2023

***n* = 25**

Question	n	min	max	mean	median
Q33	25	0	All 52	40	50

Findings:

How well do respondents remember the number of weeks they worked?

- Most participants thought out loud as they came up with their response and generally provided precise responses. However, one participant (P2373) who worked as a consultant explained that the response may or may not be that accurate. Another participant (P2464) explained that the response was a “guestimate.”
- Participants that struggled with the question (P2373, P2464, P2619, P2709) explained that it was “due to their job” explaining that they do not work a standard, regular, job like other people.
- Responses included: Responses: 0; 10 (n=2); 12; 20; 24; 36; 40 (n=4); 50 (n=3); and ALL weeks in 2023 (n=13)
- One participant (P2770) had trouble answering this for another member of the household. This individual was a roommate, so the participant had very little knowledge of their work schedule.

How did respondents come up with their answer (thought process); do they understand a year has 52 weeks?

- Two participants (P2246, P2277) explained that they calculated the weeks but did not count paid sick leave or vacation in their calculation, rather they excluded these hours from their estimate.
 - One participant (P2246) explained, "So I was about to select 'all weeks' but then I thought to myself, well, all weeks would mean I didn't skip any time at all, and I did take time off for the Christmas holiday. So, I think I would just say, what there's 52 weeks in a year, right? I'm trying to remember back to 2023. I may have taken another week-ish around Thanksgiving, but I'll round that up and say I worked 50 weeks."

In general, most participants thought of a year as having 52 weeks. However, two participants (p2245 and p2770) were unsure how many weeks are in a year, with one (p2770) asking, "Is that how many weeks are in a year?"

- One participant (P2595) who used the checkbox commented, "Well, off the top of my head I couldn't, uh, I couldn't do the math... But I ended up going to a different job, which was Amazon. And Amazon is all the time so looking at that and how I was able to finish the rest of the year I'm like, oh, Amazon's basically every week... they have the vacation, they have the sick time, but I wasn't trying to take it."

If they used the check box, why did they select that rather than put in 52 weeks?

- One participant (P2361) entered 52 weeks and then saw the checkbox and decided to check the box rather than enter "52" weeks.
 - Another participant (P2619) explained, "I was gonna type in 52 and then I saw that the option...was there so I was like well, that's redundant."
 - One participant (P2310) said that he liked having the checkbox as he did not have to "...do the math."

Do Rs follow the instruction to count any work at all during the week as a full week of work? E.g., if they lost their job on Monday, that's a week of work.

- No participants were specifically asked about this.
- Overall, participants had some calculation challenges, but this was mostly an issue for participants who explained they do not work a "standard, regular, job like other people." Other participants explained how they calculated their response, and were fairly precise, not including paid vacation and sick leave, as instructed. Participants liked the checkbox, but a few participants were unsure how many weeks were in a year. One participant found it difficult to respond on behalf of other household members.

Recommendations:

Overall, the question performed well. Considering some participants were unsure how many weeks were in a year, consider changing the check box text to:

- [] all 52 weeks in 2023

When this question is asked of other household members, beginning with the first loop of questions, consider adding a "Don't know/Unsure" response option to reduce respondent burden and avoid inaccurate responses.

Question 35

Research Question: Do respondents know what "on layoff" means?
Q35. Did (you/^(name)) lose any full weeks of work in 2023 because (you/they) were on layoff from a job or lost a job? ▪ Yes ▪ No
n = 3

Findings:**Did the respondent misreport weeks of work in the previous question because they missed the instruction about vacation, or some other reason?**

- Three participants received this question, and each answered “No.”
 - When asked if the participant (P2245) misreported weeks of work in the previous question, he explained, “I did, but since we’re self-employed it’s not like an official... Because I would read that and I would think it would have to go through official measures, like you would take sick leave from a company. I don’t know. And since we’re just self-employed, um, I didn’t really consider it.” However, the other participants saw the instruction in the previous question.

Does the respondent know there are 52 weeks in a year?

- Two participants (P2245, P2277) exhibited some confusion about how many weeks are in a year. One participant (P2245) was not sure of the number of weeks in a year. Thinking the question was referring to how many *work* weeks are in a year, another participant (P2277) explained, “About roughly, anywhere between 45 and 50 depending on where you work.”

Did the respondent report “full” weeks only?

- Two of the three participants (P2245, P2277) did not notice the instruction to report “full” weeks.
- The participants thought about the weeks worked, but none of them were on layoff.

How did respondents interpret ‘on layoff’, were they confused by this term? (Note: on layoff is different than laid off. On layoff means they will be called back to work).

- The participants did not seem to understand the term ‘on layoff’ meant that you could be called back to work. They thought of it as a more permanent action.
 - One participant (P2245) explained, “To be laid off or to be fired. To be exterminated from the position, like you’re not allowed to come back.”
 - Another participant (P2246) felt that ‘on layoff’ could mean that you quit or were fired.

Considering the three participants answered “No” and explained that they were not ‘on-layoff’ from a job, they may have focused on this rather than ‘lost a job’ when reading the question.

Recommendations:

Considering it is more likely that a respondent lost a job rather than being on layoff, consider revising the question so that ‘lost a job’ precedes ‘on layoff’:

Q35. Did (you/^(name)) lose any full weeks of work in 2023 because (you/they) lost a job or were on layoff from a job?

Question 36

Research Question: Deleting the total number of hours in a week as an instruction.
Q36. Of the remaining [fill 52- minus previous answer] weeks, how many full weeks were (you / ^name) on layoff or looking for a job? _____
n = 13

Question	n	min	max	mean	median
Q36	13	0	42	10	12

Findings:

How well do respondents remember the number of weeks looking for work? How did respondents come up with their answer (thought process); Did they think about each separately and then add together? Or just focus on one?

- Of the 13 participants that received this question, the participants seemed to remember the number of weeks looking for work and provided a precise response.
- Responses included: 0 (n=4); 2; 3; 8 (n=2); 12 (n=2); 16, 28, and 42.
- Participants (P2646, P2278) who were retired found this question awkward to receive. One participant (P2278) commented, "In my opinion, before the question that they asked did I do any work, there should have been a question asking my employment status... retired."
 - One participant (P2709) explained, "Since this is gig work, I wouldn't consider myself on layoff. Looking for a job, I always survey the opportunities available to see if there was anything I wanted to try to sign up for. So, I don't know if that would count as looking for a job."
- A few participants did not realize that the question was looking for a numeric response.
 - One participant (P2646) wasn't sure what to provide and received an error message when he typed in "Enjoying the free time of retirement." He felt the box was too large, so it was not clear that a numeric value was expected. The interviewer asked if the box was much smaller and there was a label for "weeks", would that have been clearer, and he felt it would be.
 - Another participant (P2434) tried entering "3 weeks" and received an error message to enter a valid number.
 - A third participant (2512) typed in, "I took a break from caregiver" and received an error message, not realizing the question was asking for a numeric response.

Did the respondent misreport weeks of work in the previous question because they missed the instruction about vacation, or some other reason?

- All the participants saw the instruction and did not misreport weeks of work.

Were they on layoff (expecting to be called back) or laid off/fired?

- One participant (P2464) explained that she was not laid off but was always looking for work.

Does the respondent know there are 52 weeks in a year? Did the respondent report “full” weeks only? If answer =0, explain why. (What were they doing in those 3+ weeks while not working)? Do they count voluntarily leaving a job/ quitting for this question? Do Rs know the term on layoff and that it’s different from laid off?

- These research questions were not specifically probed of participants.
- Overall, participants found this question easy to understand and did not seem to have any challenges with recall. A few participants explained that they are “always looking for job opportunities” which made this a challenging question. Furthermore, participants that were retired found the question to be awkward. A few participants typed in a response that was not numeric resulting in an error. This can be resolved with the inclusion of a label for “weeks” to follow the response box.

Recommendations:

Similar to the recommendation provided in Q35 and considering it is more likely that a respondent would be looking for a job rather than being on layoff, consider revising the question so that ‘looking for a job’ precedes ‘on layoff’:

- Q36. Of the remaining [fill 52- minus previous answer] weeks, how many full weeks were (you / ^name) looking for a job or on layoff?

While respondents who are retired are likely to answer “0” here, skip logic could be included to suppress this question for those respondents that explained they were retired in a previous question (Q32 = 3).

Consider making the numeric box smaller to allow for only up to 2-digits and include the label “Weeks” to the right of the box to ensure respondents understand we are looking for a numeric response.

Question 37

Research Question: How well do respondents remember the number of weeks? How did respondents come up with their answer (thought process); if applicable, how did they distinguish stretches.

Q37. Were the [number from Q36] weeks (you/they) were looking for work or on layoff all in one stretch?

- Yes
- No

n = 8

Findings:**If two or more, ask how many stretches. Does “stretches” make sense? Does “all at once” work better?**

- All the participants understood the question was asking if the weeks they were looking for work occurred all at once and seemed to be fine with the term “stretch.”
 - One participant (P2417) explained, “OK so this makes me thinks... continuous.” Another participant (P2332) thought this mean ‘consistently’, explaining that they did not think everyone would know what ‘stretch’ meant. They felt “all at once” would be clear.
 - One participant (P2709) preferred, “...all in one stretch.”
 - Another participant (P2332) believed that the current wording is basically like saying “all in one go.”

Overall, the term “stretch” was understood by participants.

Recommendations:

With only 4 participants that received the question, consider increasing the number of participants that were looking for work or on layoff when recruiting for the second round of interviews to continue monitoring this question for comprehension.

Question 38

Research Question: Changed response options.
Q38. During the weeks (you/they) were not working, what was the main reason? ▪ Temporary injury, illness, or other health concern - ▪ Chronic health condition or disability ▪ Retired ▪ Pregnancy or childbirth ▪ Taking care of children or others ▪ Going to school ▪ Not interested in working ▪ Some other reason
n = 5

Findings:**How did respondents decide which response option to choose? What did they think about the response options? How did they decide on “main” reason if multiple reason applied?**

- Of the five participants that received this question, they found it to be clear and each participant was able to provide a “main” reason for not working.
 - One participant (P2373) explained that he is retired, but does have a chronic health condition or disability, and is currently going to school. However, since the question asked for the main reason, then he considers that ‘retired.’

- One participant (P2646) said that this should have preceded the previous question (Q36) as it would have made more sense to him.
- Another participant (P2646) is also retired and had no difficulty selecting a response. However, he said the bottom two responses look redundant to him.

Are any of them unclear or confusing?

- One participant (P2373) did not find the responses unclear or confusing, but was concerned about the wording on one response, explaining, “I think ‘not interested in working’ is worded in kind of an insulting way... it's a value judgment I believe in Western society. If reading it from an Eastern culture.... the idea of saying not interested is potentially offensive to people. It might not be that they weren't interested, it might be that I chose not to work at a certain time...”

If “Some other reason”: Probe on possible reasons.

- One participant (P2283) explained that the reason was personal after selecting “Some other reason.” However, it was clear to this participant that it would not fall under one of the existing categories.

Were there any periods where they were “in between jobs” in the sense that they had another job, but it wasn’t starting yet?

- No participants received this probe.
- While only five participants received the question, overall, the question performed well.

Recommendations:

Consistent with the recommendation for Q32, consider underlining or bolding the words ‘main reason’ to help respondents focus on the most important reason for why they did not look for work.

Continue to monitor this question in the second round of interviews.

Consider the revision:

Q38. During the weeks (you/they) were not working, what was the main reason?

- Temporary injury, illness, or other health concern -
- Chronic health condition or disability
- Retired
- Pregnancy or childbirth
- Taking care of children or others
- Going to school
- Not interested in working
- Some other reason

Question 39

Research Question: No changes made. Do respondents understand the instructions in this question?
Q39. For how many employers did (you/^name) work in 2023? If you worked for more than one employer at the same time, only count it as one employer. ▪ One ▪ Two ▪ Three or more
n = 23

Findings:

- One participant (P2373) noted that the question does not reference "paid", explaining, "I'm going to say three or more because... it doesn't say paid here.... If your specific question is if you worked in a paid capacity, then you could ask that question, and my answer would change."

Did they read: If (name/you) worked for more than one employer at the same time, only count it as one employer? What did it mean to them?

- In total, 17 participants read the instruction and 6 participants did not read the instruction.
- Of the participants that did not read the instruction, one (P2246) changed the response to "One" after reading the instruction, having just told the interviewer that the two employers overlapped at the same time.
- Thirteen participants were confused by the instruction or found the wording or the instruction to be awkward.
 - One participant (P2253) explained, "It was a little tricky...If you worked for more than one employer at the same time, only count it as one... I am not sure exactly what that means."
 - Another participant (P2619) expressed a similar concern, "Yeah but I think it doesn't make sense to me, like why are you telling me that if I work for more than one employer... at the same time, I don't know if that's the same day, the same week, I don't know whatever that means, ... let's say... within the same week... I've done this before... I've walked a dog, done a focus group, maybe gone to the [NAME OF FACILITY]... I wouldn't count some of the side stuff as an employer, but if I did the catering thing with the guy, yes... and even though it wasn't taxable, I would consider him as an employer, and the same thing as the 1099 thing for the IX center, so I don't know why I would consider that one-- two separate entities-- that doesn't make sense."
 - An additional participant (P2709) explained, "That was a little confusing. For me, what I was thinking is, I work for the law school and the medical school, but it's all [employer name], so that's one employer in my mind. But if I worked for more than one employer at the same time, to only count it as one employer seems confusing to me...So if I were working one week and I worked a couple days for [employer name] and a couple days for [other organization name], it seems odd to count that as one employer."

- Finally, another participant (P2283) suggested splitting this into two questions. The first question would ask “How many employers did you work for in 2023?” then if you select two or three or more, you receive a follow-up question asking if you worked for any of the employers at the same time.

If they did work for more than one employer at a time, how did they come to choose their response?

- Of the participants that worked for more than one employer at the same time, some counted them as one and others counted them separately. This may have been a reflection of the confusion they had over the instruction within the question.
- One participant (P2246) explained, "Another self-employed tricky one because I do work with two employers so maybe that's what I should focus in on. I think that's what I would do... So, I do work with two employers who I contract with. But I also provide services for a number of clients. But I do, now that I'm saying that out loud, I do think that's separate from 'employer'. So, I think I would just focus on the two instead of answering three or more." Earlier, the participant explained that he worked for these employers at the same time.

There was a lot of confusion among participants in how to interpret the instruction, “If you worked for more than one employer at the same time, only count it as one employer.” This likely resulted in error when participants had more than one job, which often overlapped.

Recommendations:

Respondents do not understand the instruction consistently and this is resulting in significant misreporting. We recommend the SMEs reconsider the target of interest with this question and how to better conceptualize a shift in employment over the span of a year that better aligns with how the majority of Americans work. SMEs should consider what they are trying to measure here and whether we could ask about it in a different way.

Question 41

Research Question: Deleting the total number of hours in a week as an instruction.
Q41. In the [fill # week/weeks form Q33] that (you/^name) worked, how many hours did (you/they) usually work per week? _____ hours
<i>n</i> = 23

Question	<i>n</i>	min	max	mean	median
Q41	23	4.5	50	36	40

Findings:

The participants did not have any difficulty deciding on a response, providing an average in most cases. Responses included: 4.5, 5, 8, 14, 22, 25(n=2), 30(n=2), 40(n=11), 45(n=2), 44, and 50(n=2)

While completing the question, several participants provided spontaneous comments:

- One participant (P2310) recommended we offer ranges (e.g., 40-45 hours) as some weeks it might be 40, 50 or more. A range would be helpful.
- Some participants noted a programming error, "In the all week" when the check box was selected in question 33.
 - One participant (P2646) typed in "4-6 hours" and then received an error "Please enter a valid number" so he changed this to "4.5" and was able to go to the next question.
 - Another participant (P3022) commented, "Oh, that's easy."

Did the R work the same number of hours each week? Did their work hours or work schedule change throughout the year? Do they work more than one job? How did they determine the usual number of hours to report?

- When asked if participants worked the same number of hours per week, 7 participants responded "Yes" and 15 responded "No."
- Participants that worked more or less each week, provided an average when responding.
 - One participant (P2285) explained, "It varies... I work for Amazon, ok some weeks we're very busy and I can work 52 hours, other weeks... I could work 40 hours... the 44 would come out to about an average."
- When asked if participants worked more than one job, 3 participants said "Yes" and 8 said "No"
 - One participant (P2246) that worked multiple jobs combined all of the hours together across multiple jobs worked. Another participant with multiple jobs (P2289) also estimated based on the average of hours of all jobs in a typical week.

In general, participants found the question easy to understand and did not encounter any challenges in creating an average in response to the question.

Recommendations:

In line with the recommendation for Q36, consider reducing the size of the numeric box to allow for up to 2-digits with the label "hours per week" to the right of the box to ensure respondents understand we are looking for a numeric response.

Question 43

Research Question: This is lower priority for round 1 cognitive testing. No changes made.
Q43. Were there one or more weeks where (you/^name) worked less than 35 hours? Do not count time off with pay like holidays, vacation, or sick leave.

▪ Yes ▪ No
<i>n</i> = 15

Findings:

- The participants found this question clear and did not have any challenges. One participant (2310) explained, "That's pretty easy to understand."
- When asked if they had read the second sentence to not count time off with pay like holidays, fourteen participants had read the sentence while two did not read the sentence.
 - One participant (2369) initially answered "Yes" until the interviewer probed on whether they saw the second sentence. The participant then changed their response to "No."

Recommendations:

No changes recommended.

Question 44

Research Question: Deleting the total number of hours in a week as an instruction.
Q44. How many weeks did (you/they) work less than 35 hours? _____ weeks
<i>n</i> = 10

Question	<i>n</i>	min	max	mean	median
Q41	10	5	52	28	12

Findings:**How well do respondents remember the number of weeks? How did respondents come up with their answer (thought process)?**

- Overall, the question seemed easy for participants to answer, and they provided values such as: 5, 6, 10 (n=2), 12, 30, 48, and 52 (n=3)
 - One participant (P2464) explained that this was a little tricky to answer as she doesn't work 35 hours in a week. Furthermore, she tried to enter entered "all of them" but the instrument would not accept letter characters, so she changed entry to "48." Another participant (P2619) explained, "I haven't worked a 40 hour a week job since probably the late 80s."
- The participants all remembered the instruction about not counting time off with pay, except one participant (P2369) who entered "0" and then returned to Q32 and changed her response to "No."

Recommendations:

To be consistent with the recommendation for Q36, consider reducing the size of the numeric box to allow for up to 2-digits while retaining the label “weeks” to the right of the box to ensure respondents understand we are looking for a numeric response.

The question does not include a time frame, but it would be assumed that the question is referencing weeks in 2023 as the context was established in previous questions. However, we may still consider adding a reference period for consistency. Many respondents may have part time employment and regularly work fewer than 35 hours per week, consider adding a check box similar to the one offered earlier, with the revision recommended in previous questions, for consistency.

Consider the following revisions:

Q44. In 2023, how many weeks did (you/they) work less than 35 hours?

_____ weeks

[] all 52 weeks in 2023

Question 45

Research Question: Changed response options.
Q45. What was the main reason (you/they) worked less than 35 hours per week? ▪ Job was part-time ▪ Seasonal work ▪ Business was slow ▪ Weather conditions ▪ Physically unable to work full time ▪ Caring for family or personal obligation ▪ Some other reason
n = 10

Findings:**What did they think about the response options? Are any of them unclear or confusing?**

- All the participants felt the question was clear. Only one participant (P2770) was unsure about one category, explaining, "I think personal obligation is kind of... I don't really know what that would mean..."

How did they decide which response option to choose? How did they decide on “main” reason if multiple reason applied?

- In most cases, participants explained that there was only one reason that applied so it was easy for them to select a response. When multiple responses did apply, participants were able to decide on a ‘main’ reason.

- Only two participants indicated wanting to select more than one option. One participant (P2245) tried to select more than one option.
- Another participant (P2770) was surprised that the question did not allow for multiple responses.

If “Some other reason”: what were the reasons.

- Other reasons included “End of project – although participant has considered ‘business was slow’ as an option”, “Job was part time with some being seasonal work and sometimes weather related, so this participant selected ‘Other.’”
- Overall, the participants found the question easy to understand and were able to select a main reason for working less than 35 hours per week.

Recommendations:

Consistent with the recommendation for Q32, consider underlining or bolding the words ‘main reason’ to help respondents focus on the most important reason for why they did not look for work.

Consider adding response category “attending school or classes” as this is a likely reason for why a respondent might work less than 35 hours per week.

Consider the following revision:

Q45. What was the main reason (you/they) worked less than 35 hours per week?

- Job was part-time
- Seasonal work
- Business was slow
- Weather conditions
- Physically unable to work full time
- Caring for family or personal obligation
- Attending school or classes
- Some other reason

Question 45a

Research Question: New question. Q45 had 2 responses about reasons for “unable to do full time work” which were combined to one. Here we get the reasons.

Q45a. Why were (you/they) physically unable to work full time?

Injury

Short-term illness

Chronic health condition or disability

Some other reason

n = 0

Findings:

If “Some other reason”: what were the reasons.

Where do respondents include mental or emotional health?

- No participants received this question.

Recommendations:

No participants received this question, and it may be difficult to recruit participants in the second round of interviewing that were ‘physically unable to work full time.’ During the second round of interviews, it may be useful to display this question to participants, even though it does not apply, to get their feedback on the wording.

Question 47a

Research Question: This is lower priority for round 1 cognitive testing. Question and answer categories remained the same.
Q47a. What employer did (name/you) work for the longest in 2023? Employer name: _____
n = 22

Findings:

If they work in more than one employer in 2023, how did they determine which one was the longest?

- Most of the participants did not find it difficult to determine which employer they worked for the longest in 2023 as they talked through their response.
- Several participants (P2464, P2619, and P2770) mentioned “gig” work which made it more complicated as it was either not consistent, or they had no way to track how much work was completed.
 - One participant (P2464) explained, “I’m not even sure...I would honestly... Probably...skip this question... I don’t really want to guess.”

If they work multiple jobs for the same amount of time, how did they determine which one to put?

- One participant (P2246) explained, “Just because this one that I have here [company name], I again, on average, tend to work with them more frequently. For a second, I had to stop and ask what are they asking? Are they asking who am I worked with for the longest? But no, we’re just honing-in on the ‘2023’ part.” In this case, the participant interpreted ‘longest’ to mean the greatest number of hours, rather than the length of time with the employer.
- For participants with traditional employment (worked for a specific employer), this question is not very difficult. However, this is more challenging for participants that worked “gig” work or some other arrangement that cannot easily be identified in this question. They will likely explain this in the text field which may require some back-end coding during analysis.

Recommendations:

Consider the following revision:

Of the employers you worked for in 2023, which did you work for the longest?

Question 47e1

Research Question: Moving the class of worker questions up before the industry and occupations questions. This location is where ACS currently asks it. Option A for an A/B test but asked for all.

Q47e1. Which best describes {Employer Name from Q47a}?

- Government
- Private for-profit company
- Non-profit organization including tax exempt and charitable organizations
- Self-employed
- Family business

***n* = 25**

Findings:

Did more than one response apply? Which ones and how did you choose the “best”?

- Most participants found this question to be clear and easy to answer as one response generally fit the description of their employer. However, some participants (P3022, P2771, P2286, P2595, P2961) had to think through multiple categories that could apply.
 - One participant (P3022) found it challenging to determine a response, explaining, "Like I said, I actually paid into social security, but it was considered tax-free income... should I say the government?... I'm just going to put government or family business..." However, this participant also considered the "Non-profit" category.
 - One participant (P2771) found it difficult to answer on behalf of his roommate, explaining, "I'm not too sure. I don't know too much about what he does... what his work is categorized as. Um, I just know that he kind of, you know, does his work with a few other people and, um, they all kind of work together and get everything done. So, it's not really something where it's like a government opportunity or something like that."
 - One participant (P2286) worked for a family-owned business, although they explained that the employer is in it for profit so that it the category they selected. Another participant (P2303) explained this was also the case for their employer and would have preferred to select both options, explaining, "I needed it to be like two, I think. As far as I said for family business then it's still understandable that it comes to be for profits sake on a normal scale. So that's why I just go with family business more. But if there's an option to pick two, I'm going to pick 'Private for-profit company' then 'family.'"
 - One participant (P2961) had to consider several responses that could apply, "When I think of my company, I first think of, it's privately owned, it is privately owned by a family, but it's also a for-profit business, so what is it

primarily? Well, it's a private for-profit company primarily... But it's also owned by family stakeholders."

- Another participant (P2332) explained that he works for himself, but his sister has worked for him in the past so this could be a 'family business' but he could also consider himself 'self-employed', ultimately, he selected 'self-employed.'

Did you read/need the additional text "including tax exempt and charitable organizations" or is "non-profit org" enough?

- Participants did read the extra text. However, one participant (p2373) felt that if you worked for a 'Non-profit' then you would know that this would include tax exempt and charitable organizations. However, he felt that we should keep the text in the response.
- This question is not mutually exclusive which adds to the challenge of determining a response (e.g., a family-owned business that is for profit), however, it does ask respondents to select the response that "best" described the business. After thinking through the responses, the participants were able to come up with a response that "best" describes their employer.

Recommendations:

Consistent with the recommendation of Q33, when this question is asked of other household members, beginning with the first loop of questions, consider adding a "Don't know/Unsure" response option to reduce respondent burden and avoid inaccurate responses.

Question 47e1a

Research Question: Option A for an A/B test but asked for all.
Q47e1a. Which one of the following best describes {Employer Name from Q47a}? ▪ Federal - (Federal government civilian employee) ▪ Active Duty (U.S. Armed Forces or Commissioned Corps) ▪ State (including state colleges/universities) ▪ Local (county, city, township) (city or county school district)
n = 2

Findings:

- Only two participants received this question, and both found it easy to understand.

Do you need the extra information in the parentheses to find the right response?

- Both participants found this to be helpful.

Did participant automatically know if it's federal, state, or local? Do they need the extra information?

- One participant (P2512) said she might have gone with federal if the word 'county' hadn't been in the 'local' definition, as she had ruled out 'active duty' and 'state.' It was not clear whether this participant misinterpreted this as "country."

- Another participant (P2709) had previously mentioned that the last question was easy because their employer is state-run.

Recommendations:

With only two participants that received this question, there were few findings to base any recommendations. Continue to observe this question in the second round of cognitive testing.

Question 47e1b

Research Question: Option A for an A/B test but asked for all.
Q47e1b. Was {employer name from Q47a} incorporated?
▪ Yes ▪ No
<i>n</i> = 5

Findings:

There were no scripted probes for this question. However, participants provided some spontaneous comments.

- One participant (P2245) answered “yes” assuming that an ‘LLC’ means that the business is ‘incorporated.’ Another participant (P2464) did not think she was incorporated but was not sure.
- Another participant (P2332) explained, “I don't know what the question means... Is it a business, is that what it's asking? Uh, maybe it's asking if it's an official business or, like... yeah, I think that's what it's asking.”

Recommendations:

With only five participants that received this question, there were few findings to base any recommendations. However, it seems clear that a definition of “incorporated” should be considered by the SMEs.

Continue to observe this question in the second round of cognitive testing.

Question 47e1c

Research Question: Option A for an A/B test but asked for all.
Q47e1c. Were/Was you/ ^name the owner of {employer name from Q47a}?
▪ Yes ▪ No
<i>n</i> = 0

Findings:

No participants received this question.

Recommendations:

This question should have been asked of all Q47e1=5 (working in family business), which should have been two participants. However, no participants received this question (see **Appendix F** for full list of programming errors). Programming should be updated, and we should continue to test with the intended population in round two of cognitive interviewing.

Continue to observe this question in the second round of cognitive testing.

Question 47e1_combined

Research Question: This question-and-answer format has previously been cognitively tested in ACS. However, it was not determined if in ISR, respondents cognitively prefer the sequential class of worker questions or a single longer list question.

Option B for an A/B test. Collapsing questions Q47e1 – Q47e1c into a single question. Does revising question impact respondent's understanding?

Q47e1_combined. Which one of the following best describes {Employer Name from Q47a}?

Private Sector:

- For-profit company or organization
- Non-profit organization (including tax-exempt and charitable organizations)

Government:

- Local government (for example: city or county school district)
- State government (including state colleges/universities)
- Active Duty U.S. Armed Forces or Commissioned Corps service
- Federal government civilian employee

Self-Employed or Other:

- Own non-incorporated business, professional practice, or farm
- Own incorporated business, professional practice, or farm
- Worked without pay in a for-profit family business or farm for 15 hours or more per week

n = 13

Findings:

How easy/difficult is it to find the best response?

- About half of the participants who received this question struggled with finding the best response because they were unsure of the response options or thought there were too many options listed.
- One participant (P2277) was confused, explaining, "I think we should skip this one because I'm not really too sure exactly what it is."
- A participant (P2619) felt responses 7 and 8 were confusing as they include "own" which made her think she needed to own the business.
- One participant (P2245) felt there were a lot of categories, explaining, "This one with all the options, it's a little overwhelming going through them all, but they're all pretty clear." Another participant (P2310) had a similar concern, "Too many options here." Two other participants (P2369 and P2595) felt there were a lot of options.

- A participant (p2277) had difficulty selecting a response for another person in their household as he was not sure how to classify his job/business and didn't want to select the wrong one.
- There appears to be a programming error, see **Appendix F**, as the question did not show up for six participants (P2238, P2303, P2332, P2246, P2646, P2417).

How much of this are respondents reading?

- Eight participants reported reading through the full list of responses (P2277, P2286, P2310, P2332, P2595, P2619, P2770, P3022).
- Five participants read through half the list or less: (P2245, P2285, P2289, P2361, and P2369)

Are the section headings helpful or confusing? Do respondents try to pick one option under each heading?

- No participants commented about the section headings.

Do respondents prefer the current sequential question for class of worker (Q47e1-Q47e1c), or a singular question (Class of Worker Alternative).

- In general, participants preferred the shorter question (Q47e1) as only a few participants received more than one question. Nine participants preferred the first (shorter decomposed) version while four preferred the second version (condensed – single question). A few others did not have a preference.
 - One participant (P2245) explained, "I prefer the first one. But if I were to have been somebody involved in the other things, like government or military...I could see liking all those options. But I feel like it's kind of overwhelming to have so many options."

Recommendations:

Due to a programming error, this question was not viewed by six participants. However, two-thirds of the participants that did receive this question preferred the first (shorter) version, likely because most did not need to answer any follow up questions. We recommend proceeding with Option A from the experiment, even with the missing data from the programming error. Most respondents will not need to answer follow-up questions, and see it as lower burden to view the short list in Q47e1. If desired, we could retest these questions in round two to collect more data, after the programming fix is implemented.

Research Question: This is lower priority for round 1 cognitive testing. Question and answer categories remained the same.

Q4788. Counting all locations where {employer name) operates, what was the total number of employees in 2023?

- 1- 9
- 10-49
- 50-99
- 100-499
- 500-999
- 1,000+ or more

<i>n</i> = 25

Findings:

- There were no scripted probes for this question, however, participants provided the following spontaneous comments.
 - Several participants (P2246, P2310, P2417, P2512, P2646) explained that they were providing an estimate/guess as to the number of employees. One participant (P2646) suggested we include a 'Don't know/Not sure' option.
 - One participant (P2283) was confused as he has multiple employers. He wasn't sure how to respond, explaining, "...for people who works for two employees, like me... you're talking about both?" This may have been confusing as this participant refused to enter an employer name in a previous question so there was nothing that could be filled in this question.

Recommendations:

No recommendations.

Question 47b

Research Question: This is lower priority for round 1 cognitive testing. This question has previously been cognitively tested in ACS. The same question is also undergoing testing in the CPS basic. Revising question wording and examples for ISR.
--

Q47b. What kind of business or industry is {Employer Name from Q47a}?

Include the main activity, product, or service provided at the location where employed. (For example: elementary school, residential construction)

Kind of Business: _____

<i>n</i> = 14

Findings:**Do respondents understand that we are asking for a description of the industry?****Does revising question impact respondent's understanding?**

- Of the 14 participants that responded to this question, 11 described the business or industry they work in (answered question correctly), while 3 participants (P2286, P2595, P2619) did not answer the question correctly and described their role in the company (did not answer question correctly).
 - One participant (P3022) entered, "Healthcare." After noticing the "main activity" text in the question, she added 'patient care.'

How do people respond when multiple products or services are provided by the business they work for?

- The participants explained that there were multiple products or services provided, but they described the industry and included the main products/services that came to mind or in terms of how important they are to the overall business.

- One participant (P2369) focused on the services/products produced by her department. Another participant (P2285) responded in a similar way focusing on his section as he is unfamiliar with the operations for other sections.
- One participant (P2289), who works for Walmart, kept it broad by entering 'Multinational retail industry' as there were too many products to list.

How do they respond when they are home-based workers (e.g., work from home either as self-employed or for a company)?

- The participants explained the service or product they provide. For example, one self-employed participant (P2245) entered 'Furniture restoration, workshop.' Another participant (P2277) entered 'recruitment.'
- In general, participants were able to provide a description of the business or industry in which they work. However, a few participants described the role in their company.

Recommendations:

Consider asking Q47c before Q47b / Q47b1 which should address the concern of respondents describing their role in the company in Q47b.

Consider adding an additional example: (For example: elementary school, retail (such as, Walmart or CVS), residential construction).

Q47b. What kind of business or industry is {Employer Name from Q47a}?

Include the main activity, product, or service provided at the location where employed. (For example: elementary school, retail (such as, Walmart or CVS) residential construction)

Kind of Business: _____

Question 47b1

Research Question: This is lower priority for round 1 cognitive testing.

Nothing specific to report back. This question is used to help NPC clerical coding staff determine the best code for industry.

Q47b1. Is this business or organization mainly manufacturing, retail trade, wholesale trade, or something else?

- Manufacturing
- Retail trade
- Wholesale trade
- Something else

n = 15

Findings:

There were no scripted probes for this question.

- Eight participants selected "Something else" explaining that they would characterize this as: "Service" "Recruiting" "Analyst" "Product designer" "Social worker" "Server" "Researcher" or "Nurse."

Recommendations:

While this is a lower priority question, more than half of the participants selected "Something else" and provided a response. This may be an item that the SMEs might want to review to determine more appropriate or additional responses options to include here.

Question 47c

Research Question: This is lower priority for round 1 cognitive testing. This question has previously been cognitively tested in ACS. This same question is also undergoing testing in the CPS basic. Revising question wording and examples for ISR.

Q47c. What kind of work were (you/they) doing at {employer name from Q47a}?

For example: 4th grade teacher, entry-level plumber

Main Occupation: _____

n = 26

Findings:

What do people report when they do not have an official job title? Do they know how to answer?

- Overall, participants did not have challenges in completing this question.
- Of the 26 participants that responded to this question, 22 described their role in the company (answered question correctly), while 4 participants (P2283, P2273, P2474, P2770) provided a vague response.
- Twelve participants provided their official title, while the others described the work they do.
 - One participant (P2770) explained, "I don't really know how specific this question is supposed to be. Especially because my title is field specialist, which doesn't really mean anything... Doesn't describe anything. And explaining my job is... I don't really know how to do it in a text box. I do a lot of things."
 - Another participant (P2246) did not know their title but were able to describe the work they do by entering 'Voiceover talent' and explaining, "That's pretty much how I would describe it. I do voiceover work with them."
- The participants did not have any difficulty answering this question. However, 4 participants provided a vague response.

Recommendations:

As recommended in Q47b, consider asking Q47c before Q47b / Q47b1 which should address the concern of respondents describing their role in the company in Q47b.

Question 47d1

Research Question: This is lower priority for round 1 cognitive testing. This question has previously been cognitively tested in ACS. This same question is also undergoing testing in the CPS basic. Revising question wording and examples for ISR.
Q47d1. What were (your/their) most important activities or duties? For example: instruct and evaluate students and create lesson plans, assemble and install pipe sections and review building plans for work details. Job Duties: _____
n = 6

Findings:

- There appears to be a programming error, see **Appendix F**, as the question did not show up for several participants (P2283, P2285, P2369, P2417)

Does revising question impact respondent's understanding?

- Overall, participants did not have challenges in completing this question.
- Of the 6 participants that responded to this question, 5 participants (P2245, P2283, P2289, P2232, P2369) described their most important activities or duties (answered question correctly), while 1 participant (P2277) provided a vague response.

Are the most important ones listed first?

- Two participants (P2245 and P2369) explained that the list includes the duties that take the most time.
- Another participant (P2289) just entered them as they came to his mind.

Do respondents understand that these should be the most important activities at their job (the one described in 47a) and not in general? How did respondents decide on the order of their duties -- what activities were most important?

- The participants listed their most important activities. One participant (P2245) explained that the ones he listed "happen the most." Another participant (P2289) explained that these were the "main duties."
- Another participant (P2332), who responded on behalf of a household member, explained that this was a brief description of they do at work but explained that he wasn't entirely sure of everything they do at work.

Recommendations:

No recommendations. Continue to monitor this question during the second round of interviews.

6.2 Income Questions

6.2.1 Earned Income

Question 48a_source

Research Question: This is a new question that combines all earnings sources into one question. Currently, salary or wages are asked about separately from the other sources. This format will bring all earnings sources together in one question and will follow a format consistent with other income source questions.

Q48a_source. Select all the types of income that (^name/you) received from [fill employer] during 2023.

- Salary or wages
- Tips
- Bonuses
- Overtime pay
- Commissions

n = 22

Findings:

How many respondents had difficulty or confusion with the response options?

- All participants reported no issues differentiating between the different types of income.
- However, some participants (n=9) believed there may be some response options missing. Examples of potential missing forms of income included pay raises (e.g., holiday pay), prepayment for supplies for work, contract work paid on a per-project basis, stocks (n=2), tuition reimbursement, non-monetary incentives (e.g., cat food given in addition to other forms of payment), retroactive pay.
 - For example, explaining how they are paid on a per-project basis, one participant (P2245) stated "I don't know what I would phrase it as, but I do think there are probably other people that get paid by project or by doing a service."
 - Four participants (P2289, P2961, P2303, P2283) reported income of "commissions." Two participants agreed that commissions are income from their employer because the payment is based on how much is sold and commissions are paid by their employer as additional profit.
 - One additional participant (P2332) who did not report earning commissions was confused about this response option, stating "I think commissions is a little confusing. Because I think commission is salary... I thought commission was, like, money that you're getting."

Was anyone who regularly receives tips confused by the question wording?

- Only three participants (P2619, P2332, P2303) reported receiving tips themselves or for someone else in the household, and these participants had different understandings of who paid tips (i.e., their employer or their customers/patrons).
- Two (P2303, P2619) believed that tips were part of their income from their employer. One of these participants (P2619) explained that if she wasn't working

for her employer, she wouldn't get the tips. However, another participant (P2332) believed that tips were payments they received directly from the client for doing a good job.

- These issues stem from the question wording asking about "income that you received from [employer]." While participants have different understandings of who pays out tips, they seem able to select the appropriate response option without much difficulty.
- One participant (P2283) volunteered that they were confused about the response option "tips." This participant wondered whether the question was asking about tips that come from their company. They talked through an example of being a delivery driver and receiving tips but did not think that tips applied in their case in an office setting. The wording of the question seemed to have made them uncertain about whether tips could be paid out by an employer.

Overall, this question is easy for participants to understand. They were able to review the response options and select which options apply for themselves and others in their household. However, there was some minor confusion around the response option "tips" because of the question wording of "income that you received from [employer]."

Unfortunately, we have limited data on "tips" since only three participants reported any tipped income. These participants varied on their understanding of who pays out tips, however, all of them selected the response option "tips" without major issues.

Recommendations:

Due to the limited data, we recommend consulting with SMEs about whether the language of "tips" could be confusing in this context. We may want to consider altering the question text to exclude the direct reference to participants' employers. However, with the current evidence, those who do have tipped income are able to report this accurately. We can continue to monitor this question during the second round of interviews, as is or with SME-suggested changes.

Question 48a_amount, 48a_per

Research Question: This question was created by combining several periodicity and amount questions for earnings (Q48aa/Q48aap/Q48a1/Q48av). The goal is to reduce cognitive burden by grouping together related income items, and to reduce burden by reducing the number of screens and the amount of text respondents must read through. The amount of text seen will vary depending on how many sources they reported and whether they follow the default periodicity. The goal of this new set up is to be able to get tips separately. All sources are separate now because that MAY be easier for the respondent, so we want to look at that. The goal is to at minimum have tips separated out.

Q48_per_you. Enter the amount that you received, before taxes and other deductions, from rti in 2023.

Salary or wages	
Total	0

☒ I want to report monthly or in a different way.



Q48b_amount_you. Enter the total amount you received, before taxes and other deductions, from this employer in 2023.

	Enter Amount	Choose Frequency	Number of Payments	Total
Salary or wages		weekly		0

n Q48a_amount = 23

n Q48_per = 13*

*Some participants reviewed Q48_per to see what other format was available and provided a final response on Q48a_amount; at least five participants were presented Q48_per due to a programming error when they did not select the checkbox.

Administration notes: Participants were primarily asked to report their own income, but were asked to report up to one other person in the household. If more than one other person in the household, only the first was asked about. Subsequent questions for other household members were skipped. The counts of participants above are those who saw at least one of the questions, whether it asked about themselves, someone else in the house, or both.

Findings:**Did respondents understand that they were to sum for the entire year? Do respondents like reporting the amount yearly or would they have preferred to report it differently?**

- Most participants understood that the question asked them to sum for the entire year, however three participants did not understand that they should report the sum for the entire year. Two of these participants entered other amounts than yearly; one (P2646) entered weekly amount, and the other (P2286) entered hourly amount. Another participant (P2253) questioned whether overtime pay should be reported as hourly or yearly but decided it should be yearly and responded appropriately.
 - For example, P2286 asked "Is this hourly or a total do you know? Do I put hourly?" This participant entered "15.00 hr" into the text box, which triggered an error that said, "Please exclude commas and if necessary, use a point as a decimal separate." The participant realized that the text "hr" may be triggering the error and removed it for his final response of "15." He also reported a yearly amount for his bonus.
 - One participant (P2434) reported 2,100 for the year, which did not seem to match with her description of the job; a full-time job which she worked for 40 weeks in the year. It is unclear whether she reported a periodic amount instead of yearly or omitted a "0."
 - One participant (P2417) struggled to respond because they did not work the entire year, sharing, "Since I didn't work the whole year, I'm trying to figure out how I would calculate that." This response reflects the high respondent burden of this question.
- A few participants struggled with the wording of the question "before taxes and other deductions."
 - One participant (P2283) was stuck on understanding this phrase and after rereading several times seemed to understand. They thought that "Gross pay, I think, that's probably more straight forward."
 - One participant (P2770) pulled up their W2 statement during the interview but saw that the W2 reports total with taxes taken out. The participant was not sure how to get a total "before taxes and other deductions" (per the wording of the question) and thought that if it was too hard, they would just skip the question.

Do respondents notice and understand the checkbox for reporting for different time periods?

- Eight participants were unclear what the checkbox was used for. Even those who understood that the checkbox could be used to report in a different way were sometimes surprised by the format of the second screen, as discussed below.
- Four participants (P2595, P2332, P2283, P2770) did not see the checkbox until probed by the interviewer. If the current format is retained, two participants (P2283, P2246) preferred for the checkbox to be featured higher up on the screen. P2283 thought that it would make it easier for people to see and consider reporting in a different way before trying to use the first question. P2246 shared,

- "I noticed [the checkbox] before I started entering in the digits up there, but I think it would really jump out at me more if it was up top."
- Additionally, P2283 did not realize at first that he needed to click the arrow to view the alternative response options and was confused when he clicked the checkbox, and nothing happened.
 - Two participants thought the checkbox would give them the option to refuse to answer (P2310) or indicate they did not know the answer (P2646).

Would they prefer being asked how they want to report the amount first?

- Fourteen participants indicated they would prefer to pick the way to report first. These participants more often have irregular pay, multiple jobs, and are not salaried, which make reporting yearly totals more difficult.
 - One participant (P2595) completed calculations on their phone to report a yearly total and would prefer to report monthly and have the total calculated automatically.
 - A few participants who are salaried yearly indicated it would be better to ask for everyone, even though in their case they would prefer to report yearly. This indicates that participants do not see asking about how to report first as significantly increasing burden.
 - One participant (P2770) stated they would prefer to respond with a range rather than a single number, sharing "I feel like I'd be a lot more confident in just reporting a range... Even in overtime pay I think I would feel more confident giving a range... Number feels very... have to be more correct than a range where there's a little more forgiveness."

How do respondents feel about reporting income amounts separately? Would the respondent prefer to report some of these all together?

- Seven participants found the types of income difficult to report separately. Of these seven, four participants (P2253, P2285, P2770, P2595) found overtime pay especially difficult to report. These participants store their hourly rate in their memory, but do not have the ability to recall their total overtime pay. The question does not match how participants have the information stored in their minds. Many would not look for records to answer this question, and even if they did, it would find it difficult to find records that have a single number for total overtime pay before taxes and deductions.
 - One participant (P2770) shared, "I don't really know if I can remember. Especially the breakdown with overtime pay. Like, I would have to check my tax pay... I know I got overtime pay, but I could not tell you what that would be." This participant did pull up their W2 during the interview and shared that the W2 didn't have overtime listed. He stated he has the total easily available but not the breakdown.
 - Another participant (P2595) described that overtime was difficult to report about because the number of overtime hours varied drastically throughout the year. He knew the amount he was getting paid for overtime but could not estimate the number of overtime hours he may have worked in the year. He would rather report all of his income as one number rather than separately.
 - The other three participants mentioned that reporting one single number would be easier, though they could produce estimates of the individual types of income.

- Almost all participants provided a rounded number ending in “0” for their response. One participant (P2310) shared that he would always round to the next 5 figure amount. Twelve participants explicitly stated that their response was an estimate. Six participants (P2285, P2961, P2770, P2646, P2245, P2417) indicated that they wanted to reference their records, such as tax returns or W2s, to provide a more accurate response.
 - For example, one participant (P2961) shared, "Unless I pulled up my last paycheck from my company... I would be estimating these numbers...to be accurate, I actually would pull up my paystub."
 - Another participant (P2310) refused to answer and stated that he would skip the question and never provide this information on a Census survey.

How many respondents had difficulty? What would make more sense if they were confused?

- Fourteen of the 23 participants who responded had difficulties with this question. These issues have been mentioned in more detail on other sections, but this summarizes all challenges encountered on the question.
 - Three participants (P2286, P2434, P2646) misreported and provided hourly or weekly totals instead of a yearly sum. Another participant (P2253) was confused about whether they should report yearly or hourly.
 - One participant (P2310) refused to report due to sensitivity concerns, as stated "It's not a burden, I just don't feel the Census should need that information."
 - One participant (P2277) could not report for the other person in their household.
 - Six participants (P2283, P2285, P2770, P2245, P2417, P2595) experienced high respondent burden when answering the question. Some of these participants struggled specifically with the breakdown of income types.
 - Two participants (P2619, P2289) did not understand or see the checkbox, which would have made their reporting experience significantly easier due to their income type.

For grid question:

Is the grid format of asking for amounts, periodicity, and number of payments easy for respondents to understand?

- Two participants (P2619, P2434) thought the format of the screen after clicking the checkbox was confusing. One participant (P2619) noted that the screen was still asking for yearly amount, because the drop-down boxes were blank, and it was not immediately clear to her that she could click in the box to report a different time frame, see below.

Q48b Alternative Question				
Q48b_amount_you. Enter the total amount you received, before taxes and other deductions, from this employer in 2023.				
Salary or wages	Enter Amount	Choose Frequency	Number of Payments	Total
				0
← →				

Is there any part of this format that makes it difficult to follow?

- Most participants did not have significant issues responding to this question, and instead had other issues with their response process as outlined above.
- Several participants had issues with the screen formatting.
 - Two (P2961, P2310) disliked the hard coded 0 that needed to be removed before typing their response. One (P2310) also preferred to have hardcoded commas and a dollar sign to further indicate that the response is a dollar amount.
 - One participant (P2283) refused to provide a name for their employer, which caused an empty fill for this question. This blank fill made the question confusing for the participant, who was unsure whether they should report their income for only one of the companies they worked for or both.

Does having the confirmation of the total annual amount help respondents to catch errors? Do they know the combined total in order to check this number?

- Seven participants found the total helpful while four thought it was not very helpful. The participants who did not find the total helpful reported a single total income, so the total number repeated the number they reported. Those who think the total is helpful reported multiple types of income and to make sure the numbers reported matched their total yearly income.

Are there any changes or improvements that respondents would recommend to make these question easier for them to answer?

- Some participants would like changes to the question. As mentioned above, fourteen participants preferred to be asked the reporting period before reporting, which was the most prominent change requested.

- Six participants (P2332, P2434, P2285, P2709, P2361, P2283) suggested additional changes that they wanted to make to the question wording and display.
- One participant (P2283) thought that “gross pay” would be clearer than “net pay.”
 - One participant (P2434) preferred to have the word “yearly” in the question rather than just “in 2023.”
 - Another participant (P2709) wanted to be able to easily toggle between the different reporting options to see what the options were rather than having to use the checkbox and the next arrow.

Can the respondent “make corrections”? If it’s difficult, explain why.

- No data to support analysis.

Response difficulties for this question seemed to stem from issues with how participants think about and store information about their income, as well as issues with recall for pay of short-term, irregular work. The question was easy for those with only a full-time salary to report, but more challenging for those with other income categories. Many store in their minds information about their income in hourly or weekly amounts rather than in yearly amounts. Additionally, for some forms of pay, the records of their yearly income may not exist, for example, overtime pay separated from other types of pay and reported before taxes and deductions. When the question is more difficult to answer, participants were more likely to skip it. Participants with varying types of income preferred to report one total for the entire year, which they would have in their records, if they chose to access them.

The checkbox was also not working as intended. It appeared too far down the page for participants to notice it before starting their response process to the question on screen. Additionally, the wording (“I want to report monthly or in a different way.”) was not clear enough to match participants’ expectations of what will happen when they click the checkbox. The format for reporting by different time periods was also not clear for all participants, since the blank drop downs are not populated with any instructions or indications of how to use them. Over half of participants preferred to be asked how they want to report rather than the current question set up.

Recommendations:

In combination with the findings from other income amounts questions (See **Section 6.4.3**), we recommend moving forward with only the alternative question, which includes reporting periodicity. Any changes to this format should be retested in the second round of cognitive interviews, with a focus on mobile testing.

Some improvements should be made to the periodicity question including grey text instructions in the drop-down bars (e.g., “*How often*”), formats should be hard coded for dollar amounts, instructions should be added on how to report number of payments, and clear indication that the total is automatically calculated (e.g., all other boxes are white and

total is greyed out). Switching to the language “How often” instead of “Choose frequency” should be easier for respondents to understand.

Discussions with SMEs should explore how important it is to separate out income categories, especially overtime, which are difficult for participants to accurately report. We recommend not splitting out income types since participants lack records and do not have a clear idea of how much they made in each category. Instead, we recommend asking for “total income.”

If tipped income is especially important for SMEs, then the second round of cognitive interviewing could target those with tipped income for additional testing. However, we are concerned that respondents may lack records about tipped income as well, which will make reporting accurately very difficult.

Consider the following revision:

Q48a_alt. Enter the total amount (^name/you) received, before taxes and other deductions, from this employer in 2023. The total will calculate automatically. Your best guess is fine.

Please reference the table below for number of payments in a year to report how often you were paid. For example, if you were paid \$400 a week for all weeks in 2023, you would enter \$400, weekly, 52 payments.

Income	Enter amount	How often	Number of Payments	Total
Total Income	\$____.00	How often [drop down with weekly, bi-weekly, monthly, and yearly as options]	-	-

Question 48b_amount

Research Question: This question was created by combining several periodicity and amount questions for self-employment. The goal is to reduce cognitive burden by grouping together related income items, and to reduce burden by reducing the number of screens and the amount of text respondents must read through. The amount of text seen will vary depending on whether they follow the default periodicity.

Q48b_amount. Enter (^name's/your) gross earnings (earnings before expenses) and expenses for {fill business name} in 2023.

Gross Earnings	Expenses	Total
\$____.00	\$____.00	\$_____

n = 3

Findings:**Do respondents like reporting the amount yearly or would they have preferred to report it differently?**

- A total of three participants received this question.
 - Two of the three participants (P2283 and P2245) prefer to report yearly. One participant (P2332) preferred to report monthly because income can change drastically from month to month; this participant may have thought they would have reported income for each month rather than one value for all months of the year.
 - P2283 and P2245 preferred yearly because it would be less confusing, more straight forward, and more burdensome.

Would they prefer being asked how they want to report the amount first?

- Participants did not like the option of reporting by other time periods for business earnings, and so do not want to be asked how to report first. They preferred to report by year.

Would it be easier for them to report net earnings directly or is reporting gross earnings and expenses separately easier?

- One participant (P2332) preferred to respond with gross earnings and take-home since expenses can vary over time. This participant thought of their business earnings in terms of the total rather than split out as earnings and expenses.
- One participant (P2245) would report whatever their tax statement said. This participant did not find the total helpful in catching errors.
- This question about gross earnings for their businesses was mostly easy for participants to understand; however, we have limited data from this round of cognitive interviewing. One participant disliked the term “expenses” since those vary over time, however, we were unsure whether changing the question text to “net earnings” would improve clarity.

Recommendations:

Testing supports annual reporting for business income. However, we may want to try different wording during the second round of cognitive interviewing. We should consult with the SMEs and confirm whether they would like to try the suggested revision below. This revision would lower respondent burden by asking for only one number but may increase misreports if participants accidentally report gross earnings instead of net earnings.

Consider the following revision:

Q48b_amount. Enter (^name's/your) net earnings (gross earnings minus expenses) for {fill business name} in 2023.

Net earnings: \$____.00

6.2.2 Income Sources

Unemployment Compensation (source)

Research Question: We need to know about the source(s) of unemployment income so we can ask about the amount later in the survey. We previously asked about each of these unemployment types separately. We combined 3 questions into 1 to reduce respondent burden.

Q51A1. Which of these unemployment benefits, if any, did (^you/anyone in this household) receive in 2023?

Select all that apply.

- State or Federal unemployment compensation
- Supplemental Unemployment Benefits (SUB)
- Union Unemployment or Strike Benefits
- None of the above

n = 29

Research Question: We need to know which members of the household received the source(s) of unemployment selected.

Q51A1b. Who received (^FILL FROM Q51A1)?

Select all that apply.

<List of household members who are ages 15 and over>

n = 2

Findings:

How many respondents had difficulty or confusion?

- Only two participants received this question.
- Two participants (P2332, P2961) who reported unemployment benefits for themselves or someone else were confused about what “supplemental unemployment benefits (SUB)” meant. They were uncertain whether they or the other person in their household received this benefit.
- Two participants (P2770, P2512) indicated that the recall was somewhat difficult for this question, for P2770 when reporting for someone else in their household, and for P2512 for themselves. They questioned whether certain benefits were received in 2024 but ultimately decided that no benefits were received.

Are respondents able to provide proxy responses for household members receiving unemployment income?

- One participant (P2332) reported unemployment benefits for someone else in their household but was uncertain whether the benefits were state unemployment (the first response option) or union unemployment (the third response option). She knew the person who was on unemployment was in a union and so was confused whether the person would get state or union unemployment pay. The participant was also confused whether the first response option “state or federal unemployment compensation” would apply only to

government workers. This participant wanted a description of each response option to better understand each option.

There were limited data for this question from the first round of cognitive testing, but from this testing there may be issues with proxy reporting where respondents may not be aware of the specifics of unemployment for other people in the household.

Recommendations:

There was some concern about proxy reporting for this question, but due to limited data, there are currently no recommendations for question changes. Continue to monitor this question during the second round of interviews.

Workers Compensation (source)

Research Question: We need to know about the source(s) of workers compensation income so we can ask about the amount later in the survey.

Q52A. Which of these types of income, if any, did (^you/anyone in this household) receive as a result of a job-related injury or illness in 2023? Exclude sick pay and disability retirement.

Select all that apply.

State Worker's Compensation

Employer or employer's insurance worker's compensation

Own insurance worker's compensation

Other payments as a result of a job-related injury or illness

None of the above

n = 30

Research Question: We need to know which members of the household received the sources of worker's compensation selected.

Q52A1b. Who received (^FILL FROM Q52A)?

Select all that apply.

<List of household members who are ages 15 and over>

n = 3

Findings:

How many respondents had difficulty or confusion with the response options, particularly #3 (was "own" understood)?

- Most participants understood the response options and were able to easily select the applicable options. Some participants were confused about the response options but knew that none of them applied because they did not have a job-related illness or injury.
 - Some participants found the question wording to be complicated and read through the question text and options, several times. Some key words stand out that make participants wonder if the question applies to them, such as "illness or injury," and they must read through again to determine that they did not have a "job-related illness or injury. As one participant (P2246)

explained, "It took me reading the question two times I would say. At first, I saw 'illness' so I was like, are we talking about just sick times? But then I realized we were really just wondering about an illness or injury that came from working the job."

- Another participant (P2310) thought the instruction would be clearer if it was phrased "do not include sick pay and disability retirement" rather than "exclude."
- Nine participants had some confusion over the third response option, "own insurance worker's compensation." However, five of these participants were able to correctly guess what the response option means. Overall, misunderstanding the third response option only impacted the response process for one participant; all others were able to easily answer.
 - One participant (P2595) experienced significant confusion and changed their response from "none" to "own insurance worker's compensation," seemingly because they believed that "own insurance worker's compensation" was health insurance. This participant thought aloud, "So compensation, do they mean like if I went to the doctor for any reason and just like my insurance covers it because of the job I was at?... whichever doctor or whichever dental services you may need, um, some of your jobs might cover it... so that's how I'm interpreting that Own insurance worker's compensation... One of the jobs I had that every time I went to go get work done or orthodontics, I would show them how much the service was and then they would compensate me." This participant may have been influenced by the cognitive interview probe to further consider the third response option.
 - One participant (P2253) was unsure whether state worker's compensation was only for government employees and thought clarification would be useful.
 - One participant (P2710) thought that disability payments might count as "own insurance worker's compensation," and shared, "I have a friend who is on disability, and getting social security and also from her disability insurance...and that would probably be, I don't know if that would be, 'own insurance worker's comp', or... yeah."
 - Another participant (P2286) thought that "own insurance worker's compensation" would be for unemployed people.
 - One participant (P2261) didn't believe that "own insurance worker's compensation" existed but confirmed that it did not apply to them. This participant stated, "Well, worker's compensation, that's from your employer... So, I don't know. There's no such thing [as own insurance worker's compensation] to my knowledge. Maybe a self-employed person. I just know that it certainly wouldn't apply to me."

Ask R to explain "other payments".

- No data to support analysis.
- Overall, this question was easy for participants to understand and respond to. However, some participants did not understand the third response option "own insurance worker's compensation." It may be worthwhile to test a different phrase in the second round of cognitive interviewing to see if it would work better.

Recommendations:

- Consider bolding “job-related” in the question text to speed up the cognitive process of understanding the focus of this question.
- Consider changing to “Do not include”, which can be cognitively easier for respondents to understand.
- Consider testing alternative phrases for response option three, after consulting with SMEs. One potential example is included below but requires review by the SMEs.
- Consider the following revision, with all recommendations outlined together:

Q52A. Which of these types of income, if any, did (^you/anyone in this household) receive as a result of a **job-related** injury or illness in 2023? Do not include sick pay and disability retirement.

Select all that apply.

- 1 State Worker's Compensation
- 2 Employer or employer's insurance worker's compensation
- 3 Worker's compensation paid out by self-insured policy
- 4 Other payments as a result of a job-related injury or illness
- 5 None of the above

Social security (source)

Research Question: We need to know about Social Security reciprocity so we can ask about the amount later in the survey.

Q56a. In 2023, did (^you/anyone in this household) receive any Social Security payments from the U.S. Government?

- Yes
- No

n = 30

Research Question: We need to know which members of the household received Social Security. We are asking about all household members regardless of age, rather than asking about children separately.

Q56b. Who received Social Security payments either for themselves or as combined payments with other family members?

Select all that apply.

<List of household members who are ages 15 and over>

n = 13

Findings:**Does this question make sense?**

- No participants indicated confusion about the question text.

- One participant (P2710) thought “from the U.S. government” was redundant and did not believe social security would be paid out by anyone else.
- One participant (P2373) would prefer to answer these questions about each person in the household rather than grouped together asking about the whole household at once.

Did the R read it as the same question as the preceding one (the text is a little different)?

- No participants stated confusion about the follow-up question. All seemed to answer thinking about the people in their household they thought of in the first question.

Are respondents able to provide proxy responses for household members receiving Social Security income?

- Two adult participants (P2417 and P2595) living at home with their parents were uncertain about whether their parents collected SS income. One participant (P2417) was uncertain whether their father was receiving SS income or not. Another (P2595) participant believed their parents were only taking 401k payments and not SS income.
- This question was clear and easy for most participants to answer. Participants reporting as proxy respondents, especially adult children living with their parents, may struggle to accurately report social security income of other people in the household.

Recommendations:

We may consider adding a “don’t know/unsure” response option for proxy reports, as suggested on other questions to improve the respondent experience by reducing burden. Continue to monitor this question during the second round of interviews.

Research Question: For each adult who got SS, we need to know the reason they got it.

SSR. What were the reasons (^name/you) (^was/were) getting Social Security in 2023?

Select all that apply.

- Retired
- Disabled
- Widowed
- Spouse
- Surviving child
- Dependent child
- Other

n = 7

Administration notes: Participants were primarily asked to report their own social security status, but were asked to report up to one other person in the household. If more than one other person in the household, only the first was asked about. Subsequent questions for other household members were skipped. The counts of participants above are those who saw at least one of the questions, whether it asked about themselves, someone else in the house, or they were asked both.

Findings:**How many respondents had difficulty or confusion with the response options?**

- Most participants did not have difficulties selecting their responses; however, two participants struggled due to unique situations.
 - One participant (P2734) wrote in “met age requirements and credits” as their response. When discussing, the participant indicated that you did not need to be retired in order to collect SS. At first, the participant thought about answering “retired” but then decided to select other and write in their response. Before changing her answer, this participant shared, “The first thing that I thought of, was that I was old enough to qualify... that would have been the answer that I would have picked without looking at the answers. So, but with those answers... I guess 'retired.'”
 - Another participant (P2245) also struggled to respond because the reason why the person in their household was drawing SS payments changed over time. This participant explained, “This one's really hard, this one's really confusing... When she first started getting social security she was disabled. But then after a certain age, I think it kicks in that it changes. I don't know. I don't really quite remember. But in the 90s when she first got on it, it's because she got disabled working. And then after a certain age I think it was just because she was a certain age, so maybe it's both. Because I can see I can click, uh, more than one. And then she was also widowed. Her husband did die in 2019, and she did get his... I believe some social security payments from him. So, I'm not sure, but I know somehow, throughout her life, she's connected to getting social security through these three things. I don't directly know what it would have fallen under in 2023.” This participant decided to mark all three, retired, disabled, and widowed.
- While most participants found it easy to answer this question, some struggled due to unique circumstances. It was unclear how serious these issues may be in the larger population for the full survey.

Recommendations:

SMEs should be consulted with these data to determine the potential impact of these issues. It is unclear the frequency of these types of issues and how significant the impact could be on data quality. The SMEs can consider several options for improvements to this question that can be retested in the next round of cognitive interviewing:

- One option may be to ask for the main reason that someone was getting Social Security and restrict this question to select only one option. This could help push respondents to selecting the one response that best fits their situation.
- We may also consider removing the “disabled” response option since this question is asking about SSI and not SSDI, which should be reported elsewhere.
- We may want to consider adding a response option, such as “met age requirements and number of credits but still working,” to capture respondents who are not retired but are receiving SSI payments.

Consider the following revision:

SSR. What were the reasons (^name/you) (^was/were) getting Social Security in 2023?

Select all that apply.

- Retired
- Disabled
- Widowed
- Spouse
- Surviving child
- Dependent child
- Met age requirements and number of credits but still working
- Other

Research Question: For each child who got SS, we need to know the reason they got it.

SSCR. What were the reasons (^Child's name/the children) (^was/were) getting Social Security in 2023?

Select all that apply.

- Disabled
- Surviving child
- Dependent child
- Other

n = 0

Findings:

How many respondents had difficulty or confusion with the response options?

- No participants saw this question and there were no data to report on.

Research Question: We need to know which parent/guardian received SS on behalf of a child.

Q56g. Which parent or guardian received these Social Security benefits on behalf of a child?

<List of household members who are 19 years old and over>

n = 0

Findings:

Do the respondents understand that we are talking about children already reported as receiving SS (in the previous questions)?

- No participants saw this question and there was no data to report on.

Research Question: For each person who got SS, we ask if their first payment was in the last calendar year.

SSDIa1. Did (^name/you) receive (^your/their) first Social Security Disability payment in 2023?

- Yes
- No

n = 1

Recommendations:

No feedback provided about this question by the one participant who viewed it and no recommendations for changes. Continue to monitor this question during the second round of interviews.

Research Question: If there are children under age 19 in the household, this question is asked to make sure the respondent has not forgotten about a child. If the new questions above work well, we may be able to drop this in the future.

Q56f. Is there anyone in this household, who we have not already counted, who received Social Security income in 2023 on behalf of any children in this household? Include all children under 19 years of age.

- Yes
- No

***n* = 3**

Findings:**If answered yes, ask why they didn't report it earlier.**

- No data to support analysis.

Do respondents see this as a separate question, or does it feel repetitive?

- Two participants (P2709, P2646) thought the question was repetitive while one (P2245) was unsure what the question was asking about. None of the participants reported social security income for a surviving child.
 - As one participant (P2709) shared, "I already said we have two people in the house and listed them, so it seemed odd that this would come up."

This question felt redundant for people who reported social security income and did not report any child social security income. However, we have limited data from this round of cognitive testing.

Recommendations:

We recommend no changes to this question since we have limited data from this round of cognitive testing. It may be important to prioritize testing with households where adults do receive social security payments on behalf of children in order to see if this question feels redundant. SMEs may consider changing the routing of this question to only be asked to people who report SSR = surviving child or dependent child.

Research Question: We need to know which children under age 19 received SS.

CSS. Which children under age 19 were receiving Social Security in 2023?

Select all that apply.

<List of household members who are under age 19>

***n* = 0**

Research Question: We need to know which parent/guardian received SS on behalf of a child.
Q56g2. Which parent or guardian received these Social Security benefits on behalf of a child? Select all that apply. <List of household members who are age 19 or older>
n = 0

Research Question: For each child who got SS, we need to know the reason they got it.
CRSS. What was the reason (^Child's name) was getting Social Security in 2023? Select all that apply. ▪ Disabled child ▪ Surviving child ▪ Dependent child ▪ Other
n = 0

Recommendations:

No participants saw these questions and there was no data to report on.

Supplemental Security Income (SSI) (source)

Research Question: We need to know about SSI reciprocity so we can ask about the amount later in the survey.
Q57a: In 2023, did (^you/ anyone in this household) receive any SSI payments (Supplemental Security Income)? <i>SSI payments are assistance payments to low-income aged, blind and disabled persons, and come from state or local welfare offices, the Federal government, or both.</i> ▪ Yes ▪ No
n = 30

Findings:

Did R read the definition? Was this helpful/necessary?

- Twenty-eight participants thought the definition was helpful, if not for themselves then for other people who may not know what SSI is.
 - One participant (P2734) who did not know what SSI is wanted the definition placed within the question text instead of following the question.
 - Several quotes illustrating how helpful the definition was:
 - "It was because I wasn't quite clear what supplemental security income was so it did clarify exactly what it was asking. I think it was helpful." – P2245
 - "Well, I didn't know what SSI stood for before, so yes [it was helpful]." – P2709

- "I think it is helpful because... I feel like the more something can be defined it does fill you with confidence and guide you along the way, especially if you're doing this on your own." – P2246
- "I don't know what supplemental security income is...oh there it says." – P2734
- Eighteen participants reported reading the definition while answering the question. Those who didn't read the definition felt they knew right away that the question did not apply to them and could easily select "no."
 - One participant (P2246) shared that they did not need to read the definition to know that it did not apply, sharing: "I've read through about half of it, just being honest... I understood where it was going basically, and I know that no matter what I don't receive this."

This question was easy for participants to answer, and the SSI definition was a helpful guide for both those who are and are not familiar with SSI.

Recommendations:

Continue to include the SSI definition with this question. No recommended changes. Continue to monitor this question during the second round of interviews.

Research Question: We need to know which members of the household received SSI.
Q57b. Who received SSI (Supplemental Security Income)? Select all that apply. <List of household members who are ages 15 and over>
n = 1

Research Question: For each person who got SSI, we need to know the reason they got it.
SSIR: What were the reasons (^name/you) (^was/were) getting SSI (Supplemental Security Income) in 2023? Select all that apply. ▪ Disabled ▪ Blind ▪ On behalf of a disabled child ▪ On behalf of a blind child ▪ Other
n = 1

Findings:

- The one participant (P2332) who viewed this question was slightly confused about the options "blind" and "disabled" since they believed the category of "disabled" would include those who are blind. They shared, "I would think blind was disabled... Like, would they put blind and disabled if they were blind?"

Recommendations:

No recommendations. Continue to monitor this question during the second round of interviews.

Research Question: If there are children under age 19 in the household, this question is asked to make sure the respondent has not forgotten about a child.

Q57d: Is there anyone in this household, who we have not already counted, who received Supplemental Security Income in 2023 on behalf of any children in this household?

- Yes
- No

n = 21

Findings:

Do respondents see this as a separate question, or does it feel repetitive? If answered yes, ask why they didn't report it earlier.

- This question was presented incorrectly to at least 12 participants who do not have children in their household (see **Appendix F** for full list of programming errors). Programming errors like these can have a significant impact on respondent's feelings about the Census Bureau and the survey, as explained by P2373, "Yeah, my instinct is why are you asking me this again. But maybe because you sort of have intended to specify children. But you've already asked me how many people live in the household and so.... This sort of comes back to the issue of trust, I suppose... I already told you that, why are you fishing again?"
- Six participants (P2332, P2253, P2961, P2646, P2373, P2283) thought the question was redundant. One of these participants, (P2332), thought it was redundant because they had seen SSIR. The others thought it was redundant because Q57a already asks about the total household, and the programming error leading to this question asked for those who do not have children in the household.
 - One participant (P2332) who saw SSIR thought Q57d was redundant because SSIR includes a response option for "on behalf of a disabled child." The participant felt Q57d had already been asked.
 - Those who do not think the question is redundant pointed to the language "on behalf of any children." They saw Q57a as asking about the entire household, and Q57d about any children.
- Most participants were able to easily answer this question, but one participant (P2770) had significant difficulty understanding the wording, especially the first sentence. This participant found the different clauses in the sentence confusing and had to reread the question several times before answering no. P2464 also thought the question was awkwardly phrased.
- The programming error in the first round of testing limited evaluation of the redundancy of this question. This programming error should be fixed so this question can be reexamined as to whether it feels redundant for people with children in their household.

Recommendations:

Fix programming error so that this question is only asked when NUMHOU > 1 AND at least one person age < 18 AND Q57b[1] greater than or equal to 1, and continue to monitor this question during the second round of interviews.

Consider including the SSI definition on this screen as well as on Q57a to ensure respondents know that the questions are asking about the same topic. Some participants skip over the definition in the first question (Q57a) and may need to reference it when viewing the second question.

Consider the following revision:

Q57d: Is there anyone in this household, who we have not already counted, who received Supplemental Security Income in 2023 on behalf of any children in this household?

SSI payments are assistance payments to low-income aged, blind and disabled persons, and come from state or local welfare offices, the Federal government, or both.

- 1 Yes
- 2 No

Research Question:

We need to know which members of the household received SSI.

Q57e. Which parent or guardian received these Supplemental Security Income payments on behalf of a child?

Select all that apply.

<List of household members who are parent/guardian to a child in the household>

n = 0

Research Question: For each person who got SSI, we need to know the reason they got it.

RSSI. What were the reasons (^name/you) (^was/were) getting Supplemental Security Income on behalf of a child in 2023?

Select all that apply.

- Disabled child/children
- Blind child/children
- Other

n = 0

Research Question: We need to know which children in the household received SSI.
CSSI. Which children under age 19 were receiving Supplemental Security Income in 2023? Select all that apply. <List of household members who are under age 19>
n = 0

Recommendations:

No participants saw these questions and there were no data to report on.

Disability Income (source)

Research Question: This question identifies if anyone may have received disability income.
Q59AR. During 2023, did (^you/anyone in the household) have a disability or health problem which prevented (^you/them) from working, even for a short time, or limited the work (^you/they) could do? ▪ Yes ▪ No
n = 30

Research Question: We need to know which members of the household had a disability/health problem.
Q59b. Who had a disability or health problem which prevented or limited their work in 2023? Select all that apply. <List of household members who are ages 15 and over>
n = 7

Findings:

- Some participants struggled to understand the broad language used in this question, specifically the phrase “prevented them from working, even for a short time, or limited the work they could do.” Participants were unsure how to interpret this phrase and how severe the problems would need to be to answer “yes.”
 - Four participants (P2369, P2310, P2246, P2464) were confused about the level of severity of illness and health problems the question is asking about.
 - One participant (P2369) explained their confusion about the level of severity of issues the question is looking for, sharing, “This is a little interesting... I’m wondering, it’s not as clear-cut as prevented someone from working, but limiting the work they could do, um like if they were looking for employment or if they had to have restrictions at work, you know? I’m assuming they’re talking about the bigger picture, like if someone did manual labor for example and they could no longer due to health problems and not so much just having restrictions at work.”
 - One participant (P2310) wondered about the level of severity and whether a sick day would count as limiting work, sharing “Technically that could mean was anyone sick, did anyone have a sick day throughout the

year?... Yeah, yeah, absolutely.” He further explained that he could not imagine a person in the country who wouldn’t say yes to this question with the way it is worded.

- One participant (P2246) had some brief health issues that hindered their working and slowed them down, but only prevented them from working fully for one day. They answered “yes” to the question after sharing, “I’m going to answer yes even though it was very brief for me. It wasn’t a disability, but it was a health problem. See that’s what I feel like is a little bit tricky. I wasn’t sick enough it prevented me from working but it kind of hindered my working. Slowed it down. I’m thinking it was just a day where it did prevent me from working so I guess that counts.”
- Another participant (P2464) thought the question was asking about health issues that could qualify for SSD. She reported that she had health issues but doesn’t think they would qualify for getting benefits from the government. She was conflicted about how to answer and ultimately answered “yes.”
- Two participants (P2710, P2310) pointed out that “work” could include housekeeping and chores. One participant (P2710) assumed the question was asking about “paid work” and shared, “I think you need to specify paid work... because some people may not be able to do the work of cleaning their house or cooking or something.
- Another participant (P2245) answered “no” for someone else in his household because they stopped working due to a disability in the mid-90s. This illustrated that the time frame of the health problems may not be clear in the question. This participant explained, “I’m going to say ‘no’, because my mother-in-law had already been for -- since the mid-90s, so it wasn’t stopping her in 2023.”
- One participant (P2332) thought the question was repetitive since they already reported one member of their household as receiving disability benefits. They stated, “This seems repetitive too just cause I already had filled out all the information for [P5] that have the disability.”
- Currently, the instrument is programmed so that the household member list does not include people who do not have age reported. This was seen with one participant (P2464) on the follow-up question Q59b. We recommend changing this to present people who do not have ages reported, see **Section 7. Overall Recommendations.**

While there were no research questions for this item, there were significant problems with the current question wording, which was not consistently understood by participants. Participants were making guesses about the level of severity of health issues that the question was asking about, and the question was not currently working well as a good filter to find households where members are receiving disability income.

Recommendations:

SMEs need to weigh in on these findings with the wording issues for this question. The goal of the question is to identify people who may be receiving disability income; however, the question was not currently consistently understood, and more people may screen into the follow up questions than should, increasing respondent burden.

We may consider rephrasing the question to focus on lost income that may have been replaced by disability income to better screen respondents into Q61C. We suggest the language “prevented you from earning any amount of your income.” While this may still screen in people who did not recoup lost income through disability payments, it should eliminate those who used PTO or could not do unpaid housework.

Consider the following revision:

Q59AR. During 2023, did (^you/anyone in the household) have a disability or health problem which prevented (^you/them) from earning any amount of (^your/their) income?

- 1 Yes
- 2 No

Research Question: This question identifies if anyone may have received income from a work-related disability.

Q60a. (^Did you/Is there anyone in this household who) ever (^retire or leave/ retired or left) a job for health reasons?

- Yes
- No

n = 30

Research Question: We need to know which members of the household left/retired for health reasons.

Q60b. Who retired or left a job for health reasons in 2023?

Select all that apply.

<List of household members who are ages 15 and over>

n = 6

Findings:

- Most participants found this question easy to answer, however one participant (P2710) struggled. This participant found the question wording confusing and thought it could be interpreted as two separate questions, one about whether someone retired, and one about whether someone left a job for health reasons. She explained, "I'm not sure [what this question is asking] ...it could be two separate questions... Is there anyone in this household who ever retired? Is there anyone... who left a job for health reasons?"
- Two participants (P2464 and P2245) had issues with this series of questions where the first question (Q60a) asked whether someone “ever” left a job for health reasons, while the follow up (Q60b) only asked about 2023.
 - One participant (P2464) answered “yes” to Q60a because both she and her roommate had left a job for health reasons some time in the past. She decided to leave Q60b blank since it did not apply; neither had left a job in 2023.
 - Another participant (P2245) reported that someone in his household did retire due to health reasons so answered “yes” to Q60a but was frustrated by Q60b

since it asked specifically about 2023. He explained, "But now it says who retired or left a job for health reasons in 2023, but this first question says is there anyone in this house who EVER retired or left a job. So, I was confused because she did in 90s, it happened. But over here it says in 2023. Well, nobody." He left Q60b blank.

While there were no research questions for this item, there were significant problems with the current question wording. This series of questions needs to ask consistently about the past calendar year rather than first asking about "ever" retire/leaving a job in Q60a.

Recommendations:

Consider changing the wording of Q60a to ask about the past calendar year.

Consider the following revision:

Q60a. (^Did you/Is there anyone in this household who) (^retire or leave/ retired or left) a job for health reasons in 2023?

- 1 Yes
- 2 No

Research Question: We need to know which respondents received disability income.
Q61C. In 2023, which sources of income, if any, did (^you/name) receive due to a disability or health problem? Select all that apply. ▪ Worker's compensation ▪ Company or union disability ▪ Federal government (Civil service) disability ▪ U.S. Military retirement disability ▪ State or local government employee disability ▪ U.S. Railroad retirement disability ▪ Accident or disability insurance ▪ Black Lung miner's disability ▪ State temporary sickness ▪ Other source ▪ None of the above
n = 1

Recommendations:

Due to a programming error, this question was not correctly asked of all participants (see **Appendix F** for full list of programming errors). Only one participant saw this question. It should be asked when Q59Ar = 1 or Q60A = 1. It was unclear why the participant who did receive this question (P3022) received it, as they had not reported any disability income. This question must be retested in round two of cognitive interviewing.

Veterans Payments (source)

Research Question: We need to know about the source(s) of Veteran's payments so we can ask about the amount later on.

Q60A88. Which sources of Veteran's (VA) payments, if any, did (^you/anyone in this household) receive in 2023? Include assistance received by children of veterans.

Select all that apply.

- Service-connected disability compensation
- Survivor benefits
- Veterans' pension
- Educational assistance (including assistance received by children of veterans)
- Other Veterans' payments
- None of the above

***n* = 30**

Findings:**How many respondents had difficulty or confusion with the response options?**

- Most participants do not receive veteran's payments and are comfortable not being familiar with the response options. Most saw "veteran" in the question text and started looking for "none of the above" because they have no veterans in their household. As P2310 shared, "As soon as I saw 'Veteran's payments' in the question... I knew we don't have that."
- However, there was some confusion over the response options "survivor benefits" and "veterans' pension."
 - Two participants (P2512, P2619) were confused about the response option "survivor benefits" and what agency paid out the benefits.
 - One participant (P2512) knew she was receiving survivor benefits but thought it may be paid out by social security. She was confused about how to answer and considered an additional program that provides monetary support for home heating to survivors a type of survivor benefits, saying "[it's] a bit confusing...Well I get [monetary support for home heating] and that's a survivor benefit I suppose...." She wasn't sure if this question was asking about benefits directly from the Veteran Affairs (VA) or also social security payments. This participant did respond "survivor benefits" even though it seemed like she had only received social security payments, which represents a likely misreport of data.
 - Another participant (P2619) shared similar confusion about survivor benefits. She has collected survivor benefits for her deceased husband, which were paid out by social security. She was confused about whether the question was asking specifically about Veteran Affairs (VA) payments or also interested in social security payments. She explained, "...they're talking about veteran's payments which to me would mean that the person in the household was a veteran, but ... when I see 'survivor benefits', I guess it's, if you're a survivor of a veteran.. but, .. for social security... they call it... survivor benefits."
 - Two participants (P2646, P2351) were confused about the category "veterans' pension" because it could overlap with other benefits in the list.

- One participant (P2646) claimed that service-connected disability compensation is a type of veteran’s pension, seeing these two as one in the same.
- Another participant (P2351) shared that veterans’ pensions are poorly understood by almost everyone, even when they have tried to get information from the VA. However, they did think if someone was receiving a veteran’s pension, they probably know it exists and could select it on the list.
- One participant (P2595) raised some concerns about understanding “service-connected disability compensation,” since “service” can be a broad term interpreted in different ways. However, this participant does not receive any veteran’s payments and this confusion did not compromise his response process.
- One participant (P2373) disliked the assumptive nature of the question and the extra burden to find “none of the above.” They would prefer to first be asked if anyone received veterans’ payments, with a yes or no response, then asked the type of benefits received.

Are respondents able to provide proxy responses for household members receiving VA payments?

- One participant (P2332) had trouble reporting for someone else in their household. They indicated that they thought one person in their household was getting some of her college education paid through her dad’s veteran’s “stuff,” but they were not sure if that would count for this question. They did decide to answer “educational assistance.”

If R selected other, ask them to explain.

- No data to support analysis.
- This question was well understood and easy to answer for those who do not receive veteran’s payments. For those who receive veteran’s payments or other survivor’s benefits, there was some confusion with how to answer the question. Additionally, proxy reporting for others in the household can be difficult.

Recommendations:

Consider updating the response option to “survivor benefits administered by the VA” to clearly state what agency is paying out the benefits to prevent confusion with social security survivor benefits. We could also consider adding an instruction to exclude social security payments, which could help reduce misreports.

Consider the following revision:

Q60A88. Which sources of Veteran’s (VA) payments, if any, did (^you/anyone in this household) receive in 2023? Include assistance received by children of veterans. *Do not include Social Security payments.*

Select all that apply.

- 1 Service-connected disability compensation
- 2 Survivor benefits administered by the VA
- 3 Veterans' pension
- 4 Educational assistance (including assistance received by children of veterans)
- 5 Other Veterans' payments
- 6 None of the above

Research Question:

We need to know which members of the household received the sources of veteran's payments selected.

Q60b_88. Who received the (^FILL FROM Q60A88) either for themselves or as combined payments with other family members?

Select all that apply.

<List of household members who are ages 15 and over>

***n* = 2**

Research Question: No specific research questions. Only change is formatting for ISR.

Q60D88. (^Are/Is) (^name/you) required to fill out an annual income questionnaire for the Department of Veterans' Affairs?

- Yes
- No

***n* = 1**

Findings:

- One participant (P2646) experienced confusion with Q60b_88 because it felt redundant. This participant responded both "service-connected disability compensation" and "veteran's pension" and was asked to report who received the payments for each. He responded that he was the one to receive both of the payments and felt it would be better to ask these questions on the same page.

Recommendations:

Consider bolding the fill in Q60b_88 to help differentiate the questions.

Survivor Benefits (source)

Research Question: We need to know about the source(s) of survivor benefits so we can ask about the amount later in the survey.

Q58a. Which types of survivor benefits, if any, did (^anyone in this household/you) receive in 2023? Exclude Social Security and VA benefits.

Select all that apply.

- Company or union survivor pension (include profit sharing)
- Federal government survivor (Civil service) pension
- U.S. Military retirement survivor pension
- State or local government survivor pension
- U.S. Railroad retirement survivor pension
- Worker's compensation survivor pension
- Black Lung survivor pension
- Regular payments from estates or trusts
- Regular payments from annuities or paid-up insurance policies
- Other type of survivor benefits
- None of the above

***n* = 30**

Research Question: We need to know which members of the household received the sources of survivor benefits selected.

Q58b. Who received the (^FILL FROM Q58a)?

Select all that apply.

<List of household members who are ages 15 and over>

***n* = 2**

Findings:**How many respondents had difficulty or confusion choosing a response option?**

- Most participants do not have any difficulty or confusion when selecting the response option applicable to them. A few mention that they have not heard of some of the types of survivor benefits before, but this does not interrupt their response process in picking "none of the above."
 - As P2245 stated, "It kind of makes senses. Like you read, you know, union, federal government, military, state local government, railroad. Worker's comp survivor pensions, I don't really know what that is but I assume if someone dies at work, you would get some money or something. They all kind of make sense even if I don't know exactly what they are."
 - P2246 echoed this sentiment sharing, "Not really confusing, I'm just not super familiar with them. But I know they don't apply to me."
- However, a few participants did face challenges, with some confusion around understanding the term "survivor benefits" and whether to report benefits they receive from their own accounts.

- Four participants (P2619, P2770, P2332, P2595) did not know what survivor benefits are, which can impact data quality for those who do receive survivor benefits, as is the case for P2619.
 - P2619 initially asked "So when they say 'survivor,' they mean, like, somebody who passed away, right?" illustrating that she was unclear about the term "survivor benefits." She then indicated that she gets a small amount of money from her husband's pension and reported "company or union survivor pension."
 - The other three participants all reported "none of the above," but their lack of knowledge about survivor benefits may limit what they know to report. P2332 thought that survivor benefits were related to someone's will, sharing "I don't really know what a survivor's pension is... When they say which type of survivor benefits, I was thinking like a will. So somebody passed away, so that's what I thought it was going to ask, but... I've never heard of these things." Another participant (P2595) thought the question was asking about payment people received for surviving something traumatic based on the response options.
- Two participants (P2710, P2310) thought they should respond about their own benefits at first. P2710 selected "regular payments from annuities or paid-up insurance policies." When probed further she stated, "ok...no, I don't know if that's 'survivor' when it's me that's doing the surviving." She clarified that she only received annuities from her own accounts and not related to her deceased husband. P2310 almost reported his Real Estate Investment Trust (REIT) accounts, but then focused on the word "survivor" to know that he did not receive any survivor benefits. He thought adding additional instructions to the question might be helpful.
- Two participants (P2734, P2283) were confused about the response options relating to "regular payments." These two response options do not include the word "survivor" again, which seemed to contribute to the confusion, as with P2710 reported above. P2734 got some money from her husband's sister, but it was not "regular payments" so she was uncertain whether it applied or not. P2261 echoed this sentiment, sharing, "I really want to know what you mean when you said "regular payments from estates" here" and thought it would be helpful to have a description of this response option.
- One participant (P2512) missed the instruction "exclude social security and VA benefits" and was initially frustrated that there was not an option for widow benefits, sharing "I'm surprised they don't have widow benefits." Once she saw the instruction, she realized that widow benefits should not be included.
- One participant (P2373) felt the question was intrusive and refused to answer.
- One participant (P2361) expressed confusion about this question and Q60A88. They thought that the questions were asking about the same topic and shared, "Since I selected none of the above [on Q60A88] I would have expected not to answer this question, like I would expect it only to appear if I had selected 'survivor benefits' here." Adding the suggested instruction text to Q60A88 and the additional text to the response option "survivor benefits paid out by the VA" may help improve this issue.

Are respondents able to provide proxy responses for household members receiving survivor benefits?

- No data to support analysis.

Did they read and consider all the options or decide after the first few that these weren't relevant to them?

- Most participants (approximately 23) read or skimmed all of the response options. Those who did not read the options knew right away that the question did not apply and looked immediately for "none of the above."

Did they find the "none" response, if applicable?

- No participants experienced issues finding the "none" response option.
- This question is complex because of the wordy response options and can pose a high respondent burden. Some participants did not understand what "survivor benefits" are, even those who receive some survivor benefits. Additionally, the response options "Regular payments from estates or trusts" and "Regular payments from annuities or paid-up insurance policies" are unclear and omit the word "survivor."

Recommendations:

Consider adding additional text or an instruction to explain what "survivor benefits" are. While we only had one person who received benefits question what "survivor benefits" means, there was evidence that others are also unclear. This could pose issues with data quality if respondents are moving quickly and do not take the time to read all the response options. Additionally, providing a definition could be helpful for proxy respondents who may not be familiar with this term. A potential instruction is included below but should be reviewed with SMEs and included in the second round of cognitive testing.

We also recommend moving response options 8 and 9 to a new, separate question. This change will result in an increase in response burden for those receiving survivor benefits, but cognitively, the question should be easier to answer by grouping these payments together topically. See proposed revision below, which also includes an explanation of what "regular payments" means.

Consider the following revision:

Q58a. Which types of survivor benefits, if any, did (^anyone in this household/you) receive in 2023? Exclude Social Security and VA benefits.

Survivor benefits are benefits paid to eligible family members after an individual has passed.

Select all that apply.

- 1 Company or union survivor pension (include profit sharing)
- 2 Federal government survivor (Civil service) pension
- 3 U.S. Military retirement survivor pension
- 4 State or local government survivor pension
- 5 U.S. Railroad retirement survivor pension
- 6 Worker's compensation survivor pension
- 7 Black Lung survivor pension
- 10 Other type of survivor benefits
- 11 None of the above

Q58a_NEW. In 2023, which type of regular payments (for example, monthly or quarterly payments) did (^anyone in this household/you) receive as survivor benefits?

Survivor benefits are benefits paid to eligible family members after an individual has passed.

Select all that apply.

- 1 Regular payments from estates or trusts
- 2 Regular payments from annuities or paid-up insurance policies
- 3 None

Public Assistance (source)

Research Question: We need to know about the source(s) of public assistance so we can ask about the amount later in the survey.

Q59A88. Which types of cash assistance, if any, did (^anyone in this household/you) receive in 2023?

Select all that apply.

- (^State Program Name)/Temporary Assistance to Needy Families (TANF)/welfare/Aid to Families
- General assistance
- Emergency assistance/short-term cash assistance
- Diversion payments
- Refugee Cash and Medical Assistance program
- General Assistance from Bureau of Indian Affairs, or Tribal Administered General Assistance
- Some other program
- None of the above

n = 21

Findings:

How many respondents had difficulty or confusion choosing a response option?

- Participants had issues with the response options "general assistance" and "diversion payments," with "general assistance" causing more issues.
 - Seven participants were uncertain what "general assistance" meant and what types of programs may count for this response option. As P2245 shared, "The

only one where that really confuses me is General Assistance Like, it's not very clear what that means." Some inferred from the other response options that it should be a government program, and one participant (P2417) wondered whether COVID assistance checks would count. This category is so broad that respondents may include a wide range of cash assistance, and it is unclear what the question is interested in. One participant (P2332) responded "general assistance" to this question, and then later (when answering Q72a) indicated the "general assistance" they receive are cash payments from their parents and not an assistance program.

- Six participants (P2332, P2373, P3022, P2595, P2253, P2369) were uncertain what "diversion payments" meant, though this had less impact on the response process than the confusion over "general assistance." The phrase "diversion payments" is more technical and specific and confusion was related to wondering what it meant, such as P2373, who shared "I'm not even sure I know what you mean by diversion payments.... I think it's probably related to the criminal justice system." However, these participants were able to select "none."
- One participant (P2770) was unsure what "emergency assistance/short-term cash assistance" meant and whether it could be money from friends/family. They shared, "Is that when I ask my mom for \$50 or I don't know, you know."
- One participant (P2619) was confused about the wording "cash assistance" and had to think through its meaning before selecting her answer of "none of the above." She wasn't sure at first whether to report Medicaid for this question, but then decided that it was not "literal cash" and so chose not to report it.

Are respondents able to provide proxy responses for household members receiving public assistance?

- One participant (P2277) reported that she was not certain about reporting for everyone in the household, and shared "Not really too sure about anyone else, but I know for majority, it's none of the above."

Did they read and consider all the options or decide after the first few that these weren't relevant to them?

- Participants seemed to read or skim all of the response options before answering. Those who needed to respond "none" were able to easily find this response option.

Did the length of the response options cause problems?

- The length of the response options did not seem to cause any issues for participants.

If they choose other, please explain.

- One participant (P2332) reported an 'other' program, which they stated was related to a domestic situation in which they received money to help move.
- One participant (P2310) thought that "some other program" could include other family members or GoFundMe.
- Most participants were aware that they were not receiving cash assistance and were able to select their response of "none of the above" easily. However, there

were some concerns about the response option “general assistance.” This response option was very vague to participants, and they were not sure what should be included here.

Recommendations:

Consider adjusting the “general assistance” category to be more specific or to add examples for participants to more accurately report the cash assistance they receive. It is unclear whether SMEs are interested here in government programs or a more inclusive definition of cash assistance. A new probe focused on “general assistance” may be useful for round 2 of cognitive interviewing.

It may be useful to consider the order of Q59A88 and Q72a, which asks “In 2023, did (^you/anyone in this household) receive (^any other/any) regular financial assistance from friends or relatives not living in this household.” Currently Q72a appears at the end of the questions about types of income. However, if Q72a is asked first, respondents should subtract out assistance from friends and relatives when answering Q59A88. This effect should help improve the clarity of Q59A88 and reduce double counting of this type of income.

A last note is that only 21 participants received this question when the universe should have been all 30. We recommend reviewing the programming and confirming that the question is programmed correctly.

Consider the following revision:

Q59A88. Which types of cash assistance, if any, did (^anyone in this household/you) receive in 2023?

Select all that apply.

- 1 (^State Program Name)/Temporary Assistance to Needy Families (TANF)/welfare/Aid to Families
- 2 General assistance (for example, XXX, XXX, and XXX)
- 3 Emergency assistance/short-term cash assistance
- 4 Diversion payments
- 5 Refugee Cash and Medical Assistance program
- 6 General Assistance from Bureau of Indian Affairs, or Tribal Administered General Assistance
- 7 Some other program
- 8 None of the above

Research Question: We are checking in case the respondent forgot to think about cash assistance received on behalf of children.

Q59A89. Which types of cash assistance, if any, did (^anyone in this household/you) receive on behalf of children in the household in 2023? Do not include Food Stamps (SNAP), SSI, Energy Assistance, WIC, School meals, Childcare, and Education Assistance.

Select all that apply.

- TANF
- General assistance
- Emergency assistance/short-term cash assistance
- Diversion payments
- Refugee Cash and Medical Assistance program
- General Assistance from Bureau of Indian Affairs, or Tribal Administered General Assistance
- Some other program
- None of the above

n = 19

Research Question: We need to know which members of the household received the source(s) of public assistance selected.

Q59b_88. Who received {fill type of cash assistance}?

Select all that apply.

<List of household members who are ages 15 and over>

n = 1

Findings:

How many respondents had difficulty or confusion choosing a response option?

- P3022 was uncertain what TANF meant and P2310 thought the acronyms should be spelled out.

Is the 'Do not include' instruction helpful?

- All participants who were asked thought the instruction was helpful. For example, P2245 explained, "I know a lot of people get food stamps and WIC and if I had just read the questions, I would have assumed they were asking about those programs." Many participants indicated the question was not relevant and so the instruction was not relevant for them but could be relevant for others.

Are respondents able to provide proxy responses for household members receiving public assistance?

- No data to support analysis.

Do respondents see this as a separate question or does it feel repetitive?

- Two participants (P2285, P2464) indicated some confusion over the differences between this question and Q59A88. P2285 thought that if someone answered "none of the above" to Q59A88, then they would not be receiving any assistance for Q59A89 either. P2464 thought the time frame (i.e., the year 2023) was

different in this question and did not notice that the benefits were related to children.

If they choose other, please explain.

- No data to support analysis.

Recommendations:

Include the full words for TANF, SSI, and WIC again in this question for improved clarity.

Consider adding skip logic to skip this question if there are no children in the household to reduce respondent burden. Currently, the question is asked to all households who answer “none of the above” to Q59A88. This change could also help participants differentiate these two questions (Q59A88 and Q49A89) since those who do not have children would not receive the second question.

Consider implementing the same changes to “general assistance” that are made for Q59A88, i.e., including examples of the types of general assistance the SMEs are interested in. A new probe focused on “general assistance” may be useful for round 2 of cognitive interviewing.

Consider the following revision:

Universe: Q59A88 = 8 AND at least one person age < 18

Q59A89. Which types of cash assistance, if any, did (^anyone in this household/you) receive on behalf of children in the household in 2023? Do not include Food Stamps (SNAP), Social Security Income (SSI), Energy Assistance, Women Infants and Children (WIC), School meals, Childcare, and Education Assistance.

Select all that apply.

- 1 Temporary Assistance to Needy Families (TANF)
- 2 General assistance (for example, XXX, XXX, and XXX)
- 3 Emergency assistance/short-term cash assistance
- 4 Diversion payments
- 5 Refugee Cash and Medical Assistance program
- 6 General Assistance from Bureau of Indian Affairs, or Tribal Administered General Assistance
- 7 Some other program
- 8 None of the above

Pensions (source)

Research Question: We need to know about the pension source(s) so we can ask about the amount later in the survey. We previously asked about pensions in separate questions.

Q62Ar. Which types of pension income, if any, did (^anyone in this household/you) receive in 2023?

Do not include distributions or withdrawals from IRAs, 401(k)s, or similar accounts.

Select all that apply.

- Company
- Union
- Federal government
- State government
- Local government
- U.S. Military
- U.S. Railroad retirement
- Other type of pension
- None of the above

***n* = 30**

Research Question: We need to know which members of the household received income from the pension(s) selected.

Q62b. Who received income from a (^FILL FROM Q62Ar) pension?

Select all that apply.

<List of household members who are ages 15 and over>

***n* = 8**

Findings:**How many respondents had difficulty or confusion choosing a response option?**

- Most participants take the time to read all the response options. Those who know the question does not apply tend to skip straight to looking for “none of the above,” especially after seeing this format on several questions in a row. As P2310 stated, “I just know that I don’t have any pension income.”
- However, some participants are not clear on what a pension is.
 - Three participants (P2710, P2245, P2373) were looking for a place to report their social security income and were confused whether it should be captured in this question. As P2373 explained, “Well I guess SSI counts as a pension income.... Unless you want to exclude SSI, I’m going to click it [P clicked Federal government] ... it was earned income. It's certainly not a government hand out.” Another participant (P2710) was confused whether the option for federal government represented social security payments, sharing “So you list the federal government and state government and if you don't mean social security you oughtta exclude that or state teacher's retirement fund.. you would have to exclude that if you don't want that.”
 - One participant (P2332) shared, “So, [P4]'s in the union so I'm gonna assume that's what that is. I don't know what a pension is.”

- Two participants (P2619, P2646) may have double reported their income on this question.
 - One participant (P2619) reported a pension she receives on account of her deceased husband twice, once in Q58a and again in this question (Q62Ar). This participant expressed confusion about “survivor benefits” in Q58a and did not seem clear on which question the pension should be reported. She felt the questions were redundant and stated, “I feel like this is the same thing they just asked, didn't they?”
 - One participant (P2646) reported service-connected disability compensation and veteran’s pension on Q60A88 and also reported U.S. Military pension for this question (Q62Ar). He thought that the U.S. Military pension should have been combined with the previous questions about veteran’s benefits. It is unclear whether this U.S. Military pension is the same or different from the previously reported service-connected disability compensation and veteran’s pension.

Are respondents able to provide proxy responses for household members receiving pension income?

- Four participants (P2595, P2417, P2332, P2245) struggled to report proxy responses; two of these for their parents.
 - One participant (P2595), an adult living at home with his parents, was not sure where the funds his parents received came from. This participant selected “company” for Q59b_88 and explained, “In retirement...they get paid from the jobs that they've worked and just money they were able to save up so I’m going to assume that that's what it is all about.”
 - Another participant (P2417) had a similar reaction, stating “My dad might have a pension... I have no idea.”

Did they read and understand the “Do not include” instructions?

- Several participants thought the instructions were useful but wanted more information about other types of accounts to exclude, such as social security payments.

If they selected “other” probe for more information.

- No data to support analysis.
- This question was very difficult for proxy respondents to answer, and many took a guess at the information. Additionally, this question was tricky for those who receive social security income as they look for this option when thinking about pensions. There was also some confusion in specific instances that lead to participants double reporting income.

Recommendations:

While participants already reported their social security income earlier in the survey, they are confused about whether this question about pensions is really asking about social security. We should consider adding an additional instruction to exclude social security payments.

SMEs should consider whether a pension from the U.S. Military is separate from the previous questions about veteran’s benefits and payments (Q60A88). If these are separate, additional text could be useful to help respondents understand how they are different. If these are not different, the response option (U.S. Military) should be eliminated on Q62Ar in favor of using the data from Q60A88. A hypothetical draft is included below but should be reviewed by SMEs and updated appropriately.

See **Section 7. Overall Recommendations** for recommendations about question order, which we believe will address some of the double reporting issues observed with this question.

Consider the following revision:

Q62Ar. Which types of pension income, if any, did (^anyone in this household/you) receive in 2023?

Do not include social security payments, or distributions/withdrawals from IRAs, 401(k)s, or similar accounts.

Select all that apply.

- 1 Company
- 2 Union
- 3 Federal government
- 4 State government
- 5 Local government
- 6 U.S. Military (a pension not administered by the VA)
- 7 U.S. Railroad retirement
- 8 Other type of pension
- 9 None of the above

Annuities (source)

Research Question: We need to know about annuity reciprocity so we can ask about the amount later in the survey.

Q96Ar. In 2023, did (^you/ anyone in this household) receive any income from an annuity?

- Yes
- No

n = 30

Research Question: We need to know which members of the household received annuity income.

Q96Br. Who received annuity income?

Select all that apply.

<List of household members who are ages 15 and over>

n = 3

Findings:

- Six participants (P2310, P2770, P2417, P2464, P2710, P2734) struggled to understand the term annuity on Q96Ar.
 - Two of these participants (P2734, P2770) googled the term before providing an answer, indicating a significant impact on their response process.
 - Two of these participants (P2734, P2710) answered that they did have income from an annuity, but did not seem very confident. After googling the term, P2734 felt that the pension payout she was receiving was an annuity.
 - One participant (P2310) pointed out that someone could be getting income from an annuity and think it has a different name.
- One participant (P2277) did not know whether any of the other people in their household had income from an annuity.
- One participant (P2373) refused to answer this question due to sensitivity and privacy concerns.

While the focus of this research was not on comprehension of the terms, the data from this question reveals that understanding of the term “annuity” is crucial to the response process. Respondents who want to be thorough will look up what the term annuity means and use that definition to guide their responses.

Recommendations:

To provide consistent text for all respondents, we recommend including a definition of annuity for this question. We have provided a drafted definition from the Wisconsin Office of the Commissioner of Insurance¹, which should be reviewed by SMEs.

Consider the following revision:

Q96Ar. In 2023, did (^you/ anyone in this household) receive any income from an annuity?

An annuity is a written contract typically between you and a life insurance company in which the insurance company makes a series of regularly spaced payments to you in return for a premium or premiums you have paid. An annuity is not life insurance.

- 1 Yes
- 2 No

¹ <https://oci.wi.gov/Documents/Consumers/PI-214.pdf>

Retirement Accounts (source)

Research Question: We need to know about the retirement source(s) so we can ask about the amount later in the survey. The most common types of retirement accounts are listed first.

Q97Ar. In 2023, which types of retirement accounts, if any, did (^you/anyone in this household) have that were designated specifically for retirement savings?

Select all that apply.

- 401(k)
- 403(b)
- Roth IRA
- Regular IRA
- KEOGH plan
- SEP plan (Simplified Employee Pension)
- Other type of retirement account
- None of the above

n = 30

Research Question: We need to know which members of the household received income from the retirement account(s) selected.

Q97Br. Who had a (^FILL FROM Q97Ar)?

Select all that apply.

<List of household members who are ages 15 and over>

n = 15

Findings:**How many respondents had difficulty or confusion choosing a response option?**

- Most participants think the response options are clear and think it is acceptable to not understand the accounts they do not personally have.
 - For example, P2770 shared, "I think it's another one where, I know what I know and I don't what I don't know. So, like, if you asked me to explain the difference between these, I absolutely would not be able to... I do not know what this is so I assume I do not have it."
 - Another participant (P2245) felt similarly, sharing, "It is confusing, but only because I am just like ignorant on, you know, the definitions themselves. I don't really think it's a problem with the questions itself, I just think, you know, I'm not knowledgeable on it."
- However, some participants know they have a retirement account but do not know what type of account it is. This can lead to misreports and lower data quality because they are uncertain which accounts they have.
 - When participants think they or someone in the household has a retirement account, but they are not sure what types of accounts, they take different strategies. One participant (P2710) answered "other." Another participant (P2277) answered "none of the above."
 - Four participants (P2361, P2351, P2285, P2709) were uncertain about 403b accounts in a way that could potentially impact their response process. P2285

thought a 403b account was for college savings for his children. P2361 knew she had a retirement account from a nonprofit, but she wasn't sure which type of account it was. She explained, "I do have a retirement account from a nonprofit I worked for... It might be a 403(b), I can't remember how it's designated, but I think it's different than a 401(k), so... Maybe like a definition here would be helpful. Kind of like how SEP plan has it spelled out here in parentheses."

- Two participants (P3022, P2351) experienced significant confusion and difficulty when deciding on an answer.
 - One participant (P3022) was confused about whether the pension her work contributes to should be reported for this question. At first, she answered, "other type of retirement account," and then after the probes, changed her answer to "none of the above." She originally thought the money that her work contributed to her pension would be considered a retirement plan, and then changed her mind. "I have a, uh, a retirement plan through work, they contribute to, I don't have to contribute to, I don't have to contribute to, so I'm going to put 'other type of retirement account', because it's not 403, and it's not a 401, it's not any kind of IRA, it's not a KEOGH ... I think I would [have a retirement plan], since I've been there for ten years, but I think it's just the hospital's retirement.... So retirement savings, meaning so you're saving for your retirement, so did you plop any of your money in here, and, I did not, but the only other retirement account that I know that I have is the pension plan that they provide, so, that's where I came to on that one."
 - Another participant (P2351) was confused about the intent of the question and whether he should report accounts that he was contributing to or receiving money from. He was insistent that Census would not care to know about accounts that were not being used to fund the household. He explained, "What's not clear is whether money is being taken out or being added to those accounts... or whether or not they are related to the funding of the household." He ultimately decided to answer, "none of the above," even though it sounded as though he did have retirement accounts that he was actively drawing down from.
- One participant (P2310) thought the response option should be "traditional IRA" and had not heard of "regular IRA" before.
- One participant (P2373) refused to answer due to concerns about sensitivity and privacy. This participant stated, "You've now really just gotten so invasive on asking information... about all these particular pensions that I am so close to saying, 'Holy shit, this is a nefarious survey. They are gathering so much information, I have no guarantees on what this information will be used for and I am just about ready to say I don't want to go to go any further with your survey.'"

Are respondents able to provide proxy responses for household members with retirement accounts?

- Two participants (P2245, P2770) were uncertain reporting for other household members. One (P2770) was uncertain reporting for their roommate and could only confidently report for themselves. Another (P2770) was unsure and shared, "It is clear, and I do know she had some kind of retirement, but she had already paid into it a long time ago and I'm not sure... Like she was retired, I'm not sure

though what it would be classified as or if it would have changed over time because... I just don't know."

Was the ending of the question understood ("that were designated specifically for retirement savings")?

- Most participants found this phrase clear and easy to understand. However, three participants (P2646, P2278, P2770) indicated the phrase was only clear when they read the response options.

What were the "other" responses?

- Four participants selected "other" for various reasons, including one with a legitimate other type of retirement account, two with other accounts that could be used for retirement, and one who did not know which type of retirement account she has.
 - One participant (P2710) used "other" because she knew she had a retirement account but was not sure what type of account it is.
 - One participant (P2286) had a general investment account invested in stocks and bonds.
 - One participant (P2246) reported a high yield savings account that he could use for retirement. It sounded like this was a savings account that could be used for anything, including retirement.
 - One participant (P2709) indicated they had a thrift savings account from working for the federal government.

There were some problems with this question due to low knowledge among the general population about retirement accounts. Several participants struggled to answer and select the appropriate retirement account type. Additionally, participants had questions about some of the account types, most commonly about a 403b account.

Recommendations:

While there are cons to adding a "don't know" or "not sure" option, the data supports that this could be a legitimate response from the general public for this question. Respondents may know they have a retirement account, but not know what type of account; this is especially true for proxy reporting. Allowing for a "not sure" option should improve data quality by increasing the consistency with which these participants answer this question. Additionally, providing a "not sure type of account" response option will allow the follow up amounts question to be asked even in cases where respondents do not know the type of account. Otherwise, we risk respondents with unknown retirement accounts skipping this question and missing data on the amounts in the account. We recommend either 1) adding a "not sure" option or 2) adding an instruction to select "other type of retirement account" when someone is unclear about the type of account. If we move forward with this option, the follow-up amounts question should fill appropriately when this response option is selected.

It may also be worthwhile to add a definition for 403b accounts. This account type is the one with the most questions and adding a definition could help respondents feel more confident in their selection.

Consider the following revision:

Q97Ar. In 2023, which types of retirement accounts, if any, did (^you/anyone in this household) have that were designated specifically for retirement savings?

Select all that apply.

- 1 401(k)
- 2 403(b) (typically available to employees of public schools and tax-exempt organizations)
- 3 Roth IRA
- 4 Regular IRA
- 5 KEOGH plan
- 6 SEP plan (Simplified Employee Pension)
- 7 Other type of retirement account
- 8 I have a retirement account, but not sure type of account
- 9 None of the above

Research Question: For each retirement account identified, this question asks if a withdrawal or distribution was taken.

Q98Ar. Did (^you/NAME) withdraw any money or receive a distribution from (^your/their) (^FILL FROM Q97Ar) in 2023, including any distributions (^you/they) may have been required to take?

Yes

No

n = 15

Findings:

- There was a programming error such that Q98Ar was skipped for all people in single person households. Q98Ar should be asked to all respondents who answered Q97Ar = 1-7, regardless of household size (see **Appendix F** for more information about programming errors.)
- One participant (P2245) was not confident proxy reporting for another person in her household. She knows that her mother-in-law received letters indicating she needed to take out a certain amount or she would be taxed but thought it may have been for annuities instead of from the retirement accounts.
- One participant (P2310) thought that there should be instructions to exclude rollovers.

Recommendations

Update the programming so this question is asked regardless of household size and retest in the second round of cognitive interviewing.

Employer's Pension Plan

Research Question: This question is asked for each person who worked at a job or business last year. It asks about the existence of a pension or other type of retirement plan on the job. This question is just to ask about if their employer offered a pension or retirement plan and then we ask if they participated in the plan in Q74b. These questions do not have any other follow up about what type of plan or the amount.

For the first fill: If they had one employer, then use "the" as the fill. If they had more than one employer, then use "any" as the fill.

Q74a. Did any employer or union that (^name/you) worked for in 2023 offer a pension plan to any of its employees?

- Yes
- No

n = 25

Findings:**Is the R counting non-pension plans like 403B, 401k?**

- Many participants associate pension plans with government positions and think they are rare for private companies today. As P2961 stated, "...a lot of companies these days have done away with pension plan." Because pension plans are not very common today, some people conflate them with other retirement options. Ten participants were not clear on what a pension plan is and confused pension plans with other retirement accounts, such as a 401k. Fourteen participants were clear about what a pension plan is and thought it was different from other retirement account options.
 - Some participants only have a vague idea about what a pension plan is, such as P2245, who described "I think a pension plan is where you pay in and then you can withdraw money, but they have like certain rules about, like, how much you can withdraw or taxable things. I'm not really sure." P2595 also understood the pension plan as a way to save for retirement, but was not clear on the mechanism, sharing, "Ways to save money for the future and to just have money for emergencies and things like that. It's for something later down the line... just having extra funds for later."
 - Six participants (P2332, P2277, P2434, P2595, P2283, P2646) thought that a 401k could be a type of pension plan, such as P2646, who stated, "[A pension plan is] part of the hiring process... They offer a pension option for the employees...could be a matching 401 or something different, something other than that."
 - P2277 shared similar confusion, stating, "Well, like the previous page, the 401k, pretty much a retirement fund."
 - P2434 also conflated pension plans and 401k, sharing, "After you...been there for so many years they offer you like a 401K plan, stuff like that, a IRA, stuff like that, they offer you the different little plans, to help you save."

Do they know this information if they weren't in the union themselves?

- Of those asked, 8 indicated they could answer on behalf of all types of employees at their workplace, and 6 had reservations and lacked confidence in their answers, especially for other people in their household.
 - Two participants (P2464, P2332) decided to answer "no" because they had no idea whether there was a pension offered to other employees.
 - P2464 worked several gig jobs, such as participating in a mock jury for a law firm and was not knowledgeable about the benefits these employers would offer to full time employees. She would have no way of knowing.
 - P2709 was confused about how this question was asked because they do not get a pension but thought others may, sharing "This is confusing because I work for [employer name] and I assume they offer a pension plan to some of their employees, but not me."
- Two participants (P2332, P2310) preferred to have a "don't know" response option because they struggled to answer about all employees at their job. P2332 shared "I'm going to say no cause I have no idea. I think they should have an I don't know button." P2310 thought it would be very difficult to answer for other people in his household and thought a "don't know" option would be helpful.
- One participant (P2373) skipped the question because they felt it was too invasive.
- This question can be difficult for respondents to answer depending on the type of job they worked and how large their workplace is, and especially difficult for proxy reporting. There was also low general knowledge about pension plans which may impact how accurately respondents can report for their entire workplace.

Recommendations:

While there are cons to having a "don't know" response option, it is a legitimate response for this question. Combined with the lack of knowledge about pension plans, it may be best to present a "don't know" option so that respondents can accurately and consistently report about pension plans at their workplaces. Having a "don't know" response for this question may improve the respondent experience by recognizing it as a legitimate response.

Alternatively, this question may be best asked about only the respondent and other people in their household rather than the entire workplace. If this question is retained to ask about the entire workforce, it may be useful to add a definition of a pension plan to increase the consistency of respondent answers. A potential definition is included below. Adding the definition should improve data quality and reduce respondent burden for those who may answer "yes" and be asked the follow up questions when the workplace does not have pension plans.

Consider the following revision:

Q74a. Did any employer or union that (^name/you) worked for in 2023 offer a pension plan to any of its employees?

A pension plan is an employee benefit plan established or maintained by an employer or by an employee organization (such as a union), or both, that promises a specified monthly benefit at retirement. The plan may state this promised benefit as an exact dollar amount, such as \$100 per month at retirement. Or, more commonly, it may calculate a benefit through a plan formula that considers such factors as salary and service². Do not include defined contribution plans such as 401k and 403b plans.

- 1 Yes
- 2 No
- 3 Don't know

Research Question: This question is asked for each person who worked at a job or business last year. It asks about the existence of a pension or other type of retirement plan on the job. This question is just to ask about if their employer offered a pension or retirement plan and then we ask if they participated in the plan in Q74b. These questions do not have any other follow up about what type of plan or the amount.

For the first fill: If they had one employer, then use "the" as the fill. If they had more than one employer, then use "any" as the fill.

Q74a2. Were/was you/name eligible to participate in the pension plan?

- Yes
- No

n = 7

Findings:

Is everyone eligible or just certain employees?

- Three participants (P2709, P2595, P2434) reported that not all employees were eligible at their workplace and four participants (P3022, P2277, P2369, P2289) reported that all employees were eligible.
 - Those who reported everyone is eligible indicated there was often a number of years worked required before eligible for a pension plan.

Recommendations:

No recommended changes for this question. Continue to monitor this question during the second round of interviews.

Research Question: We need to know if each person participated in the plan.

Q74b. Did (^name/you) participate in the pension plan?

- Yes
- No

n = 6

² <https://www.dol.gov/general/topic/retirement> and <https://www.dol.gov/general/topic/retirement/typesofplans>

Findings:

- One participant (P2595) answered affirmatively that they participated in the pension plan but was thinking about their 401k plan.

Recommendations:

Adding a definition to the filter question Q74a should help reduce misreports and lower respondent burden for those who misreport pension plans when thinking about defined contribution plans. Continue to monitor this question during the second round of interviews.

Income-Earnings Accounts Outside of Retirement (source)

Research Question: We previously asked about each of these sources separately. We combined the interest-earning assets into one list to reduce respondent burden. We are keeping these separate from the assets that pay dividends.

Q99Ar. Besides retirement accounts, in 2023, which types of assets, if any, did (^you/anyone in this household) have that may have paid interest?

Select all that apply.

- Interest-earning checking account
- Savings account
- CD (certificate of deposit)
- Savings bond
- Other savings or investments that pay interest
- None of the above

***n* = 30**

Findings:**How many respondents had difficulty or confusion choosing a response option?**

- Many participants had no difficulty or confusion choosing a response option. Most said the options were clear and they were not confused by any of the types of accounts listed.
 - Six participants experienced some issues with their responses, such as not knowing the answer for themselves or other people in their household and misunderstanding the question.
 - The most significant issue was a misunderstanding by P2595 who reported an “other” account when they were thinking about paying their student loans and associated interest. This participant did not understand that the question was asking about accounts that earn them interest.
 - One participant (P2332) indicated that when they saw the word “assets” they first thought about a house or cars rather than accounts. This participant was also slightly confused about why the option was interest-earning checking account and not also interest-earnings savings account.
 - One participant (P2277) answered “none” because they were unsure.
 - One participant (P2770) could not answer for their roommate.
 - One participant (P2417) was unsure whether his investment accounts (described as similar to index funds) should be included in this question.

- One participant (P2351) changed her response from “none” after probing by the interviewer, revealing that she did not totally understand the question at first.
- Two participants (P3022, P2351) were confused about the accounts listed because they generate such small dollar amounts from interest that it did not make sense to them that the Census Bureau would be interested to know about them. P2351 explained that he thought if an account was only generating 1% interest, it did not seem like it was really an “interest earning” account. He thought the question should be rephrased to include a minimum amount of interest that an account was earning, such as “which types of assets earning more than 5% interest.”
- Two participants (P2373, P2310) expressed sensitivity and privacy concerns about this question.
 - One participant (P2373) skipped this question since she felt it was too invasive, which she had indicated for most of the financial questions.
 - Another participant (P2310) talked through his responses without entering them in the survey and shared, “Maybe I don’t want the Census to know... all of my financial...about my cash...Maybe I’ve got crypto and I don’t want to report on that.. that’s like a private... you don’t want people knowing you’ve got keys... it’s confidential by nature...you could compromise... by answering.”

Are respondents able to provide proxy responses for household members?

- One participant (P2770) was unable to answer for their roommate but could confidently answer for themselves.

What did the R report for “other”?

- The other accounts reported included a stock market account, mutual funds, money market account, a high yield savings account, cryptocurrency, a brokerage account, and acorns.
- One participant (P2710) had loaned money to a friend and was being paid back with interest, so included that as an “other” asset for this question.
- One participant (P2595) had a severe misunderstanding of the question and reported an “other” account when they were thinking about paying loans with their associated interest. This participant explained, “For me student loans and, um... yeah, I’d say student loans and car payments.”

If “none”, do they have bank accounts? Clarify - these don’t earn interest or the interest rate is very low?

- Only one participant (P2277) reported “none of the above” because they were not sure. They do have a checking account but no savings account and believed they do not earn any interest.
- Another participant (P2512) initially reported “none of the above,” but when probed about her bank accounts realized she does have two checking and a savings account that do earn interest. It is unclear why this participant did not originally report these accounts; however, this is likely due to these accounts earning so little interest that she did not think it was of interest to the Census Bureau.

While straightforward for many participants, there are some concerns with measurement error for those who misunderstand the question or those who do not realize their accounts generate interest. The “other” category was also being used for a wide range of account types which may be better captured by other response options already available. However, low financial knowledge may make it a good idea to retain the “other” response option for those who do not recognize their interest-generating accounts as one of the options listed, such as a high yield savings account.

Recommendations:

The wording of “assets” seems to imply a large account generating a lot of income, which is not true for the majority of Americans. Consider changing this word to “accounts” and retesting this question in round two of cognitive interviewing. While “accounts” may not match perfectly for the response option “savings bond,” the benefits of this more inclusive word with a lower monetary bar than “assets” could be worth the change. This recommendation assumes that the SMEs are interested in ALL interest-generating accounts, no matter how small the monetary value.

This question is cognitively complex and with retirement accounts already reported in previous questions, it may be worthwhile to consider moving “besides retirement accounts” to an instruction. This approach matches the format of many other questions with instructions and reduces the cognitive burden for respondents. If this recommendation is followed, it should be retested in round two of cognitive interviewing to confirm that participants do not attempt to report retirement accounts.

Consider the following revision:

Q99Ar. In 2023, which types of accounts, if any, did (^you/anyone in this household) have that may have paid interest? Do not include retirement accounts.

Select all that apply.

- 1 Interest-earning checking account
- 2 Savings account
- 3 CD (certificate of deposit)
- 4 Savings bond
- 5 Other savings or investments that pay interest
- 6 None of the above

Research Question: We need to know which members of the household received interest income from the source(s) selected.

Q99Ba. Who had the (^FILL FROM Q99Ara)? For joint accounts, include each person.

Select all that apply.

<List of household members who are ages 15 and over>

n = 18

Findings:**Is the instruction about joint accounts clear?**

- The instruction about joint accounts is clear for most participants. However, the instruction is unclear in situations where two people have a joint account together and then also have separate accounts. For example, if a husband and wife had one savings account together and two separate, individual savings accounts, the question and instruction are confusing. The question asks, “who had **the** (FILL)?”, which implies that there is only one account of each type per household.
 - Two participants (P2646, P2283) shared some confusion about the instruction per the example outlined above.
- One participant (P2734) reported only “Other savings or investments that pay interest” and found this question’s fill confusing. She did not initially realize that it was a follow up question and was confused about having to remember and report all other accounts.

Did they want to report a HH member under age 15 for any of the accounts (even if not the one asked about)?

- One participant (P2283) wanted to report a savings account for their 10-year-old child.
- This question was straightforward for many participants but can be more complicated when multiple people in a household have the same kinds of accounts and when those accounts are independent and jointly owned. For example, a husband and wife each have their own individual savings account, and then jointly share a savings account.

Recommendations:

Consider adjusting the wording from “the” to “a” to better match the prevalence of these interest-earning accounts in a given household. This is a change that we recommend globally across these questions about who has the account, see **Section 7. Overall Recommendations** for more information.

Only one participant indicated that a child in their household had a savings account. The SMEs should consider how important this income data is and whether it is worth it to add children to the list of household members for this question. Further research and a specific probe about children could be added to the second round of cognitive testing.

We may consider adding additional text when the fill is “Other savings or investments that pay interest” to better connect this as a follow up question. One of the overall recommendations (See **Section 7. Overall Recommendations**) is to include more connections to previous questions with wording such as “In the previous question you reported (^FILL FROM Q99Ara). Who had a(n) (^FILL FROM Q99Ara)?” This should help maintain consistency and prominence of the topics across questions.

Consider the following revision:

Q99Ba. In the previous question you reported (^FILL FROM Q99Ara). Who had a(n) (^FILL FROM Q99Ara)? For joint accounts, include each person.

Select all that apply.

<List of household members who are ages 15 and over>

Research Question: We previously asked about each of these sources separately. We combined the assets that pay dividends into one list to reduce respondent burden. We are keeping these separate from the assets that earn interest.

Q99Arf. In 2023, which types of assets did (^you/ anyone in this household) have that pay dividends?

Select all that apply.

- Shares of stock in corporations
- Mutual funds
- Other savings or investments that pay dividends
- None of the above

n = 30

Findings:**How many respondents had difficulty or confusion choosing a response option?**

- Twelve participants did not understand what dividends were or thought dividends and interest were the same thing.
 - One participant (P3022) originally selected "other" before probing, which led to her changing her mind. She initially wanted to report a CD account and after probing decided that CDs did not provide dividends since they paid out at the end of the time they mature.
 - One participant (P2770) decided to skip the question and not provide a response because they were so unsure what dividends means.
 - One participant (P2332) preferred to have a "don't know" option because she did not understand what the question was asking about. She shared, "I don't know what the question's asking and share of stocks, mutual funds, other saving... I don't have any of that so I would put None of the above. Again, I think it should be an 'I don't know' question because I don't know if a lot of people even know what that is."
- The response options were clear for all participants, who mostly felt confident in their responses. One participant (P2770) knew they didn't have shares or stock or mutual funds but was unsure about whether or not they might have something that would qualify as "other savings or investments that pay dividends."
- One participant (P2734) felt they had already reported these accounts in other questions.

Are respondents able to provide proxy responses for household members?

- Most participants felt confident in their responses, especially those who are part of a married couple; they could easily report this information for their spouse. One participant (P2277) was not confident and selected “none” because they did not know the answer for others in their household.

What did the R report for “other”?

- Participants reported “other savings or investments that pay dividends” as a money market account, real estate appreciation, and mutual funds and stocks.
 - P2286 selected shares of stocks in corporations and other savings or investments that pay dividends, but when probed indicated that the other accounts were dividends from his privately managed mutual fund and stocks.
- This question can be difficult for respondents to answer since general knowledge about dividends is low. However, this did not impact the response process for most participants, since they were able to recognize the accounts, they and others in their household have. The utility of the option “other savings or investments that pay dividends” seems limited since participants are reporting accounts that should not be included as paying dividends or are already reported in other questions.

Recommendations:

SMEs should consider removing the “other” option on this question to avoid the report of accounts that do not pay dividends.

Consider the following revision:

Q99Arf. In 2023, which types of assets did (^you/ anyone in this household) have that pay dividends?

Select all that apply.

- 1 Shares of stock in corporations
- 2 Mutual funds
- 3 None of the above

Research Question: We need to know which members of the household received dividends from the source(s) selected.

Q99Bf. Who had (^FILL FROM Q99Arf)? For joint accounts, include each person.

Select all that apply.

<List of household members who are ages 15 and over>

n = 11

Findings:**Is the instruction about joint accounts clear?**

- Most thought the instruction was clear. However, one participant (P2734) thought the instruction would be clearer if the wording was changed to “if joint accounts, include each person.”

- One participant (P2310) struggled to answer this question with the fill “shares of stocks in corporations” because she conflated this with a 401k.

Recommendations:

Consider repeating the word “dividend” on this follow up question to avoid confusion about which types of accounts the question is asking about. The fills could add “that pay dividends” to the end of the response options from Q99Arf so Q99Bf would read, for example, “Who had shares of stocks in corporations that pay dividends?” and “Who had mutual funds that pay dividends?”

Consider the following revision:

Q99Bf. Who had (^FILL FROM Q99Arf with “that pay dividends”)? For joint accounts, include each person.

Select all that apply.

<List of household members who are ages 15 and over>

Research Question: This question asks about capital gains received.
CAPGDIS. Did (^you/NAME) receive any capital gains from (^your/their) (^FILL FROM Q99Arf) in 2023?
▪ Yes ▪ No
n = 8

Findings:

Does the R know what capital gains are? Even if they knew, could they answer the question?

- Four (P2417, P2709, P2734, P2595) of the seven participants were not totally confident in their understanding of capital gains. However, they were able to make an educated guess and no participants decided to leave the question blank.
 - One participant (P2417) was unsure what capital gains are and initially answered “no” before changing her response deciding to “put yes because the market went up this year so I’m sure her stock went up.”
 - P2709 took a guess about the answers for P2, sharing “It was kind of a guess I would say.”
- There may have been a programming error experienced with P2285, who selected both P1 and P2 at Q99Bf but was only asked about P2 for CAPGDIS (see **Appendix F** for all programming errors).
- This question can be difficult for respondents to answer because they have limited knowledge about capital gains.

Recommendations:

SMEs should consider the severity of this issue. From this data, it seems like respondents should be able to make an informed guess, but may not be totally accurate in their reporting, especially for proxy responses.

Property Income (source)

Research Question: This combines the property source questions (Q65A2 and Q65A3) into one 'select all that apply' version.
Q65A2. Which types of income, if any, did (^name/you) receive in 2023? Select all that apply. ▪ Royalties ▪ Rent ▪ Income from roomers or boarders (exclude amounts paid by relatives) ▪ Income from estates or trusts (exclude estates or trusts already reported) ▪ None of the above
n = 30

Findings:**How many respondents had difficulty or confusion choosing a response option?**

- Most had no issues selecting a response because they did not have any other types of income. However, four participants (P2351, P2417, P2332, P2710) were confused about the differences between rent and income from roomers or boarders.
 - One participant (P2332) decided to select both options to report their income, sharing "I would think income from roomers or boarders is rent, but it could also be electric bills so that's kind of what made me think maybe I should click both...I was thinking of it like electric bill, food, sometimes they, like, pay for wi-fi. So income from roomers could be wi-fi, electric and they also pay rent."
 - Another participant (P2710) thought that maybe the difference was rent would be paid for properties the respondent does not also occupy. They shared, "Uh, what, what would you say is the income from roomers or boarders, how is that different from rent? Although rent could come from, you're renting out your garage, or you're renting out a property that's not where you live."
- Two participants (P2351, P2464) were confused about whether to count rent paid to someone in a subletting situation.
 - P2464 is a subletter and was not sure if he should report "income from roomers or boarders" as income for his roommate since that income is just going to pay the rent to the owners. He thought the question was tricky to answer.

Are respondents able to provide proxy responses for household members?

- Several participants mentioned reporting rent collected by other people in their household, which seemed easy for them to report.

If they had answered about rental income in the previous question, did they also report it here?

- Zero participants reported that they worked as a landlord or in the type of employment where rental income would have been their source of employment income in Qs 47 or 48, so there is no data available for analysis.

Were the instructions here helpful?

- Most participants found the instructions helpful, especially “exclude amounts paid by relatives.” However, a few were confused.
 - One participant (P2286) was uncertain whether to count stocks he inherited from his father here because he had previously included it on Q99Arf. He shared, “This one is a bit confusing. My account at Edward Jones came from my father-in-law who passed away about 20 years ago. So I am not sure if this question applies because it came from him or whether it is just my account.”
 - Another participant (P2278) was confused about why amounts paid by relatives should not be included. There could be a situation where her sister paid rent and she was unclear why that should not be counted. She explained, “...if my sister moved in with me she'd be a roomer or a boarder, and if she's paying me to room or board her what difference would it make if she's a relative? I mean I could see them excusing your children or even if you take in your elderly parents, but anybody outside of that if they're a roomer or a boarder hopefully they're gonna be paying you something...”
- A few participants had concerns or issues with the instructions for estates or trusts.
 - One participant (P2734) was unsure whether she had already reported income from trusts appropriately in previous questions. She decided to select it to report again for this question just in case.
 - Another participant (P2361) was confused about where someone may have been able to report estates or trusts earlier in the survey.
- This question poses some issues with the overlapping nature of the categories “rent” and “income from roomers or boarders.” These categories need to be clarified to avoid over reporting and inaccurate reporting of these income types.

Recommendations:

Consider adjusting the categories of “rent” and “income from roomers or boarders” to clarify the intent of these response options. A suggested alteration is presented below but should be reviewed and tweaked by SMEs. Further testing of these options and other options proposed by the SMEs could be considered in round two of cognitive interviews.

This current suggestion does not address the issue with subletters, which should also be considered by SMEs. If subletting income should not be included, then an instruction may help to clarify this. One potential instruction is drafted below for review.

An alternative option to consider is the addition of a new question that asks whether the respondent and other people in the household own any property. If this new question is answered affirmatively, then Q65A2 could fill with all of the response options (i.e., only those who own property will be able to answer options 2 and 3). If this new question is answered negatively, then Q65A2 could fill with only the response options 1, 4, and 5. However, the increased burden of a new question should be considered with the severity of the issues on Q65A2. This additional question may also be useful for screening for MORT_YN due to the issues observed for participants who do not own property.

Consider the following revision:

Q65A2. Which types of income, if any, did (^name/you) receive in 2023?

Do not report money that you give to the owner of the property, such as a subletting situation.

Select all that apply.

- 1 Royalties
- 2 Income from a rental property you do not reside in
- 3 Income from roomers or boarders at a property you reside in (exclude amounts paid by relatives)
- 4 Income from estates or trusts (exclude estates or trusts already reported)
- 5 None of the above

Research Question: We need to know which members of the household received the type(s) of income selected.

Q65b. (royalties, rent, roomers, estate). Who received the (^FILL FROM Q65A2)? For joint ownership, include each person.

Select all that apply.

<List of household members who are ages 15 and over>

n = 5

Findings:

Is the instruction about joint ownership clear?

- This instruction was reviewed on previous questions and was not probed about again on this question. Please see other questions for feedback about the instruction.
- One participant (P2332) who sublet an apartment to other people and answered “rent” and “income from roomers or boarders” on Q65A2 struggled to answer this question. He indicated that the roommates would give him all the money and he would give it to the property manager. He did not keep the money or earn any interest or other financial gain. He clarified that he did not own the house.

Did they want to report a household member younger than 15?

- No data to support analysis.

Recommendations:

No recommended changes to this question, but the issue of how to deal with subletting situations should be addressed on Q65A2. Continue to monitor this question during the second round of interviews.

Education Assistance (source)

Research Question: We need to know if anyone attended school beyond high school to then ask about educational assistance.

Q66a. In 2023, did (^you/anyone in this household) attend school beyond the high school level including a college, university, vocational, business, or trade school?

- Yes
- No

***n* = 30**

Findings:**Did the R report VoTech (high school) here?**

- No participants indicated they attended high school when answering this question as “yes.” One participant (P2310) initially wanted to answer “yes” because his son is in high school, but then took the time to read the question and correctly responded “no.”
- Several participants (P2332, P2734) initially missed that the question was asking about the year 2023.

Did the “beyond the high school level” deter them?

- All participants thought the phrase “beyond the high school level” was clear and easy to understand, especially with the examples. However, a few wondered if educational activities not listed should be reported, such as online classes.
- One participant (P2710) wasn’t sure how to report for her grandchild who was attending high school and also community college classes. She decided to answer “yes.”

Recommendations:

This question worked well and there were minimal issues. No changes recommended.

Research Question: We need to know about education assistance reciprocity so we can ask about the amount later in the survey.

NQ66bd. Which types of educational assistance, if any, did (^anyone in this household/you) receive for tuition, fees, books, or living expenses in 2023?

Do not include VA educational benefits.

Select all that apply.

- Pell Grant
- Assistance from a welfare or social service office
- Other government assistance
- Scholarships, grants, etc.
- Other assistance (employers, friends, etc.)

***n* = 8**

Research Question: We need to know which members of the household received the education assistance selected.

Q66c. Who received the (^FILL FROM Q66b)?

Select all that apply.

<List of household members who are ages 15 and over>

n = 3

Findings:

How many respondents had difficulty or confusion choosing a response option?

- No participants had issues selecting a response option.

Are respondents able to provide proxy responses for household members?

- One participant (P2332) seemed to only report for themselves and not any other members of the household, though it was unclear if others in the household attended school.

What did they report for “other government assistance” and “other”?

- One participant (P2710) wondered whether she should answer “other assistance” to report a 529 account that she had set up for her grandchild. She asked, “Would ‘other’ include, I don’t know what you call it, the fund where parents set aside money every year and it’s tax-free, you know?”
- Two participants (P2417, P2332) used the “other” response option to indicate educational assistance from family.
 - One participant (P2417) thought that “family” should be listed in “other assistance” since that is one of the most common sources of educational assistance. They shared, “I did notice for ‘other assistance,’ my family helped me, my parents helped me pay for school, but I don’t see ‘family assistance’ here, it just says employers and friends.”

Recommendations:

Consider adding “family” to the examples in “other assistance” since it is one of the most common sources of educational assistance.

Consider the following revision:

NQ66bd. Which types of educational assistance, if any, did (^anyone in this household/you) receive for tuition, fees, books, or living expenses in 2023?

Do not include VA educational benefits.

Select all that apply.

- 1 Pell Grant
- 2 Assistance from a welfare or social service office
- 3 Other government assistance
- 4 Scholarships, grants, etc.
- 5 Other assistance (employers, family, friends, etc.)

Child Support (source)

Research Question: We need to know about child support reciprocity so we can ask about the amount later in the survey.

Q70a. In 2023, did (^you/anyone in this household) receive any child support payments?

Yes

No

n = 30

Research Question: We need to know which members of the household received the child support payment(s).

Q70b. Who received these child support payments?

Select all that apply.

<List of household members who are ages 15 and over>

n = 1

Recommendations:

These questions are currently asked of all respondents. To lower respondent burden, we should consider asking them only to respondents who report children in the household.

Regular Financial Assistance (source)

Research Question: We need to know about regular financial assistance reciprocity so we can ask about the amount later in the survey.

Q72a. In 2023, did (^you/anyone in this household) receive (^any other/any) regular financial assistance from friends or relatives not living in this household?

Do not include amounts that must be paid back.

- Yes
- No

n = 30

Research Question: We need to know which members of the household received the regular financial assistance payment(s).

Q72b. Who received this regular financial assistance?

Select all that apply.

<List of household members who are ages 15 and over>

n = 3

Findings:**Did the respondent read the instruction?**

- Most participants read the instructions, however the three (P2734, P2512, P2361) who skipped the instructions thought they were helpful after being prompted. One participant (P2734) thought it would be better to have the instruction immediately after the question text.
- One participant (P2770) initially answered “no” and then thought about it further and changed their answer to “yes.” This participant initially did not think about their parents paying their phone bill monthly as applicable to this question. This participant shared “Just thinking about other forms of financial assistance...It's not super significant or a big stand out whereas I do have I have friends where their parents pay their rent... The money my parents give me is like paying my phone bill, it's just not traditional.”
- One participant (P2464) thought this was a question that could be too personal to answer for her roommate.

Recommendations:

No recommendations. Continue to monitor this question during the second round of interviews.

Other Money Income (source)

Research Question: We need to know about any other income received so we can ask about the amount later in the survey. The options listed are the most common responses to this question. We need to keep the ‘other’ category for write-ins- we code these responses.

Q73A1R. Which types of other income, if any, did (^anyone in the household/you) receive in 2023? Select all that apply.

- Income from Alaska Permanent Fund
- Income from foster child care
- Income from alimony
- Income from jury duty
- Income from armed forces reserves
- Income from severance pay
- Income from hobbies
- Income from other sources
- None

n = 30

Findings:**How many respondents had difficulty or confusion choosing a response option?**

- Most participants did not have any difficulties choosing a response option. However, some were not clear what the question was looking for in the response option “income from other sources.”

- Three participants (P2770, P2464, P2619) had questions about double reporting income with this question, especially with the response option “income from other sources.”
 - P2770 wondered whether they should exclude other income they already reported.
 - P2619 and P2464 decided to select “none” because they felt she had included all of the potential other sources on previous questions.

Are respondents able to provide proxy responses for household members?

- No data to support analysis.

Did they understand “hobbies”?

- Overall participants understand “hobbies” as an extra activity outside of work that typically starts as something fun that can then be used to make a little bit of money on the side. Many thought about arts and crafts, including painting, writing, and baking. Some also think about reselling collectibles, gambling, and playing video games. This response option seems clear and consistently understood by participants.

What did R report for “other”?

- Most participants who responded “other” wanted to report random odd jobs they picked up throughout the year, reselling goods, and completing surveys or interviews.
- One participant (P2710) reported “other” as their social security income.
- P2286 reported royalties for this question. It is unclear why this participant did not report royalties for Q65A2.
- This question performed well overall, with participants easily responding with their other sources of income. The response option about income from hobbies was well understood. However, the “income from other sources” response option was very broad and used to double report income by some participants.

Recommendations:

While most participants infer that we do not want them to double count any of their sources of income, this question may need an explicit instruction because it is so open-ended. This should help improve data quality by explicitly indicating to respondents that we do not want them to double report their income. We propose rewording with the instruction at the beginning of the question.

SMEs should also consider whether they want to include additional response options, especially income from gig work that may not have been reported on other questions and income from reselling goods. If included, these response options should be tested in the second round of cognitive interviewing.

We also recommend reordering the response options so that more common types of incomes appear higher in the list. Respondents tend to review all of the response options, but having more common items higher may encourage review of all the responses while

also decreasing respondent burden. See proposed text below, with the original response order numbers retained.

Consider the following revision:

Q73A1R. Not counting sources of income that you have already reported, from which of the following additional sources did you receive income in 2023?

Select all that apply.

- 7 Hobbies
- 8 Gig work
- 9 Reselling goods
- 6 Severance pay
- 2 Foster child care
- 3 Alimony
- 5 Armed forces reserves
- 4 Jury duty
- 1 Alaska Permanent Fund
- 10 Other sources
- 11 None

Research Question: We need to know which members of the household received the type(s) of other income selected.

Q73A1b. Who received (^FILL FROM Q73A1R)?

Select all that apply.

<List of household members who are ages 15 and over>

n = 14

Recommendations:

No recommendations. Continue to monitor this question during the second round of interviews.

6.2.3 Income Amounts

Research Question:

These questions are created by combining several periodicity and amount questions. For example, public assistance combines Q59ep, Q59e, Q59e2 and Q59e3. The goal is to reduce cognitive burden by grouping together related income items, and to reduce burden by reducing the number of screens and the amount of text respondents must read through. The amount of text seen will vary depending on how many sources they reported and whether they follow the default periodicity.

Description of how questions will function:

All the following income amount questions will function this way unless otherwise specified.

Income amount questions that don't have a commonly selected periodicity will initially ask amounts using a grid format. The grid format will have a row for each source reported in the corresponding source question. The frequency, amount and number of payments will be entered. The frequency column will have a drop-down with options of:

- weekly
- monthly
- yearly

The 'number of payments received' box will only be fillable if something other than yearly is selected. There will be a total line for the year that is auto populated based on these entries. The respondent will be able to change fields entered to render a new total amount, if needed. If this can't be programmed in the instrument for the cognitive interviews, then a printout of what it would like with probes could be used instead.

Income amounts that have a commonly selected periodicity will initially ask for the amount using a default periodicity. There will be an option for the respondent to check if they prefer to report the amount in a different way. If they select this, they will then be taken to a screen with the grid format of asking for amounts. This screen will be the same that is used for income amounts that vary in the way periodicity is reported. See example question (Q59) below).

Reporting format: Data for all of the questions using this format will be combined and reported about together. The table below presents all of the income topics as well as how many participants received the question and whether the topic included the alternative screen. Those topics without alternative screens will include data only from the one screen applicable. Some of the income topics include additional follow up questions which will be presented later in the report. Some of the most challenging questions will also be presented one by one to give space for topic-specific issues; these questions are starred in the table below.

Q59amt. Enter the amount you received from State or Federal unemployment compensation in 2023:

	Enter Amount Each Month	Number of Payments	Total
State and Federal unemployment compensation			

☐ I want to report yearly or in a different way.



Q59_alt. Enter the amount you received from State or Federal unemployment compensation in 2023:

	Enter Amount	Choose Frequency	Number of Payments	Total
State and Federal unemployment		v		0
		← →		

Overall findings:

How many respondents had difficulty? How many respondents answered “don’t know”?

- Overall, the income amount questions can be extremely hard or impossible for participants to answer. They do not know the exact answers off the top of their heads and some are reluctant to spend the time and effort to look up their records. In some cases, records do not exist at all. **Exhibit 6-1** below presents the questions that participants could not report an amount, this is the total both for themselves and for proxy reports. There were 34 instances where participants could not report for themselves, and 10 instances where participants could not proxy report for others in their households.
 - Questions asking about interests and dividends for their accounts (Q63cp and RETIRENEW1) posed the most challenges for participants. See question-specific findings for further details about these two questions.
 - Some participants became frustrated by the detailed questions. P2734 audibly sighed before saying, “And again, I don’t know those numbers off the top of my head at all” when they saw the question DISTNEW (distributions from retirement accounts).

Exhibit 6-1. Number of Don’t Knows by Question for Self and Proxy Reports

Variable Name	Q Topic	Could not self report	Could not proxy report	Total Count of Instances
ANNEW1	Annuity income	1	1	2
DISTNEW	Distributions from retirement account	4	1	5
NONRETIRENEW12	Report total in checking accounts	5	2	7

Variable Name	Q Topic	Could not self report	Could not proxy report	Total Count of Instances
Q52amt	Worker's comp	1	0	1
Q56amt	Social Security	0	1	1
Q58E1	Survivor benefits	1	0	1
Q60V	Veteran's payments	1	1	2
Q62E1	Pension	2	1	3
Q63cp	Nonretirement accounts – interests and dividends	8	1	9
Q65c	Rental income	0	1	1
Q72cp	Regular financial assistance	1	0	1
RETIRENEW1	Retirement accounts – interests and dividends	8	1	9
RETIRENEW2	Report total in retirement account	3	0	3
Grand Total		35	10	45

- Some preferred to leave the question blank than to provide an inaccurate estimate, such as P2351 on Q60V (veterans payments), who shared "I have to say I don't remember what I got each month. I can estimate it, I'll be wrong." P2464 agreed with this on NONRETIRENEW12 (total in checking accounts), saying that any guess would be purely a guess.
 - Some of these participants explicitly wanted a "don't know" response option to indicate their uncertainty. P2595 shared, "I would honestly skip it, just because I don't have that information. Um, also, if there was an option on there... just a fill-in that says... something along the lines of not knowing... that would be awesome." P2710 shared similar sentiments, stating "And you need a 'not sure'!.. Or a 'check my tax return, you will find it there.'"
 - Other participants brought up the preference to report a range rather than an exact number, such as P2770 on Q72cp (regular financial assistance) and P2710 on Q58E1 (survivor benefits). A few participants also mentioned issues with the reference period. Interviews took place in fall of 2024 and questions asked about 2023. Some participants could recall the information at current but not report for 2023. For example, P2332 on Q63cp (nonretirement accounts – interests and dividends) shared, "It's saying for 2023, I don't know honestly. I could check what it is now, but I don't know for '23." When they do not know the answer to a question, participants reported that they were making a rough estimate or a guess about their answer. **Exhibit 6-2** below presents the questions and topics where participants verbalized that they were making a guess. For example, when P2361 answered RETIRENEW2, "I'm just going to make up a number... And that was easy to do...it's in the range of reason."

Exhibit 6-2. Number of Estimated Answers by Question

Variable Name	Q Topic	Count of Participants
NONRETIRENEW12	Report total in checking accounts	3
Q57c	SSI	1
Q58E1	Survivor benefits	1
Q59e	Cash assistance	1
Q62E1	Pension income	1
Q63cp	Nonretirement accounts – interests and dividends	2
RETIRENEW1	Retirement accounts – interests and dividends	2
RETIRENEW2	Report total in retirement account	2
Grand Total		13

Are respondents able to provide proxy responses for household members?

- Due to time constraints, not all participants were asked each question for the other people in their household, even when it applied. From the data we were able to collect, participants did experience difficulties reporting detailed financial information for others in their household, even for spouses. One participant (P2245) struggled to report any information for her mother-in-law. She explained, "I have honestly no idea. I didn't get power of attorney over her, my husband did since it was his mom. He was the one who took care of all the, you know, financial stuff so I really am just now sure. But I do know she got a payment every month, but I can't tell you how much it was...The hard part would be if someone was trying to figure this out and they had someone who has dementia... you wouldn't be able to go to them and ask them these questions. They wouldn't know."
- For participants reporting on behalf of their roommates, these questions can be too sensitive to discuss. When viewing NONRETIRENEW12 (total in checking accounts) P2770 shared, "Absolutely no idea and I would not ask these questions." They indicated they would ask their roommate whether or not they have an account or even what type of financial assistance they receive, but would not be comfortable asking about the amounts.

How many respondents had difficulty? How many respondents want to reference their records?

Some participants are open and willing to pull up their records to respond to the questions. These "superstar" reporters are a specific type of participant who want to provide as accurate data as possible when filling out surveys. The prevalence of this type of respondent in the general population is unknowable, but in our small, non-representative sample, 10 participants indicated the need and willingness to access their records to provide accurate responses. **Exhibit 6-3** below presents the questions and topics participants indicated they needed records in order to answer. Four of these include instances where participants provided an estimate, while the other 13 reflect cases where participants refused to provide a response.

Exhibit 6-3. Need for Records by Question

Variable Name	Q Topic	Count of P number
ANNEW1	Annuities	3
CONTRIB1	Contribution to retirement	1
DISTNEW	Distributions from retirement account	1
NONRETIRENEW12	Report total in checking account	1
NQ669D	Educational assistance	1
Q56amt	Social Security	1
Q58E1	Survivor benefits	1
Q59amt	Unemployment	1
Q62E1	Pension income	1
Q63cp	Nonretirement accounts – interests and dividends	5
RETIRENEW1	Retirement accounts – interests and dividends	4
RETIRENEW2	Report total in retirement account	2
ROLLAMTA	Roll over amount from IRA	1
Total		23

- Participants do not have detailed financial information for a previous year stored in their memory. They struggle to answer the amounts questions without records.
 - For example, P2595 shared “If I’m able to log in and search, that’s the only way I’ll know how much I had at the end of 2023.”
 - P2245 thought the only way to accurately answer these questions would be to retrieve tax records for everyone in the household, sharing “If I were to have to do this, I’d have to get a copy of everybody’s taxes. That would be the only way I would be able to go through and do this questionnaire.”
 - Another participant (P2734) thought respondents should be asked to retrieve tax returns before starting the survey, stating “Jeez... I think I would tell people to have their tax returns handy before they start.”
- When the questions are so detailed and participants start to get frustrated because they cannot easily answer questions, the risk of breakoffs increases.
 - One participant (P2734) indicated difficulties reporting for ANNEW1 (annuities) and shared, “if I was going to answer accurately, I would have to go back through [my records]... I might skip it if I’d already gotten bored with the survey.” This participant said it would depend how committed she was to the survey, if she knew the purpose of it, and if she thought the purpose was worthwhile.
 - Some may be willing to skip individual questions and still try to answer the rest of the survey, such as P2361, “In all honesty if I was taking this survey, I may not answer this question [RETIRENEW1] because it would take me a lot of time to like find my log-ins for my accounts and yeah I... wouldn’t do that... If it said... an estimation, a ballpark figure... I’d be more comfortable

answering it personally." Other participants echo the need for an instruction allowing them or encouraging them to estimate.

- In some cases, the data for a given income amount may not exist at all. For example, one participant (P2595) explained on Q63cp (Nonretirement accounts – interests and dividends), "That part I do not know... If I had access to how much I've had accumulated, because I know on some checks it will tell me how much is being sent that way. If I was doing this solo, I probably would have logged into payroll account and looked at all check in 2023. Or maybe just find a tax form." This issue of no records came up with several participants on questions asking for interests and dividends from accounts (Q63cp, RETIRENEW1). Please see these question-specific sections for more information about lack of records.

How many respondents had difficulty? How many respondents refused to answer?

In addition to those who reported they did not know an answer, there were several participants who refused to answer, primarily because of privacy concerns. Seven participants (P2261, P2278, P2283, P2310, P2961, P2283, P2310) refused to report at least one question in the income section.

- P2261 was the participant who refused to answer the most questions, skipping at least 6 questions. This participant indicated they would never provide this detailed financial information on a survey.
- Another participant (P2278) refused two questions (Q63cp, NONRETIRENEW12) about interest and dividends earned from nonretirement accounts and the total amount in those accounts. This participant had a strong reaction, sharing "That's none of your business! You're the Census Bureau, you're not providing me with any money, this is crazy, I think all these income questions should be removed...This makes me feels like... you might be messing with our social security... I would never give this information out. Ever." This participant was willing to provide total household income, but not the level of granularity the survey asks for.
- Another participant (P2310) refused based on both burden and privacy for Q63cp, stating "I would need to really go through my accounts to figure this out... I'm not going to do that to fill out a Census form."

For default question:

How many respondents had difficulty? What would make more sense if they were confused?

- Six participants (P2245, P2246, P2278, P2286, P2417, P3022) indicated they thought the checkbox was clear, while four (P2253, P2261, P2351, P2734) thought it was unclear. While more people said it was clear, this may be acquiescence to the probe after a long interview. We do think there are concerns with the checkbox language as well as placement.
 - The language of the checkbox only mentions "yearly," which prompts participants to think the only alternative reporting option is to report yearly. For example, P2245, who shared "...you can report the amount, uh, the total amount yearly if you wanted to." Another participant (P2734) guessed that the only other reporting option was to report yearly.

- There may be some issues with this checkbox dependent on the type of income. For example, one participant (P2253) was confused about what other ways he could report distributions from his retirement account, since he only took one distribution for the year. He wanted the checkbox to be removed entirely to make the question easier to understand. Another participant (P2261) was confused once they viewed the alternative version because, as they explained, "But social security is once a month. There's no other option there, so..." He thought it would only make sense to report in the alternative format if payment was bi-weekly or another frequency. Another participant (P2332) felt similarly about unemployment and felt there was no other option than weekly since unemployment is paid out weekly.
- One participant (P2351) who was unclear did understand that the checkbox would allow them to report their social security in a year amount instead of monthly payments, but did not think the functionality was clear. They were not sure what the alternative reporting would look like and would have to look at it before understanding what the alternative option looks like. This participant explained, "Yearly amount, I'm not at all sure that's clear. I can click that [the checkbox] and see what it says there [P clicks check box and goes to next page] So it does what I ask it would be, if they know the numbers."
- In addition to issues with participants not providing an answer, four participants (P2619, P2245, P2646, P2710) had issues with double reporting income because of confusion about what each filter question in the sources section was asking, especially for pensions.
 - Three participants (P2619, P2245, P2646) struggled with double reporting pensions.
 - Two participants (P2619, P2245) accidentally reported both a survivor benefit pension and a pension in the source questions. Both only receive one pension. P2619 reported the exact same income twice, once for the survivor's pension (Q58E1) and once for pension (Q62E1). She asked, "Didn't I just do that?" This participant knew something was wrong but was not sure what. P2245 had a similar interaction with the survey, double reporting a union survivor pension (Q58E1) and pension (Q62E1).
 - One participant (P2646) caught his confusion and reported his pension income only once. He had initially indicated both veteran's payments and a pension, but when entering income realized that he should only report this income source once. When he saw Q62E1 (pension income) after Q60V (veteran's payments) he wanted to go back to Q60V, delete his responses, and move the numbers to Q62E1. He was confused about why he was receiving both questions and felt it was redundant. These two instances illustrate some of the problems already discussed about the filter questions for pension income.
 - Another participant (P2710) also experienced issues with double reporting with confusion about a federal government pension and social security. This participant realized that she may have made a mistake when answering Q62E1 (pension income) and asked, "Federal government pension, is that different than social security?" This participant decided to leave this question blank.

Did the respondents report the periodicity requested or make a mistake?

- Only one participant (P2332) misreported weekly amounts instead of monthly amounts on the default screen for Q59amt (unemployment) because they only thought about unemployment in weekly payments. They did not realize the question asked about monthly values.

Do respondents like reporting the amount monthly or would they have preferred to report it differently? Would they prefer being asked how they want to report the amount first?

- Preference for the default or alternative screen seems highly dependent on the income topic, with participants preferring the format that works best for them for a given question.
- When asked, two participants (P2286, P2332) indicated they felt the set up of the default screen first worked well. P2286 thought this on both Q62E1 (pension) and Q65d (rental income). P2332 thought this on Q59amt (unemployment) and shared that he didn't think there was any way to report differently because they pay out unemployment weekly. When the amount they want to report matches the default screen, then participants think it is working okay.
- However, five participants (P2245, P2283, P2351, P2770, P2961) indicated a preference to be asked about reporting period preference before being asked to report the amounts. Several of these participants preferred the alternative version of the question where they could choose the time period themselves.
 - P2245 thought the alternative format was more convenient but was slightly concerned that some people might not understand the dropdown menu. He shared, "I like the drop down and I like this box better than the checkmark... this feels a lot more efficient, and this seems more intuitive... Doesn't look very cluttered. Sometimes with the checkbox it's like visual clutter, but this is very clear."
 - P2961 thought about his unemployment income in weekly amounts rather than monthly and preferred the alternative question so he could report weekly. When reviewing the default screen he shared, "So this is asking the amount you received each month from state and federal unemployment so I would love to just report this, you know, here's my weekly amount... I don't see that as an option. The number I think of... I think weekly."
- However, some participants preferred to have the alternative screen first because the time period they wanted to report for did not match the default screen. For example, P2283 wanted to report RETIRENEW1 (Retirement accounts – interests and dividends) yearly and so preferred the alternative screen. Another example was P2770 who liked that at Q72cp (regular financial assistance) they could report 12 payments of \$50 right away without having to click the checkbox; the alternative screen (which is the only option for regular financial assistance) worked better for their reporting needs.

For grid question:

Is the grid format of asking for amounts, periodicity, and number of payments easy for respondents to understand? Is there any part of this format that makes it difficult to follow?

- When asked, seven participants thought the grid made sense and explained that it was easy to use to report their data. For example, P2245 shared, "I did like that drop down. Because people get paid in all sorts of different ways and they way they think to organize it in their head and remember it, it's different for everybody." Another participant (P2261) explained, "If you get \$1000 a month in social security, number of payments would be 12, and then the total would be 12,000. I don't think there's anything confusing about that."
- However, eight participants had some struggles with the grid format, primarily around the number of payments when they wanted to report a single one-time payment, the totals, and the overall presentation.
 - Some had issues with the grid when they received only one lump sum of the income type in a year. To report this, they must enter "1" into the number of payments. This is confusing for questions that ask for monthly reports, such as Q59e (cash assistance), and that only present the alternative version, such as Q72cp (regular financial assistance).
 - In one case, a participant (P2434) wanted to report one value for the year for Q72cp (regular financial assistance) and tried to click into the total box to enter the one payment she received.
 - One participant (P2710) also had issues with reporting multiple one-time payments for Q58E1 (survivor benefits) in the grid.
 - Another participant (P2734) indicated she wanted to provide a yearly total for Q62E1 (pension) but did not seem to see the checkbox for alternative reporting. The interviewer suggested that she could put in the amount and a "1" in the number of payments, but the participant refused to do that because the question asks for a report of each month. tP2253 wanted to provide one lump sum for DISTNEW and was not sure how to report that monthly.
 - Others were confused about the overall presentation.
 - One participant (P2351) reacted to the default screen for Q60V (Veterans payments) with confusion, stating "Now this is confusing... That Enter Amount and Amount Each Month and then a Total doesn't make any sense at all."
 - Another participant (P2709) did not understand "the number of payments" in the question text since they received payments all year for their pension income (Q62E1). This participant explained, "It's confusing when you say each month and the number of payments. What does number of payments mean? I would want to report it per month. But I think this is really confusing. This number of payments thing is confusing. I know it more as a monthly amount. So I don't know why you're asking number of payments. If you're asking how much I get each month, wouldn't that be enough?"

- The automatic calculation is not always obvious to participants.
 - One participant (P2734) did not initially understand that the total would be automatically calculated and was worried about having to do the math herself.
 - Another participant (P2434) revealed that the automatic totaling was not obvious when she tried to enter a one-time payment into the total box for Q72cp (regular financial assistance).
 - Another participant (P2770) thought that when she reported payments biweekly (i.e., chose biweekly in the dropdown) that the grid would automatically calculate the total for the year without having to put in the number of payments. She got confused about how many biweekly payouts she received for Q63cp (Nonretirement accounts – interests and dividends) and decided to skip the question altogether rather than provide a response.

Does having the confirmation of the total annual amount help respondents to catch errors? Do they even know this amount to check the total (i.e., is the total meaningful to them)?

- Six participants (P2245, P2246, P2278, P2286, P2434, P2646) thought the automatic total was helpful, while four (P2332, P2351, P2770, P2734) thought it was not too helpful. Those that liked the automatic total thought it was convenient, could help prevent errors, and was overall helpful. Those who did not think the total was helpful were neutral about it and did not feel it obstructed their response process, but just did not need it to respond. For example, P2351 stated “Having the total box doesn’t hurt, but not sure it helps. But it certainly is simpler for calculation purposes, so I see nothing wrong with this.”

Can the respondent “make corrections above”? Are there situations (like one month is different from the others where this won’t work?

- There are no data to support analysis about making corrections. However, there were several instances when participants struggled to fit irregularly, inconsistent amounts into this reporting structure.
 - One participant (P2734) struggled to answer Q63cp (Nonretirement accounts - interest and dividends) because the amount varies from month to month. They shared, “For me personally that amount fluctuates...It would be really hard [to answer].” This participant said even with records it would be difficult to report this on a monthly time frame because of the variation in interest.
 - One participant (P2710) reported on Q58E1 (survivor benefits) that the question was difficult to answer because she gets several yearly payments from several separate accounts, which places burden on her to add them up and report in one number.
 - One participant (P2961) struggled with Q59amt (Unemployment) because the payment came every two weeks but was a weekly amount.

There were some significant issues with the income amounts questions, both the topic of income and the display of the questions. Participants struggled to report exact income amounts and many preferred to skip the questions than spend time to retrieve their records. Some were willing to guess, but others were hesitant to do so without explicit

instructions. The income amounts questions pose extremely high respondent burden due to these factors.

Recommendations:

We recommend considering a reduction of income amount items to focus on key topics. The questions that should be considered for removal are RETIRENEW1 (Retirement accounts – interests and dividends) and Q63cp (Nonretirement accounts – interests and dividends). See next sections for question-specific findings about these two questions. We believe these questions could be replaced by RETIRENEW2 and NONRETIRENEW12, respectively. Removing these two questions should help reduce respondent burden and improve data quality. These questions had the highest number of missing responses, and most misunderstandings about the topic.

We also recommend adding instructions to encourage respondents to estimate their responses, preferably both at the start of the interview and on key questions, such as RETIRENEW2 and NONRETIRENEW12.

We recommend changes to the order of questions (see **Section 7. Overall Recommendations**) so that these amounts questions follow their filter question directly. This should help improve data quality by maintaining consistency for respondents across questions and reduce respondent burden by grouping questions about the same accounts together.

Finally, we recommend moving forward with the alternative version that asks periodicity for all amounts questions alone, without first showing the default question. Asking the periodicity for reporting first may increase burden for those who want to report using the most commonly used time period; however, it should decrease confusion for those who need to report in a time period that is uncommon for the given type of income. We recommend some changes to the alternative grid, as follows:

- Some improvements should be made to the periodicity question including grey text instructions in the drop-down bars (e.g., “*How often*”), formats should be hard coded for dollar amounts, instructions should be added on how to report one payout per year, and clear indication that the total is automatically calculated (e.g., all other boxes are white and total is greyed out).
- We also recommend providing a reference guide to report the number of payments by frequency. This should be tested in the second round of cognitive interviewing to ensure that it is understood.

Any changes to this format should be retested in the second round of cognitive interviews, with a focus on mobile testing. If we decide not to move forward with periodicity as the only amount question, then each income type should be reviewed for the most common reporting period and updated. For example, the unemployment question should ask about weekly payments instead of monthly.

Consider the following revision:

Q59_alt. Enter the amount, frequency, and number of payments you received from {unemployment fill} in 2023. The total will calculate automatically. Your best guess is fine.

Please reference the table below for number of payments in a year to report how often you were paid. For example, if you were paid \$400 a week for all weeks in 2023, you would enter \$400, weekly, 52 payments.

Unemployment	Enter amount	How often	Number of Payments	Total
(^unemployment source fill from Q51A1)	\$____.00	How often [drop down with weekly, bi-weekly, monthly, and yearly as options]	-	-

Social Security Disability Follow Up Questions

Q562d3. Is this \$(total amount from Q562d) before or after any monthly Medicare deductions?

After deductions

Before deductions

n = 0

Q562md. How much were (name's/your) monthly Medicare deductions?

Include Medicare Advantage, Part B, and Part D premiums.

\$(text).00 per month

n = 0

Q558. In 2023, did (name/you) receive an initial Social Security Disability payment that was larger than the usual payment that we haven't accounted for yet?

Sometimes the initial payment is larger to make up for the delay in receiving the first payment.

- Yes
- No

n = 0

Q559. How much was that initial disability payment?

\$(text).00 per month

n = 0

No participants saw these questions and there is no data to report on.

Withdrawals/distributions from retirement plan

DISTNEW. Default screen: Enter the total amount withdrawn or distributed from (^name's/your) retirement account in 2023.

Amount

(^retirement source
fill from Q98AR(1-7))

\$____.00

[] I want to report monthly or in a different way.

DISTNEW_alt. Alternative periodicity screen: Enter the total amount withdrawn or distributed from (^name's/your) {retirement account} in 2023.

Amount

Per

Number of
payments

Total

(^retirement
source fill from Q97Ar)

\$____.00

____(drop down)

n = 10

Findings:

- Five participants (P2417, P2710, P2734, P2245, P2246) were unable to provide a response for this question because they do not know the answer. One participant (P2246) shared, "I feel like if I got to this question either I would have to look at it, like go into my account, or if not, to see if I did have the option to skip it." Another participant (P2734) felt similarly, sharing, "And again, I don't know those numbers off the top of my head at all...If I wanted to answer... I would have to look it up.. We have it, we have the paperwork."
- One participant (P2361) likely should not have received this question and was confused about what "distributed" meant.

Recommendations:

This question has a high value of missingness from participants and SMEs should review it closely to evaluate its utility. Adding instructions about estimates may be helpful to encourage guesses (e.g., "your best guess is fine").

If retained, review programming and confirm that skip patterns are implemented correctly.

Withdrawals/Distributions from Retirement Plan Follow Up Questions

ROLLA. Did (^you/name) re-invest or "roll over" any of the money into an IRA or some other kind of retirement plan?

- Yes
- No

n = 7

Findings:

- This question does not specify a reference period, leading one participant (P2710) to answer “yes” even though it happened before 2023. She answered yes because “...when I retired I did, but it wasn't in '23.”
- One participant (P2310) was confused about the question order and did not understand the flow of questions from income about hobbies (Q73A1R) to re-investing his 403b (ROLLA). He felt like he “broke the survey” and was confused why this was being asked here.

Can you explain what roll over means?

- Two participants (P2245, P2261) thought that “roll over” was clear, while three (P2246, P2286, P2710) were unable to give a solid definition.
 - One participant (P2246) who was uncertain explained that she did not really know, even though she answered yes, “I don't know exactly. I really should know more. Reinvesting. What I was getting from it was just like adding to, or contributing. That's how I answered...[I answered yes] because I thought of it as contributing. Because I know that I do that on a frequent basis.”
 - Another participant thought about reinvesting but could not verbalize an explanation.
- One participant (P2361) struggled with this question and was unable to answer it. She did not know what the question was asking about and asked, “When it says any of the money is talking about anything I may have withdrawn or distributed?”
- General knowledge about roll overs was mixed and some did answer “yes” in cases where it seems they should not have, misunderstanding “roll over” as general contributions.

Recommendations:

Asking about contributions with CONTRIB1 first before asking about roll overs may help prevent participants from answering “yes” to roll overs when they are thinking about regular contributions to their accounts. Additionally, add a reference period to the question.

See **Section 7** for overall recommendations about question order, including transition statements that may help improve the survey experience.

Consider the following revisions:

ROLLA. In 2023, did (^you/name) re-invest or “roll over” any of the money into an IRA or some other kind of retirement plan?

- Yes
- No

ROLLAMTA. How much did (^you/name) re-invest or “roll over” into an IRA or some other kind of retirement plan in 2023?

n = 3

Findings:

- One participant (P2310) wanted to report "100%" because they did not know what the dollar amount is. The survey would not allow him to input a percent sign and he noted that the field was not coded with a dollar sign to indicate that dollars should be reported.

Recommendations:

- All questions that ask for reports in dollar amounts should be formatted with a dollar symbol to encourage reporting dollars.

ROLLB. (^Do/Does) (^you/name) plan to re-invest or roll over any of the money?

- Yes
- No

n = 4

ROLLAMTB. How much (^do/does) (^you/name) plan to re-invest or "roll over" into an IRA or some other kind of retirement plan?

n = 0

Recommendations:

ROLLB was presented to participants incorrectly when they reported ROLLA = no. The programming logic should be reviewed and updated appropriately. See **Appendix F** for all programming errors.

Retirement Interest/Dividends

RETIRENEW1. Default screen: For {name fill}, enter the total amount of interest or dividends received from {retirement account} in 2023, including small amounts reinvested or credited to the account.

amount Number of payments Total

(^retirement source

fill from Q97Ar) \$____.00 _____

[] I want to report monthly or in a different way

RETIRENEW_alt. Alternative screen: For {name fill}, enter the total amount of interest or dividends received from {retirement account} in 2023, including small amounts reinvested or credited to the account.

amount Frequency Number of payments Total

(^retirement source

fill from Q97Ar) \$____.00 _____

n = 19

Findings:

- Only 3 participants (P2289, P2646, P2285) out of the 19 who saw the question were able to provide a response, and those three struggled to answer. This

question is extremely difficult for participants to answer since this information is not stored for retrieval in their memories. Nine participants did not provide an answer (both self and proxy reports) because they did not know the answer.

- One participant (P2283) understood what the question was asking but said he did not have any information about the interests received from the retirement account in 2023.
- Another participant (P2417) seemed to understand the question but was not used to thinking about his retirement accounts in this way. He shared, "I don't know... I don't keep track of how much it's grown...I don't usually hear it described that way."
- Two participants were confused about what the question was asking about, thinking that the money had to be withdrawn because of the wording "received."
 - One participant (P2619) thought that the money from her account had to be withdrawn to earn any interest and was confused about the concept of crediting money back to the account. She answered "0" because she is not currently taking any money out of her retirement account.
 - Another participant (P2770) shared similar confusion with the question, stating "This is where I'm confused, where I'm like... received, did I withdraw? I didn't withdraw anything... I would skip this because it's confusing and I don't know."
- Some participants indicated if completing the survey on their own, they would be willing to look up their records. However, some doubted that an easy answer existed in their records.
 - One participant (P2286) explained that he would have to pull his account records quarterly and add up the interest received. He reported that he would probably just try to estimate and not dig into it.
 - Another participant (P2361) thought looking up records for this question would take too much time, sharing "...In all honesty if I was taking this survey, I may not answer this question because it would take me a lot of time to like find my log-ins for my accounts and yeah I... wouldn't do that... If it said... an estimation, a ballpark figure... I'd be more comfortable answering it personally."
- Two participants (P2289, P2285) who were able to answer, responded incorrectly with their contributions rather than interest or dividends.
 - One participant (P2289) initially provided contributions rather than the money earned from interest and dividends. After probing by the interviewer, he changed his response.
 - One participant (P2646) indicated he had no idea and provided a wild guess. He would not go back to his records and would always estimate for this question.
- Another participant (P2253) was uncertain what the question was asking about and decided to skip rather than make a guess. He explained, "This one is a little bit tricky as I really don't know how to answer this one as far as interest or dividends received from 401k- I don't really know how to answer this. Is it what I received personally, or the 401k account received as far as interest? I didn't really check the interest or dividends."
- Two participants experienced issues with the survey.

- One participant (P2361) noticed a typo in the survey fill where the fill “you” did not have a comma following it, so the question read “for you enter the total amount...”
- One participant (P2361) disliked that some of the boxes were right aligned, and some were left aligned.

This question posed significant burden and caused confusion for respondents. Most were not able to answer this question, and those who tried to answer misreported their contributions instead of the interest earned. Respondents likely do not have one single place to pull records about the interest and dividends from their retirement accounts and would have to add up multiple reports of their earnings from the year. Additionally, some participants were confused about the wording “received” because it sounds like they withdrew money from their retirement account.

Recommendations:

We recommend removing this question from the survey and retaining RETIRENEW2 with the recommended changes. RETIRENEW1 is extremely burdensome for respondents and will likely result in poor data quality due to the type of income.

RETIRENEW2: The Census Bureau can estimate the amount earned in this account based on the size of the account. How much money was in (name's/your)?
--

\$(text).00

n = 9

Findings:

- Two participants (P2283, P2286) were unclear what account this question was referring to.
 - One participant (P2283) was confused about what account the question was asking about. The participant shared, "I don't actually understand the question... They are saying they want us to estimate the amount earned in this account. Which account?"
- Three participants (P2283, P2286, P2734) were confused about the instruction that the Census Bureau could estimate the amount earned.
 - P2734 explained, "I'm not really sure what they're asking me...They want me to tell you how much was in my 403(b)? And therefore what my.. What's the difference between that, are they saying my distribution, are they saying how much it earned? I have no idea what that means."
 - P2283 put in placeholder numbers into the response box and wanted to see the calculation happen in real time.
- One participant (P2361) indicated they were not willing to look up their records because it would be too burdensome, sharing, "I would have to get into a few different accounts and find this number, so yeah I may not go through all of that..."

- One participant (P2710) indicated that she wasn't sure at what point in the year to answer about since there was no reference period and the amount varies in her account throughout a given year.
- One participant (P2361) indicated that they preferred this question over RETIRENEW1 and was able to provide an estimate in the range of reason, sharing, "I'm just going to make up a number... And that was easy to do."
- One participant (P2734) saw a typo with the "your" fill where it filled "your's."

Recommendations:

With some adjustments, RETIRENEW2 may be able to take the place of RETIRENEW1 as a question that is easier for respondents to answer. Some may have privacy concerns, but this question should perform better for those who are willing to answer it. Sensitivity should be explored in the second round of cognitive interviewing.

We recommend the following changes:

- Remove the information about estimating interest earned. This is confusing and participants do not understand it.
- Add a specific reference period for respondents, especially those who want to report using records.
- Reference the account.
- Include a statement that their best guess is fine to encourage estimates.

RETIRENEW2: At the end of 2023, how much money was in (name's/your) {retirement account}? Your best guess is fine.

\$_{text}.00

Contributions to Retirement Accounts

CONTRIB1. Earlier you said that (^you/name) (^have/has) a retirement account, such as a 401(k), 403(b), IRA, or other account designed specifically for retirement savings. Did (^you/they) contribute any money to (^your/their) plan(s), for example, through payroll deductions? Do not include amounts reinvested or "rolled over" from other retirement accounts.

- Yes
- No

n = 18

CONTRIB2. What is the easiest way for you to tell us (^your/ name's) contribution to their retirement account in 2023?

- Percent of earnings
- Annual dollar amount

n = 12

CONTRIB3a. What percent of (^you/their) earnings did (^you/they) contribute to (^your/their) account(s) in 2023?

_____ %

n = 6

CONTRIB3b. How much did (you/they) contribute to (your/their) account(s) in 2023?

n = 4

Findings:

- CONTRIB1 does not specify a time period, which led some participants to answer affirmatively (e.g., P2710, P2734), even though they did not contribute in the last year.
 - One of these participants (P2734) realized their mistake when they saw the follow up question, CONTRIB2. She would have answered “no” to CONTRIB1 if it specified the year 2023, which CONTRIB2 does include. On CONTRIB2 she asked, “Oh wait a minute, did they say I had to contribute in that year?”
- One participant (P2646) was confused by the example “through payroll deductions” in CONTRIB1 and changed their response from “yes” to “no” because they did not contribute through payroll deductions.
- One participant (P2361) wondered if it was a typo in CONTRIB1 where it read “account designed specifically for retirement savings.” They thought it should be “designated” instead.
- One participant (P2770) responded positively to CONTRIB2 and being able to indicate how they would prefer to report.
- There was a fill issue that one participant (P2369) experienced on CONTRIB2. The question read “What is the easiest way for you to tell us your contribution to their retirement account in 2023?”
- There were a few issues with the programming and wording of these contribution questions, such as a missing reference period and inaccurate fills, but overall, they performed well.

Recommendations:

- Consider the following recommended changes:
- Include a reference period for CONTRIB1.
- Change “designed” to “designated,” if appropriate.
- Update the fills on CONTRIB2 to fill “your” appropriately.

Consider the following revisions:

CONTRIB1. Earlier you said that (^you/name) (^have/has) a retirement account, such as a 401(k), 403(b), IRA, or other account designated specifically for retirement savings. In 2023, did (^you/they) contribute any money to (^your/their) plan(s), for example, through payroll deductions? Do not include amounts reinvested or “rolled over” from other retirement accounts.

- Yes
- No

CONTRIB2. What is the easiest way for you to tell us (^your/ name's) contribution to (your/their) retirement account in 2023?

- Percent of earnings
- Annual dollar amount

Interest/Dividends on Non-Retirement Accounts Follow Up Questions

Q63cp. Default screen: Enter the amount (^name/you) received in interests and dividends in 2023 from {fill}, including small amounts reinvested or credited to the account.

For a joint account, split the amount in half for each person.

amount

(^fill from Q99AR

or Q99BR) \$____.00

[] I want to report monthly or in a different way.

Q63cp_alt. Alternative screen: Enter the amount (^name/you) received in interests and dividends in 2023 from {fill}, including small amounts reinvested or credited to the account.

For a joint account, split the amount in half for each person.

Frequency	Number of	Total amount	payments
(^fill from Q99AR or Q99BR)	\$____.00	____(drop down)	_____

n = 18

Findings:

- Of the 18 participants who viewed Q63cp, 83% (15) experienced some difficulties with providing a response. These difficulties include issues discussed above, such as not knowing the answer, having to make a guess, needing records to answer, not understanding the question, and refusing due to burden and privacy concerns.
 - One problem with this question is that participants do not readily have interest information about their nonretirement accounts stored in their memories. This amount of interest income is so low for most participants that they do not even see it as a type of income. As P2710 explained, "Well the amount is peanuts in a checking account. The interest rate is so low. I wouldn't have any idea." Others echoed these sentiments indicating they only receive a few cents every month in interest.
 - Additionally, the amount fluctuates so it can be difficult to report a certain amount per month, or other time period. For example, P2734 said it would be very hard even with records to report interest on a monthly basis because the amount fluctuates.
- Two participants misreported for this question, believing it was asking about amounts in these accounts rather than the interest.
 - One participant (P2286) misreported for this question and entered the total dollar amount in the account rather than the interest earned in 2023.
 - Another participant (P2434) reported the contributions she makes to her savings account every month rather than the interest earned.

- The fill for this question also posed a problem for some. One participant (P2734) indicated they had "other savings or investments," which when filled in Q63cp was confusing. The question appeared so far from the original filter question (Q99Ara) and without any additional context. Per the recommendation on Q99Ara, updating the wording of this fill to "Other savings or investments that pay interest" may help mitigate this issue.
- While most understood the instruction for joint accounts, some participants, such as P2961, would prefer to have the people listed on the same page so that it would be easier to split the account in half. P2961 shared, "...it would be cool if... They had P2 here [on same screen]. That's the way I would have improved this question."

This question was extremely difficult for participants to respond to due to issues with retrieval for this information. It was difficult for most participants to answer this question without the access to records, and some misunderstood the question to ask about the totals in their interest-earning accounts rather than the interest the accounts earned. The amount of interest earned for most was negligible and they question why the Census Bureau wants to know this information.

Recommendations:

Due to the significant challenges with response and the limited utility of this question in its current form, we recommend removing this question from the survey. The amount of income reported with this question is negligible for most respondents and the burden extremely high, paired with a risk for misreporting. NONRETIRENEW12 may pose as a replacement for this question with some changes, as suggested below.

NONRETIRENEW12. The Census Bureau can estimate the amount earned in this account based on the size of the account. How much money did (you/name) have in checking accounts at the end of 2023?

\$(text).00

n = 17

Findings:

- NONRETIRENEW12 has similar issues to RETIRENEW2, with confusion around the information about estimating interest earned, and lack of reference to the specific account.
- Seven participants indicated they did not know the answer (both self and proxy reports) and chose to skip rather than make a guess. Several indicated they did not know unless they reviewed their records due to the time frame; they do not store a historical record of the size of their interest-earning accounts in their memories.
- The question does not specify which account it is referring to, which was confusing to one participant (P2351).
- One participant (P2351) doubted the information that the Census Bureau could estimate the amount based on the size of the account.

- Two participants (P2261, P2278) refused because they thought the question was intrusive, but these participants refused other questions as well.
- One participant (P2770) indicated he would rather report a range.

While not as severe as the problems with RETIRENEW2, we recommend implementing similar changes for consistency and retain this question in favor of Q63cp. Some may have privacy concerns, but this question should perform better for those who are willing to answer it. Sensitivity should be explored in the second round of cognitive interviewing.

Recommendations

We recommend the following changes:

- Remove the information about estimating interest earned. This is confusing and participants do not understand it.
- Reference the account.
- Include a statement that their best guess is fine to encourage estimates.

NONRETIRENEW12. At the end of 2023, how much money did (you/name) have in {fill}? Your best guess is fine.

\${text}.00

Rental Income

Research Question: Rental income will be asked about separately to simplify the loss option. It is typically reported yearly, so the yearly amount will be asked, and a checkbox will be available for losses. The other income sources will then be asked in the same way as the other amount questions.

Q65c. Enter the total amount (^name/you) received for rental income during 2023, after expenses. If there was a loss, enter the amount of that loss and select "Loss."

amount

Rental income \$____.00 ☐ Loss

n = 3

Findings:

- One participant (P2332) answered "income from roomers or boarders" and "rent" for Q65A2, but the participant lives with roommates who pay the rent money to him and he pays the landlord. When asked Q65c, the participant was very confused and did not understand why he received the question. He stated, "The question doesn't make sense to me. I don't know if it's asking if I've gotten rental assistance or if I got money from other people... I didn't receive an income for renting gout a place to people so 0? I'm not really sure.... I'm not really sure what it's asking."

Do they understand when to use the loss box?

- The two participants (P2417, P2734) who correctly received this question understood the loss checkbox.

Would they have preferred to report gross income and expenses from rent separately?

- No data to support analysis.

Recommendations:

No recommendations. Changes to Q65A2 should help prevent respondents from receiving this question when they should not. Continue to monitor this question during the second round of interviews.

6.3 Poverty Questions

6.3.1 Housing

Question MORT_YN

Research Question: We have collapsed two questions into one to cut back on respondent fatigue. We must be able to process this out so that we have different variables on mortgages vs home equity loans, but we shouldn't have to ask more than one question to get to it.

MORT_YN: Which of these loans do you have on this property?

Select all that apply.

- Mortgage or similar
- Second Mortgage
- Home Equity Loan
- None

n = 16

Findings:

How many respondents had difficulty? What would make more sense, if they were confused?

- Of the thirteen participants who reviewed this question, there were two issues identified.
- Two participants (P2710, P2734) raised questions about their understanding of the question. Both of these participants were unsure what "this property" referred to in the question text.
 - One participant (P2710) was unable to provide an answer and asked "What property? I mean are you talking about my home, or other things and stuff?"
 - Another participant (P2734) had a similar concern, asking, "What property am I talking about?" This participant was able to select the response "home equity loan" after reading through the response set. When probed, the participant thought that having the address of the property listed in the question would help to improve clarity, especially when someone owns multiple homes.
 - While participants did not struggle to respond to the question, one participant (P3022) shared, "All paid for...no car loan, no house loan", illustrating that his

first thought was about “property” in general, including vehicles, and not solely focusing on his residence.

- Due to the question order, MORT_YN was asked over half-way through the questionnaire, following questions about income. Therefore, the question was missing the context of previous questions about their home or residence which might help respondents understand what “this property” meant in the context of other questions. The question text itself is not specific enough and could refer to many different types of property, as evidenced by one participant’s (p2710) reaction to the question. Furthermore, this may result in increased respondent burden as participants only understand the question meaning, and specifically the meaning of “this property,” after they read through the response options.
- Another two participants (P2277, P2595) found it difficult to respond as they do not own the home they are living at. Both participants answered “none” but indicated their parents may have loans on the property they live in, but they personally do not have a loan. Note that this response issue could potentially impact other people who are not knowledgeable about their home’s financial status, such as a cohabiting partner.

Did anyone confuse home equity loans and mortgages?

- Most participants seem to understand the differences between home equity loans and mortgages, especially when the options apply to their situation.
- When asked about the difference between home equity loans and mortgages, none of the participants thought that home equity loans were used to purchase a home. Of the 12 who were asked, six participants (P2261, P2253, P2961, P3022, P2417, P2369) stated that they understood home equity loans as being taken against the equity one already has in the home, and two participants (P2710 and 2417) stated they would use home equity loans for a repair or renovation. Two participants (P2310 and P2734) said they generally understood or were familiar with the difference between the two, without elaborating.
- However, one participant (P2710) was somewhat unclear about the distinction and said a home equity loan and second mortgage could be the same thing. This did not impact their response process as they skipped the question due to confusion about what property was being asked about and not due to lack of clarity surrounding what loans they have on their property/ies.
- Generally, the participants found the response options clear and did not confuse home equity loans and mortgages, but there was evidence that the wording “this property” was too vague. Without the context of a prior question defining ‘residence’, participants thought of many different types of properties and response burden was increased because the question text cannot stand alone without the response options.
- Since many of the other questions ask about the entire household, it may be helpful to emphasize that the question is only referring to the respondent themselves so that people who live in properties for which others have loans are not confused about how to answer, such as those who live with parents.

Recommendations:

SMEs should be consulted to determine the preferred option to move forward, but there are two ways to reduce confusion about the phrase “this property.”

We recommend as the first option, to consider filling the address respondents reported earlier in the survey into the question text. This fix will address the ambiguity of “this property” for those who may own multiple homes, as well as reduce respondent burden by clarifying the question meaning. For cases when the respondent has refused to provide an address or the address details are missing, we recommend wording that will refer to the respondent’s current residence.

Additionally, SMEs should consider whether we can simplify the question by asking about whether the respondent themselves has a loan on the property. This will reduce respondent burden and improve data quality in cases where the respondent cannot proxy report about their home’s loan status. We recommend adding “yourself” to the question text to get a more accurate report of the respondent’s loan status.

The second option to consider is the question order for this item. If the wording is not changed, placing the question immediately following questions about the respondent’s home should help improve clarity, especially if placed immediately following the question asking for the respondent’s address. Placement of this question may improve data quality regardless of changes to the text of the question and should be considered whether a fill is added or not.

Note that these recommendations assume that this is an individual-level question and not household. If the intent for this question is household level, we recommend using “...do you or anyone in this household...” and including a “don’t know” response option.

Finally, these findings should be taken in tandem with Q65A2 where we posed the potential for an additional question about whether anyone in the household owns a property. If the SMEs decide to move forward with a new question about property ownership, then those who answer negatively can skip this question (MORT_YN).

Consider the following revisions:

[IF ADDRESS PROVIDED BY RESPONDENT:] “Which of these loans do you, yourself, have on this property: [**FILL_STREETADDRESS**]?”

[IF NO ADDRESS PROVIDED BY RESPONDENT:] “Which of these loans do you, yourself, have on the property where you currently live?”

Question NUMROOMS

Research Question: We need to find out how many bedrooms there are to value the house for the SPM. We can't use the exact question from the ACS because it's a follow up question to one about the total number of rooms in the unit.

NUMROOMS: How many separate bedrooms do your living quarters contain?

Count as bedrooms those rooms you would list if these living quarters were for sale or rent. If this is an efficiency/studio apartment, enter 0.

[Text entry, whole digits]

***n* = 28**

	<i>n</i>	<i>min</i>	<i>max</i>	<i>mean</i>	<i>median</i>
NUMROOMS	28	1	5	2.75	3

Findings:**How many respondents had difficulty? What would make more sense, if they were confused?**

- A total of 28 participants received this question and no major difficulties were reported.
- Two participants reported having minor issues with answering the question.
 - One participant (P2770), explained, "Yes, I mean, there are, like um, open space areas that you know, you can, uh, have a futon in there or something like that and turn it into a bedroom."
 - Another participant (P2286) said it was only challenging because he uses a bedroom as an office, but he did count it correctly as a bedroom.
- An additional two participants (P2770 and P2710) expressed that the term "living quarters" was either outdated or unclear, and (P2710) began to wonder aloud if living quarters only referred to sleeping space only after being probed about the phrase.
- One participant (P2261), who did not indicate any confusion, explained that asking "how many bedrooms" would be clearer than asking about "separate bedrooms."

Did they read the instructions and apply them correctly?

- Of the 25 participants who were probed about the instructions, all either stated they read or were observed to have read the instructions before answering, except for two (P2310 and P2277) who did not read them until after being probed. The instructions were applied correctly.
- The participants found this question relatively straightforward to answer. Four participants provided examples, either about their own home or others, when thinking aloud about this question, such as having a basement being renovated with a sleeping area but not counting as a bedroom for real estate purposes. The term "living quarters" was generally understood.

Recommendations:

The question was for the most part easily understood by participants. No recommendations. Continue to monitor this question during the second round of interviews.

6.3.2 Food Assistance

Question SNAP_YN

Research Question: For the SNAP questions, we need to know who received SNAP at the person level, but only need to know the amount at the household level. People refer to SNAP as a variety of things, so we provide a list of everything they might call it, but we don't actually need to know these separately. People also likely refer to them as more than one thing but know that it's all the same program.

In the past, we've asked two questions for this. The first one has SNAP and food stamps. The second has the state program fill, which is just SNAP or food stamps in the vast majority of states, and the phrase "even for one month." A bunch of people in states where the fill is SNAP or food stamps say yes on the second question after saying no on the first. We have no idea if this is because they needed to be prompted a second time or if "even for one month" is making the difference. Regardless, we know that SNAP is underreported, so it's not an issue of people being bullied into over-reporting. We really want to be sure that this question works and that we aren't going to lose those people who need to be asked twice.

We've also moved these questions in the survey.

This is an extra high priority question.

SNAP_YN: At any time during 2023, even for one month, did (you/anyone in this household) receive benefits from SNAP (the Supplemental Nutritional Assistance Program), the Food Stamp program, (state program fill,/blank) or use a SNAP or food stamp benefit card?

Do not include WIC.

- Yes
- No

n = 28

Findings:

Does the question make sense? What is confusing?

- The participants seemed to understand and were able to answer the question. Of the 21 participants probed, 16 had heard of all the programs listed. It was unclear for two participants (P2710 and P2310) whether they were familiar with all the programs. One participant (P2961) was familiar with SNAP but not WIC, while another participant (P2286) was not familiar with any of the programs.
- The only difficulty in comprehension expressed by 3 participants (P2512, P2710, P2961) was in understanding what WIC was.
 - One participant (P2310) explained that the acronyms should be spelled out. Similarly, another participant (P2710) stated we should specify what WIC is if it is not supposed to be included, and another (P2512) asked what WIC is after reading the instruction. However, this did not impact their response process as they did not receive SNAP.
- Additionally, two participants (P2709, P2310) spontaneously shared that they found this question redundant.

- One participant (P2709), asked, “Wasn't that already asked? It seems like this was asked already on with other income or something, but I'm not sure.”

Did they notice the “even for one month” instruction?

- Of those asked, 22 out of 23 participants noticed the instruction. One participant (P2277) said they “didn’t really” notice the instruction, but after being probed, explained that they would answer “yes” even if they got SNAP for a “week.” This participant answered “no” to SNAP_YN.

If someone only knows about this program as one thing—that is, they call it SNAP or food stamps or the state program name and don’t realize they are all the same thing—do they answer “yes”?

- Eight participants noted that they thought of SNAP and food stamps as either the same, or essentially the same thing. Of these 8, one participant (P2512) answered “yes,” and another (P2373) skipped/refused to answer. The other 6 participants answered “no.”
- Of the four participants who said “yes” to this question, two were probed about what they call these programs. One (P2464) said they have heard of all the programs but knows SNAP to be food stamps and another (P2512) said they are all the same. This participant explained that the “Food Share” program is for seniors and is different. This may be a separate government assistance program that was not reported elsewhere, such as in NCREC, but it is unclear if this participant is only familiar with the “Food Share” program or receives it.

If people said no, would they have said “yes” if we asked in a different way?

- When asked if they received any help buying food in 2023, five participants said “no,” (P2246, P2709 P2245 P2434, P3022) and the one participant (P2277) said they use coupons.

Essentially, we want to know why people answered the way they did here. [Do not draw attention to WIC because we want to know in the next question if they remember not to include it.]

- The majority of participants seemed to answer based on their understanding of “SNAP” and/or “food stamps,” and the majority read and understood the instructions about “even one month.”
- Overall, this question performed well and was understood by participants. While it did not impede their response process, some participants preferred to have acronyms, such as WIC, spelled out. These participants did not receive WIC and were unfamiliar with the program.

Recommendations:

We should consider spelling out the WIC acronym. We might also want to consider testing this question in the second round of cognitive interviews with more participants who receive food benefits.

Consider the following revision:

At any time during 2023, even for one month, did (you/anyone in this household) receive benefits from SNAP (the Supplemental Nutritional Assistance Program), the Food Stamp program, (state program fill,/blank) or use a SNAP or food stamp benefit card?

Do not include the Women, Infants, and Children (WIC) program.

Question SNAP_ROST

Research Question: Basically, the same as on SNAP_YN, but we have now learned that WIC is always distributed on separate WIC EBT cards, so we also need to know whether we need an instruction telling them to leave WIC out when reporting this.

SNAP_ROST: Who received SNAP [, (state program fill) benefits,] or foods stamps at any time in 2023?

Select all that Apply.

[Names from household roster]

n = 4

Findings:

Does the question make sense? What is confusing?

- Only 4 participants received this question so there was limited data to address whether the question was confusing; however, none of the four participants indicated confusion.
- Proxy reporting seemed fairly easy for the two participants (P2332, P2464) who were asked to report for others in their household.
 - When asked whether they might be unsure about any household member(s), P2332, said no because they did the family members' applications and remembered details such as one of them being over the income limit and being ineligible, indicating that proxy reporting was not challenging in this situation.
 - One participant, who has a housemate (P2464), reported SNAP receipt only for herself, and stated that she was "moderately or pretty confident" about her housemate not receiving SNAP benefits.
- While it did not affect the response process, it should be noted that one participant (P2512) spontaneously mentioned, "I guess it is different" after reading the question wording, whereas they had answered all the programs are the same during probing in SNAP_YN.

The previous question noted an instruction about not including WIC. Did Rs remember that? Do they need to see the instruction again?

- No data to support analysis.

Recommendations:

There was no indication that there was confusion with this question; however, due to limited data, additional testing with SNAP recipients may be considered.

Question SNAP_AMT

Research Question: We need to know the amount of money the household receives, but not the specifics for each person. We're also trying to get this into fewer questions.

This is an extra high priority question.

SNAP_AMT: What was the value of SNAP [,(state program fill) benefits,] or food stamps received in 2023 for the entire household?

\$(text).00 per [periodicity dropdown—month, year]

n = 4

Findings:**Does the question make sense? What is confusing?**

- Only 4 participants received this question so there was limited data to address whether the question was confusing to participants; however, none of the four participants who reviewed the question brought up difficulties with comprehension. Two participants (P2512, P2464) specifically described their knowledge of SNAP/food stamps, with one (P2464) noting that she knows it is for supplemental nutrition and it cannot be used for cash or redeemed at a restaurant.
- There may be issues with proxy reporting for this question if the respondent does not know the SNAP benefit situation for all members of the household.
 - One participant (P2351), who skipped the question, said they did not know the amount, and shared, "I don't like answering 'don't know' for this question because... if I were a household... If I had a roommate, I wouldn't know if they were receiving food stamps. And that would be an honest to God 'Don't know.'"

Does the format work? How did they do the math? Did the respondent add all benefits for all recipients together?

- Participants did not express major challenges with the format of the question.
 - One participant (P2332) inquired as to whether the question was asking yearly or monthly number of payments and suggested taking out that part of the question or asking how many months they received the food stamps because all food stamps are monthly.
 - Another participant (P2464) said she wasn't looking forward to doing math and was glad that the question did the math for her.
 - Finally, one participant (P2512) said the total for the year did not sound right.

If you get other benefits (like P-EBT/Summer EBT or TANF) on your SNAP card, have you included them in this value?

- One participant (P2351) received "the summer card" in 2023; however, this participant did not know/ report their total SNAP amount, so did not include it in the value.
- Another participant (P2245) received "Sun Bucks" for 2024, but not 2023, so did not include it.

Do you know what source the money on your SNAP card is coming from?

- There are no data to support analysis.

If you receive multiple benefits on the same card, can you distinguish how much money is from each source?

- There are no data to support analysis.
- Overall, participants understood this question but struggled with proxy reporting for their entire household and reporting in a yearly period instead of monthly.

Recommendations:

Consider implementing similar changes as suggested to income amounts questions so that participants are presented a grid and can choose to report their food benefits in different periodicity. This format also allows for different state-specific payment periods to be considered. SMEs should be consulted on the frequencies in the drop down to confirm whether all should be presented (weekly, bi-weekly, monthly, yearly) or a subset (e.g., weekly, monthly, yearly).

Adding a “don’t know” or “unsure” option could be useful for proxy situations, especially with unrelated roommates. SMEs should be consulted as to whether they would prefer to ask about only the respondent’s food benefits or the household’s given the potential for measurement error. The current proposed revision below retains the universe of the entire household. If we move forward with a “don’t know” option, the respondent would be routed to SNAP_RNG after selecting “don’t know,” which may be a better user experience than skipping the question and then being presented with a range follow up.

Consider the following revision:

SNAP_amt. Enter the value, frequency, and number of payments **your entire household** received from SNAP[, (state program fill) benefits,] or food stamps in 2023. The total will calculate automatically. Your best guess is fine.

Please reference the table below for number of payments in a year for each frequency. For example, if you were paid \$40 a week for all weeks in 2023, you would enter \$40, weekly, 52 payments.

Value	Enter amount	Choose Frequency	Number of payments	Total
Value of SNAP[, (state program fill) benefits,] or food	\$____.00	Choose frequency [drop down with weekly, bi-weekly, monthly, and yearly as options]	-	-

[] Don't know / not sure → GO TO **SNAP_RNG**

Question SNAP_FREQ

Research Question: Follow up to SNAP_AMT, so same reasons.
SNAP_FREQ: How many monthly SNAP [, state program fill,] or food stamp payments were received in 2023? (Amount fill from SNAP_AMT) for ____ (text box 2 digits <13) months
n = 0

Findings:

- No participants received this question.

Does the question make sense? What is confusing? Does the format work? Is showing the question on the same screen confusing or helpful?

- No data to support analysis.

Recommendations:

We recommend collapsing this question with SNAP_amt with the same format as the income amounts questions. Continuing to use this format should make response easy since respondents will already be trained in the grid format from previous questions. Collapsing these two questions should also reduce respondent burden by decreasing the total number of questions.

Question SNAP_CHK

Research Question: Follow up to SNAP_AMT, so same reasons.
SNAP_CHK: Your total SNAP[, state program fill,] or food stamp payments was \$[fill from SNAP_AMT * SNAP_FREQ]. Does that look right to you? ▪ Yes ▪ No, I need to correct something.
n = 0

Findings:

- No participants received this question.

I think we need to find out if this check in particular annoys the respondents. I could see a world where most people haven't done the math for the year and are annoyed by being asked ANOTHER question when they probably don't need to be. Does the question make sense? What is confusing? Does the format work? Is it helpful or hurtful to put it all on the same screen? If you said "no, I need to correct something," what went wrong and what would you have needed to fix?

- No data to support analysis.

Recommendations:

We recommend removing this question in favor of presenting the grid, where the total will automatically calculate for respondents. This should allow them to confirm in real time the total for the year. If a check of the total is important for SMEs, this question (SNAP_CHK) should be included immediately following the SNAP_amt grid.

Question SNAP_RNG

Research Question: Just need to test it at some point.
SNAP_RNG: If you don't know the exact value, please estimate. What was the value of SNAP [,(state program fill) benefits.,] or food stamps received in 2023 for the entire household? \$0 to \$999 \$1,000 to \$2,999 \$3,000 or more
n = 0

Findings:

- No participants received this question.

Is seeing the amount for the whole year meaningful to you? Do you think of your benefits this way?

- No data to support analysis.

Recommendations:

No recommendations. Continue to monitor this question during the second round of cognitive testing, especially if other changes to the SNAP questions are implemented.

Question SNAP_RNG2

Research Question: Just need to test it at some point.
SNAP_RNG2: Was it...? ▪ \$0 to \$99 ▪ \$100 to \$499 ▪ \$500 or more
n = 0

Findings:

- No participants received this question.

What did you think of this question? (look for comments like “redundant” or “too difficult to narrow down”, etc. Probe more if necessary.)

- No data to support analysis.

Recommendations:

- No recommendations. Continue to monitor this question during the second round of cognitive testing, especially if other changes to the SNAP questions are implemented.

6.3.3 School Meals

Question SMEAL_YN

Research Question: We are trying to reduce the number of questions we are asking, while also adding questions on school breakfasts. We have to know whether or not students USUALLY (more than half the time) ate at school, regardless of whether they received free or reduced-price meals. We also need to get the count of kids in all the different meal categories (didn’t eat, had breakfast, got lunch for free, etc.), so we need the follow up question of which kids which meals and which meals they got for free.

SMEAL_YN: During 2023, did any of the children in this household usually eat a complete breakfast and/or lunch provided by the school?

- Yes
- No

n = 8

Findings:

How many respondents had difficulty? What would make more sense if they were confused?

- Of the eight participants who reviewed this question, two (P2961 and P2289) had difficulty, indicating that clearer question wording regarding the age of children being asked about and the definition of “provided” would have helped with comprehension and retrieval.
- One participant (P2961) originally clicked “no” after reading the question multiple times. When probed about his rereading by the cognitive interviewer, the participant shared “I did...my daughter goes to... my son, he usually brings his lunch, he's a first grader. My daughter... she's in daycare, and so, yeah so, she might qualify for that... So, I would say maybe yes for her... the school feeds her.” At that point he changed his answer to yes, and the interviewer noted that he was at first thinking of his older son. The participant said that was correct, because he doesn't usually think of the daycare as a school; however, he also shared that sometimes his son eats a school lunch.
- Another participant (P2289) has two children, one of whom is school-aged. He answered “no” to this question and stated that his wife provides breakfast and lunch money for that child to buy lunch at school. He shared that the phrase “provided by” means that the school provides everything.

If not done in think aloud, have them think through each child and note if they eat at school or not to check their answer and where the question might go wrong.

- None of the participants had more than one school-aged child in 2023; however, two participants (P2961 and P2289) had one school-aged child and one younger child who attended a childcare program. One participant responded “yes” and one of these responded “No” to SMEAL_YN, despite both having similar situations where their older child purchased meals at school.

Did the respondent notice the word “complete” in the question? Did the inclusion of “complete” change their answer to the question?

- Of the 7 participants who were asked this probe, three (P2303, P2369, P2283) noticed the word ‘complete’, one did not (P2961), and three participants (P2245, P2289, P2332) did not directly address whether they noticed the word. No participants said it would have changed their responses, with four (P2961, P2369, P2289, P2283) specifically stating it would not have changed their response.
- When receiving this probe, one participant (P2303) seemed to interpret the word “complete” to be referring to all meals instead of complete meals: “Yeah, I know like morning, afternoon, evening... Like, breakfast, lunch, and dinner.”
- Another participant (P2245) stated they don’t exactly know what a complete breakfast or lunch refers to and speculated that it likely includes a drink and sides. However, this participant has a homeschooled child and answered “no” to SMEAL_YN, so this did not impact their response.

Does “provided” mean the same as “prepared”?

- Participants were probed about their understanding of the terms “provided” and “prepared” to better understand which term might fit the intent of the question. Of those asked, only one participant (P2289) said these words mean the same thing. Four participants (P2303, P2245, P2961 P2369) thought the meanings of ‘prepared’ and ‘provided’ were different but struggled to clearly verbalize the differences.
- One participant (P2303) said ‘prepared’ is “future” tense.
- One participant (P2245) described how schools may provide a wrapped Smuckers peanut butter and jelly which they did not prepare.
- Three participants (P2283, P2303, P2245) preferred the word “provided,” two participants (P2961, P2310) prefer the word “prepared,” and one (P2332) would prefer “free” instead of either of these terms.
- Those participants who preferred the word ‘prepared’ (P2961 and P2310) had that preference because ‘provided’ implied ‘free’ to them, which made it confusing for them to answer. However, some of this interpretation of “provided” may have been influenced by question order effects of the preceding items about food assistance.

Recommendations:

Due to question order effects of this question being presented immediately after the one about SNAP, respondents may be primed to think this question is asking about government benefits or subsidized lunch programs when reading the word “provided.” We recommend

changing the order of questions so that this item does not immediately follow questions about SNAP. See **Section 7. Overall Recommendations** for more details. We also believe that adding language to the question text to include meals sold by the school is important because purchased lunches are currently underreported.

Additionally, although this question was only supposed to be presented to participants with children aged 5-18, two participants, who only had children under 5, were presented this question. Even with correcting this programming error, we may want to consider including language to specify what age children should be included when answering. It is possible that households with multiple children, such as P2961, screen into SNAP_YN, but only the younger child is provided food by their preschool.

There may also have been some confusion over the word “usually,” though there was not a direct probe about the word. We may want to consider specifying what “usually” means or changing the wording of the question to use the definition “more than half the time.”

Finally, it should be considered whether the universe is respondents with children aged 5-18 during the current year or the year being asked about in the survey, as those children who were 5 years old this year likely did not eat a school meal last year except in a preschool or daycare program.

Consider the following potential revision, which should be reviewed by SMEs for what is most in line with their analytic goals:

Please think about all the children aged 5-18 years in this household.

During 2023, did any of these children eat breakfast and/or lunch **provided or sold** by the school more than half of the time?

- Yes
- No

Question SMEAL_ROST

Research Question: See above (SMEAL_YN).			
SMEAL_ROST: For each child, please indicate which school-provided meals they usually ate in 2023. Select all that apply.			
Child	Breakfast	Lunch	None
[Child 1]	☐	☐	☐
[Child 2]	☐	☐	☐
[Child N]	☐	☐	☐
n = 4			

Findings:

Does the question make sense? What is confusing?

- Three of the four participants who reviewed this question had some challenges understanding or answering it, partially due to unclear wording and partially due to being presented the question when they should not have been.
- For one participant (P2961), the question only was presented for his son, despite discussing both his son and daughter in SMEAL_YN. His son typically brings (picks) his lunch but sometimes buys a lunch; it is his preschool-age daughter who is provided breakfast and lunch every day. It is unclear if the participant did not see the term “usually,” if the term was too vague to map his response correctly, or his focus on his daughter in the preceding question is why he listed his son.
- One participant (P2310) only selected “breakfast” even though his child eats both breakfast and lunch at school; his child gets breakfast for free and pays for lunch. This participant thought aloud about whether “provided” meant free and had decided that it does when choosing to only answer “breakfast.”
- Another participant (P2369) could not choose meals because she was answering about her 4-year-old (see below).

Does the format work? Note if the respondent should have selected more than they did, or they did not choose “none” and instead left the row blank.

- The format was understood by participants. However, the programming error affecting both SMEAL_YN and this question led to it being asked of parents who have children under age 5. This created confusion for those without school-aged children.

If the respondents don’t check any meals, probe as to what went wrong in the previous question.

- One participant (P2369) was unable to check any meals as her 4-year-old child was not listed in the instrument. This was a result of the participant being screened in for this question and the former (SMEAL_YN) despite not having any school-aged children. This participant verbally stated that her child received both breakfast and lunch at preschool.
- The primary challenge with this question was that parents whose children were under age 5 during the year of inquiry were presented the question incorrectly. The instrument had not prompted them in the prior question to only think about school-aged children, so they could not answer this follow up.

Recommendations:

Adjust the programming to correctly present the filter question SMEAL_YN to those with children ages 5-18, along with the changes to the question text in SMEAL_YN to prompt respondents to only think about their school-aged children. If SMEAL_YN is changed to include the text “more than half the time,” then this language should be duplicated in SMEAL_ROST.

Question SUBMEAL_YN

Research Question: We need to know which kids got free or reduced-price meals and for which meals. We have previously not asked about breakfast, so that part is new.

SUBMEAL_YN: During 2023, did [any of these children/this child] receive free or reduced price school meals?

- Yes
- No

***n* = 8**

Findings:**Does the question make sense? What is confusing?**

- The question made sense to most participants, but one participant (P2303) did not immediately understand the phrase “free or reduced price,” and another participant (P2332) seemed to be answering about their own experience instead of their child who is not school-aged.
- One participant (P2303) said they needed to read the question twice to understand what was meant by “free or reduced price.”
- Another participant (P2332), who did not have school-aged children, answered “no” to SMEAL_YN but “yes” to this question and seemed to be answering about her own experiences receiving free or reduced price lunch in childhood, stating that they had qualified.

Would it be clearer if we specified breakfast and/or lunch again?

- It would be clearer if breakfast and/or lunch was spelled out again. One participant (P2310) said that he only considered lunch, but that if the question asked about meals, he would have said “yes” for both children. This participant had noted that the children’s schools give them breakfast in SMEAL_YN.

Do we need to note that we want people to say yes if the kids are getting free meals because everyone at the school is getting free meals (versus schools where individuals have to apply)?

- Two participants had children who receive and eat free meals at schools where at least one meal per day is provided free for all students. One (P2369) clicked “yes” and another (P2310) clicked “no” for this question. Therefore, based on limited data available, it would likely improve the judgement and retrieval process to be clear that those whose children receive a free meal along with all other students should still say “yes” to this question.

Are people thrown off by the phrase “reduced price” vs. “free or reduced school meals”?

- Generally, participants were not thrown off by the phrase “reduced price” and preferred it to the phrasing without the word “price.”
- One participant (P2332) shared that they did not know there was a “reduced price” option, thinking it was either free or paid. This person was the only participant probed who preferred the phrase “free or reduced school meals.”

- Of the other seven probed, participants either had no preference or explicitly preferred the current phrasing: “free or reduced price school meals,” over options like “free or reduced school meals,” or “free or reduced lunch.”
- One participant (P2310) noted that without the word “price” included, the phrase “reduced meal” could mean a “small” meal.
- For this question, in addition to the programming error, the question wording can also be improved to assist with data accuracy.

Recommendations:

This question was presented to all participants who received SMEAL_YN, not just participants who answered “yes” to SMEAL_YN. Presenting to the correct universe of respondents will be important in reducing confusion for this question.

Although “meals” was the language used in the question, one participant (P2310) who said “no” was thinking only of lunches even though his children receive free breakfast. If the words breakfast and lunch were spelled out, this may have avoided. This language of breakfast and/or lunch is already used in SMEAL_YN, so it could be used here for consistency as well.

We may infer based on the limited data available that specifying that schools where free meals are provided for all students should be included.

Consider the following revision:

During [2023], did [any of these children/this child] receive free or reduced-price school breakfast and/or lunch?

If free or reduced price meals are provided to all students at the school, regardless of need, please answer “yes.”

- Yes
- No

Question SUBMEAL_ROST

Research Question: See above (SUBMEAL_YN).

SUBMEAL_ROST: For each child, please indicate which school-provided meals were free or reduced price in 2023.

Select all that apply.

Child	Breakfast	Lunch	None
[Child 1]	☐	☐	☐
[Child 2]	☐	☐	☐
[Child N]	☐	☐	☐

n = 3

Findings:**Does the question make sense? What is confusing?**

- Only one participant (P2303) of the three who were presented this question had a school-aged child eating free or reduced-price meals. None of the three participants reported any confusion, but one participant (P2369) felt the question was redundant. This is likely due to confusion over the language “provided” in SMEAL_YN.

Does the format work? Note if the respondent should have selected more than they did, or they did not choose “none” and instead left the row blank.

- The grid was only presented to one participant (P2303) and this participant selected one meal. Due to the limited data available, more testing may be needed.

If the respondents don’t check any meals, probe as to what went wrong in the previous question.

- The two participants who did not check any meals (P2369 and P2332) were not able to check any meals because they do not have school-age children; this seems to be a programming error (see **Appendix F**).
- The main issue with this question is that two of the three participants who reviewed it should not have received it due to the survey logic.

Recommendations:

- Update the survey logic for SMEAL_YN, which filters to this question, to prevent those without children ages 5-18 in the household from being asked this question.

6.3.4 Non-Cash Benefits*Question NCREC*

Research Question: This is a combination of several yes/no screener questions, to try to reduce respondent burden. Some of them also had follow up questions that we no longer need to ask. This is an extra high priority question.

NCREC: At any time during 2023, even for one month, did (you/anyone in this household) receive any of the following?

Non-Cash Benefit	Yes	No
WIC	☐	☐
Energy Assistance	☐	☐
Heating or Cooling Assistance	☐	☐
Rental Assistance/Section 8 Voucher	☐	☐
Public Housing	☐	☐
Internet or Broadband Assistance	☐	☐

n = 29

Findings:

Does the question make sense? Do people know whether they have different programs?

- The question made sense for most participants; however, three participants (P2512, P2246, P2361) raised issues.
 - One participant (P2512) found it “odd” that “energy” was listed on a different line from “heating and cooling” but also noted that they are received separately.
 - Another participant (P2246) shared that, “The only thing that gave me a little pause, and then I was like, no, that’s not at all relevant, but I was thinking about the fact that I signed up with a new provider for internet in 2023 and it was at a discounted price. But that was just an offer that they were doing at the time so I would not call that internet or broadband assistance.”
 - Another participant (P2361) noted that they were not certain if the question was referring to “government” assistance, indicating that using more precise wording of the question or response options may improve judgement.

Does the format work?

- The only issue raised about the format was by one participant (P2310) who noted that he normally thinks of “no” as being on the left and “yes” as being on the right.

What are they considering when they respond to each source?

- A participant (P2619) said that if [you] are getting one of these programs, you would know that you have it, indicating that even for the participants who were not familiar with all these programs, it did not impact their response process.
- However, four participants (P2434, P2261, P2245, P2417) specifically indicated they are aware of or familiar with the programs on the list.
- One participant (P2464) shared that she has encouraged her roommate to apply for the internet assistance but because the home is not in her name, it has not happened.

Do they select No or just select the Yes options and leave the others blank?

- The 27 participants who selected “no” to all used the “no” button, and the 2 participants (P2512 and P2332) who said “yes” to any of the benefits also selected “no” on the benefits they did not receive.

Do you receive any other assistance from the federal, state, or local government that we missed?

- Two participants mentioned that they have medical programs- Medicaid (P2619) and “ICare” (P2512). Both of these participants consider these programs to be “assistance.”
- One participant (P2245) said they did not receive other assistance in 2023, but in other years they received FEMA assistance.
- Three participants suggested programs or options that should be added, although they did not indicate that they themselves received them in 2023: “elderly” programs (P3022), stimulus checks (P2246), and “cell phone” or an “other” box (P2310).

Do people use the hover/help info for WIC? Do people recognize this as the full name of the WIC program?

- There were limited data to support analysis. One participant (P2278) said she believes WIC is used to buy food products, and that the program used to be for women with children but is now for "damn near anybody."
- Overall, this question performed well and was easy to understand. However, participants do report receiving other kinds of government assistance that may be important to capture, such as health programs, cell phone assistance, and elderly programs.

Recommendations:

SMEs should consider whether this question is focused on government-funded assistance, and if so, this wording could be added to the question text to improve clarity. Currently, the question is primarily understood through the response options. Adding this language to the text could help reduce cognitive burden and increase the clarity of the question being asked.

SMEs should also consider whether they are interested in an "other" option for government-funded assistance to capture other forms of assistance not currently included in this list.

Consider the following revision:

At any time during [2023], even for one month, did (you/anyone in this household) receive any of the following forms of **government-funded** assistance?

- WIC
- Energy Assistance
- Heating or Cooling Assistance
- Rental Assistance/Section 8 Voucher
- Public Housing
- Internet or Broadband Assistance
- Other form of government-funded assistance

Question WIC_ROST

Research Question: We need to find out who is getting the WIC benefits so we can assign the value of the WIC benefits. The current question we ask is "Who received WIC for themselves or on behalf of a child?" and we know that this is not giving us accurate information because it's confusing to have benefits be for a kid but be paid to the adult. We have tried here to come up with better wording that gets at what we want--how many people in the household are getting WIC, and whether they are kids or moms.

WIC_ROST: Who were the WIC benefits for?

Select all that apply.

[Roster names (children under 6, women between 15 and 45)]

n = 1

Findings:

Does the question make sense? How do people think about who receives the benefits—the kid that it is for, or the adult who actually gets the money? Which of these did people report-- the names of people who the benefits were for or who actually gets the money?

- There was limited exposure to this question. The one participant (2332) who received this question reported only the child's name, indicating that there were no significant comprehension or retrieval challenges for this participant.

Recommendations:

- No recommendations. Continue to monitor this question during the second round of interviews. More testing with WIC recipients may be warranted during the second round of cognitive testing.

Question WIC_MNTH

Research Question: We need to know how many months people received WIC.	
WIC_MNTH: For how many months was WIC received in 2023?	
Name	Months
[Name 1]	[text]
[Name 2]	[text]
[Name N]	[text]
<i>n</i> = 0	

Findings:

- No participants received this question.

Does the question make sense? What is confusing? Any trouble with the grid (if more than 1 name shown).

- No data to support analysis.

Recommendations:

- No recommendations. Continue to monitor this question during the second round of cognitive testing.

Question ENG_ASST

Research Question: This is combining a couple of questions with weird universes. We need to know how much energy assistance was received. We've historically never asked this at any periodicity other than annually.	
ENG_ASST: During 2023, how much [fill from NCREC--energy assistance/heating or cooling assistance/energy, heating, and cooling assistance] was received for the entire year? \$[text].00	
<i>n</i> = 1	

Findings:**Does the question make sense? What is confusing?**

- The data reported did not indicate any significant confusion, but there was limited exposure to this question. The participant (P2512) who reviewed this question initially clicked the “don’t know” checkbox and entered numerical data. During probing, the participant removed the “don’t know” check. It is unclear whether there was initial confusion, or this was simply an accidental “click.”

Do respondents need a separate question for each benefit (if more than 1 listed)?

- Based on limited data available, there is no evidence that respondents need a separate question for each benefit. The participant (P2512) received two types of energy assistance. She said she was able to add up the benefits for the entire year.

Would it be easier to report this at a different frequency?

- With the limited data available, there is no indication that it would be easier to report this at a different frequency. The participant said yearly is preferable because the benefit is given in a lump sum.

What sources are the respondents including when they’re reporting this?

- The participant who reviewed this question, receives a veteran-related energy benefit available through her late spouse, and a local utility company benefit.
- There are limited data available for this question. Our one participant who reviewed it did not have any response process challenges.

Recommendations:

- No recommendations. Continue to monitor this question during the second round of interviews.

Question ENG_RNG

Research Question: These are the follow up questions when someone skips ENG_ASST. We just need to test them at some point.

ENG_RNG: If you don’t know the exact value, please estimate.

During 2023, how much energy assistance was received for the entire year?

- \$0 to \$999
- \$1,000 to \$2,999
- \$3,000 or more

n = 1

Findings:**Do they remember what is being asked about (since it's not filled in again)? Or should "heating and cooling" be added to the question?**

- With only one participant that received this question, there was limited data to assess this question; however, there was no indication that respondents will forget what is being asked about. The participant (P2512) who reviewed the question remembered and stated that energy assistance applied to heating and cooling, as far as she knows. She shared that she believes that "anyone" would know that the check that is provided covers heating and cooling and lights. This participant was presented this question despite answering ENG_ASST which appears to be a programming error (see **Appendix F**).
- There were no response issues raised with this question besides the programming error.

Recommendations:

- This question was only seen because of a programming error; if testing is needed on participants who have indeed skipped ENG_ASST, a larger number of low-income participants will need to be recruited during the second round of cognitive testing. We do recommend fixing the programming error and continue to monitor this question during the second round of interviews.

Question ENG_RNG2

Research Question: See above (ENG_RNG).
ENG_RNG2: Was it...? ▪ \$0 to \$99 ▪ \$100 to \$499 ▪ \$500 or more
n = 1

Findings:**What did you think of this question? (Looking for comments like "redundant" or "too difficult to narrow down", etc. Probe if necessary.)**

- There are limited data available for this question. The one participant (P2512) who reviewed it, shared, "It closes in a little bit better...it's their way of zeroing it in a little bit better."
- The participant was presented this question despite answering ENG_ASST which appears to be a programming error (see **Appendix F**).
- There were no response issues found with this question besides the programming error.

Recommendations:

- This question was only tested because of a programming error; if testing is needed on participants who have indeed skipped ENG_ASST, a larger number of low-income participants will need to be recruited during the second round of cognitive testing. We do recommend fixing the programming error and continue to monitor this question during the second round of interviews.

6.3.5 Child Care

Question *CHCARE_PAID*

Research Question: We're trying to get at what kind of care children are getting so that eventually the SPM can account for child care costs better.

CHCARE_PAID. Which type(s) of paid care were used for [CHILD] in 2023?

Select all that apply.

- Child care center/preschool/nursery school
- Home-based child care provider/paid care in provider's home
- Paid care inside of your home (e.g., nanny/babysitter)
- Paid care with family, friends, or neighbors
- Before and/or after-school care
- Summer camps
- Other
- None, did not pay for child care

***n* = 7**

Findings:

Does the question make sense?

- All 7 of the participants who received this question understood the question to be asking about only 'paid' care. ' None of the 7 participants who received this question tried to report unpaid care.

What was confusing?

- None of the 7 participants who received this question reported any confusion with the question. However, one participant (P2332) did report some confusion with the response option "Home-based child care provider/paid care in provider's home" because it seemed to overlap with the response option "paid care inside your home (e.g., nanny/babysitter). This occurred because the participant did not originally perceive "provider" in the former response option. This issue did not interfere with this participant's response process and they were able to select "None, did not pay for child care."

If the respondent answered "other," what types of care did they use?

- None of the participants who received this question answered "other" so there was no data to answer this research question.

Are we missing any types of care that people think are common?

- When asked, three participants (P2303, P2332, P2369) did not think of any other types of paid care that were missing from the response options. However, one participant (P2245) did think that day camps are separate and different than summer camps and might be important to include. This participant explained, "I know even on holiday breaks, like easter break, spring break, they have day camps around me that are open because parents can't take time off work during

the holiday breaks, so they will send them to that day camp of like the week that they have off."

- Note that while this participant selected "none, did not pay for child care" as a response option when responding to CHCARE_PAID, they later were shown CHCARE_AMT due to a programming error (see **Appendix F** for list of all programming errors). When shown CHCARE_AMT, the participant entered an amount spent for sending their child to two of these day camps. It was unclear whether the participant noticed the option to select "other" or was uncertain whether 'day camps' should be included in their response.

Are they selecting more than one option for the same kind of care?

- None of the participants who received this question selected more than one type of paid care.
- Overall, the participants found this question easy to answer. Participants understood the question was asking about paid care only and did not try to report any unpaid care on this question. One participant may have misreported their answer, but it was not clear why this occurred. Another participant had some confusion about one of the response options but was able to select their response without issue.

Recommendations:

No recommendations. The question was easily understood by participants. Although not having an option for day camps may have impacted the response of one participant, this was a single occurrence. The "other" option should still suffice for caregivers who may want to report alternative types of paid care. Continue to monitor this question during the second round of interviews.

Question CHCARE_UNPAID

Research Question: We're trying to get at what kind of care children are getting so that eventually the SPM can account for child care costs better.

CHCARE_UNPAID. Which types of free child care were used for [CHILD] in 2023?

Select all that apply.

- Care by a parent/guardian at home
- Head Start
- Pre-Kindergarten
- Free care with family, friends, or neighbors
- Fully-subsidized child care through subsidy or voucher
- Other
- None

***n* = 7**

Does the question make sense?

- All 7 participants who received this question understood it to be asking about unpaid care and were able to recognize how the question differed from the previous question (CHCARE_PAID) about paid care.

- A total of five participants selected “Free care with family, friends, or neighbors” as a response and reported that this care occurred in their home and outside of their home.
 - Two participants (P2332, P2961) said this care was provided both in home and outside of home.
 - One participant (P2245) said this care was provided outside of their home.
 - One participant (P2303) said this care was provided in their home.

What was confusing?

- Participants were asked about whether the option “Care by a parent/guardian at home” made sense to them, and 5 participants indicated the option made sense and understood it to mean something like a stay-at-home parent or “homemaker.”
- None of the 7 participants who received this question reported any confusion with the question or any other response options. However, one (P2961) seemed to think the question and response options were redundant, saying “Care by parent/guardian... That's always free.” Additionally, despite indicating having children, two participants (P2283, P2269) selected ‘none’ for both paid and unpaid forms for childcare.

If the respondent answered “other,” what types of care did they use?

- None of the participants who received this question answered “other” so there is no data to answer this research question.

Are we missing any types of care that people think are common?

- Most of the participants (P2245, P2283, P2369, P2961) who received this question did not think any other types of care were missing.
- However, one participant (P2332) thought that an option for ‘Churches providing free childcare’ was missing, and explained, “Some churches have free child care throughout the week.”

Are they selecting more than one option for the same kind of care?

- No data to support analysis.

Do respondents understand “unpaid” and “free” as the same?

- Two participants (P2245, P2369) believed that “unpaid” and “free” have different meanings. For them, “unpaid” meant there was no cost to the parent/guardian for the care, but someone was getting paid for providing care via taxes or a grant. Comparatively, “free” care would be care that no one was paying for. For example, one participant (P2369) noted this “unpaid” care is different from family and friends doing child care for free because no one is paying them.
- Three participants (P2245, P2332, P2961) indicated some preference for “free” over “unpaid” since it seemed like a clearer word.
 - One participant (P2245) preferred “free” because the types of care listed in the response options are free to the parent, even if the caregivers are getting paid. They shared, “I think in a parent's mind it probably makes more sense to say free.”

- Another participant (P2332) could see benefits of both, but “free” is very clear, explaining, “I think unpaid sounds more professional, but free is, like, straight to the point.”
- One participant (P2303) preferred “unpaid” over “free.”

Are there other “unpaid” arrangements, like trading services? Do respondents also call those “Free”?

- Most participants (P2303, P2332, P2369, P2961) said they could not think of any other “unpaid” childcare arrangements.
- However, one participant (P2245) did report trading child care with others, and said they sometimes watch the other person’s child as a trade. This participant thought that trading child care with others was a fairly normal practice.

Overall, the participants found this question easy to answer. Participants understood the question was asking about unpaid care only and were able to differentiate this question from the previous question about paid care. However, it is possible that respondents may not think of the daily care they provide for their own children as a form of unpaid child care, potentially leading to misreporting. Two participants viewed there to be a difference between free and unpaid care, suggesting that free care means ‘*no one*’ is being paid, but all participants understood the intent behind the question about free care. The majority of participants preferred the term “free” over “unpaid,” as it was clearer and straight to the point. One participant mentioned engaging in other “unpaid” arrangement of taking turns with another parent in watching each other’s kids.

Recommendations:

To help reduce the chance of respondents misreporting unpaid care, we suggest revising the “Care by a parent/guardian at home” response option to reflect the SMEs’ intent more adequately. Currently, most participants interpret the question to mean having a stay-at-home parent with a few participants not seeming to think of the daily care they provide as a form of child care.

Consider the following options for clarifying the intent behind this response option:

Option 1: If the intent is to capture stay-at-home parents only: “Care by a parent/guardian at home (for example, stay-at-home parent or homemaker)”

Option 2: If the intent is to capture all care provided by parents: “Care by a parent/guardian at home (for example, everyday care provided by parent/guardian)”

Additionally, although participants perception of free vs. unpaid care did not impact their response process, if desired, to clarify the meaning behind “free care,” an italicized definition can be added to the question. SMEs should review this instruction and tweak as needed.

We also recommend dropping the dash between “fully” and “subsidized” to conform with grammar standards.

Question *CHCARE_MAIN*

Research Question: We’re trying to get at what kind of care children are getting so that eventually the SPM can account for child care costs better.
CHCARE_MAIN. What was the main type of child care received by [CHILD] in 2023? ▪ Child care center/preschool/nursery school ▪ Home-based child care provider/paid care in provider’s home ▪ Paid care inside of your home (e.g., nanny/babysitter) ▪ Paid care with family, friends, or neighbors ▪ Before and/or after-school care ▪ Summer camps ▪ Other paid forms of child care ▪ Care by a parent/guardian at home ▪ Head Start ▪ Pre-Kindergarten ▪ Free care with family, friends, or neighbors ▪ Fully-subsidized child care through subsidy or voucher ▪ Other ▪ None
<i>n</i> = 5

Findings:

Does the question make sense? What was confusing?

- Of the 5 participants who received this question, most understood the question to be asking, between previously reported types of paid and unpaid care used, which types of child care they use most frequently. However, one participant (P2691) thought the question was referring to the main person or institute taking care of his child the most and thus selected “Other” to represent the child spending most of his time in school, which was not an option he had previously selected.
 - This participant explained, “Well, for P3, he was actually at a school, and so, I actually would select other here.” The participant was able to choose a different option due to a programming limitation that listed all options for CHCARE_PAID and CHCARE_UNPAID instead of only displaying options previously selected by the participant (see **Appendix F** for list of all programming errors).

Did the respondent struggle because they use multiple types of child care equally?

- None of the participants reported any struggles selecting a main type of care and knew, between care options. For one participant (P2245), although their child occasionally attended day care or stayed at a neighbor’s house, the participant

was easily able to identify that the majority of the time he's cared for by the parent at home.

- None of the participants reported multiple types of care equally.
- Overall, participants were easily able to identify which type of care they used the most. Due to programming limitation that listed all options for CHCARE_PAID and CHCARE_UNPAID instead of only displaying options previously selected, one participant did not interpret the question as asking them to choose between previously indicated types of paid and unpaid care. This participant chose "other" since their child technically spends the most time being watched by others in school. None of the participants reported using multiple types of care equally, so this scenario did not impact any one's response process.

Recommendations:

We recommend updating the programming so only options previously selected in CHCARE_PAID and CHCARE_UNPAID are displayed. This will help ensure respondents only choose between types of care they have previously indicated using, aiding with the interpretation of the question. Testing in round two of cognitive interviewing should review this intended design. To reinforce this design, we may also consider adding text to the question, such as "From the types of child care you reported using, what was the main type of care received by [CHILD] in 2023?"

Consider the following revision:

CHCARE_MAIN. From the types of child care you reported using, what was the **main** type of care received by [CHILD] in 2023?

- Child care center/preschool/nursery school
- Home-based child care provider/paid care in provider's home
- Paid care inside of your home (e.g., nanny/babysitter)
- Paid care with family, friends, or neighbors
- Before and/or after-school care
- Summer camps
- Other paid forms of child care
- Care by a parent/guardian at home
- Head Start
- Pre-Kindergarten
- Free care with family, friends, or neighbors
- Fully-subsidized child care through subsidy or voucher
- Other
- None

Question CHCARE_AMT

Research Question: We're trying to get the child care amounts in fewer questions than we used to ask, but it also seems like we probably can't just ask for an annual amount because people might need us to do the math. As part of our bigger question about care during work vs other child care, we also want to know here if people would report a different value if they were told to only consider child care provided for work-related reasons.

CHCARE_AMT. Across all types of child care, how much was paid for each child in 2023?

[Child 1]	\$[text].00 [periodicity dropdown- weekly/every other week (biweekly)/twice a week/monthly/yearly]
[Child 2]	\$[text].00 [periodicity dropdown- weekly/every other week (biweekly)/twice a week/monthly/yearly]
[Child N]	\$[text].00 [periodicity dropdown- weekly/every other week (biweekly)/twice a week/monthly/yearly]

***n* = 5**

Findings:**Does the question make sense? What is confusing?**

- Of the 5 participants that received this question, there was no confusion. Most participants felt it was clear and they were able to easily use the grid format. However, one participant (P2961) struggled with reporting a yearly amount in the grid. This participant wanted to report yearly although they don't actually make one yearly payment, so the number of payments column was a little confusing to them.
- Are there any complications (like they pay for more stuff in the summer than during the school year)?
- None of the 5 participants who saw this question reported any complications with reporting the amount spent on child care due to changes in rates throughout the year.

What would be the easiest way for them to report it? Could they give a yearly amount if that was the only option (only asked of those who did not report a yearly amount)?

- Although one participant (P2369) struggled a bit with the grid, two other participants (P2245, P2961) thought the periodicity dropdown menu is the best way to report the findings. Another participant (P2961) liked having options about how to report and used both yearly and weekly options when reporting about members in his household. He also noted that the current set up was the best way to report for both his children at once.
- One participant (P2245) was able to easily enter information for the two one-off day camps she sent her child to by selecting the yearly option. She also said that, if she sent her child to a day care she would probably report monthly or bi-weekly depending on how payments were set up.

- Another participant (P2369) had a little trouble entering a yearly amount. She doesn't make a single yearly payment but wanted to report yearly which required her to put "1" for number of payments. Since the number of payments wasn't reflective of her reality, it was a bit counterintuitive.

If the respondent reported \$0, why?

- Two participants (P2283, P2332) responded \$0 because they do not pay for child care. They received this question due to a programming error (see **Appendix F**) as both these participants selected "None, did not pay for child care" for CHCARE_PAID.

If we specified "only include care needed while at work, in training or school, or while looking at work," would it have changed the amount you reported? If yes, what would the amount be?

- Two participants (P2245, P2369) said their amount reported would not change if "only include care needed while at work, in training or school, or while looking at work" was specified.
- This question was easily understood by participants. Of the five participants who received this question, most had no trouble with the grid format and preferred the periodicity dropdown option as the best way to report amount of money spent on child care. One participant did use different dropdown options when reporting on amount spent on child care for different members of their household, suggesting that having a variety of ways to report will work best for respondents. One participant did have some confusion using the grid when reporting a yearly amount when it came to amount of payments, because she didn't actually make one payment so entering "1" as number of payments felt slightly counterintuitive. While there was limited exposure to the probe of "If we specified "only include care needed while at work, in training or school, or while looking at work," would it have changed the amount you reported?" two participants said it would not change their amount reported.

Recommendations:

To reduce confusion when reporting a yearly amount, as demonstrated below, we recommend adding an italicized instruction to enter "1" for number of payments after the question.

Additionally, while participants indicated their reported amount would not change if the question specified "only include care needed while at work, in training or school, or while looking at work," there was limited exposure to this probe. To increase certainty of whether or not respondents' answers would change, for the second round of testing, we recommend recruiting more parents to increase probability of participants who are exposed to this question.

There was also not a direct probe asked about complicated child care arrangements, such as more expensive care during the summer compared to the school year. We are concerned that irregular care will be difficult for respondents to report in this format, since it asks for one amount for the entire year. Including an instruction to provide an average may be

useful, as well as probing directly about this issue in the second round of cognitive interviewing.

Finally, SMEs should also consider whether they are interested in child care expenses for children older than 13. The current programming targets only children younger than 13; however, children older than 13 may still engage in summer camps or other types of care. If SMEs are interested in expenses for older children, then the universe should be updated for these questions.

Consider the following revision:

Across all types of child care, how much was paid for each child in 2023?

If reporting a yearly amount, enter '1' for number of payments. Please provide your best guess at an average weekly or monthly amount for 2023.

[Child 1]	\$[text].00 [periodicity dropdown- weekly/every other week (biweekly)/twice a week/monthly/yearly]
[Child 2]	\$[text].00 [periodicity dropdown- weekly/every other week (biweekly)/twice a week/monthly/yearly]
[Child N]	\$[text].00 [periodicity dropdown- weekly/every other week (biweekly)/twice a week/monthly/yearly]

Question *CHCARE_SUB*

Research Question: This is a new question. We want to get this information in as few questions as possible.

CHCARE_SUB. Was/were the child's/children's care fully or partially covered by a voucher or child care subsidy?

Child	Yes	No
[Child 1]	☐	☐
[Child 2]	☐	☐
[Child N]	☐	☐

***n* = 5**

Findings:

Does the question make sense? What is confusing?

- The question made sense to all 5 participants who received this question. Although not all participants knew exactly what a voucher or subsidy was, it did not impact their response process. Although participants did not know the exact meaning of the words, they knew they had not gone through the process to receive a voucher or subsidy. As explained by one participant (P2245), "I

honestly don't know a whole whole lot about the vouchers and subsidies. Occasionally I hear people talking about them about their kids, but um, I never went through the process of it."

- Two participants (P2332, P2369) were not entirely certain of the difference between a subsidy and voucher, but tended to think of subsidy as a discount for child care whereas a voucher would pay for the child care itself. One participant (P2332) shared, "I think subsidy is like, a lessened amount. Maybe voucher would be... I think it's the same thing... Like the income-based thing, I think that's what subsidy was. And then voucher would just be like something paying for the child care itself." Again though, this did not have an impact on their response process.

Does the format work?

- The grid format for this question does work. None of the 5 participants who received this question struggled with answering in the grid format nor did they report any challenges or confusion with it.
- Overall, this question was easy for participants to answer. Although some participants were unsure of the meaning of subsidy and voucher or the difference between the two, it did not impact participants' response process. All participants knew whether or not they received a subsidy or voucher and were able to answer accordingly. Additionally, none of the participants reported any challenges or confusion with the grid format.

Recommendations:

- No recommendations. The question was easily understood by participants. Continue to monitor this question during the second round of interviews.

Question CHCARE_PROB

Research Question: This is a question Commerce is making us add to the 2025 ASEC and keep moving forward. It comes from the SIPP, though we've edited a bit.

CHCARE_PROB Did [you / anyone in this household] have to work fewer hours in 2023 because of problems obtaining child care?

- Yes
- No

n = 5

Findings:

Does the question make sense? What is confusing?

- None of the 5 participants who saw this question reported any confusion with the question wording.
- However, we found that participants were interpreting this question in two different ways. As discussed more below, some participants thought of short-term situations where they can't find child care (e.g., staying home from work to watch a sick kid), whereas others were thinking of more chronic situations such as the difficulty they experienced with finding child care during the COVID-19 pandemic.

- How participants interpreted the question also impacted whether or not they included 'using paid time off' to watch their children when answering.

What situations did people think of? Did they think of isolated situations (babysitter was sick one day and parent had to stay home) or chronic problems (can't get care after 3pm so reduced their hours)?

- There was an even split between participants who thought of isolated situations and those who thought of chronic situations when answering the question. Two participants (P2369, P2961) thought of more chronic problems that extended for more than one day.
 - For example, one participant (P2369) thought of issues similar to what was encountered during the pandemic, where child care places were closed, and it was struggle for her to work her full amount of hours due to not having child care.
 - Another participant (P2961) interpreted the question as, did not having child care prevent them from having a different work schedule overall (e.g., working additional hours or turning down work) rather than working less than their normal hours for a day or two because their child is sick. Specifically, P2691 says, "You know, did anybody turn down work... Did our kids prevent us from working any more additional hours at our job, in terms of getting child care for our kids. Did we have any problems getting child care... So we could work more hours."
- On the contrary, two participants (P2245, P2303) thought of infrequent situations, having difficulty finding care for only a short period of time.
 - Thinking broadly about any situation rather than only about struggling to find child care for an extended period of time, P2245 interpreted the question to mean "If you don't have anyone to watch your kid, you can't go to work."

Do they count using their vacation time (paid time off) when answering? Or just unpaid time?

- One participant (P2303) did count using their vacation time when answering whereas two participants (P2369, P2961) did not count this time. For one participant (P2961), while he did not think of using paid time off when answering the question, he did recall there was a time when his wife was sick and he had to take PTO to watch their child. However, this situation did not come to mind when he first read the question, so he did not think that situation applied to the question.
- One participant (P2245) is self-employed so the question of using time off was not applicable to them.

Overall, there was some inconsistency in how participants are interpreting the question. While some participants understood the question to be asking about any time where they might have missed work due to not having child care (e.g., short and infrequent situations), other participants were only thinking about chronic problems that have made finding child care difficult, such as day care closures during the pandemic or not taking on additional work or certain job opportunities because it would interfere with child care. As a result, not all participants are thinking about moments where they might have used their paid time off

to watch their kids. Updating question wording to clarify whether question is referring to infrequent or chronic situations would help alleviate confusion and promote more consistency in how respondents interpret the question.

Recommendations:

Due to inconsistencies in interpretation, we recommend discussing with SMEs which type of situations (infrequent vs. chronic) they are hoping to capture with this question and updating question wording accordingly. Depending on the intent of the question, we recommend updating the question wording in one of the following two ways:

If the intent is to include infrequent situations, consider the following revision:

Did [you / anyone in this household] have to work fewer hours in 2023 because of problems obtaining child care?

Please include infrequent instances of missing work, such as, child was sick from school or usual care provider was not available and parent and/or guardian had to take time from work to watch their child.

If the intent is to only focus on chronic situations, consider the following revision:

Did [you / anyone in this household] have to work fewer hours in 2023 because of chronic problems obtaining child care (e.g., can't get care after 3pm so reduced their hours or turned down opportunities for more work/overtime)?

Question *CHCARE_PROBTIME*

Research Question: This is a question Commerce is making us add to the 2025 ASEC and keep moving forward. It basically comes from SIPP, though I've swapped it into our desired amount/periodicity format, so we need to test it at some point.

[text] [Periodicity dropdown—hours, days, weeks]

CHCARE_PROBTIME. Considering all of your children, how much time did you lose from work in 2023 because of trouble finding child care?

***n* = 0**

Findings:

- There was no exposure to this question. As such, there is no data to support analysis.

Recommendations:

- For second round of testing, we recommend recruiting more parents to increase probability of participants who are exposed to this question. Continue to monitor this question during the second round of interviews.

Question CHCARE_ADAPT

Research Question: This is a question Commerce is making us add to the 2025 ASEC and keep moving forward. It basically comes from SIPP, though I've swapped it into our desired amount/periodicity format, so we need to test it at some point.

CHCARE_ADAPT. During 2023, did you [or anyone in the household] take any of the actions below in order to care for your [child/children] because child care was closed, unavailable, or unaffordable, or you were concerned for your [child's/children's] safety in care?

Select all that apply.

- Took unpaid leave
- Used vacation, sick days, or other paid leave
- Cut your work hours
- Quit a job
- Were fired from a job
- Did not look for a job
- Supervised one or more children while working
- Other (specify)
- None of the above

***n* = 0**

Findings:

There was no exposure to this question. As such, there is no data to support analysis.

Recommendations:

For second round of testing, we recommend recruiting more parents to increase probability of participants who are exposed to this question. Continue to monitor this question during the second round of interviews.

6.3.6 Child Support*Question AWAY_KIDS*

Research Question: This is the start of the child support block. We need to get people in universe for the next set of questions (those who have children who live elsewhere and pay child support). We have historically asked a screener question first--do you have children living elsewhere?--we think because people might be offended to just straight up be asked if they paid child support (again, we think. We aren't 100% sure of the rationale). We don't actually need that data point, but maybe could use it? There's an open question there. Basically, we want to reduce respondent burden (i.e., ask fewer questions) but not make them uncomfortable.

AWAY_KIDS. Did (you/anyone in this household) have any children living elsewhere with their other parent or guardian during 2023?

Yes No

- [Adult 1]
- [Adult 2]
- [Adult N]

***n* = 27**

Findings:

Does the question make sense? What is confusing?

- The majority of the 27 participants who received this question found this question understandable and easy to answer, but about a third of participants were confused as to whether adult children or children living in situations similar to foster care were to be included when answering the question.
- Most participants understood the question was asking about children who were not already included in the household roster.
 - For example, one participant (P2619) who lived with his adult son understood the question was asking about where his adult son's children were living and not the adult son.
 - Another participant (P2619) elaborated, "...he's in the household so it's almost like saying did P2 have any children living elsewhere with their other parent even though I know it doesn't make sense for that situation but... you're talking about the people in the household."
- However, 9 participants did have some confusion about which children the question was referring to.
- Five participants (P2278, P2512, P2595, P2710, P2734) questioned whether adult children who are living on their own should be included in the question when answering.
 - For example, P2595 who lives with their parents questioned whether their adult siblings should be considered. It was after he reread "with their other parent" that he was able to come to answer "No," realizing the question did not apply to his parents since he and his siblings are "all from the same parents."
 - Another participant (P2734) also noted that it would be helpful if a certain age was listed in this question to aid with understanding. As P2734 stated, "It might be beneficial [poor audio but something about clarifying] Under a certain age... If you care if it's under 21, under 18."
 - All the 5 participants who reported this confusion did end up answering "No" to this option after re-reading through the question. Although the confusion does not appear result in misreporting, it does add some response burden for respondents trying to understand the intent of the question.
 - Due to a programming error where the question only asked about the child's other parent and not guardian (see **Appendix F** for list of all programming errors), two participants (P2369, P2710) noted this absence of "guardian" and that impacted how they answered the question.
 - P2310 did not provide an answer for this question because they found deciphering the meaning of the question challenging. Since the question only appeared to ask about "other parent," P assumed it was referring to a divorce situation but was confused by lack of specification about whether child is staying with the other parent full- or part-time or if the child is in foster care or something similar.
- Five participants (P2351, P2361, 2434, P2464, P3022) made the comment that they have no children, possibly indicating some confusion as to why they were being asked this question. This did not impact their response process. In fact, many were able to answer the question faster because they knew the "yes" option did not apply to them.

- None of the 27 participants who received this question struggled with the grid format.

Are their children living with someone other than a parent/ guardian?

- None of the participants who received this question reported having any children living with someone other than a parent/guardian.

Overall, none of the participants struggled with the grid format and the majority of the participants understood the question was asking about whether they had additional children who were not already listed in the household roster. A point of confusion for a few participants though was whether or not their adult children should be considered. While this did not impact the validity of their responses (e.g., none of the participants considered their adult children as the intended subjects of the question and answered “No”), the confusion did require participants to re-read the question a few times for clarification, suggesting there is some response burden.

Due to a programming error that resulted in question asking about the child’s “other parent” and not “other parent *or guardian*”, two participants noted the exclusion of guardian did impact their responses and led to some confusion about whether or not they should consider a child who is living with someone other than a parent (e.g., foster care). These comments confirm the importance of using the phrasing “parent or guardian” for this question.

Finally, a few participants did make a note that they don’t have any children whatsoever, indicating potential confusion as to why they were being asked this question.

Recommendations:

To help reduce confusion for respondents who only have adult children, we recommend updating the wording to include “any children under the age of 18” as it is the traditional cutoff of child support in most states. However, there are situations where child support may be paid for children over the age of 18 (e.g., if a child has disabilities). Further discussion with SMEs may be beneficial for finalizing question wording to ensure the target of measurement will be captured by this question.

We also recommend adding a “Not applicable” option to the grid. This can help reduce confusion for respondents who do not have any children.

Consider the following revision:

Did (you/anyone in this household) have any children under the age of 18 who were living elsewhere with their other parent or guardian during 2023?

Yes	No	Not applicable – does not have any children
	[Adult 1]	
	[Adult 2]	
	[Adult N]	

Question CHSUP_ROST

Research Question: This is the start of the child support block. We need to get people in universe for the next set of questions (those who have children who live elsewhere and pay child support). We have historically asked a screener question first--do you have children living elsewhere?--we think because people might be offended to just straight up be asked if they paid child support (again, we think. We aren't 100% sure of the rationale). We don't actually need that data point, but maybe could use it? There's an open question there. Basically, we want to reduce respondent burden (i.e., ask fewer questions) but not make them uncomfortable.

CHSUP_ROST. In 2023, did (you/anyone in this household) pay any child support for children living elsewhere?

Adult	Yes	No
[Adult 1]	☐	☐
[Adult 2]	☐	☐
[Adult N]	☐	☐

***n* = 1**

Findings:

There was limited exposure to this question. As such, there is no data to support analysis.

Recommendations:

For second round of testing, we recommend recruiting more parents to increase probability of participants who are exposed to this question. We may also consider recruiting complex family situations, for example, children living at two homes, to attempt to further test some of these questions. However, the recruitment needs and limitations of the entire survey will need to be considered as we draft recruitment quotas for the second round of cognitive interviewing.

Question CHSUP_AMT

Research Question: We need to get the child support paid per person. We're really just testing the new format here--we don't want this to be a person block because we're trying to cut down on the number of questions. I am also guessing that in the vast majority of cases, there's only going to be one adult in the household paying child support.

CHSUP_AMT. How much child support was paid in 2023?

[Adult 1]	\$(text).00
[Adult 2]	\$(text).00
[Adult N]	\$(text).00

***n* = 0**

Findings:

There was no exposure to this question. As such, there are no data to support analysis.

Recommendations:

For the second round of testing, we recommend recruiting more parents to increase probability of participants who are exposed to this question. Continue to monitor this question during the second round of interviews.

[This page intentionally left blank]

7. Overall Recommendations

This section presents global recommendations for issues that impact multiple ASEC Income and Health Insurance questions. We provide several considerations to improve the questions prior to the conduct of the second round of cognitive testing.

7.1 Income

7.1.1 *Introduction with instructions*

During cognitive testing, several participants asked whether they should have their financial information and records available. They explained that they were unsure what to expect going into the interview. As a result, participants were not prepared to answer many of the questions.

The prenotification letter should describe the survey and the data we are collecting so participants can be prepared. This may be somewhat challenging as we will want to balance the need for more accurate reporting with the increased perceived respondent burden that would be associated with such preparation. However, respondents deserve to have some context before entering the survey.

In addition, the introduction of the survey (initial introduction screen) would be a prime location to explain that some financial records would be helpful to have during completion of the survey. Furthermore, instructions should be provided to respondents to only report each income source one time.

We could include testing of prenotification and/or introductory text in the second round of cognitive interviewing.

7.1.2 *Allowing estimates*

If SMEs believe that an estimate is acceptable, that instruction could be included in the introduction as well. This raises a larger question as to whether estimates are acceptable. It was determined during cognitive testing that many participants were already providing estimates, so prompting for this would lead to more complete data and reduce item nonresponse. As explained by one participant (P2361),

"In all honesty, if I was taking this survey, I may not answer this question [RETIRENEW1] because it would take me a lot of time to like find my log-ins for my accounts and yeah I... wouldn't do that... If it said... an estimation, a ballpark figure... I'd be more comfortable answering it personally."

If SMEs would prefer that this instruction is not included in the introduction, the instruction could be included as a soft check prompt if respondents try to go to the next question without responding. We may also consider including this instruction on certain questions

that are more likely to need to be estimated, such as income from interest-earning accounts.

7.1.3 Section introductions / Transition statements

As respondents progress through various income and finance topics, it can be somewhat confusing or disorienting as to the content being covered. We would highly recommend including a short instruction or transition statement at the beginning of new sections. We believe this will improve the survey experience, along with the suggested reordering of questions described next.

7.1.4 Additional definitions

While comprehension of financial terms is not key to the response process for many items, there are several that may benefit from adding instructions to define terms. In some cases, respondents may look up definitions on their own, which could lead to measurement error if they review incongruent definitions. Adding definitions may also be helpful for proxy reports, in which respondents may not know the term themselves, but seeing a definition could help them remember and report for someone else in their household.

7.1.5 Reordering of questions

The order of the questions seemed to increase respondent burden because they were not organized logically, especially questions about income sources and amounts. Participants found it challenging to move back and forth between very different types of income when responding. Reordering of questions should help align topic areas to establish context and improve the survey experience. We recommend reordering the questions to present more common sources of income before less common sources. For example, we recommend asking the overall pension question (Q62Ar) first before other questions that also include the word “pension,” such as survivor benefits (Q58a) and military pension (Q60A88). When participants saw “pension” as an option in the survivor benefits and the military pension questions, some tried to select it to report their pension income. Participants are looking for the type of income they have to report and try to fit it into the categories presented, even when not appropriate. **Exhibit 7-1** below presents an abbreviated list of the question order changes by topic, with the income questions first asked of sources of income, then amounts of income. We provide a full list of all questions and their recommended order in **Appendix G**, presenting each question, a summary of the topic, and both the original and new order. These question order changes should be tested in the second round of cognitive interviews.

Another option we could consider is reordering questions with a responsive design based on the reported age of the respondent. If the respondent reports they are 65 years or older, we could first present questions about pension, retirement withdrawal, and social security. If the respondent is under 65, then we could present employment sources of income first, and ask questions about pensions, retirement withdrawal, and social security later in the survey.

Exhibit 7-1. Abbreviated Question Order Changes Listed by Topic

<i>New placement</i>	<i>Original placement</i>	<i>Topic</i>
1	1	Employment
2	14	Employer's pension
3	2	Earned income
4	11	Pensions
5	3	Unemployment
6	4	Worker's comp
7	21	Retirement contributions
8	13	Retirement withdrawals and roll overs
9	5	Social security
10	6	SSI
11	7	Disability
12	19	Regular financial assistance
13	10	Public assistance
14	15	Income earning accounts
15	12	Annuity
16	8	Veteran's income
17	9	Survivor benefits
18	17	Educational assistance
19	18	Child support
20	16	Property
21	20	Other money income
22	22	Food assistance
23	24	Non-cash benefits
24	25	Child care
25	26	Child support
26	23	School meals

7.1.6 Overall summary screen

During cognitive testing, it was evident that some participants responded to several questions while thinking of the same source of income or account. In essence, this led to "double-counting." One consideration to help aid respondents would be to include an overall summary screen which would allow participants to review each of the accounts that they noted to ensure they did not double-count items. Moreover, this screen might help respondents to determine that an account was not listed. The premise of this summary screen is similar to the approach TurboTax includes on their platform, allowing the individual

to review what was entered for accuracy. If an error is found, they can return to the question to make adjustments. While this will involve additional programming, we do believe this will result in more accurate data reporting. This may also increase respondent burden since it will take more time to review and confirm their sources of income; however, many participants in the cognitive interviews indicated a desire to accurately report data. Respondents may feel positively about being given the opportunity to review the data they have reported and make corrections. We believe this summary screen should appear directly after the section about income, before any other questions (e.g., food assistance, childcare).

7.1.7 Validations / Confirmations

Another approach to increase data quality and reliability would be to include various validations and confirmations. This can be done through the inclusion of programming logic around key questions that may contribute to respondents providing duplicate information. For example, if a respondent selects “Veteran’s pension” in question 60A88 and “yes” to “U.S. Military retirement survivor pension” in question 58a, a soft check could pop-up to ensure that the respondent is referring to different accounts.

We would not recommend consistency logic to be included on all questions, but the survey would benefit from inclusion on some items, where respondents are likely to get confused or double report. A standard message could appear on specific questions confirming with respondents that this information was not already reported on a previous question.

Specific validation logic could be programmed to look for similar values or trigger a consistency check if the respondent previously selected or entered data in a previous question. These checks can be overridden by the respondent if the information is correct. However, if the information entered was incorrect, they can return to a previous question to make a correction, then return to the last unanswered question.

These validations/confirmations require some additional programming and testing but should result in more accurate data reporting.

7.1.8 Respondent burden and reducing breakoffs

It was clear during cognitive testing that respondent burden associated with answering many of the questions is quite high. Knowledge is not available or would require review of financial documents. While some participants will take the time to report accurately, others will either provide an estimate, leave the question blank, or breakoff entirely. To mitigate these concerns, we suggest the following:

1. Consider removing questions that pose the highest respondent burden and lowest data quality. Some questions might be unnecessarily burdensome considering they have low analytic value (e.g., amount of income from interest-earning accounts,

Q63cp). For example, most participants estimated the amount of interest they received in an Interest-earning savings account or standard savings account. In most cases, the amounts are going to be quite low. It may be worth considering whether it is analytically useful to ask for this level of information, considering the added burden.

One participant (P2310) refused to answer question 63cp based on both burden and privacy concerns explaining, “I would need to really go through my accounts to figure this out... I’m not going to do that to fill out a Census form.”

2. Consider allowing a “Don’t know” response option for certain questions, as specified on the question-specific findings in earlier sections. While Census Bureau treats all nonresponse in the same way analytically, providing a “don’t know” response can improve the respondent experience by allowing respondents to indicate their true response – that they do not know the answer. This may help to minimize break-offs, encouraging respondents to review more questions and provide the information they do know.

Another option to immediately offering the “Don’t know” option is to suppress the option unless the respondent attempts to go to the next question, leaving the current question unanswered. In this case, we allow “Don’t know” as a legitimate response in lieu of item nonresponse.

3. Consider allowing response ranges of questions with less importance. Another option to address item nonresponse would be to provide ranges when a respondent attempts to go to the next question, leaving the current question unanswered. This would allow us to gather some information, although not as precise as a specific value, but analytically preferable to item nonresponse. This format is already employed in the question series about energy assistance (ENG_RNG and END_RNG2) and could work well for other items in the survey.
4. Improved question context. Consider providing additional context to tie previous questions together. One way to do this would be to change “who had X account” questions from “the account” to “this type of account” as recommended in the discussion of Question 99Ba. Another option would be to include a statement prior to asking the follow-up question, for example: “In the previous question you reported [fill account type name]. Who had this type of account?”
5. Consider additional features to improve reporting. All questions asking for numeric values should include a label outside of the response box. For example, add a “\$” when looking for a monetary value. Add “Weeks” when asking about the number of weeks. Furthermore, decrease the response box to be the width of the maximum numerical value allowed. For example, if asking weeks that the respondent was

looking for a job in a specific year, the response box should only allow two numbers. This will avoid inadvertent alpha-numeric responses, resulting in errors, as we found during the cognitive testing.

6. Ensuring consistency when referring to the year throughout the instrument. Consider using standard language and formatting when referring to the year throughout the questionnaire. This helps “train” the respondent and increases data quality. For example, we found an inconsistent format in how the time frame “2023” was presented. In some cases, “In 2023,” preceded the question and in other questions, we found “...,in 2023.” at the end of the question. We recommend consistently beginning the question with “In 2023,” to make it easier for respondents to understand the time frame. Furthermore, there were some child care questions that did not include a time frame. We recommend ensuring that all questions requiring a time frame have one clearly specified.

7.1.9 Recommendation for format of grids

As discussed extensively in **Section 6.2.2**, we recommend moving forward presenting only the alternative version of the grids, allowing respondents to report in the time period they prefer for all financial amounts questions. Additionally, we recommend several tweaks to the presentation of the grid questions to improve functionality. See **Section 6.2.2** for further details about these recommendations.

7.1.10 Programming of instrument for the second round of cognitive interviews

Cognitive testing was difficult to complete during the first round of testing, in many cases, due to programming errors. We were unable to assess the performance of several questions due to incorrect or broken skip logic and problems with fills. We assume that these will be corrected during the second round of interviews in order to fully assess the questions.

7.1.11 Information sharing from government

Finally, while this is outside the scope of this project, it is a finding that is worth noting. Some participants expressed confusion that the Census Bureau would need this level of detailed financial information since it would already be available within tax data reported annually to the IRS.

While sharing of this level of data poses additional challenges, there have been other Census Call Orders that have investigated the sharing of data between government agencies. This may be a long-term answer to the data collection challenges faced on the ASEC questionnaire, and potentially lead to better quality data.

7.2 Health Insurance

7.2.1 Health insurance

Questions in this section need to be reviewed for how best to address the issue of respondents who are covered by insurance of a non-household member, in particular youth not living at home and covered until age 26 under their parents' insurance.

7.2.2 Medical out of pocket expenses

In the questions that asked for a dollar amount of expenses, the field to enter the amount also allowed for text entries. Those who entered text entries were treated as having answered the question with a value, and therefore skipped out of the follow up questions offering ranges for non-respondents. We recommend either not allowing text responses or routing them the same as for blank responses.

7.2.3 Migration

For the 1-year and the 10-year time frame for questions, the current formulation mentions "x year(s) ago, that is, September 1, 2014/2024"

The date was provided as a fixed date, not as it related to the interview date. In addition, all but one participant focused on the month and year or the number of years, or both, but not on the specific date. For these reasons we recommend reformulating the time frames as "1/10 year(s) ago, that is, <CURRENT MONTH>, <1/10 YEARS AGO>.

[This page intentionally left blank]

8. Conclusions

The first round of cognitive testing uncovered several issues with the questions in both the Health Insurance and Income modules. As noted, the Income section was challenging for many participants due to contextual issues resulting from the order of questions. As a result, we highly recommend the reordering of questions. Furthermore, consistency in formatting (e.g., placing the year time frame at the beginning of the question, and standard formatting of numeric responses) is recommended to reduce respondent burden. Consider whether to allow “Don’t Know” responses on questions that are highly burdensome or require data retrieval. This should help to reduce item-nonresponse or potential breakoffs and could improve the respondent experience. Finally, it is highly recommended that the programmed instrument is thoroughly tested following any changes that result from the Round 1 findings to ensure that Round 2 testing is not influenced by programming issues. The recommended changes outlined in this report are grounded in survey methodology best practices and should help to both improve the respondent experience and generate more complete and accurate reported data.

[This page intentionally left blank]

Appendix A. Recruitment Screener

Web Survey Screener Specifications

Introduction and consent

Web intro/consent

RTI International, a nonprofit research organization, is conducting research on behalf of the U.S. Census Bureau to improve questions in one of its national surveys.

To determine if you are eligible to participate in the research, we will ask you a few screening questions about your background and your household. Eligible participants can receive \$40 for a virtual interview, which will last 90 minutes.

If you are eligible for the study, we will call or email you to schedule a time for the interview.

Your participation in the eligibility screening is completely voluntary. You may stop at any time or skip questions that you do not want to answer.

This voluntary survey is being conducted under the authority of Title 13 U.S. Code, Sections 131 and 182. Federal law requires that your answers are kept confidential (Title 13, U.S. Code, Section 9), and protects your privacy under the Privacy Act (Title 5 U.S. Code, Section 552a). Routine uses of these data are limited to those identified in the Privacy Act System of Record Notice titled “COMMERCE/CENSUS-5, Decennial Census Programs.” The Census Bureau can use your responses only to produce statistics and is not permitted to publicly release your responses in a way that could identify you, your business, organization, or institution.

We estimate that completing these screening questions will take 15 minutes on average. This information collection has been approved by the Office of Management and Budget (OMB). You can validate that this survey is a legitimate using the Office of Management and Budget's approval number 0607-0725, which expires 12/31/2025. We are required to tell you this number to conduct this survey. Send comments regarding this estimate or any other aspect of this survey, including suggestions for reducing the time it takes to complete this survey to adrm.pra@census.gov.

If you have questions about the research, you may contact RTI's project director, [D: NAME], at [D: PHONE NUMBER] or [D: EMAIL]

Consent to Participate

Do we have your permission to ask you a few questions to find out if you are eligible for this study?

If you agree to participate, please click “Yes, I agree” below and then the “NEXT” button to continue. If you choose not to participate, please click “Exit” and then the “NEXT” button to exit the survey.

- ☐₁ Yes, I agree [[Skip to Q1](#)]
☐₂ Exit [[Skip to REFUSAL](#)]

|-----[NEXT SCREEN](#)-----|

Module 1: Key eligibility screener

Q1. Age

How old are you?

[] [If Q2<18, skip to INELIGIBLE]
[PROGRAMMER: NUMERIC ENTRY ONLY; RANGE = (6-110)]

|-----NEXT SCREEN-----|

Q2. Federal employment status

Are you employed by the Federal Government? (if federal contractor, mark NO)

☐ 1 Yes [skip to INELIGIBLE]
☐ 2 No

|-----NEXT SCREEN-----|

Q3. Location

In what state or district do you currently live?

State: []

In what city and ZIP code do you currently live?

City: []

ZIP code []

[PROGRAMMER: CITY – TEXTBOX with 50 characters Max.; State – TEXTBOX; ZIP code – 5 digits NUMERIC ENTRY ONLY]

|-----NEXT SCREEN-----|

Q3.1 Location II

Which of the following best describes the place where you now live?

☐ 1 A large city
☐ 2 A suburb
☐ 4 A small city or town
☐ 5 A rural area

|-----NEXT SCREEN-----|

Module 2: Demographic characteristics**Q4.1 SOGI-1**

What sex were you assigned at birth, on your original birth certificate?

- ☐₁ Male
- ☐₂ Female
- ☐₄ I don't want to answer

-----NEXT SCREEN-----

Q6. Race

What is your race and/or ethnicity? *Please select all that apply.*

- ☐₁ American Indian or Alaska Native White
- ☐₂ Asian
- ☐₃ Black or African American
- ☐₄ Hispanic or Latino
- ☐₅ Middle Eastern or North African
- ☐₆ Native Hawaiian or other Pacific Islander
- ☐₇ White

-----NEXT SCREEN-----

Q7. Education

What is the highest grade of school you have completed, or the highest degree you have received?

- ☐₁ Less than high school diploma or equivalent
- ☐₂ High school diploma (including GED or ABE certificate)
- ☐₃ Some college, no degree
- ☐₄ Associate's degree (AA, AS, or equivalent)
- ☐₅ Bachelor's degree (BA, BS, or equivalent)
- ☐₆ Post Bachelor's degree (MA, MS, PhD, JD, MD, etc.)
- ☐₇ I have not completed any formal education

-----NEXT SCREEN-----

Q7.1. Internet use frequency

How frequently do you use the Internet? *This includes accessing the Internet through a cell phone, computer, or tablet.*

- ☐₁ Daily
- ☐₂ At least once a week
- ☐₃ At least once a month
- ☐₄ Less than once a month
- ☐₅ Rarely

-----NEXT SCREEN-----

Q7.2. Smartphone ownership

Do you own a smartphone (such as an iPhone or Android)?

- ☐₁ Yes
☐₂ No

-----NEXT SCREEN-----

(For ASEC) Q8.1. Marital event in the past yearIn 2023, did you become— *Please select all that apply.*

- ☐₁ Married?
☐₂ Widowed?
☐₃ Separated?
☐₄ Divorced?
☐₅ None of the above

[PROGRAMMER: Make 5 (“None of the above”) as an exclusive option.]

-----NEXT SCREEN-----

Module 3: Household characteristics**Q9. Cohabitation status**

Does anyone live or stay with you at your current address? Also include people who only sometimes live or stay with you.

- ☐₁ Yes [ask Q10]
☐₂ No [skip to Q14]

-----NEXT SCREEN-----

(For ASEC) Q10. Cohabitation status II[Ask if Q9 = Yes] Who lives or stays with you? *Please select all that apply.*

- ☐₁ Parent(s)
☐₂ Grandparent(s)
☐₃ Husband/wife/spouse
☐₄ Unmarried partner
☐₅ Children
☐₆ Grandchildren
☐₇ Other relatives(s)
☐₈ Roommates
☐₉ Friends
☐₁₀ Other – please specify

[PROGRAMMER: WHEN 10 (“Other”) IS SELECTED, DISPLAY “please specify” TEXTBOX.]

-----NEXT SCREEN-----

Q11. Number of adults

[If Q9=1] How many people age 18 or older currently live or stay at your address, INCLUDING yourself?

[] adult/adults

[PROGRAMMER: NUMERIC ENTRY ONLY; RANGE = (1-19)]

|-----NEXT SCREEN-----|

Q12. Number of children in household

[If Q9=1] How many people younger than 18 currently live or stay at your address?

[] child/children

[PROGRAMMER: NUMERIC ENTRY ONLY; RANGE = (0-19)]

|-----NEXT SCREEN-----|

(For ASEC) Q12.2. Young child (age between 5 and 13) in household

[Ask if Q12>=1] Is any child living or staying at your address 13 or younger?

☐₁ Yes

☐₂ No

|-----NEXT SCREEN-----|

(For ASEC) Q13. Children event in the past year

In 2023, did you or a partner or spouse —

☐₁ give birth to any children?

☐₂ adopt any children?

☐₃ foster any children?

☐₄ None of the above

|-----NEXT SCREEN-----|

Module 4: Health Insurance and social programs

(For ASEC) Q14. Health insurance coverage

Do you currently have health insurance?

- ☐₁ Yes
- ☐₂ No, I don't have any health insurance
- ☐₃ Don't know

|-----NEXT SCREEN-----|

(For ASEC) Q15. Type of health insurance

[Ask if Q14=1] What type of health insurance? *Please select all that apply.*

- ☐₁ Insurance coverage through an employer, school, or other group-based program (through you or another family member)
- ☐₂ Medicare
- ☐₃ Medicaid or other type of government-assistance plan for people with low incomes or disabilities
- ☐₄ Coverage purchased through healthcare.gov or other state-led marketplace associated with the Affordable Care Act (also known as Obamacare)
- ☐₅ TRICARE, VA healthcare, or other military health care
- ☐₆ Other type of insurance – please specify

|-----NEXT SCREEN-----|

(For ASEC) Q16. Health insurance policy holder

[Ask if Q15=1 or Q15=4 or Q15=5] Is this health insurance in your own name, or do you get it through someone else?

- ☐₁ It's in my name
- ☐₂ I get it through someone else
- ☐₃ Don't know

|-----NEXT SCREEN-----|

(For ASEC) Q17. Lack of access to regular healthcare

If you are sick or need to see a medical professional, where do you go? *Please select all that apply.*

- ☐₁ Doctor's office
- ☐₂ Hospital
- ☐₃ Walk-in health clinic (e.g., MinuteClinic, Patient First, Urgent Care)
- ☐₄ Pharmacy
- ☐₅ Other places, please specify:
- ☐₆ None of the above

[PROGRAMMER: Make 6 (“None of the above”) as an exclusive option.]

-----NEXT SCREEN-----

(For ASEC) Q18. Social Assistance programs

In 2023, did you or someone in your household receive benefits from any of the following programs? *Please select all that apply.*

- ☐₁ Supplemental Nutrition Assistance Program (SNAP), sometimes referred to as food stamps
- ☐₂ Special Supplemental Nutrition Program for Women, Infants, and Children (WIC)
- ☐₃ School Lunch Program
- ☐₄ Temporary Assistance for Needy Families (TANF)
- ☐₅ Energy assistance (heating/cooling)
- ☐₆ Housing or rent assistance
- ☐₇ Broadband or internet assistance
- ☐₈ Other public assistance – please specify
- ☐₉ Did not receive any of the benefits above

[PROGRAMMER: IF 8 (“Other”) IS SELECTED, DISPLAY “Please specify” TEXTBOX.]

[PROGRAMMER: Make 9 (“Did not receive any of the benefits above”) as an exclusive option.]

-----NEXT SCREEN-----

Module 5: Employment and Income

-----NEXT SCREEN-----

(For ASEC) Q22. Employment

Were you working at any time in 2023?

- ☐₁ Yes
- ☐₂ No

-----NEXT SCREEN-----

Q21. Work arrangement

[Ask if Q22=1] In 2023, did you work for an employer, were you self-employed, or did you have some other work arrangement?

- ☐₁ I worked for an employer
- ☐₂ I was self-employed
- ☐₃ I had another work arrangement — Please specify

[PROGRAMMER: IF 3 (“Other”) IS SELECTED, DISPLAY “Please specify” TEXTBOX.]

-----NEXT SCREEN-----

Q23.1. Unemployment

[Ask if Q22=1] In 2023, did you have any periods where you were **not** working?

- ☐₁ Yes, I was retired for some time
☐₂ Yes, I was unemployed or out of work for some time
☐₃ Yes, I was unable to work due to disability for some time
☐₄ Yes, I was not working for some other reason (please specify)
☐₅ No

-----NEXT SCREEN-----

Q24. Number of jobs

[Ask if Q22 = 1] At any point in 2023, did you work two or more jobs at the same time?

Please include any side jobs you did for pay in addition to a primary job.

- ☐₁ Yes
☐₂ No

-----NEXT SCREEN-----

(For ASEC) Q25. New job in the past year (life event)

[Ask if Q22=1] Did you start a job in 2023?

- ☐₁ Yes
☐₂ No

-----NEXT SCREEN-----

(For ASEC) Q26 Seasonal/non-standard work (last year)

[Ask if Q22=1] In 2023 did you do any of the following types of work?

Type of Work	Yes (1)	No (2)
Q26.1 Temporary or seasonal work (<i>for example, holiday sales associate, summer camp counselor, crop harvester, etc.</i>)		
Q26.2 In-person jobs or tasks through companies that connect you directly with customers using a website or mobile app (<i>for example, delivering food or groceries or driving for a rideshare service</i>)		
Q26.3 Freelancing or consulting work		
Q26.4 Other types of side jobs that provide additional income streams. <i>Do not include time spent answering online surveys</i> Please Specify:		

[PROGRAMMER: IF Q26.4 =1, DISPLAY "Please specify" TEXTBOX.]

-----NEXT SCREEN-----

(For ASEC) Q30. Other income

In 2023, did you receive income from any of the following sources? *Please select all that apply.*

- ☐ ₁ Interest and dividends earned from savings or investments
- ☐ ₂ Retirement or pension income, including regular payments from estates, trusts, or annuities
- ☐ ₃ Rental income
- ☐ ₄ Commission
- ☐ ₅ Bonus
- ☐ ₆ Tips
- ☐ ₇ Unemployment benefits
- ☐ ₈ Worker compensation
- ☐ ₉ Social Security or supplemental security income
- ☐ ₁₀ TANF or other public assistance benefits
- ☐ ₁₁ None of the above

[PROGRAMMER: Option 11 to be programmed as exclusive]

-----NEXT SCREEN-----

Module 6: Contact info

Finally, we just have a few more questions about your contact information. If you are eligible and selected to participate in the study, we will use the information to contact you to schedule the interview.

Q31. Name

What is your name?

Name: [_____]

Q32. Email

What is your email address?

[_____]

[PROGRAMMER: email verification]

-----NEXT SCREEN-----

Q33. Phone

What is the best telephone number to reach you? (*Numbers only, please do not include special characters*)

Phone ([____]) [____] - [_____]

Q34. Time to call

What is the best time to reach you by phone?

- ☐ ₁ Mornings (8-10 AM)
- ☐ ₂ Midday (11 AM-1 PM)
- ☐ ₃ Afternoons (2-5 PM)
- ☐ ₄ Evenings (after 5 PM)

Q35. Referral

Could you think of any family or friends who may be interested in participating in our interview? Please provide their name and email address for us to reach out to them in the next screen.

- ☐ ₁ Yes
- ☐ ₂ No

|-----NEXT SCREEN-----|

Q35.1. Referral name

[Ask if Q35=1] What is the name of your family or friend?

Name: [_____]

Q35.2. Referral email

[Ask if Q35=1] What is the email address of your family or friend?

[_____
[PROGRAMMER: email verification]

|-----NEXT SCREEN-----|

Q36.1 Interview participation.

Would you be able to participate in a [90; 60] minute virtual interview at a day/time to be determined in [MONTH]? The interview will use a free software called Microsoft Teams.

- ☐ ₁ Yes
- ☐ ₂ No

|-----NEXT SCREEN-----|

Q36.2 Screen sharing.

Would you be willing to share your phone or computer screen during the interview?

- ☐₁ Yes
☐₂ No

|-----NEXT SCREEN-----|

Q36.3 Recording.

We would like to audio and video record interviews. Would you be willing to have the interview video and audio recorded?

- ☐₁ Yes
☐₂ No

|-----NEXT SCREEN-----|

Q37. Advertisement source

How did you hear about this study?

- ☐₁ Community publication (for example, local paper)
☐₂ Flyer
☐₃ Friends or family
☐₄ RTI or Census Bureau employee
☐₅ Craigslist
☐₆ Facebook
☐₇ Reddit
☐₈ Other – specify: _____

|-----NEXT SCREEN-----|

Exit/Completion

Thank you for taking the time to answer our questions today. We will get back to you soon if you are eligible for an interview.

Refusal/Screened out

Based on your responses, you are not eligible to participate in this study. Thank you for taking the time to answer our questions today.

[This page intentionally left blank]

Appendix B. Participant Recruitment Materials

General Advertisement Template

Get paid for sharing your opinions

RTI International and Research Support Services, research organizations that are working with the U.S. Census Bureau, are looking for adults (ages 18 and over) to answer questions about their household and give their reactions about questions in a national survey. The interview will be conducted online using a secure video conferencing app, Microsoft Teams. **The interview will take about 90 minutes. We will provide \$40 for participating in the remote interview.**

To see if you are eligible for the study, please complete a short questionnaire at:

https://research.rm.census.gov/jfe/form/SV_6zcHA8uxfRXgW6W

You may also call [D: PHONE NUMBER] to learn more about the study and see if you are eligible.

Please feel free to pass this message along to other people that might be interested in helping with this research.

Specific Advertisement Template

Get paid for sharing your opinions

RTI International and Research Support Services, research organizations that are working with the U.S. Census Bureau, are looking for adults (ages 18 and over) to answer questions about their household and give their reactions about questions in a national survey. We are recruiting participants who meet one or more of the following criteria:

[ASEC criteria:]

- Have child(ren) between 5-13 years of age in the household
- Have extended family living in the household
- Have retired in the past year
- [Any specific characteristics as needed]

The interview will be conducted online using a secure video conferencing app, Microsoft Teams. **The interview will take about 60 minutes. We will provide \$50 for participating in the remote interview.**

To see if you are eligible for the study, please complete a short questionnaire at

https://research.rm.census.gov/jfe/form/SV_6zcHA8uxfRXgW6W

You may also call [D: PHONE NUMBER] to learn more about the study and see if you are eligible.

Please feel free to pass this message along to other people that might be interested in helping with this research.

Example Craigslist Posting



reply

Posted 4 months ago_

Get paid for sharing your opinions (St. Petersburg)

RTI International

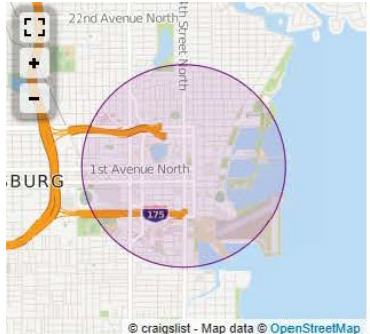
RTI International and Research Support Services, research organizations that are working with the U.S. Census Bureau, are looking for adults (ages 18 and over) to answer questions about their household and give their reactions about questions in a national survey. The interview will be conducted online using a secure video conferencing app, Microsoft Teams.

The interview will take about 90 minutes. We will provide \$40 for participating in the remote interview.

To see if you are eligible for the study, please complete a short questionnaire at:
https://research.rm.census.gov/jfe/form/SV_6zcHA8uxfRXgW6W

You may also call 866-280-1520 to learn more about the study and see if you are eligible.
Please feel free to pass this message along to other people that might be interested in helping with this research.

- Principals only. Recruiters . please don't contact this job poster.
- OK to highlight this job opening for persons with disabilities.



© craigslist - Map data © OpenStreetMap

compensation: \$40 for a 90-minutes interview

employment type: [contract](#)

job title: Research participant

[non-profit organization](#)

[telecommuting ok](#)

post id: 7787357548 posted: 4 months ago updated: 3 months ago best of

Re-Contact Email

This email template is designed to contact the recruits who completed the previous CPS cognitive interview screener but were not selected for interview scheduling. CPS recruitment has spent approximately 3-4 weeks to look for a couple of specific characteristics to fulfill the requirement, which leaves many recruits suitable for ASEC recruitment. However, since the screeners are evolved to separate surveys with some different questions, we need to get these people to fill out the ASEC screener in order to assess their eligibility.

Email text:

Hi [NAME],

You are receiving this email because you previously responded to a Craigslist/Reddit advertisement about a research study conducted on behalf of the U.S. Census Bureau. We have concluded the previous research study but have another opportunity available:

RTI International and Research Support Services, research organizations that are working with the U.S. Census Bureau, are looking for adults (ages 18 and over) to answer questions about their household and give their reactions about questions in a national survey. The interview will be conducted online using a secure video conferencing app, Microsoft Teams.

The interview will take about 90 minutes. We will provide \$40 for participating in the remote interview.

To see if you are eligible for the study, please complete a short questionnaire at:

https://research.rm.census.gov/jfe/form/SV_6zcHA8uxfRXgW6W

You may also call [D: PHONE NUMBER] to learn more about the study and see if you are eligible.

Please feel free to pass this message along to other people that might be interested in helping with this research.

Thank you,

[SIGNATURE]

Outreach email for CO10 recruits or the referrals by CO11 recruits

Seeking your feedback on another Census Bureau research opportunity

Hello,

We hope this message finds you well.

[IF PREVIOUSLY SCREENED PARTICIPANT: You previously expressed interest in participating in research conducted by the U.S. Census Bureau seeking opinions about survey questions in a national household survey. Although that research has concluded and we did not have the chance to collect your feedback, we now have another research opportunity.]

[IF PARTICIPANT REFERRAL: Your friend [Name] expressed interest in participating in research conducted by the U.S. Census Bureau seeking the public's opinions about questions in a national survey. They suggested we also reach out to you for your opinions via this email address.]

The interview will be conducted online using a secure video conferencing app, Microsoft Teams. **The interview will take about 60 minutes. We will provide \$50 for participating in the remote interview.**

To see if you are eligible for the new study, please complete a short questionnaire at

https://research.rm.census.gov/jfe/form/SV_6zcHA8uxfRXgW6W

You may also call [D: PHONE NUMBR] to learn more about the study and see if you are eligible.

Please feel free to pass this message along to other people that you may know.

[This page intentionally left blank]

Appendix C. Cognitive Interview Participant Consent Form

What is the purpose of this interview?

The U.S. Census Bureau is conducting interviews to help with the design and content about a portion of the Current Population Survey (CPS). This module, called the Annual Social and Economic Supplement (ASEC) is an important source of information about our nation on topics such as employment, health insurance, and income. It's important that the questions make sense, are easy to answer, and that everyone understands the questions in the same way. You are one of about 60 people who are being asked to participate in these interviews. Findings from these interviews will be used to clarify survey questions and instructions on the survey.

What will happen if I take part in this interview?

If you agree to take part in this study, you will be asked to answer questions about your household, including yourself and other people that live with you. The interview will be conducted virtually by a staff member from RTI International or Research Support Services, who are doing this study for the U.S. Census Bureau.

We would also like to audio and video record the interview. Only the people who work on this study will review the recording. It will help us make sure we accurately capture your answers. If you don't want to be recorded, that's okay – you may still participate in the interview.

How much time is required to participate?

The interview will last approximately 90 minutes.

Do I have to take part in this interview?

No, participation in this interview is voluntary. You can stop the interview at any time, and you don't have to answer a question if you don't want to. You will not lose any rights you would normally have if you choose not to join this interview.

What are the possible risks and benefits from participating in this interview?

There are no direct benefits to you from doing this interview. Your involvement in this study will help us improve the questions for the Current Population Survey. There is no more than minimal risk in participating.

How will my privacy be protected?

By law, we are required to keep your answers confidential. The U.S. Census Bureau is conducting this study under the authority of 13 U.S.C. Sections 131, 141, 182, 193, and 196. Your privacy is protected by the Privacy Act of 1974 (5 U.S.C. Section 552a). Only research staff from the U.S. Census Bureau, RTI International, and Research Support Services will know your answers to interview questions. The Census Bureau can use your responses only to produce statistics and is not permitted to publicly release your responses in a way that could identify you or other members of your household.

This collection has been approved by the Office of Management and Budget (OMB). This eight-digit OMB approval number, 0607-0725, confirms this approval and expires on 12/31/2025. Without this approval, we could not conduct this study.

How will I be compensated?

You will receive \$40.

What if I have questions about the interview?

If you have concerns or questions about the interview, you may contact RTI's project director, [D: NAME], at [D: PHONE NUMBER] OR [D: EMAIL].

Participant's Agreement:

I have read the information provided above. I voluntarily agree to participate in this interview.

() I agree for this interview to be audio and video recorded.

() I do NOT agree for this interview to be audio and video recorded.

Use your mouse or finger to sign your name in the box below.

SIGN HERE

Type today's date below.

Fill in the following information below:

First Name: _____

Last Name: _____

Appendix D. Health Insurance, Out of Pocket Expenses, and Migration Cognitive Protocol

Revised 9/11/2024

My name is [INTERVIEWER NAME] and I will be conducting our research session today. I work for RSS, a survey research company, and I am talking to you on behalf of the U.S. Census Bureau and the U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics.

IF NOTETAKER OR OBSERVER PRESENT: <I also have my colleague [COLLEAGUE] who will be [taking notes for us today/observing the interview to see how the questions are working].>

Thanks for agreeing to help us today. The purpose of today's session is to help us see how well our questions work for an online survey. We're interested in how people understand these questions and how they come up with their answers. We are not evaluating you, so there are no right or wrong answers. We are looking to see what works and what we can improve.

Before we start, I want to talk about the consent form I shared with you via email. Did you have a chance to review and sign this form? [IF NO: Can you please open the link to this form in your email?] I just want to review some of the important information that was included in that consent document:

- With your permission, I would like to record our conversation. This will allow me to concentrate on what you are saying instead of taking a lot of notes while you are talking. It will also help me write a summary of the interview.
- All your responses and everything you say will be kept strictly confidential, and only researchers working on this project will see your answers or hear the recording. Your name will not be used in any of our reports. Nothing you tell us today will be shared with other federal agencies or with anyone else.
- Your participation is voluntary, and you may stop at any time. You may choose not to answer any questions you don't want to answer.
- The interview should take about 90 minutes.
- The form also has the contact name and telephone number of the project director, should you have any additional questions about the study. It also contains information about how to get in touch with the Institutional Review Board representative if you have any questions about your rights as a research participant in this study.
- As a thank you for your time today, you will receive a \$40 electronic gift card immediately after we complete the interview.
- Do you have any questions about any of this? [ANSWER ANY QUESTIONS THEY HAVE]
- Do you agree to participate? [IF YES, CONTINUE]
- Do you agree to be recorded? [IF YES, CONTINUE / IF R DOES NOT AGREE TO BE RECORDED, TELL THEM THE INTERVIEW WILL BE RESCHEDULED TO HAVE A NOTE TAKER PRESENT AND END INTERVIEW]

IF THE PARTICIPANT HAS CONSENTED TO RECORDING, START THE RECORDING.

[ONCE THE RECORDING IS ON]: Now that I have started the recording, would you please confirm that I have your permission to record the interview?

[RECORD DEVICE]: Could you tell me what type of device you are using?

[IF COMPUTER]: Is it a Mac or PC?

[IF SMARTPHONE]: Is it an Android or iPhone?

INSTRUCTIONS:

FOR ALL QUESTIONS, "PROBE" IS WHAT YOU DO WHEN R FINISHES THE QUESTION. "OBSERVE" IS SOMETHING THAT DOESN'T NEED TO BE ASKED.

"OBSERVE" FOLLOWED BY "PROBE" IS SOMETHING TO ASK IF NOT OBSERVED OR SAID IN THINK ALOUD.OBSERVE.

"PROBE IF NECESSARY" MEANS TO PROBE IF THEY WERE NOT ASKED BEFORE OR THE INTERVIEWER NOT SURE. IF R ANSWERED THE PROBES PREVIOUSLY, ASK AGAIN ONLY IF IT SEEMS LIKE THERE ARE PROBLEMS.

FOR ALL QUESTIONS, NOTE AND/OR PROBE ANY SIGNIFICANT PROBLEMS, COMMENTS, OR BEHAVIORS THAT ARE NOT INCLUDED IN THE PROBES.

I am going to share the link to the survey in the chat box now. Please open the link, and then share your screen with me. [SEND QUALTRICS LINK IN CHATBOX]

LINK TO QUALTRICS: https://research.rm.census.gov/jfe/form/SV_6u0I54agUyLdgfY

[ONCE SCREEN IS SHARED]: You can start the survey now. Please enter [CASE ID] in the case ID box.

[REMIND THEM THE DATE, TIME, AND YOUR NAME, IF NEEDED]

[P ENTERS THEIR NAME, ADDRESS, AND HH ROSTER]

You will now begin the think aloud portion of the interview. Please tell me how you are thinking about the questions and your answers as you go through the survey. I will also ask you follow-up questions after you answer each question. You may begin now.

R's Health Insurance

1. Did you have health insurance at any point between January and December 2023?

Yes – 1

No – 2

1.1. PROBE: What does "health insurance" mean to you?

1.2. PROBE: Did you consider Medicare, Medicaid, or insurance purchased on healthcare.gov when answering this question?

1.3. OBSERVE/PROBE: DID THE R NOTICE THE TIMEFRAME IN THEIR THINK ALOUD? IF NOT, ASK:

Did you notice the time frame in the question? Does your answer reflect this?

SKIP IF Q1=2

2. Between January and December 2023, were you covered by any of the following types of health insurance? Do not include plans that cover only dental, drug, or vision.

Private health insurance – 1

Medicare – 2

Medicaid or other government program – 3

- Veterans health care (enrolled for VA) – 4
- TRICARE or other military health care – 5
- Indian Health Service – 6
- Something else – 7
- Not sure – 8

PROBE ON THE FOLLOWING:

- 2.1.** Does the term “Private health insurance” (1) make sense to you?
- 2.2.** Does the term “Medicaid or other government program” (3) make sense?
- 2.3.** (IF CLICKED ON **MEDICARE** AT ANY POINT): Was the list that opened helpful? Should it include more information?
- 2.4.** (IF CLICKED ON **MEDICAID** AT ANY POINT): Was the list that opened helpful? Should it include more information?
- 2.5.** Did you have trouble with any of the other names or terms?
- 2.6.** How did you arrive at your answer?

OBSERVE AND PROBE AS NEEDED:

- 2.7.** Did R read and follow the instructions about dental, vision plans?
- 2.8.** How did the R react when the additional information dropped down?
 - 2.8.a.** Did they understand what was happening?
 - 2.8.b.** Did they click other options to see the extra information for those?

2a. How did you get your private health insurance? Mark all that apply.

- Current job (yours or another family member) – 1
- Former job (yours or another family member) – 2
- Union or professional association – 3
- Directly from an insurance company – 4
- Broker – 5
- State or Federal Marketplace – 6
- Healthcare.gov – 7
- [^State-Specific Portal Name] – 8

- 2a.1.** PROBE: Does the response “Directly from an insurance company” (4) make sense?
- 2a.2.** PROBE: Do you think “State or Federal Marketplace,” “Healthcare.gov,” and/or the state-specific portal name are different names for the same thing? If so, was this confusing?
- 2a.3.** PROBE: Did you have any trouble deciding on a response?

IF Q1 = 2 OR SKIPPED

- 3.** Did you have health insurance for even a short time in 2023?
 - Yes – 1
 - No – 2

3.1. PROBE: Is this question redundant/annoying?

3.2. (IF R SAID YES) PROBE: Since you reported that you had some insurance in 2023, can you tell me why you said No to the previous question?

Q2= 7 OR 8 BUT NOT 1

4. How did you get your health insurance [that you're not sure how to report/ that was not listed]?

A job – 1

The government -2

Some other way - 3

I'm not sure – 4

4.1. NO PROBE BUT NOTE ANY PROBLEMS OR ALTERNATIVE WORDING.

IF Q4=1

5.1 Was that insurance tied to military service?

Yes – 1

No – 2

5.1.1. NO PROBE BUT NOTE ANY PROBLEMS OR ALTERNATIVE WORDING.

IF Q5.1=1

5.2 Who provided that insurance?

TRICARE – 1

CHAMPVA – 2

Veterans Administration (VA) Care – 3

Other – 4

5.2.1. NO PROBE BUT NOTE ANY PROBLEMS OR ALTERNATIVE WORDING.

IF Q4=2

6.1 Was that insurance through a job with the federal, state, or local government?

Yes – 1

No – 2

6.1.1. PROBE: Did you need all three types of government listed to answer the question? Or does "government" cover all three?

IF Q6.1=2

6.2 Who provided that insurance?

Medicaid or Medical Assistance – 1

Children's Health Insurance Program (CHIP) – 2

Medicare – 3

Military – 4

Indian Health Service – 5

Other – 6

6.2.1. NO PROBE BUT NOTE ANY PROBLEMS OR ALTERNATIVE WORDING.

[ANYONE WHO HASN'T YET GIVEN A VALID INSURANCE TYPE]

6.3 What kind of health insurance did you/they have?

Church – 1

Charity care – 2

HealthShare – 3
Other

6.3.1 (IF R SELECTS “OTHER”, RECORD THEIR RESPONSE AND PROBE): Please tell me about this insurance. How did you get it? What is covered? Do you pay for it?

IF Q4=3 OR 4

7.1 How did you get this insurance?

Former employer – 1
Union or professional association – 2
Indian Health Service – 3
Student insurance – 4
Parent or spouse’s plan – 5
Purchased – 6
Some other way – 7

7.1.1. PROBE: What does “student insurance” mean to you?

7.1.2. PROBE: What does “purchased” mean to you?

7.1.3. PROBE: Does the order of the response options work – could you easily find what you wanted?

7.1.4. OBSERVE/PROBE: For those who choose “Some other way”, what do people say?

IF Q7.1=5

7.2 How did they get this insurance?

Job – 1
Purchased – 2
Some other way – 3
Don’t know – 4

7.2.1. IF “SOME OTHER WAY” OBSERVE/ PROBE: What do people say?

7.2.2. (THOSE WHO CHOOSE PURCHASED, SOME OTHER WAY, OR DON’T KNOW)

PROBE: Tell me why you chose “purchased” / “some other way” / “don’t know”.

IF Q7.1=6 OR Q7.2=2

7.3 Was that insurance through healthcare.gov [or state exchange portal names]?

Yes – 1
No – 2
Don’t know – 3

7.3.1. PROBE: Did you know what “healthcare.gov” was?

R has health insurance

11. How long did you have [^health insurance type] in 2023?

All year – 1
Part of the year – 2
I did not have [^health insurance type] in 2023 – 3

11.1. (IF CHOOSE “DO NOT HAVE INSURANCE” (3)) PROBE: In previous questions your answers indicated that you had this insurance for some portion of 2023. Can you tell me why you selected that you didn’t have insurance?

11.2. OBSERVE/PROBE: THIS QUESTION IS ASKED AGAIN FOR EACH INSURANCE SELECTED. Do people notice that they are being asked about different insurances? Or do they think it’s the same question?

IF Q11=1-3

12. Have you recorded all the insurance type(s) you had last year? Do not include plans that cover only dental, drug, or vision.

Yes – 1

No – 2

12.1. OBSERVE: Did R read and follow the instructions about dental, vision plans?

13. What other health insurance(s) did you have in 2023? Mark all that apply.

Private health insurance -- 1

Medicare –2

Medicaid or other government program – 3

Veterans health care (enrolled for VA) – 4

TRICARE or other military health care – 5

Indian Health Service – 6

Other:

PROBE IF NECESSARY/IF NOT ASKED:

13.1. Does the term “Private health insurance” (1) make sense to you?

13.2. Does the term “Medicaid or other government program” (3) make sense?

13.3. (IF CLICKED ON **MEDICARE** AT ANY POINT): Was the list that opened helpful? Should it include more information?

13.4. (IF CLICKED ON **MEDICAID** AT ANY POINT): Was the list that opened helpful? Should it include more information?

13.5. Did you have trouble with any of the other names or terms?

OBSERVE AND PROBE:

13.6. PROBE: How did you arrive at your answer?

13.7. Did R read and follow the instructions about dental and vision plans?

13.8. How did the R react when the additional information dropped down?

13.8.a. Did they understand what was happening?

13.8.b. Did they click other options to see the extra information for those?

13a. How did you get your private health insurance? Mark all that apply.

Current job (yours or another family member) – 1

- Former job (yours or another family member) – 2
- Union or professional association – 3
- Directly from an insurance company – 4
- Broker – 5
- State or Federal Marketplace – 6
- Healthcare.gov – 7
- [^State-Specific Portal Name] – 8

PROBE IF NECESSARY:

- 13a.1.** Does the response “directly from an insurance company” make sense?
- 13a.2.** Do you think “State or Federal Marketplace,” “Healthcare.gov,” and/or the state-specific portal name are different names for the same thing? If so, was this confusing?

OBSERVE AND PROBE:

- 13a.3.** PROBE: Did you have any trouble deciding on a response?
- 13a.4.** OBSERVE: If someone hit “private insurance” earlier by mistake- what do they choose/do on this question?

- 14.** How long did you have [^health insurance type/this other insurance] in 2023?
- All year – 1
 - Part of the year – 2

14.1. NO PROBE BUT NOTE ANY PROBLEMS OR ALTERNATIVE WORDING.

[IF ANSWERED PART OF THE YEAR TO Q14 OR Q11]

- 15.** Were you uninsured for part of 2023?

- Yes – 1
- No – 2

15.1. PROBE: Did you understand the term “uninsured”? Is “without insurance” clearer?

- 17.** Whose name was your [^health insurance type] policy in? (who was the policyholder?)
[HH Roster]

17.1. PROBE: This question has 2 questions. The 2nd one is in parentheses. Did you understand these to be the same question?

17.2. PROBE: Which question did you understand better?

- 18.** Did [your or Person in Q17’s] employer or union help pay for the health insurance?

- Yes – 1
- No – 2

18.1. PROBE: What do you think is included in “pay for”? (Is this question about insurance premiums? Is there anything else included?)

18.2. OBSERVE: Are people able to answer this if they are not the policy holder?

- 18a.** Did [your or Person in Q17’s] employer or union pay all or part of the insurance?

- All – 1
- Part – 2

18a.1. OBSERVE/ PROBE: Do they know we're asking about their premiums only?

18b. Did [you/Person in Q17] receive a tax credit or subsidy based on family income to help pay for the insurance?

Yes – 1

No – 2

18b.1. PROBE: What is this question asking about? Can you tell me what subsidies are? Tax credits?

HH Member HI

19a. Did anyone else in your household also have [health insurance type] in 2023?

Yes – 1

No – 2

19a.1. PROBE: When you answered this, did you think about your particular insurance policy with the specific provider? Or did you think about this type of insurance more broadly?

Q19a=1

20. Which people in your household had [health insurance type] in 2023? Mark all that apply.

[HH Roster]

20.1. OBSERVE: Did the R answer the previous question incorrectly? If so, what do they do/ answer here?

21. How long did the following people have [insurance type] in 2023?

[HH Roster with yes/no grid for All year and Part year]

21.1. PROBE: Are the column headings clear?

21.2. OBSERVE: Did the R struggle with the grid format?

22. Besides {list insurances that were asked about}, was anyone in your household covered by any other type of health insurance in 2023?

Yes – 1

No – 2

22.1. OBSERVE: Are people overwhelmed/confused by the list of insurances within the question? Or is this working fine for them?

22.2. OBSERVE/PROBE: Did you read each insurance type in the question?

22.3. PROBE: Did you need to see each insurance listed in order to answer the question correctly?

22a. Which people in your household were covered by some other type of health insurance?

Mark all that apply.

[HH Roster]

22a.1. PROBE: The time frame is not mentioned. Are you still only thinking about 2023?

22d. Whose name was [Person in Q20]'s [^health insurance type] policy in? (who was the policyholder?)

[HH Roster of persons over age 17]

22d.1. PROBE IF NECESSARY: This question has 2 questions. The 2nd one is in parentheses. Did you understand these to be the same question? Which question did you understand better?

22e. Did [Person in Q22d's] employer or union help pay for the health insurance?

Yes – 1

No – 2

22e.1. PROBE IF NECESSARY: What do you think is included in "pay for"? (Is this question about insurance premiums? Is there anything else included?)

22e.2. OBSERVE: Are people able to answer this if they are not the policy holder?

22f. Did [Person in Q22d's] employer or union pay all or part of the insurance?

All – 1

Part – 2

22f.1. OBSERVE/ PROBE IF NECESSARY: Do they know we're asking about their premiums only?

22g. Did [Person in Q22d] receive a tax credit or subsidy based on family income to help pay for the insurance?

Yes – 1

No – 2

22g.1. PROBE IF NECESSARY: What is this question asking about? Can you tell me what subsidies are? tax credits?

22b. Was [Person] uninsured at any point in 2023?

Yes – 1

No – 2

22b.1. PROBE IF NECESSARY: Did you understand the term "uninsured"? Is "without insurance" clearer?

22c. How long was [Person] uninsured in 2023?

All year – 1

Part of the year – 2

22c.1. NO PROBE BUT NOTE ANY PROBLEMS OR ALTERNATIVE WORDING.

23. What "other" [if coming from Q22a, NOT Q22b or Q22c] health insurance(s) did [Person] have in 2023? Mark all that apply.

Private health insurance – 1

Medicare – 2

Medicaid or other government program – 3

Veterans health care (enrolled for VA) – 4

TRICARE or other military health care – 5

Indian Health Service – 6

23.1. NO PROBE BUT NOTE ANY PROBLEMS OR ALTERNATIVE WORDING.

23a. How did [^Person] get their private health insurance? Mark all that apply.

- Current job (theirs or another family member) – 1
- Former job (theirs or another family member) – 2
- Union or professional association – 3
- Directly from an insurance company – 4
- Broker – 5
- State or Federal Marketplace – 6
- Healthcare.gov – 7
- [^State-Specific Portal Name] – 8

PROBE IF NECESSARY

23a.1. Does the response “Directly from an insurance company” (4) make sense?

23a.2. Do you think “State or Federal Marketplace,” “Healthcare.gov,” and/or the state-specific portal name are different names for the same thing? If so, was this confusing?

PROBE/OBSERVE:

23a.3. PROBE: Did you have any trouble deciding on a response?

23a.4. OBSERVE: If someone hit “private insurance” earlier by mistake- what do they choose/do?

23a.5. OBSERVE: Any other terms misunderstood?

24. How long did [^Person] have [^health insurance type] in 2023?

- All year -- 1
- Part of the year - 2

24.1. NO PROBE BUT NOTE ANY PROBLEMS OR ALTERNATIVE WORDING.

25. Was [^Person] uninsured for part of 2023?

- Yes – 1
- No – 2

25.1. PROBE IF NECESSARY: Did you understand the term “uninsured”? Is “without insurance” clearer?

25a. Whose name was [Person in 22a]’s [^health insurance type] policy in? (who was the policyholder?)
[HH Roster of persons over age 17]

25a.1. PROBE IF NECESSARY: This question has 2 questions. The 2nd one is in parentheses. Did you understand these to be the same question? Which question did you understand better?

25b. Did [Person in Q25a’s] employer or union help pay for the health insurance?

- Yes – 1
- No – 2

25b.1. OBSERVE/ PROBE IF NECESSARY: Do they know we're asking about their premiums only?

25b.2. OBSERVE: Are people able to answer this if they are not the policy holder?

25c. Did [Person in Q25a's] employer or union pay all or part of the insurance?

All – 1

Part – 2

25c.1. OBSERVE/ PROBE IF NECESSARY: Do they know we're asking about their premiums only?

25d. Did [Person in Q25a] receive a tax credit or subsidy based on family income to help pay for the insurance?

Yes – 1

No – 2

25d.1. PROBE IF NECESSARY: What is this question asking about? Can you tell me what subsidies are? tax credits?

27. Was anyone else in your household uninsured for all of 2023?

Yes – 1

No – 2

27.1. NO PROBE BUT NOTE ANY PROBLEMS OR ALTERNATIVE WORDING.

27a. Which other people in your household were uninsured for all of 2023? Mark all that apply.
[HH Roster]

27a.1. NO PROBE BUT NOTE ANY PROBLEMS OR ALTERNATIVE WORDING.

HH Member HI Loop

28. What health insurance(s) did [^Person] have in 2023?

Mark all that apply.

Private health insurance – 1

Medicare – 2

Medicaid or other government program – 3

Veterans health care (enrolled for VA) – 4

TRICARE or other military health care – 5

Indian Health Service – 6

Other

PROBE IF NECESSARY:

28.1. (IF CLICKED ON **MEDICARE** AT ANY POINT): Was the list that opened helpful? Should it include more information?

28.2. (IF CLICKED ON **MEDICAID** AT ANY POINT): Was the list that opened helpful? Should it include more information?

28.3. Did you have trouble with any of the other names or terms?

28.4. How did you arrive at your answer?

OBSERVE AND PROBE AS NEEDED:

28.5. Did R read and follow the instructions about dental, vision plans?

28.6. How did the R react when the additional information dropped down?

28.6.a. Did they understand what was happening?

28.6.b. Did they click other options to see the extra information for those?

29. How did [^Person] get this private health insurance? Mark all that apply.

Current job (theirs or another family member) – 1

Former job (theirs or another family member) – 2

Union or professional association – 3

Directly from an insurance company – 4

Broker – 5

State or Federal Marketplace – 6

Healthcare.gov – 7

[^State-Specific Portal Name] – 8

29.1. PROBE IF NECESSARY: Does the response “Directly from an insurance company” (4) make sense?

29.2. PROBE IF NECESSARY: Do you think “State or Federal Marketplace,” “Healthcare.gov,” and/or the state-specific portal name are different names for the same thing? If so, was this confusing?

29.3. PROBE: Did you have any trouble deciding on a response?

29.4. OBSERVE: If someone hit “private insurance” earlier by mistake- what do they choose/do?

29.5. OBSERVE: Any other terms misunderstood?

30. How long did [^Person] have [^insurance type] in 2023?

All year – 1

Part of the year – 2

30.1. NO PROBE BUT NOTE ANY PROBLEMS OR ALTERNATIVE WORDING.

31. Was [Person] uninsured for part of 2023?

Yes – 1

No – 2

31.1. PROBE IF NECESSARY: Did you understand the term “uninsured”? Is “without insurance” clearer?

31a. Whose name was [Person in 27a]’s [^health insurance type] policy in? (who was the policyholder?)
[HH Roster of persons over age 17]

31a.1. PROBE IF NECESSARY: This question has 2 questions. The 2nd one is in parentheses. Did you understand these to be the same question? Which question did you understand better?

31b. Did [Person in Q31a's] employer or union help pay for the health insurance?

Yes – 1

No – 2

31b.1. OBSERVE/ PROBE IF NECESSARY: Do they know we're asking about their premiums only?

31b.2. OBSERVE: Are people able to answer this if they are not the policy holder?

31c. Did [Person in Q31a's] employer or union pay all or part of the insurance?

Yes – 1

No – 2

31c.1. OBSERVE/ PROBE IF NECESSARY: Do they know we're asking about their premiums only?

31d. Did [Person in Q31a] receive a tax credit or subsidy based on family income to help pay for the insurance?

Yes – 1

No – 2

31d.1. PROBE IF NECESSARY: What is this question asking about? Can you tell me what subsidies are? tax credits?

**RETURN TO HH MEMBER HI LOOP IF MORE THAN 1 HH MEMBER (Q28).
PROBE FOR 2 HH MEMBERS AND UNIQUE SITUATIONS FOR OTHER HH MEMBERS**

R's Out of Pocket Expenses

32. In 2023, how much did you pay for all health insurance premiums covering yourself or others in the household?

Include comprehensive plans and supplemental plans such as vision and dental insurance. Do not include any Medicare deductions from Social Security, Social Security Disability/ Social Security and Social Security Disability.

\$ _____

[ALLOW SOMEONE TO SKIP THIS QUESTION IF THEY DON'T KNOW]

32.1. OBSERVE/PROBE: Where did R stop reading the question?

32.2. OBSERVE: Does the answer provided follow the instructions?

32.3. PROBE: In general, did you understand this question? What would make it easier to understand this question?

32.4. PROBE: Is there any information that isn't necessary?

32.5. PROBE: Did you understand the instructions as to what to include or not?

IF PROVIDED AN ANSWER:

32.6. PROBE: How did you arrive at your answer?

32.7. (IF R HAS EMPLOYER SPONSORED INSURANCE) PROBE: Is your answer before or after any contributions from an employer?

32.8. (IF R RESPONDS \$0) PROBE: Tell me why it costs you nothing (e.g., they were insured, employer pays all).

33. If you don't know the exact amount, please estimate. In 2023, how much did you pay for all health insurance premiums covering yourself or others in the household?

\$0 to \$999 – 1

\$1,000 to \$2,999 – 2

\$3,000 and above – 3

33.1. PROBE: The instructions don't appear again in this question. Did you follow what to include and not include when answering?

33.2. PROBE: Did you have any trouble with the ranges?

33.3. PROBE: How did you arrive at your answer?

34. Choose the range that represents how much you paid for health insurance premiums in 2023.

\$0 to \$199 – 1

\$100 and \$499 – 2

\$500 to \$999 – 3

34.1. PROBE: Did you understand that this question is to further refine your response? Is this annoying? Difficult to answer?

35. In 2023, how much was paid out-of-pocket for your own medical care?

Include:

- copays for doctor and dentist visits
- diagnostic tests
- prescription medicine
- glasses and contacts
- and medical supplies

Include any amount paid out-of-pocket on your behalf by anyone in this household.

\$_____

[ALLOW SOMEONE TO SKIP THIS QUESTION IF THEY DON'T KNOW. THERE ARE FOLLOW-UPS.]

IF THEY PROVIDED AN ANSWER:

35.1. OBSERVE/PROBE: Where did R stop reading the question?

35.2. PROBE: Are the categories of what to include confusing?

35.3. PROBE: Does the “on behalf of” instruction matter? Did you ignore this? (if not) Did you factor it into your answer?

35.3. PROBE: Would you answer the same if the question was simplified to “How much was paid out of pocket for your medical care? Include copays, prescription medicine, etc.”.

35.4. PROBE: What additional or other wording would help you recall small medical spending?

35.5. (IF SOMEONE RESPONDS ZERO) PROBE: So, you had no out of pocket medical expenses, is that right? Are there any expenses that you considered reporting but decided not to?

(IF SKIP Q35)

36. If you don't know the exact amount, please estimate.

In 2023, how much was paid out-of-pocket for your own medical care?

Include:

- copays for doctor and dentist visits
- diagnostic tests
- prescription medicine
- glasses and contacts
- and medical supplies

Include any amount paid out-of-pocket on your behalf by anyone in this household.

\$0 to \$999 – 1

\$1,000 to \$2,999 – 2

\$3,000 and above – 3

36.1. OBSERVE/PROBE: Where did R stop reading the question?

36.2. PROBE: How did you feel being asked this question? (LOOK FOR INDICATIONS AS TO WHETHER IT WAS REPETITIVE, IRRITATING, ETC.)

36.3. PROBE: Are the categories of what to include confusing?

36.4. PROBE: Does the “on behalf of” instruction matter? Did you ignore this? (if not) Did you factor it into your answer?

36.5. PROBE: Would you answer the same if the question was simplified to “How much was paid out of pocket for your medical care? Include copays, prescription medicine, etc.”.

36.6. PROBE: What additional or other wording would help you recall small medical spending?

37. Choose the range that represents how much you paid for your own medical care not including premiums in 2023.

\$0 to \$199 – 1

\$100 and \$499 – 2

\$500 to \$999 – 3

37.1. PROBE IF NECESSARY: Did you understand that this question is to further refine your response? Is this annoying? Difficult to answer?

38. In 2023, how much was paid out-of-pocket for your non-prescription healthcare products? Include spending on items like vitamins, allergy and cold medicine, and anything else not yet reported.

\$ _____

[ALLOW SOMEONE TO SKIP THIS QUESTION IF THEY DON'T KNOW. THERE ARE FOLLOW-UPS.]

IF THEY ANSWER:

38.1. OBSERVE/PROBE: How did you arrive at an answer for this question?

38.2. PROBE: Did the examples in this question help you think about smaller medical expenses?

38.3. PROBE: Were some of these expenses already reported in the previous questions?

39. If you don't know the exact amount, please estimate how much was paid out-of-pocket for your non-prescription healthcare products.

\$0 to \$999 – 1

\$1,000 to \$2,999 – 2

\$3,000 and above – 3

39.1. PROBE: The instructions don't appear again. Did you follow what to include when answering?

39.2. OBSERVE/PROBE: How did you arrive at an answer for this question?

39.3. PROBE: Did the examples in this question help you think about smaller medical expenses?

39.4. PROBE: Were some of these expenses already reported in the previous questions?

40. Choose the range that represents how much you paid for other medical spending in 2023.

\$0 to \$199 – 1

\$100 and \$499 – 2

\$500 to \$999 – 3

40.1. PROBE IF NECESSARY: Did you understand that this question is to further refine your response? Is this annoying? Difficult to answer?

HH Member Out of Pocket Expenses

32_notR. In 2023, how much did [Person] pay for all health insurance premiums covering themselves or others in the household?

Include comprehensive plans and supplemental plans such as vision and dental insurance. Do not include any Medicare deductions from Social Security, Social Security Disability/ Social Security and Social Security Disability.

\$_____

[ALLOW SOMEONE TO SKIP THIS QUESTION IF THEY DON'T KNOW. THERE ARE FOLLOW-UPS.]

32_notR.1. OBSERVE/PROBE: Where did R stop reading the question?

32_notR.2. OBSERVE: Does the answer provided follow the instructions?

32_notR.3. PROBE: In general, did you understand this question? What would make it easier to understand this question?

32_notR.4. PROBE: Is there any information that isn't necessary?

32_notR.5. PROBE: Did you understand the instructions as to what to include or not?

IF PROVIDED AN ANSWER:

32_notR.6. PROBE: How did you arrive at your answer?

32_notR.7. (IF R HAS EMPLOYER SPONSORED INSURANCE) PROBE: Is your answer before or after any contributions from an employer?

32_notR.8. (IF R RESPONDS \$0) PROBE: Tell me why it costs you nothing (e.g., they were insured, employer pays all).

33_notR. If you don't know the exact amount, please estimate. In 2023, how much did [Person] pay for all health insurance premiums covering themselves or others in the household?

\$0 to \$999 – 1

\$1,000 to \$2,999 – 2

\$3,000 and above – 3

33_notR.1. PROBE: The instructions don't appear again in this question. Did you follow what to include and not include when answering?

33_notR.2. PROBE: Did you have any trouble with the ranges?

33_notR.3. PROBE: How did you arrive at your answer?

34_notR. Choose the range that represents how much [Person] paid for health insurance premiums in 2023.

\$0 to \$199 – 1
\$100 and \$499 – 2
\$500 to \$999 – 3

34_notR.1. PROBE: Did you understand that this question is to further refine your response? Is this annoying? Difficult to answer?

35_notR. In 2023, how much was paid out-of-pocket for [Person's] medical care?

Include:

- copays for doctor and dentist visits
- diagnostic tests
- prescription medicine
- glasses and contacts
- and medical supplies

Include any amount paid out-of-pocket on [Person's] behalf by anyone in this household.

\$ _____

[ALLOW SOMEONE TO SKIP THIS QUESTION IF THEY DON'T KNOW. THERE ARE FOLLOW-UPS.]

IF THEY PROVIDED AN ANSWER:

35_notR.1. OBSERVE/PROBE: Where did R stop reading the question?

35_notR.2. PROBE: Are the categories of what to include confusing?

35_notR.3. PROBE: Does the "on behalf of" instruction matter? Did you ignore this? (if not) Did you factor it into your answer?

35_notR.4. PROBE: Would you answer the same if the question was simplified to "How much was paid out of pocket for your medical care? Include copays, prescription medicine, etc.".

35_notR.5. PROBE: What additional or other wording would help you recall small medical spending?

35_notR.6. (IF SOMEONE RESPONDS ZERO) PROBE: So, you had no out of pocket medical expenses, is that right? Are there any expenses that you considered reporting but decided not to?

(IF SKIP Q35)

36_notR. If you don't know the exact amount, please estimate.

In 2023, how much was paid out-of-pocket for [Person's] medical care?

Include:

- copays for doctor and dentist visits
- diagnostic tests
- prescription medicine
- glasses and contacts

- and medical supplies

Include any amount paid out-of-pocket on [your/Person's] behalf by anyone in this household.

\$0 to \$999 – 1

\$1,000 to \$2,999 – 2

\$3,000 and above – 3

36_notR.1. OBSERVE/PROBE: Where did R stop reading the question?

36_notR.2. PROBE: How did you feel being asked this question? (LOOK FOR INDICATIONS AS TO WHETHER IT WAS REPETITIVE, IRRITATING, ETC.)

36_notR.3. PROBE: Are the categories of what to include confusing?

36_notR.4. PROBE: Does the "on behalf of" instruction matter? Did you ignore this? (if not) Did you factor it into your answer?

36_notR.5. PROBE: Would you answer the same if the question was simplified to "How much was paid out of pocket for your medical care? Include copays, prescription medicine, etc.".

36_notR.6. PROBE: What additional or other wording would help you recall small medical spending?

37_notR. Choose the range that represents how much [Person] paid for [their] medical care not including premiums in 2023.

\$0 to \$199 – 1

\$100 and \$499 – 2

\$500 to \$999 – 3

37_notR.1. PROBE IF NECESSARY: Did you understand that this question is to further refine your response? Is this annoying? Difficult to answer?

38_notR. In 2023, how much was paid out-of-pocket for [Person's] non-prescription healthcare products? Include spending on items like vitamins, allergy and cold medicine, and anything else not yet reported.

\$_____

[ALLOW SOMEONE TO SKIP THIS QUESTION IF THEY DON'T KNOW. THERE ARE FOLLOW-UPS.]

IF THEY ANSWER:

38_notR.1. OBSERVE/PROBE: How did you arrive at an answer for this question?

38_notR.2. PROBE: Did the examples in this question help you think about smaller medical expenses?

38_notR.3. PROBE: Were some of these expenses already reported in the previous questions?

39_notR. If you don't know the exact amount, please estimate how much was paid out-of-pocket for [Person's] non-prescription healthcare products.

\$0 to \$999 – 1
\$1,000 to \$2,999 – 2
\$3,000 and above – 3

39_notR.1. PROBE: The instructions don't appear again. Did you follow what to include when answering?

39_notR.2. OBSERVE/PROBE: How did you arrive at an answer for this question?

39_notR.3. PROBE: Did the examples in this question help you think about smaller medical expenses?

39_notR.4. PROBE: Were some of these expenses already reported in the previous questions?

40_notR. Choose the range that represents how much [Person] paid for other medical spending in 2023.

\$0 to \$199 – 1
\$100 and \$499 – 2
\$500 to \$999 – 3

40_notR.1. PROBE IF NECESSARY: Did you understand that this question is to further refine your response? Is this annoying? Difficult to answer?

R's Migration ROYA

1A. MIGSAM_1 - RESIDENCE 1 YEAR AGO (ROYA) – FOR ALL RESPONDENTS

Q1A: Were you living at [Current Address- just street address] one year ago, on September 1, 2023?

- Yes
- No

1A.1. PROBE: Did you have any difficulty with this question? If so, why?

1A.2. PROBE: When answering this question, did you consider the date provided or just focus on "one year ago"?

1A.3. PROBE: Did you consider a temporary stay elsewhere as your address 1 year ago? Or only primary residences where you lived?

2A. MIGCOU_1 - COUNTRY OF RESIDENCE 1 YEAR AGO – FOR RESPONDENTS WITH A DIFFERENT RESIDENCE 1 YEAR AGO

Q2A: Were you living in the United States (within the 50 states and the District of Columbia) one year ago, on September 1, 2023?

- Yes
- No

2A.1. PROBE: Is your definition of the United States the same as the one in parentheses? Did you read/ need this information?

3A. MIGSTA_1 - STATE OF RESIDENCE 1 YEAR AGO – FOR RESPONDENTS WITH A DIFFERENT RESIDENCE 1 YEAR AGO

Q3A: In which state and county did you live one year ago, on September 1, 2023?

- | | | |
|------------------------|------------------|------------------|
| • Alabama | • Kentucky | • Ohio |
| • Alaska | • Louisiana | • Oklahoma |
| • Arizona | • Maine | • Oregon |
| • Arkansas | • Maryland | • Pennsylvania |
| • California | • Massachusetts | • Rhode Island |
| • Colorado | • Michigan | • South Carolina |
| • Connecticut | • Minnesota | • South Dakota |
| • Delaware | • Mississippi | • Tennessee |
| • District of Columbia | • Missouri | • Texas |
| • Florida | • Montana | • Utah |
| • Georgia | • Nebraska | • Vermont |
| • Hawaii | • Nevada | • Virginia |
| • Idaho | • New Hampshire | • Washington |
| • Illinois | • New Jersey | • West Virginia |
| • Indiana | • New Mexico | • Wisconsin |
| • Iowa | • New York | • Wyoming |
| • Kansas | • North Carolina | |
| | • North Dakota | |

5A.* MIGPLC_1 – CITY OR TOWN OF RESIDENCE 1 YEAR AGO – FOR RESPONDENTS WITH A DIFFERENT RESIDENCE 1 YEAR AGO

Q5A: What city or town in [State] did you live in one year ago, on September 1, 2023?
[Respondent self-reports via write-in.]

5A.1. PROBE: Did you have difficulty recalling this information?

5A.2. PROBE: Did you feel uneasy about reporting this information?

5A.3. PROBE: Which was easier to report – county or city?

6A. – M1RES_1 - MAIN REASON FOR MOVE – FOR RESPONDENTS WITH A DIFFERENT RESIDENCE 1 YEAR AGO

Q6A: What was the main reason for your most recent move, to [current street address]?
[DISPLAYED INFORMATION WHEN FOLDED:]

1. Family
2. Nonfamily relationship
3. Work
4. Education or training
5. Housing or neighborhood hardship
6. Better-suited housing or neighborhood
7. Health
8. Natural disaster
9. Better-suited climate or region
10. Legal or institutional
11. Other

[DISPLAYED INFORMATION WHEN UNFOLDED:]

- **Family**
 - *Examples: birth of a child; to help parent; divorced; death in family*
- **Nonfamily relationship**
 - *Examples: to be with unmarried partner; wanted to live with friend; conflict with roommate*

- **Work**
 - *Examples: shorter commute; starting new job; unemployed; armed forces; retired*
- **Education or training**
 - *Examples: college; trade school; unpaid internship; desirable public school district*
- **Housing or neighborhood hardship**
 - *Examples: unaffordable housing costs; foreclosure; eviction; landlord negligence – such as refusal to provide repairs, pest or mold control, or heating; neighborhood safety concerns; homelessness*
- **Better-suited housing or neighborhood**
 - *Examples: found less expensive housing; desirable neighborhood; wanted to own home; down-sized; amenities such as garage, pool, or yard*
- **Health**
 - *Examples: needed home without stairs; aging; injury; illness; assisted living; exited rehabilitation*
- **Natural disaster**
 - *Examples: hurricane or tornado damage; flooding; wildfire risk*
- **Better-suited climate or region**
 - *Examples: less cold or rainy; wanted to live in a city; wanted to live in the Southwest; closer to the mountains*
- **Legal or institutional**
 - *Examples: re-entry from prison; foster care; requirements of parole; probation ended*
- **Other**
 - *Any reason that does not fit into one of the categories above*

6A.1. PROBE: Did the respondent read all of the options, or only the start of the list?

6A.2. PROBE: Did you have difficulty with question? Tell me about that.

6A.3. PROBE: Was your most recent move from the county/city you just provided to your current address? If not, what move did you think about when answering?

6A.4. PROBE: Were you thinking about your personal reasons for moving or the household as a whole?

6A.5. Did the reasons fit easily into one of the response options? If no, was it that they did they not fit any category? Or did they fit more than one?

6A.6. PROBE: Did the additional information about each option help?

6A.7. PROBE: The options are sometimes about the place you left and sometimes about the new residence. Did you notice this? Was it confusing?

6A.8. PROBE: How do you feel about the number of response options?

6A.9. (IF SELECTED OTHER/NOT MY DECISION) PROBE: Please tell me more about that.

7A. – M2RES _1- ADDITIONAL REASONS FOR MOVE – FOR RESPONDENTS WITH A DIFFERENT RESIDENCE 1 YEAR AGO

Q7A: What were the other reasons, if any, for your most recent move?

[DISPLAYED INFORMATION WHEN FOLDED:]

1. Family
2. Nonfamily relationship
3. Work
4. Education or training
5. Housing or neighborhood hardship
6. Better-suited housing or neighborhood
7. Health
8. Natural disaster
9. Better-suited climate or region
10. Legal or institutional
11. Other [INTENTIONAL SPACE]
12. None

[DISPLAYED INFORMATION WHEN UNFOLDED:]

- **Family**
 - *Examples: birth of a child; to help parent; divorced; death in family*
- **Nonfamily relationship**
 - *Examples: to be with unmarried partner; wanted to live with friend; conflict with roommate*
- **Work**
 - *Examples: shorter commute; starting new job; unemployed; armed forces; retired*
- **Education or training**
 - *Examples: college; trade school; unpaid internship; desirable public school district*
- **Housing or neighborhood hardship**
 - *Examples: unaffordable housing costs; foreclosure; eviction; landlord negligence – such as refusal to provide repairs, pest or mold control, or heating; neighborhood safety concerns; homelessness*
- **Better-suited housing or neighborhood**
 - *Examples: found less expensive housing; desirable neighborhood; wanted to own home; down-sized; amenities such as garage, pool, or yard*
- **Health**
 - *Examples: needed home without stairs; aging; injury; illness; assisted living; exited rehabilitation*
- **Natural disaster**
 - *Examples: hurricane or tornado damage; flooding; wildfire risk*
- **Better-suited climate or region**
 - *Examples: less cold or rainy; wanted to live in a city; wanted to live in the Southwest; closer to the mountains*
- **Legal or institutional**
 - *Examples: re-entry from prison; foster care; requirements of parole; probation ended*
- **Other**
 - *Any reason that does not fit into one of the categories above*
- **None**
 - *No additional reasons for moving*

7A.1. PROBE: Did you have difficulty with question? Tell me more about that.

7A.2. PROBE: Were you thinking about your personal reasons for moving or the household as a whole?

7A.3. PROBE: Was it easy to come up with additional reasons? If yes, did you want to report more reasons?

7A.4. PROBE: Were the reasons you came up with important or minor?

7A.5. PROBE ALL HH MEMBERS: Did the reasons fit easily into one of the response options? If no, Was it that they did they not fit any category? Or did they fit more than one?

7A.6. PROBE: Did the additional information about each option help?

7A.7. PROBE: Would you prefer to provide your 3 reasons another way?

7A.8. PROBE: If there was a question that asked you to rank your reasons for move from most to least important, could you do that?

7A.9. (IF SELECTED OTHER) PROBE: Please tell me more about that.

7A.10 (IF THE RESPONDENT CHOSE THE SAME ANSWER AS IN THE PREVIOUS QUESTION) PROBE: Please tell me more about that —are these 2 separate reasons that fall into the same category? Or the same reason that you are repeating?

8A. – MIGSAMERES_1 - IS THE PRIOR RESIDENCE THE SAME AS ROYA – FOR RESPONDENTS WITH A DIFFERENT RESIDENCE 1 YEAR AGO

Q8A: Other than your move to [Current address – just street], did you move another time between September 1, 2023 and today?

- Yes
- No

8A.1. PROBE: Did this question make sense to you? Do you feel like you already answered this?

9A. MIGALL_1 – COHABITATION WITH RESPONDENT OVER PAST 1 YEAR

Q9A: Listed below are the other members of your household who are at least 1 year old. Which of these people, if any, lived with you one year ago, on September 1, 2023?

[ALL OTHER HOUSEHOLDERS]

9A.1. PROBE: Did you have any difficulty with this question? Tell me.

9A.2. PROBE: When answering this question, did you consider the date provided or just focus on “one year ago”?

9A.3. PROBE: Was it difficult to decide if someone was living with you, if they usually or sometimes live somewhere else?

HH Living with R - ROYA Loop

***** BEGIN PERSON LOOP – 6A_I – 8A_I *****

6A_I. M1RES_1_I – MAIN REASON FOR MOVING – FOR COHABITANTS FROM MIGALL UNIVERSE: PERSON SELECTED IN 9A (MIGALL_1) (SOMEONE LIVING WITH THE R ONE YR AGO)

Q6A_i What was [name selected in 9A]’s main reason for their most recent move, to [current address – street only]?

[DISPLAYED INFORMATION WHEN FOLDED:]

1. Family
2. Nonfamily relationship
3. Work
4. Education or training
5. Housing or neighborhood hardship
6. Better-suited housing or neighborhood
7. Health
8. Natural disaster
9. Better-suited climate or region
10. Legal or institutional
11. Other

[DISPLAYED INFORMATION WHEN UNFOLDED:]

- **Family**
 - *Examples: birth of a child; to help parent; divorced; death in family*
- **Nonfamily relationship**
 - *Examples: to be with unmarried partner; wanted to live with friend; conflict with roommate*
- **Work**
 - *Examples: shorter commute; starting new job; unemployed; armed forces; retired*
- **Education or training**
 - *Examples: college; trade school; unpaid internship; desirable public school district*
- **Housing or neighborhood hardship**
 - *Examples: unaffordable housing costs; foreclosure; eviction; landlord negligence – such as refusal to provide repairs, pest or mold control, or heating; neighborhood safety concerns; homelessness*
- **Better-suited housing or neighborhood**
 - *Examples: found less expensive housing; desirable neighborhood; wanted to own home; down-sized; amenities such as garage, pool, or yard*
- **Health**
 - *Examples: needed home without stairs; aging; injury; illness; assisted living; exited rehabilitation*
- **Natural disaster**
 - *Examples: hurricane or tornado damage; flooding; wildfire risk*
- **Better-suited climate or region**
 - *Examples: less cold or rainy; wanted to live in a city; wanted to live in the Southwest; closer to the mountains*
- **Legal or institutional**
 - *Examples: re-entry from prison; foster care; requirements of parole; probation ended*

- **Other**

- *Any reason that does not fit into one of the categories above*

6Ai.1. PROBE: Did you feel that you had to give a different reason than what you answered for yourself in an earlier question?

****6Ai.2. PROBE ALL HH MEMBERS: Did the reasons fit easily into one of the response options? If no, was it that they did not fit any category? Or did they fit more than one?****

HH MEMBERS LIVING WITH R OYA	MAIN REASON FOR MOVE	**PROBE 6Ai.2: Did the reasons fit easily into one of the response options?**
P2		
P3		
P4		
P5		

6Ai.3. PROBE: Was the reason for their move their decision? Or someone else's decision?

6Ai.3. (IF SELECTED OTHER OR NOT THEIR DECISION) PROBE: Please tell me more about that.

7A_I. M2RES_1_I – ADDITIONAL REASON(S) FOR MOVING – FOR COHABITANTS FROM MIGALL

Q7A_i : What were the other reasons, if any, for [person]'s most recent move?

[DISPLAYED INFORMATION WHEN FOLDED:]

1. Family
2. Nonfamily relationship
3. Work
4. Education or training
5. Housing or neighborhood hardship
6. Better-suited housing or neighborhood
7. Health
8. Natural disaster
9. Better-suited climate or region
10. Legal or institutional
11. Other [space]
12. None

[DISPLAYED INFORMATION WHEN UNFOLDED:]

- **Family**

- *Examples: birth of a child; to help parent; divorced; death in family*

- **Nonfamily relationship**

- *Examples: to be with unmarried partner; wanted to live with friend; conflict with roommate*

- **Work**
 - *Examples: shorter commute; starting new job; unemployed; armed forces; retired*
- **Education or training**
 - *Examples: college; trade school; unpaid internship; desirable public school district*
- **Housing or neighborhood hardship**
 - *Examples: unaffordable housing costs; foreclosure; eviction; landlord negligence – such as refusal to provide repairs, pest or mold control, or heating; neighborhood safety concerns; homelessness*
- **Better-suited housing or neighborhood**
 - *Examples: found less expensive housing; desirable neighborhood; wanted to own home; down-sized; amenities such as garage, pool, or yard*
- **Health**
 - *Examples: needed home without stairs; aging; injury; illness; assisted living; exited rehabilitation*
- **Natural disaster**
 - *Examples: hurricane or tornado damage; flooding; wildfire risk*
- **Better-suited climate or region**
 - *Examples: less cold or rainy; wanted to live in a city; wanted to live in the Southwest; closer to the mountains*
- **Legal or institutional**
 - *Examples: re-entry from prison; foster care; requirements of parole; probation ended*
- **Other**
 - *Any reason that does not fit into one of the categories above*
- **None**
 - *No additional reasons for moving*

7Ai.1. PROBE: Was it easy to come up with additional reasons? If yes, did you want to report more reasons?

7Ai.2. PROBE: Were the reasons you came up with important or minor?

7Ai.3. PROBE: Would you prefer to provide the other reasons another way?

7Ai.4. (IF SELECTED OTHER) PROBE: Please tell me more about that.

7Ai.5. (IF THE RESPONDENT CHOSE THE SAME ANSWER AS IN THE PREVIOUS QUESTION) PROBE: Please tell me—are these 2 separate reasons that fall into the same category? Or the same reason that you are repeating?

8A_I. – MIGSAMERES_1_I - IS THE PRIOR RESIDENCE THE SAME AS ROYA UNIVERSE: *JUST THE ONE PERSON SELECTED FOR THIS LOOP.*

Q8A_i: Other than [name]'s move to [Current address – just street], did they move another time between September 1, 2023 and today?

- Yes
- No

***** END PERSON LOOP *****

**RETURN TO HH LIVING WITH R – ROYA LOOP (Q6A_i) IF MORE THAN 1 HH MEMBER.
ALL PROBES FOR 2 HH MEMBERS AND UNIQUE SITUATIONS FOR OTHER HH
MEMBERS.**

****PROBE 6Ai.2 FOR ALL HH MEMEBR****

HH not Living with R – ROYA Loop

**** START OF LOOP FOR PEOPLE (ALTHOUGH ONLY CHOOSING ONE PERSON) WHO DID NOT LIVE WITH R ONE YEAR AGO****

1A-L. NXTSAM_1-L - RESIDENCE 1 YEAR AGO (ROYA)

UNIVERSE: Q1A = 2 (R NOT LIVING AT ADDRESS ONE YR AGO) AND PEOPLE WHO WERE NOT SELECTED ON Q9A (OTHER HH MEMBER NOT LIVING WITH R ONE YEAR AGO)

Q1A-L: Was [name] living at [Current Address] one year ago, on September 1, 2023?

- Yes
- No

Q1A-L.1. PROBE: Was this question easy to understand? If not, do you think there is a better way for us to ask for this information?

Q1A-L.2. PROBE: Did this question seem redundant?

2A-L. NXTCOU_1-L - COUNTRY OF RESIDENCE 1 YEAR AGO – FOR RESPONDENTS NOT LIVING WITH R 1 YEAR AGO AND NOT LIVING AT CURRENT ADDRESS 1 YEAR AGO

Q2A-L: Was [name] living in the United States (within the 50 states and the District of Columbia) one year ago, on September 1, 2023?

- Yes
- No

3A-L. NXTSTA_1-L - STATE OF RESIDENCE 1 YEAR AGO

Q3A-L: In which state and county did [name] live in one year ago, on September 1, 2023?

- | | | |
|------------------------|------------------|------------------|
| • Alabama | • Kentucky | • Ohio |
| • Alaska | • Louisiana | • Oklahoma |
| • Arizona | • Maine | • Oregon |
| • Arkansas | • Maryland | • Pennsylvania |
| • California | • Massachusetts | • Rhode Island |
| • Colorado | • Michigan | • South Carolina |
| • Connecticut | • Minnesota | • South Dakota |
| • Delaware | • Mississippi | • Tennessee |
| • District of Columbia | • Missouri | • Texas |
| • Florida | • Montana | • Utah |
| • Georgia | • Nebraska | • Vermont |
| • Hawaii | • Nevada | • Virginia |
| • Idaho | • New Hampshire | • Washington |
| • Illinois | • New Jersey | • West Virginia |
| • Indiana | • New Mexico | • Wisconsin |
| • Iowa | • New York | • Wyoming |
| • Kansas | • North Carolina | |
| | • North Dakota | |

5A-L.* NXTPLC_1-L – CITY OR TOWN OF RESIDENCE 1 YEAR AGO

Q5A-L: What city or town in [State] did [name] live in one year ago, on September 1, 2023?

[Respondent self-reports via write-in.]

6A-L. – NXT1RES_1 -L - MAIN REASON FOR MOVE

Q6A-L: What was the main reason for [name]’s most recent move to [current street address]?

[DISPLAYED INFORMATION WHEN FOLDED:]

1. Family
2. Nonfamily relationship
3. Work
4. Education or training
5. Housing or neighborhood hardship
6. Better-suited housing or neighborhood
7. Health
8. Natural disaster
9. Better-suited climate or region
10. Legal or institutional
11. Other

[DISPLAYED INFORMATION WHEN UNFOLDED:]

- **Family**
 - *Examples: birth of a child; to help parent; divorced; death in family*
- **Nonfamily relationship**
 - *Examples: to be with unmarried partner; wanted to live with friend; conflict with roommate*
- **Work**
 - *Examples: shorter commute; starting new job; unemployed; armed forces; retired*
- **Education or training**
 - *Examples: college; trade school; unpaid internship; desirable public school district*
- **Housing or neighborhood hardship**
 - *Examples: unaffordable housing costs; foreclosure; eviction; landlord negligence – such as refusal to provide repairs, pest or mold control, or heating; neighborhood safety concerns; homelessness*
- **Better-suited housing or neighborhood**
 - *Examples: found less expensive housing; desirable neighborhood; wanted to own home; down-sized; amenities such as garage, pool, or yard*
- **Health**
 - *Examples: needed home without stairs; aging; injury; illness; assisted living; exited rehabilitation*
- **Natural disaster**
 - *Examples: hurricane or tornado damage; flooding; wildfire risk*
- **Better-suited climate or region**
 - *Examples: less cold or rainy; wanted to live in a city; wanted to live in the Southwest; closer to the mountains*
- **Legal or institutional**
 - *Examples: re-entry from prison; foster care; requirements of parole; probation ended*

- **Other**

- Any reason that does not fit into one of the categories above

****6A-L.1. PROBE ALL HH MEMBERS: Did the reasons fit easily into one of the response options? If no, did they not fit any category? Or fit more than one?**

HH MEMBERS NOT LIVING WITH R OYA	MAIN REASON FOR MOVE	**PROBE 6A-L.1: Did the reasons fit easily into one of the response options?**
P2		
P3		
P4		
P5		

6A-L.2. PROBE: Was the reason for their move their decision? Or someone else's decision Would an option "Not their decision" be helpful?

6A-L.3. (IF SELECTED Other) PROBE: Please tell me more about that.

7A-L. – NXT2RES_1_ -L - ADDITIONAL REASONS FOR MOVE

Q7A-L: What were the other reasons, if any, for [name]'s most recent move?

1. Family
2. Nonfamily relationship
3. Work
4. Education or training
5. Housing or neighborhood hardship
6. Better-suited housing or neighborhood
7. Health
8. Natural disaster
9. Better-suited climate or region
10. Legal or institutional
11. Other [space]
12. None

[DISPLAYED INFORMATION WHEN UNFOLDED:]

- **Family**

- Examples: birth of a child; to help parent; divorced; death in family

- **Nonfamily relationship**

- Examples: to be with unmarried partner; wanted to live with friend; conflict with roommate

- **Work**

- Examples: shorter commute; starting new job; unemployed; armed forces; retired

- **Education or training**

- Examples: college; trade school; unpaid internship; desirable public school district

- **Housing or neighborhood hardship**
 - *Examples: unaffordable housing costs; foreclosure; eviction; landlord negligence – such as refusal to provide repairs, pest or mold control, or heating; neighborhood safety concerns; homelessness*
- **Better-suited housing or neighborhood**
 - *Examples: found less expensive housing; desirable neighborhood; wanted to own home; down-sized; amenities such as garage, pool, or yard*
- **Health**
 - *Examples: needed home without stairs; aging; injury; illness; assisted living; exited rehabilitation*
- **Natural disaster**
 - *Examples: hurricane or tornado damage; flooding; wildfire risk*
- **Better-suited climate or region**
 - *Examples: less cold or rainy; wanted to live in a city; wanted to live in the Southwest; closer to the mountains*
- **Legal or institutional**
 - *Examples: re-entry from prison; foster care; requirements of parole; probation ended*
- **Other**
 - *Any reason that does not fit into one of the categories above*
- **None**
 - *No additional reasons for moving*

7A-L.1. PROBE: Was it easy to come up with additional reasons? If yes, did you want to report more reasons?

7A-L.2. PROBE: Were the reasons you came up with important or minor?

7A-L.3. (IF SELECTED OTHER) PROBE: Please tell me.

7A-L.4. (IF THE RESPONDENT CHOSE THE SAME ANSWER AS IN THE PREVIOUS QUESTION) PROBE: Please tell me more about that —are these 2 separate reasons that fall into the same category? Or the same reason that you are repeating?

8A-L. – NXTSAMERES_1-L - IS THE PRIOR RESIDENCE THE SAME AS ROYA

Q8A-L: Other than [name]’s move to [Current address – just street], did they move another time between September 1, 2023 and today?

- Yes
- No

**** END OF LOOP FOR PERSON WHO DID NOT LIVE WITH R ONE YEAR AGO****

RETURN TO HH NOT LIVING WITH R – ROYA LOOP (Q1A-L) IF MORE THAN 1 HH MEMBER.

ALL PROBES FOR 2 HH MEMBERS AND UNIQUE SITUATIONS FOR OTHER HH MEMBERS.

****PROBE 6A-L.1 FOR ALL HH MEMEBR****

R’s Migration R10YA

1B. MIGSAM_10 - RESIDENCE 10 YEARS AGO (R10YA) – FOR RESPONDENTS WITH SAME RESIDENCE 1 YEAR AGO (AND THEREFORE DID NOT RECEIVE REASONS FOR MOVE QUESTIONS YET)

Q1B: Were you living at [Current Address- just street] ten years ago, on September 1, 2014?

- Yes
- No

1B.1. PROBE: Did you have any difficulty with this question? If so, why?

1B.2. PROBE: When answering this question, did you consider the date provided or just focus on “ten years ago”?

2B. MIGCOU_10 - COUNTRY OF RESIDENCE 10 YEARS AGO – FOR RESPONDENTS WITH A DIFFERENT RESIDENCE 10 YEARS AGO

Q2B: Were you living in the United States (within the 50 states and the District of Columbia) ten years ago, on September 1, 2014?

- Yes
- No

2B.1. PROBE: Is your definition of the United States the same as the one in parentheses? Did you read/ need this information?

3B. MIGSTA_10 – STATE OF RESIDENCE 10 YEARS AGO – FOR RESPONDENTS WITH A DIFFERENT RESIDENCE 10 YEARS AGO

Q3B: In which state and county did you live in ten years ago, on September 1, 2014?

- | | | |
|------------------------|------------------|------------------|
| • Alabama | • Kentucky | • Ohio |
| • Alaska | • Louisiana | • Oklahoma |
| • Arizona | • Maine | • Oregon |
| • Arkansas | • Maryland | • Pennsylvania |
| • California | • Massachusetts | • Rhode Island |
| • Colorado | • Michigan | • South Carolina |
| • Connecticut | • Minnesota | • South Dakota |
| • Delaware | • Mississippi | • Tennessee |
| • District of Columbia | • Missouri | • Texas |
| • Florida | • Montana | • Utah |
| • Georgia | • Nebraska | • Vermont |
| • Hawaii | • Nevada | • Virginia |
| • Idaho | • New Hampshire | • Washington |
| • Illinois | • New Jersey | • West Virginia |
| • Indiana | • New Mexico | • Wisconsin |
| • Iowa | • New York | • Wyoming |
| • Kansas | • North Carolina | |
| | • North Dakota | |

5B. MIGPLC_10 – CITY OR TOWN OF RESIDENCE 10 YEARS AGO – FOR RESPONDENTS WITH A DIFFERENT RESIDENCE 10 YEARS AGO

Q5B: What city or town in [State] did you live in ten years ago, on September 1, 2014? [Respondent self-reports via write-in.]

5B.1. PROBE: Did you have difficulty recalling this information?

5B.2. PROBE: Did you feel uneasy about reporting this information?

5B.3. PROBE: Which was easier to report – county or city?

6B. – M1RES_10 - MAIN REASON FOR MOVE – FOR RESPONDENTS WITH A DIFFERENT RESIDENCE 10 YEARS AGO

Q6B: What was the main reason for your most recent move, to [current street address]?
[DISPLAYED INFORMATION WHEN FOLDED:]

1. Family
2. Nonfamily relationship
3. Work
4. Education or training
5. Housing or neighborhood hardship
6. Better-suited housing or neighborhood
7. Health
8. Natural disaster
9. Better-suited climate or region
10. Legal or institutional
11. Other

[DISPLAYED INFORMATION WHEN UNFOLDED:]

- **Family**
 - Examples: birth of a child; to help parent; divorced; death in family
- **Nonfamily relationship**
 - Examples: to be with unmarried partner; wanted to live with friend; conflict with roommate
- **Work**
 - Examples: shorter commute; starting new job; unemployed; armed forces; retired
- **Education or training**
 - Examples: college; trade school; unpaid internship; desirable public school district
- **Housing or neighborhood hardship**
 - Examples: unaffordable housing costs; foreclosure; eviction; landlord negligence – such as refusal to provide repairs, pest or mold control, or heating; neighborhood safety concerns; homelessness
- **Better-suited housing or neighborhood**
 - Examples: found less expensive housing; desirable neighborhood; wanted to own home; down-sized; amenities such as garage, pool, or yard
- **Health**
 - Examples: needed home without stairs; aging; injury; illness; assisted living; exited rehabilitation
- **Natural disaster**
 - Examples: hurricane or tornado damage; flooding; wildfire risk
- **Better-suited climate or region**
 - Examples: less cold or rainy; wanted to live in a city; wanted to live in the Southwest; closer to the mountains
- **Legal or institutional**
 - Examples: re-entry from prison; foster care; requirements of parole; probation ended

- **Other**

- Any reason that does not fit into one of the categories above

6B.1. OBSERVE/PROBE: Did the respondent read all of the options, or only the start of the list?

6B.2. PROBE: Did you have difficulty with the question? Tell me more about that.

6B.3. PROBE: Was your most recent move from the county/city you just provided to your current address? If not, what move did you think about when answering?

6B.4. PROBE: Were you thinking about your personal reasons for moving or reasons applicable to the household as a whole?

6B.5. PROBE: Did the reasons fit easily into one of the response options? If not, was it that they did not fit any category? Or did they fit more than one?

6B.6. PROBE: Did the additional information about each option help?

6B.7. PROBE: The options are sometimes about the place you left and sometimes about the new residence. Did you notice this? Was it confusing?

6B.8. PROBE: How do you feel about the number of response options?

6B.9. (IF SELECTED OTHER OR NOT MY DECISION) PROBE: Please tell me more about that.

7B. – M2RES _10- ADDITIONAL REASONS FOR MOVE – FOR RESPONDENTS WITH A DIFFERENT RESIDENCE 10 YEARS AGO

Q7B: What were the other reasons, if any, for your most recent move?

[DISPLAYED INFORMATION WHEN FOLDED:]

1. Family
2. Nonfamily relationship
3. Work
4. Education or training
5. Housing or neighborhood hardship
6. Better-suited housing or neighborhood
7. Health
8. Natural disaster
9. Better-suited climate or region
10. Legal or institutional
11. Other [INTENTIONAL SPACE]
12. None

[DISPLAYED INFORMATION WHEN UNFOLDED]:

- **Family**

- Examples: birth of a child; to help parent; divorced; death in family

- **Nonfamily relationship**

- Examples: to be with unmarried partner; wanted to live with friend; conflict with roommate

- **Work**

- Examples: shorter commute; starting new job; unemployed; armed forces; retired

- **Education or training**
 - Examples: college; trade school; unpaid internship; desirable public school district
- **Housing or neighborhood hardship**
 - Examples: unaffordable housing costs; foreclosure; eviction; landlord negligence – such as refusal to provide repairs, pest or mold control, or heating; neighborhood safety concerns; homelessness
- **Better-suited housing or neighborhood**
 - Examples: found less expensive housing; desirable neighborhood; wanted to own home; down-sized; amenities such as garage, pool, or yard
- **Health**
 - Examples: needed home without stairs; aging; injury; illness; assisted living; exited rehabilitation
- **Natural disaster**
 - Examples: hurricane or tornado damage; flooding; wildfire risk
- **Better-suited climate or region**
 - Examples: less cold or rainy; wanted to live in a city; wanted to live in the Southwest; closer to the mountains
- **Legal or institutional**
 - Examples: re-entry from prison; foster care; requirements of parole; probation ended
- **Other**
 - Any reason that does not fit into one of the categories above
- **None**
 - No additional reasons for moving

7B.1. PROBE: Was it easy to come up with additional reasons? If yes, did you want to report more reasons?

7B.2. PROBE: Were the reasons you came up with important or minor?

7B.3. PROBE: Would you prefer to provide the other reasons another way?

7B.4. (IF SELECTED OTHER) PROBE: Please tell me more about that.

7B.5. (IF THE RESPONDENT CHOSE THE SAME ANSWER AS IN THE PREVIOUS QUESTION) PROBE: Please tell me more about that—are these 2 separate reasons that fall into the same category? Or the same reason that you are repeating?

8B. – MIGSAMERES_10 – IS THE PRIOR RESIDENCE THE SAME AS R10YA – FOR RESPONDENTS WITH A DIFFERENT RESIDENCE 10 YEARS AGO

Q8B: Other than your move to [Current address – just street], did you move another time between September 1, 2014 and today?

- Yes
- No

8b.1. PROBE: Did this question make sense to you? Do you feel like you already answered this?

9B.* MIGALL_10 – COHABITATION WITH RESPONDENT 10 YEARS AGO

Q9B: Listed below are the other members of your household who are at least 10 years old. Which of these people, if any, lived with you ten years ago, on September 1, 2014?

[ALL OTHER HOUSEHOLDERS 10 yrs old or more]

9B.1. PROBE: Did you have any difficulty with this question? Tell me more about that.

9B.2. PROBE: When answering this question, did you consider the date provided or just focus on “ten years ago”?

9B.3. PROBE: Was it difficult to decide if someone was living with you, if they usually or sometimes lived somewhere else?

HH Living with R – R10YA Loop

***** BEGIN PERSON LOOP – 6B_I – 8B_I *****

6B_I. M1RES_10_I – MAIN REASON FOR MOVING – FOR COHABITANTS FROM MIGALL UNIVERSE: ANY PERSON SELECTED IN 9B (SOMEONE LIVING WITH THE R 10 YR AGO)

Q6B_i What was [name selected from 9B]’s main reason for their most recent move, to [current address – street only]?

[DISPLAYED INFORMATION WHEN FOLDED:]

1. Family
2. Nonfamily relationship
3. Work
4. Education or training
5. Housing or neighborhood hardship
6. Better-suited housing or neighborhood
7. Health
8. Natural disaster
9. Better-suited climate or region
10. Legal or institutional
11. Other

[DISPLAYED INFORMATION WHEN UNFOLDED:]

- **Family**
 - Examples: birth of a child; to help parent; divorced; death in family
- **Nonfamily relationship**
 - Examples: to be with unmarried partner; wanted to live with friend; conflict with roommate
- **Work**
 - Examples: shorter commute; starting new job; unemployed; armed forces; retired
- **Education or training**
 - Examples: college; trade school; unpaid internship; desirable public school district
- **Housing or neighborhood hardship**
 - Examples: unaffordable housing costs; foreclosure; eviction; landlord negligence – such as refusal to provide repairs, pest or mold control, or heating; neighborhood safety concerns; homelessness
- **Better-suited housing or neighborhood**
 - Examples: found less expensive housing; desirable neighborhood; wanted to own home; down-sized; amenities such as garage, pool, or yard

- **Health**
 - Examples: needed home without stairs; aging; injury; illness; assisted living; exited rehabilitation
- **Natural disaster**
 - Examples: hurricane or tornado damage; flooding; wildfire risk
- **Better-suited climate or region**
 - Examples: less cold or rainy; wanted to live in a city; wanted to live in the Southwest; closer to the mountains
- **Legal or institutional**
 - Examples: re-entry from prison; foster care; requirements of parole; probation ended
- **Other**
 - Any reason that does not fit into one of the categories above

6B_i.1. PROBE: Did you feel that you had to give a different reason than what you answered for yourself in an earlier question?

****6B_i.2. PROBE ALL HH MEMBERS: Did the reasons fit easily into one of the response options? If not, was it that they did not fit any category? Or did they fit more than one? ****

HH MEMBERS LIVING WITH R 10YA	MAIN REASON FOR MOVE	**PROBE 6B_i.2: Did the reasons fit easily into one of the response options? **
P2		
P3		
P4		
P5		

6B_i.3 (IF SELECTED OTHER OR NOT THEIR DECISION) PROBE: Please tell me more about that.

7B_I. M2RES_10_I – ADDITIONAL REASON(S) FOR MOVING – FOR COHABITANTS FROM MIGALL

Q7B_i : What were the other reasons, if any, for [person]’s most recent move?
[DISPLAYED INFORMATION WHEN FOLDED:]

1. Family
2. Nonfamily relationship
3. Work
4. Education or training
5. Housing or neighborhood hardship
6. Better-suited housing or neighborhood
7. Health
8. Natural disaster
9. Better-suited climate or region
10. Legal or institutional
11. Other
[SPACE]
12. None

[DISPLAYED INFORMATION WHEN UNFOLDED:]

- **Family**
 - *Examples: birth of a child; to help parent; divorced; death in family*
- **Nonfamily relationship**
 - *Examples: to be with unmarried partner; wanted to live with friend; conflict with roommate*
- **Work**
 - *Examples: shorter commute; starting new job; unemployed; armed forces; retired*
- **Education or training**
 - *Examples: college; trade school; unpaid internship; desirable public school district*
- **Housing or neighborhood hardship**
 - *Examples: unaffordable housing costs; foreclosure; eviction; landlord negligence – such as refusal to provide repairs, pest or mold control, or heating; neighborhood safety concerns; homelessness*
- **Better-suited housing or neighborhood**
 - *Examples: found less expensive housing; desirable neighborhood; wanted to own home; down-sized; amenities such as garage, pool, or yard*
- **Health**
 - *Examples: needed home without stairs; aging; injury; illness; assisted living; exited rehabilitation*
- **Natural disaster**
 - *Examples: hurricane or tornado damage; flooding; wildfire risk*
- **Better-suited climate or region**
 - *Examples: less cold or rainy; wanted to live in a city; wanted to live in the Southwest; closer to the mountains*
- **Legal or institutional**
 - *Examples: re-entry from prison; foster care; requirements of parole; probation ended*
- **Other**
 - *Any reason that does not fit into one of the categories above*
- **None**
 - *No additional reasons for moving*

7B_i.1. PROBE: Was it easy to come up with additional reasons? If yes, did you want to report more reasons?

7B_i.2. PROBE: Were the reasons you came up with important or minor?

7B_i.3. PROBE: Would you prefer to provide the other reasons another way?

7B_i.4. (IF SELECTED OTHER) PROBE: Please tell me more about that.

7B_i.5. (IF THE RESPONDENT CHOSE THE SAME ANSWER AS IN THE PREVIOUS QUESTION) PROBE: Please tell me more about that—are these 2 separate reasons that fall into the same category? Or the same reason that you are repeating?

8B_I. – MIGSAMERES_10Y_I - IS THE PRIOR RESIDENCE THE SAME AS ROYA

Q8B_i: Other than [name]’s move to [Current address – just street], did they move another time between September 1, 2014 and today?

- Yes
- No

***** END PERSON LOOP *****

**RETURN TO HH LIVING WITH R – R10YA LOOP (Q6B_i) IF MORE THAN 1 HH MEMBER.
ALL PROBES FOR 2 HH MEMBERS AND UNIQUE SITUATIONS FOR OTHER HH
MEMBERS.**

****PROBE 6B_i.2 FOR ALL HH MEMEBR****

HH not Living with R – R10YA Loop

**** START OF LOOP FOR PEOPLE (ALTHOUGH ONLY CHOOSING ONE PERSON) WHO DID
NOT LIVE WITH R TEN YEARS AGO****

1B-L.* NXTSAM_10-L - RESIDENCE 10 YEARS AGO (R10YA)

UNIVERSE: RESPONDENT AGES 10+ WHO WAS NOT ON MIGALL_10 COHABITANT LIST
(DID NOT LIVE WITH R 10 YRS AGO)

Q1B-L: Was [person] living at [Current Address] ten years ago, on September 1, 2014?

- Yes
- No

1B-L.1. PROBE: Was this question easy to understand? If not, do you think there is
a better way for us to ask for this information?

1B-L.2. PROBE: Did this question seem redundant?

2B-L.* NXTCOU_10-L - COUNTRY OF RESIDENCE 10 YEARS AGO – FOR PEOPLE WHO DID
NOT LIVE WITH RESPONDENT 10 YRS AGO AND WERE NOT AT CURRENT ADDRESS

Q2B-L: Was [name] living in the United States (within the 50 states and the District of
Columbia) ten years ago, on September 1, 2014?

- Yes
- No

3B-L.* NXTSTA_10-L – STATE OF RESIDENCE 10 YEARS AGO

Q3B-L: In which state and county did [name] live in ten years ago, on September 1, 2014?

- | | | |
|---------------------------|------------------|------------------|
| • Alabama | • Kansas | • North Dakota |
| • Alaska | • Kentucky | • Ohio |
| • Arizona | • Louisiana | • Oklahoma |
| • Arkansas | • Maine | • Oregon |
| • California | • Maryland | • Pennsylvania |
| • Colorado | • Massachusetts | • Rhode Island |
| • Connecticut | • Michigan | • South Carolina |
| • Delaware | • Minnesota | • South Dakota |
| • District of
Columbia | • Mississippi | • Tennessee |
| • Florida | • Missouri | • Texas |
| • Georgia | • Montana | • Utah |
| • Hawaii | • Nebraska | • Vermont |
| • Idaho | • Nevada | • Virginia |
| • Illinois | • New Hampshire | • Washington |
| • Indiana | • New Jersey | • West Virginia |
| • Iowa | • New Mexico | • Wisconsin |
| | • New York | • Wyoming |
| | • North Carolina | |

5B-L.* NXPLC_10-L – CITY OR TOWN OF RESIDENCE 10 YEARS AGO

Q5B-L: What city or town in [State] did [reference person name] live in ten years ago, on September 1, 2014?

[Respondent self-reports via write-in.]

6B-L. – NXT1RES_10 -L - MAIN REASON FOR MOVE

Q6B-L: What was the main reason for [name]’s most recent move to [current street address]?

[DISPLAYED INFORMATION WHEN FOLDED:]

1. Family
2. Nonfamily relationship
3. Work
4. Education or training
5. Housing or neighborhood hardship
6. Better-suited housing or neighborhood
7. Health
8. Natural disaster
9. Better-suited climate or region
10. Legal or institutional
11. Other

[DISPLAYED INFORMATION WHEN UNFOLDED:]

- **Family**
 - *Examples: birth of a child; to help parent; divorced; death in family*
- **Nonfamily relationship**
 - *Examples: to be with unmarried partner; wanted to live with friend; conflict with roommate*
- **Work**
 - *Examples: shorter commute; starting new job; unemployed; armed forces; retired*
- **Education or training**
 - *Examples: college; trade school; unpaid internship; desirable public school district*
- **Housing or neighborhood hardship**
 - *Examples: unaffordable housing costs; foreclosure; eviction; landlord negligence – such as refusal to provide repairs, pest or mold control, or heating; neighborhood safety concerns; homelessness*
- **Better-suited housing or neighborhood**
 - *Examples: found less expensive housing; desirable neighborhood; wanted to own home; down-sized; amenities such as garage, pool, or yard*
- **Health**
 - *Examples: needed home without stairs; aging; injury; illness; assisted living; exited rehabilitation*
- **Natural disaster**
 - *Examples: hurricane or tornado damage; flooding; wildfire risk*
- **Better-suited climate or region**
 - *Examples: less cold or rainy; wanted to live in a city; wanted to live in the Southwest; closer to the mountains*
- **Legal or institutional**
 - *Examples: re-entry from prison; foster care; requirements of parole; probation ended*
- **Other**
 - *Any reason that does not fit into one of the categories above*

****6B-L.1. PROBE ALL HH MEMBERS: Did the reasons fit easily into one of the response options? If not, was it that they did not fit any category? Or did they fit more than one? ****

HH MEMBERS NOT LIVING WITH R 10YA	MAIN REASON FOR MOVE	**PROBE 6B-L.1: Did the reasons fit easily into one of the response options? **
P2		
P3		
P4		
P5		

6b.L.2. PROBE: Was the reason for their move their decision? Or someone else's decision?

6B-L.3. (IF SELECTED OTHER OR NOTE THEIR DECISION) PROBE: Please tell me more about that.

7B-L. – NXT2RES_10_ -L- ADDITIONAL REASONS FOR MOVE

Q7B-L: What were the other reasons, if any, for [name]'s most recent move?

Displayed information when folded:

1. Family
2. Nonfamily relationship
3. Work
4. Education or training
5. Housing or neighborhood hardship
6. Better-suited housing or neighborhood
7. Health
8. Natural disaster
9. Better-suited climate or region
10. Legal or institutional
11. Other
12. None

[DISPLAYED INFORMATION WHEN UNFOLDED:]

- **Family**
 - Examples: birth of a child; to help parent; divorced; death in family
- **Nonfamily relationship**
 - Examples: to be with unmarried partner; wanted to live with friend; conflict with roommate
- **Work**
 - Examples: shorter commute; starting new job; unemployed; armed forces; retired
- **Education or training**
 - Examples: college; trade school; unpaid internship; desirable public school district
- **Housing or neighborhood hardship**
 - Examples: unaffordable housing costs; foreclosure; eviction; landlord negligence – such as refusal to provide repairs, pest or mold control, or heating; neighborhood safety concerns; homelessness

- **Better-suited housing or neighborhood**
 - Examples: found less expensive housing; desirable neighborhood; wanted to own home; down-sized; amenities such as garage, pool, or yard
- **Health**
 - Examples: needed home without stairs; aging; injury; illness; assisted living; exited rehabilitation
- **Natural disaster**
 - Examples: hurricane or tornado damage; flooding; wildfire risk
- **Better-suited climate or region**
 - Examples: less cold or rainy; wanted to live in a city; wanted to live in the Southwest; closer to the mountains
- **Legal or institutional**
 - Examples: re-entry from prison; foster care; requirements of parole; probation ended
- **Other**
 - Any reason that does not fit into one of the categories above
- **None**
 - No additional reasons for moving

7B-L.1. PROBE: Was it easy to come up with additional reasons? If yes, did you want to report more reasons?

7B-L.2. PROBE: Were the reasons you came up with important or minor?

7B-L.3. (IF SELECTED OTHER) PROBE: Please tell me more about that.

7B-L.4. (IF THE RESPONDENT CHOSE THE SAME ANSWER AS IN THE PREVIOUS QUESTION) PROBE: Please tell me more about that —are these 2 separate reasons that fall into the same category? Or the same reason that you are repeating?

8B-L. – NXTSAMERES_10-L – IS THE PRIOR RESIDENCE THE SAME AS R10YA

Q8B-L: Other than [name]’s move to [Current address – just street], did they move another time between September 1, 2014 and today?

- Yes
- No

***** END PERSON LOOP *****

RETURN TO HH NOT LIVING WITH R – R10YA LOOP (Q1B-L) IF MORE THAN 1 HH MEMBER. ALL PROBES FOR 2 HH MEMBERS AND UNIQUE SITUATIONS FOR OTHER HH MEMBERS. **PROBE 6B-L.1 FOR ALL HH MEMEBR**
--

[END OF INSTRUMENT]

Thank you, those are all the questions that I have. Do you have any other thoughts or comments that I did not cover, that you would like to share now?

[TURN OFF THE RECORDER]

[PROVIDE INFORMATION ON RECEIVING \$40 INCENTIVE]

Appendix E. Income with Employment and Poverty: Cognitive Protocol

Revised: Sept 10, 2024

Participant ID	
Interview Date	
Time	
Interviewer	
Mode: Desktop/Laptop/Cell Phone/Tablet	
COMPUTER: Apple or PC?	
PHONE: Android or iPhone?	

My name is [INTERVIEWER NAME] and I will be conducting our research session today. I work for [RTI], a survey research company, and I am talking to you on behalf of the U.S. Census Bureau.

[IF OBSERVER IS PRESENT: I also wanted to let you know that this interview is being observed by someone from the Census Bureau. They are observing the interview because they were a part of the team that designed these questions and want to see how they are working.]

Thanks for agreeing to help us today. The purpose of today's session is to help us see how well our questions work for an online survey. We're interested in how people understand these questions and how you come up with your answers. We are not evaluating you, so there are no right or wrong answers. We are looking to see what works and what we can improve.

Before we start, I want to talk about the consent form I shared with you via email. Did you have a chance to review and sign this form? [IF NO: Can you please open the link to this form in your email?] I just want to review some of the important information that was included in that consent document:

- With your permission, I would like to record our conversation. The recording will capture completion of the survey on-screen along with the audio stream. This will allow me to concentrate on what you are saying instead of taking a lot of notes while you are talking. It will also help me write a summary of the interview.
- All your responses and everything you say will be kept strictly confidential, and only researchers working on this project will see your answers or hear the recording. Your name will not be used in any of our reports. Nothing you tell us today will be shared with other federal agencies or with anyone else.
- Your participation is voluntary, and you may stop at any time. You may choose not to answer any questions you don't want to answer.
- The interview should take about 90 minutes.
- The form also has the contact's name and telephone number of the project director, should you have any additional questions about the study. It also contains information about how to get in touch with the Institutional Review Board

representative if you have any questions about your rights as a research participant in this study.

- As a thank you for your time today, you will receive a \$40 electronic gift card immediately after we complete the interview.
- Do you agree to participate and be recorded? [IF YES – CONTINUE]

I will now begin the recording.

[SNAG-IT RECORD] AFTER THE RECORDING STARTS, ASK THE PARTICIPANT TO CONFIRM THAT THEY CONSENT TO COMPLETING THE INTERVIEW AND HAVING IT RECORDED.

Could you tell me what type of device you are using, for example, desktop, laptop, tablet, or cell phone?

[IF DESKTOP/LAPTOP]: Is it a Mac or PC?

[IF SMARTPHONE]: Is it an Android or iPhone?

Instructions:

For all questions, “Probe” is something that should be asked when the P finishes the question.

“Observe” is something that doesn’t need to be asked.

“Observe” followed by “Probe” is something that doesn’t need to be asked if the information requested is obvious through observation or think aloud. If it is not observed, then these should be asked.

If a question and its probes are repeated, the instruction reads “Probe if necessary”. If the probes were not asked before or the interviewer cannot remember if these probes were asked, ask the probe. If the person answered the probes previously, they do not need to answer them again (unless it seems like there are problems).

For all questions, note and /or probe any significant problems, comments, or behaviors that are not included in the probes, as would normally be done.

I will now provide the survey link in the chat window on Teams.

QUALTRICS LINK:

https://research.rm.census.gov/jfe/form/SV_03aOSYHBnYvCRFA

INTERVIEWER: If the participant has issues with doing this, see the instructions below. There is also a tech help document with screenshots here:

\\CBMS002FS.BOC.AD.CENSUS.GOV\cbms_share2\Inter-group Projects\CPS Projects & Info\CPS ISR\ASEC\CO11 Shared Space\Interviewer Materials\CPS\Usability - Round 1\Technology Help.docx

If you could now share your screen so I will be able to see you entering responses into the survey.

Desktop/Laptop Case: In either the middle of the screen or the top of screen, you will see a square with an arrow. Go ahead and click on that. It will then ask you what screen you want to share. You can either share the full screen or just the web page you are on.

If Mac: (If in browser) At the bottom middle of the screen, you will see a square with an arrow pointing up (if you hover on it, the button will say "Open share tray".) Click this button. It will provide a list of screens to share at the bottom of the page. Click the appropriate one for sharing the CPS instrument. (If they are using the app, the share button will be at the top righthand corner of the screen by the red "leave" button and will resemble what you see on a Windows OS.)

Mobile case:

(iPhone) In the Teams App click the button with the three dots at the bottom next to the red hang-up button. Once you click on it, the display should be expanded. At the top row you will see "Share" with a square and an arrow pointing up. You can click that button. Then select "Share screen" and make sure "Audio" is toggled on next to it. There will be a "Screen Broadcast" box the opens and you can select "Start Broadcast". It will count down and it will be sharing when the red dot is blinking. Now to go to the link you just opened as you can click anywhere outside of the Screen Broadcast box.

If Android: In the Teams App click the button with the three dots at the bottom next to the red hang-up button. Once you click on it, the display should be expanded. At the top row you will see "Share" with a square and an arrow pointing up. You can click that button. You can click that button. Then select "Share screen" and make sure "Audio" is toggled on next to it. There will be a "Screen cast" box the opens and you can select either a "Single App" or "Entire Screen" in the drop down then Press "Start". (If they choose "Single App", then they will need to select the correct browser to show the CPS instrument.)

[If able to see screen] Okay great I can see your screen. Now we can get started. As you get started, please let me know if anything is unclear or confusing with the questions. Now, please begin completing the survey. I will have a lot of follow-up questions so please wait until I instruct you to go to the next screen.

Necessary Household Questions from CPS, needed for fills (no probes)

Enter ID, date, start time, your name.

ADDRESS: What is your current physical address?

HOME: Are your living quarters...

1. Owned or being bought by you or someone in your household?
2. Rented for cash?
3. Occupied without payment of cash rent?

ROSTER: Name, age, sex for each person in household.

Intro: You will now begin the think aloud portion of the interview.

Main Questionnaire

Employment

[I: FOLLOWING FIRST PERSON IN LOOP – PROBE AS NEEDED. YOU DON'T NEED TO ASK PROBES OF INFORMATION WE ALREADY KNOW ABOUT.]

Q29a. Did you do any work for pay or profit at any time during 2023, even for one day?

- Yes – 1
- No – 2

[NOTE TO INTERVIEWER: DO NOT PROBE ON THIS QUESTION IF THE ANSWER = "NO" – ADMINISTER THE PROBES TO THE FOLLOW-UP QUESTION INSTEAD.]

[IF YES] - Probe 1: Please explain the work you did in 2023.

Probe 2: Would you answer differently, or think of different kinds of work, if the question asked about a "job or business" instead of "work"? E.g., Did you work at a job or business at any time in 2023?

Probe 3: Did you include work in 2023 that you did not get a paycheck for? E.g., manage a rental property or sell something online?

NOTE: IF THIS IS THE 2ND ADULT IN THE LOOP – AND BOTH ADULTS ANSWERED "YES" – ASK THE PARTICIPANT TO CLICK THE ARROW TO ADVANCE PAST THIS SECTION TO QUESTION TO SAVE TIME -- **Q51A1**

(If Q29a=no)

Q29b. Did you/ ^name do any temporary, part-time, or seasonal work, even for one day during 2023?

- Yes – 1
- No – 2

Probe 1: Please explain the work you did in 2023.

Probe 2: Would you answer (the previous question) differently, or think of different kinds of work, if that question asked about a "job or business" instead of "work"? E.g., Did you work at a job or business at any time in 2023?

Probe 3: Did you include work in 2023 that you did not get a paycheck for? For example, manage a rental property or sell something online?

Q30. Did you/ ^name spend any time trying to find a job or on layoff during 2023?

- Yes - 1
- No – 2

Probe 1: How did you interpret 'on layoff'? were you confused by this term?

[NOTE TO INTERVIEWER: "ON LAYOFF" IS DIFFERENT THAN "LAID OFF". ON LAYOFF MEANS THEY WILL BE CALLED BACK TO WORK].

Q31. How many weeks in total were you/they looking for work or on layoff in 2023?

_____ weeks
[] all weeks in 2023

Probe 1: How did you count the number of weeks looking for work or on layoff? Probe if counted partial week(s)

[IF THEY USED CHECKBOX] Probe 2: Why did you select the check box rather than put in 52 weeks?

[IF THEY **DID NOT USE** CHECKBOX] Probe 3: Do you know how many weeks are in a year? Or are you a little uncertain?

[NOTE TO INTERVIEWER: WE WANT TO KNOW IF PEOPLE KNOW HOW MANY WEEKS ARE IN A YEAR, OR IF WE NEED TO REMIND THEM.]

(If Q29b is no, did not work in 2023)

Q32. What was the main reason you/ ^name did not work in 2023?

- Temporary injury, illness, or other health concern - 1
- Chronic health condition or disability - 2
- Retired - 3
- Pregnancy or childbirth - 4
- Taking care of children or others - 5
- Going to school - 6
- Unable to find work - 7
- On layoff - 8
- Not interested in working - 9
- Some other reason - 10

Probe 1: How did you decide which response option to choose? How did you decide on the “main” reason if multiple reason applied?

Probe 2: Are any of the options unclear or confusing?

If “Some other reason”: You selected “Some other reason”: Probe 3: Please provide the other reason:

If choose “temporary illness”: You selected “temporary illness”: Probe 4: Can you tell me how long the illness lasted?

Q33. During 2023, how many weeks did you/ ^name do any work, even for a few hours? Include paid vacation and sick leave as work.

_____ weeks

[] all weeks in 2023

[IF P USED THE CHECKBOX] Probe 1: Why did you select the check box rather than enter “52 weeks”?

If Q33 equal to 50 or 51 weeks. Worked almost all weeks.)

Q35. Did you/ ^name lose any full weeks of work in 2023 because you/they were on layoff from a job or lost a job?

- Yes
- No

[Observe: Did participant misreport weeks of work in the previous question because they missed the instruction about vacation, or some other reason.] Probe 1: Do you recall whether you saw the instruction to include paid vacation and sick leave as work in the previous question?

[IF CHECKBOX USED IN PREVIOUS QUESTION] – Probe 2: Why did you select the check box rather than enter 52 weeks?

[IF CHECKBOX **NOT USED** IN PREVIOUS QUESTION] – Probe 3: Can you tell me how many weeks of work are in a year?

[NOTE TO INTERVIEWER: WE WANT TO KNOW IF PEOPLE KNOW HOW MANY WEEKS ARE IN A YEAR, OR IF WE NEED TO REMIND THEM.]

Probe 4: In the previous question, how did you remember/ count the number of weeks that you worked?

Probe 5: How did you interpret 'on layoff'? were you confused by this term? Do you know that it's different from laid off?

[NOTE TO INTERVIEWER: ON LAYOFF IS DIFFERENT THAN LAID OFF. ON LAYOFF MEANS THEY WILL BE CALLED BACK TO WORK.]

Probe 6: Did you notice the instruction to report "full" weeks only? Did you report any partial weeks?

Probe 7: What does "lost a job" mean to you?

(If Q33 Less than 50 weeks. Worked less than 50 weeks)

Q36. Of the remaining [fill 52- minus previous answer] weeks, how many full weeks were you / ^name on layoff or looking for a job?
_____weeks

[Observe: Did participant misreport weeks of work in the previous question because they missed the instruction about vacation, or some other reason] Probe 1: Do you recall whether you saw the instruction to include paid vacation and sick leave as work in the previous question?

[IF CHECKBOX USED IN PREVIOUS QUESTION] – Probe 2: Why did you select the check box rather than enter 52 weeks?

[IF CHECKBOX **NOT USED** IN PREVIOUS QUESTION] – Probe 3: Can you tell me how many weeks of work are in a year?

Probe 4: In the previous question, how did you remember/ count the number of weeks that you worked?

Probe 5: How did you interpret 'on layoff'? were you confused by this term? Do you know it's different than laid off?

[NOTE TO INTERVIEWER: ON LAYOFF IS DIFFERENT THAN LAID OFF. ON LAYOFF MEANS THEY WILL BE CALLED BACK TO WORK.]

(If answer > 0): Probe 6: Did you notice the instruction to report “full” weeks only? Did you report any partial weeks?
(If answer = 0): Probe 7: Why did you answer zero? Could you tell me what you were doing in those weeks while not working?

(If Q36 greater than 1 week. On lay off or looking for 2+ weeks.)

Q37. Were the [number from Q36] weeks you/they were looking for work all in one stretch?

- Yes
- No

Probe 1: Does “stretches” make sense? Does “all at once” work better?
(If Q37 = yes) Probe 2: How many stretches?

(Q36 is equal to 0 or 1 week. (This is for people who were mostly not looking for work.))

Q38. During the weeks you/they were not working, what was the main reason?

- Temporary injury, illness, or other health concern - 1
- Chronic health condition or disability - 2
- Retired - 3
- Pregnancy or childbirth - 4
- Taking care of children or other persons - 5
- Going to school - 6
- Not interested in working - 7
- Some other reason - 8

Probe 1: How did you decide which response option to choose? How did you decide on the “main” reason if multiple reason applied?

Probe 2: Are any of the options unclear or confusing?

(If “Some other reason”): Probe 3: You selected “some other reason” – could you tell me more about that? What were the reasons?

(If choose “temporary illness”): Probe 4: You selected “temporary illness” – could you tell me a little about that? Did this linger most of the year?

Probe 5: Were there any periods when you were “in between jobs” in the sense that you had another job, but it wasn’t starting yet?

- (If yes): Probe 6: How did you answer this question for that situation?
- (If no): Probe 7: Thinking of this scenario – “in between jobs” but you had another job that it wasn’t starting yet - How would you answer this question?

Q39. For how many employers did you/ ^name work in 2023? If you worked for more than one employer at the same time, only count it as one employer.

- One
- Two
- Three or more

[Observe: Did the P read the instruction? (2nd sentence) - (If not read aloud or mentioned)]: Probe 1: Did you notice and read the second sentence?

(If >= Two) Probe 2: Did you have any weeks where you worked for more than one employer at the same time?

(If yes): Probe 3: How did you count those employers?

Q41. In the [fill # week/weeks form Q33] that you/ ^name worked, how many hours did you / they usually work per week?

_____ hours

[INTERVIEWER: NOTE THAT IF THEY CHECKED "ALL WEEKS IN 2023" – THE QUESTION FILL IS AWKWARD. LET P KNOW THAT WE ARE AWARE OF THE ISSUE.]

Probe 1: Do you work the same number of hours each week?

Probe 2: Do you work more than one job?

(If yes): Probe 3: How did you determine the usual number of hours to report?

Q43. Were there one or more weeks where you/ ^name worked less than 35 hours?

Do not count time off with pay like holidays, vacation, or sick leave.

- Yes – 1
- No – 2

(If no) [Observe: Did they read the instruction? (2nd sentence)] Probe 1: Did you see the second sentence? Did you have any weeks where you were on holidays, vacation, or sick leave? (IF YES) Did you consider this when answering the question?

Q44. How many weeks did you/they work less than 35 hours?

_____ weeks

[Observe: Did they remember the instruction about not counting time off with pay?] Probe 1: Did you have any weeks where you counted time off with pay like holidays, vacation, or sick leave?

Q45. What was the main reason you / ^name worked less than 35 hours per week?

- Job was part-time - 1
- Seasonal work - 2
- Business was slow - 3
- Weather conditions - 4
- Physically unable to work full time -5
- Caring for family or personal obligation -7
- Some other reason - 8

Probe 1: How did you decide which response option to choose? How did you decide on the "main" reason if multiple reason applied?

Probe 2: Are any of the options unclear or confusing?

[If "Some other reason"]: Probe 3: What is the other reason(s)?

Q45a. Why were you/they physically unable to work full time?

- Injury
- Short-term illness
- Chronic health condition or disability
- Some other reason

[If "Some other reason"]: Probe 1: You selected "Some other reason, what was the reason or reasons?

Probe 2: Where would you include mental or emotional health reasons?

Q47a. What employer did (name/you) work for the longest in 2023?

Employer name: _____

[If they work in more than one employer in 2023] Probe 1: How did you determine which employer you worked for the longest?

[NOTE TO INTERVIEWER – NEXT QUESTIONS ARE RANDOMIZED: HALF OF PARTICIPANTS GET THE Q47 SERIES FIRST (Q47E1 – Q47E1C) AND HALF GET Q48A FIRST. EVERYONE SHOULD GET ALL OF THE QUESTIONS, BUT WE DON'T WANT WHAT THEY SEE FIRST TO INFLUENCE THEIR PREFERENCE.]

[PROVIDE TO PARTICIPANT] We would not like to get your input on a few questions. The questions are similar, but we would like to know which format you prefer.

Q47e1. Which best describes {Employer Name from Q47a}?

- Government - 1
- Private for-profit company - 2
- Non-profit organization including tax exempt and charitable organizations - 3
- Self-employed - 4
- Family business - 5

[If P considered or chose Non-profit]: Probe 1: Did you read/need the additional text “including tax exempt and charitable organizations”? or is “non-profit organization” enough?

Probe 2: Did more than one response options apply? Which ones? How did you choose what “best” describes this employer?

(Q47e1 = Government)

Q47e1a. Which one of the following best describes {Employer Name from Q47a}?

- Federal - (Federal government civilian employee) - 1
- Active Duty (U.S. Armed Forces or Commissioned Corps) - 2
- State (including state colleges/universities) - 3
- Local (county, city, township) (city or county school district) - 4

Probe 1: Do you need the extra information in the parentheses to find the right response?

[If they work for the government/ not active duty] Probe 2: Do you automatically know if it’s federal, state, or local? Do you need the extra information?

Q47e1b. Was {employer name from Q47a} incorporated?

- Yes
 - No
-

Q47e1c. Were/Was you/ ^name the owner of {employer name from Q47a}?

- Yes - 1
 - No - 2
-

Q47e1_combined. Which one of the following best describes {Employer Name from Q47a}?

- For-profit company or organization
- Non-profit organization (including tax-exempt and charitable organizations)
- Local government (for example: city or county school district)
- State government (including state colleges/universities)
- Active-Duty U.S. Armed Forces or Commissioned Corps service
- Federal government civilian employee
- Own non-incorporated business, professional practice, or farm
- Own incorporated business, professional practice, or farm
- Worked without pay in a for-profit family business or farm for 15 hours or more per week

[Observe: How much of this list are the participants reading?]

Probe 1: How easy or difficult is it to find the best response?

TEST Q.

AFTER BOTH CLASS OF WORKER QUESTIONS ARE ASKED:

We just provided two versions of the same question.

Probe 1: Which version do you prefer?

[INTERVIEWER: HAVE P BACK UP TO REVIEW SCREENS IF NEEDED]

Q4788. Counting all locations where {Name's employer} operates, what was the total number of employees in 2023?

- 1- 9
 - 10-49
 - 50-99
 - 100-499
 - 500-999
 - 1,000+ or more
-

Q47b. What kind of business or industry is {Employer Name from Q47a}?

Include the main activity, product, or service provided at the location where employed. (For example: elementary school, residential construction)

Kind of Business: _____

Probe 1: Were multiple products or services provided by the business you work for?

(If yes): Probe 2: How did you decide what to respond?

Q47b1. Is this business or organization mainly manufacturing, retail trade, wholesale trade, or something else?

- Manufacturing
- Retail trade
- Wholesale trade
- Something else

Q47c. What kind of work were you/they doing at {employer name from Q47a}?

For example: 4th grade teacher, entry-level plumber

Main Occupation: _____

[Observe: What do people report when they do not have an official job title? Do they know how to answer?]

Q47d1. What were your/their most important activities or duties?

For example: instruct and evaluate students and create lesson plans, assemble and install pipe sections and review building plans for work details.

Job Duties: _____

Probe 1: Did you provide all your duties and duties in general? Or the most important?

Probe 2: How did you decide what was most important?

Probe 3: Was there a reason for the order in which you listed the duties? For example, the first activities were what you spend the most time on?

Income

Earned Income

[Continue loop from I&O's section – everyone who said they worked and told us their main job]

Q48a_source

Select all the types of income that (^name/you) received from [fill employer] during 2023.

- 1 Salary or wages
- 2 Tips
- 3 Bonuses
- 4 Overtime pay
- 5 Commissions

Probe 1: Did you have any trouble differentiating between these types of income? Was there anything missing?

[If selected "Tips" or "Commissions"]: Probe 2: Do you consider Tips / Commissions as income from your employer?

Q48a_amount

Default screen:

Enter the total amount (^name/you) received, before taxes and other deductions, from this employer in 2023.

	amount
(^earnings source fill from Q48a_source)	\$____.00

Total:

[] I want to report monthly or in a different way.

[If **P** checked to report differently in the default screen, they will receive Q48_per.]

Q48_per

Alternate screen:

Enter the amount (^name/you) received, before taxes and other deductions, from this employer in 2023.

	Per amount	Number of payments
(^earnings source fill from Q48a_source)	\$____.00	____(drop down)

[Observe: Did participant report amounts for the right periodicity (e.g. year)?]

Probe 1: Just to confirm, you entered [\$] per [Week/Month/Year] – Is that correct?

[Observe: Where did participants struggle with the data entry, especially the check box and follow-up question with the grid.] Probe 2: Did you have any challenges entering the information into this grid?

Probe 3: Were some of these types of income hard to report separately? Would you prefer to report some of these together?

Probe 4: Would you have preferred to be asked how you want to report the amounts (bi-weekly, monthly, etc.) first?

Probe 5: Was it clear what the checkbox was there for?

Probe 6: Did you find the format of this question(s) easy to understand? Would you change anything to make it easier?

Probe 7: Did seeing the total amount help you catch errors? Was this total meaningful to you (i.e. does the participant have a sense of what the total is to judge if there is an error?)

Q48b_amount

Universe: participants indicated being self-employed in I&O section

Default screen:

Enter (^name's/your) gross earnings (earnings before expenses) and expenses for {fill business name} in 2023.

Gross Earnings	Expenses	Total
\$____.00	\$____.00	_____

[Observe: Did participant report amounts for the right periodicity (e.g. year)]

Probe 1: Just to confirm, you entered [\$] per year– Is that correct?

Observe: Where did participant struggle with the data entry, especially the check box and follow-up question with the grid.] Probe 2: Did you have any challenges entering the information into this grid?

Probe 3: Would you have preferred to be asked how you want to report the amounts (bi-weekly, monthly, etc.) first?

Probe 4: Is reporting gross earnings and expenses easier than just reporting the net earnings?

Probe 5: Did seeing the total amount help you catch errors? Was this total meaningful to you (i.e. does the participant have a sense of what the total is in order to judge if there is an error?)

[NOTE TO INTERVIEWER:

- FOR LOOPS ASKING ABOUT MORE THAN ONE PERSON, ONLY PROBE THE ADDITIONAL PEOPLE IF P IS HAVING TROUBLE FITTING THE

SCENARIO INTO A RESPONSE. DO NOT ASK PROBES THAT THEY'VE ALREADY ANSWERED.

- DON'T PROBE IF THEY SIMPLY DON'T KNOW THE INFORMATION FOR SOMEONE ELSE BUT KEEP A ROUGH TRACK OF THE QUESTIONS THAT WERE HARDEST TO PROXY REPORT.]

END OF I&O + EARNED INCOME LOOP

Income Sources

Unemployment Compensation (Source)

Q51A1. Which of these unemployment benefits, if any, did (^you/anyone in this household) receive in 2023?

Select all that apply.

- 1 State or Federal unemployment compensation
- 2 Supplemental Unemployment Benefits (SUB)
- 3 Union Unemployment or Strike Benefits
- 4 None of the above

Probe 1: How confident are you in your responses for yourself? For others?

Q51A1b. Who received (^FILL FROM Q51A1)?

Select all that apply.

<List of household members who are ages 15 and over>

Workers Compensation (Source)

Q52A. Which of these types of income, if any, did (^you/anyone in this household) receive as a result of a job-related injury or illness in 2023? Exclude sick pay and disability retirement.

Select all that apply.

- 1 State Worker's Compensation
- 2 Employer or employer's insurance worker's compensation
- 3 Own insurance worker's compensation
- 4 Other payments as a result of a job-related injury or illness
- 5 None of the above

Probe 1: Did you understand each of the response options?

Probe 2: Was "own insurance worker's compensation" (#3) clear to you?

[If select Other payments....] Probe 3: Could you tell me more about your response?

Who received (^FILL FROM Q52A)?

Select all that apply.

<List of household members who are ages 15 and over>

Social Security (Source)

Q56a. In 2023, did (^you/anyone in this household) receive any Social Security payments from the U.S. Government?

- 1 Yes
 - 2 No
-

Q56b. Who received Social Security payments either for themselves or as combined payments with other family members?

Select all that apply.

<List of all household members>

Probe 1: Did you understand that this is a follow up to the previous question, still asking about the same topic?

SSR. What were the reasons (^name/you) (^was/were) getting Social Security in 2023?

Select all that apply.

- 1 Retired
- 2 Disabled
- 3 Widowed
- 4 Spouse
- 5 Surviving child
- 6 Dependent child
- 7 Other

Probe 1: Did you have any trouble choosing a response?
[If other selected] Probe 2: Please explain the other reason.

SSCR. What were the reasons (^Child's name/the children) (^was/were) getting Social Security in 2023?

Select all that apply.

- 1 Disabled
- 2 Surviving child
- 3 Dependent child
- 4 Other

Probe 1: Did you have any trouble choosing a response?
[If other selected] Probe 2: Please explain the other reason.

Q56g: Which parent or guardian received these Social Security benefits on behalf of a child?

<List of household members who are 19 years old and over>

Probe 1: Did you understand that we are talking about children already reported as receiving SS in the previous questions?

SSDIa1. Did (^name/you) receive (^your/their) first Social Security Disability payment in 2023?

- 1 Yes
- 2 No

Q56f. Is there anyone in this household, who we have not already counted, who received Social Security income in 2023 on behalf of any children in this household? Include all children under 19 years of age.

- 1 Yes
- 2 No

[If answered yes] Probe 1: Did you forget to report this recipient earlier?

Probe 2: Did this question feel repetitive, like you've answered it before?

CSS. Which children under age 19 were receiving Social Security in 2023?

Select all that apply.

<List of household members who are under age 19>

Q56g2. Which parent or guardian received these Social Security benefits on behalf of a child?

Select all that apply.

<List of household members who are age 19 or older>

CRSS. What was the reason (^Child's name) was getting Social Security in 2023?

Select all that apply.

- 1 Disabled child
- 2 Surviving child
- 3 Dependent child
- 4 Other

Supplemental Security Income (SSI) (Source)

Q57a: In 2023, did (^you/ anyone in this household) receive any SSI payments (Supplemental Security Income)?

SSI payments are assistance payments to low-income aged, blind and disabled persons, and come from state or local welfare offices, the Federal government, or both.

- 1 Yes
- 2 No

Probe 1: Did you read the definition under the question? Was it helpful? Necessary?

Q57b. Who received SSI (Supplemental Security Income)?

Select all that apply.

<List of household members who are ages 15 and over>

SSIR: What were the reasons (^name/you) (^was/were) getting SSI (Supplemental Security Income) in 2023?

Select all that apply.

- 1 Disabled
 - 2 Blind
 - 3 On behalf of a disabled child
 - 4 On behalf of a blind child
 - 5 Other
-

Q57d: Is there anyone in this household, who we have not already counted, who received Supplemental Security Income in 2023 on behalf of any children in this household?

- 1 Yes
- 2 No

[If answered "Yes"] – Probe 1: Did you forget to report this recipient earlier?

Probe 2: Did this question feel repetitive, like you've answered it before?

Q57e. Which parent or guardian received these Supplemental Security Income payments on behalf of a child?

Select all that apply.

<List of household members who are parent/guardian to a child in the household>

RSSI. What were the reasons (^name/you) (^was/were) getting Supplemental Security Income on behalf of a child in 2023?

Select all that apply.

- 1 Disabled child/children
 - 2 Blind child/children
 - 3 Other
-

CSSI. Which children under age 19 were receiving Supplemental Security Income in 2023?

Select all that apply.

<List of household members who are under age 19>

Disability Income (Source)

Q59AR. During 2023, did (^you/anyone in the household) have a disability or health problem which prevented (^you/them) from working, even for a short time, or limited the work (^you/they) could do?

- 1 Yes
 - 2 No
-

Q59b. Who had a disability or health problem which prevented or limited their work in 2023?

Select all that apply.

<List of household members who are ages 15 and over>

Q60a. (^Did you/Is there anyone in this household who) ever (^retire or leave/retired or left) a job for health reasons?

- 1 Yes
 - 2 No
-

Q60b: Who retired or left a job for health reasons in 2023?

Select all that apply.

<List of household members who are ages 15 and over>

Q61C. In 2023, which sources of income, if any, did (^you/name) receive due to a disability or health problem?

Select all that apply.

- 1 Worker's compensation
- 2 Company or union disability
- 3 Federal government (Civil service) disability
- 4 U.S. Military retirement disability
- 5 State or local government employee disability
- 6 U.S. Railroad retirement disability
- 7 Accident or disability insurance
- 8 Black Lung miner's disability
- 9 State temporary sickness
- 10 Other source
- 11 None of the above

[Observe: Did participant read all of the options or just the first few?]

[Observe: Did participant who did not have any disability income find/use the "none" option?]

Probe 1: Were any of the response options confusing or unclear?

[If selected Other] Probe 2: Please explain the other source.

Veterans Payments (Source)

Q60A88. Which sources of Veteran's (VA) payments, if any, did (^you/anyone in this household) receive in 2023? Include assistance received by children of veterans.

Select all that apply.

- 1 Service-connected disability compensation
- 2 Survivor benefits
- 3 Veterans' pension
- 4 Educational assistance (including assistance received by children of veterans)
- 5 Other Veterans' payments
- 6 None of the above

Probe 1: Were any of the response options confusing or unclear?

[If selected Other] Probe 2: Please explain the other payment.

Q60b_88. Who received the (^FILL FROM Q60A88) either for themselves or as combined payments with other family members?

Select all that apply.

<List of household members who are ages 15 and over>

Q60D88. (^Are/Is) (^name/you) required to fill out an annual income questionnaire for the Department of Veterans' Affairs?

- 1 Yes
- 2 No

Survivor Benefits (Source)

Q58a. Which types of survivor benefits, if any, did (^anyone in this household/you) receive in 2023? Exclude Social Security and VA benefits.

Select all that apply.

- 1 Company or union survivor pension (include profit sharing)
- 2 Federal government survivor (Civil service) pension
- 3 U.S. Military retirement survivor pension
- 4 State or local government survivor pension
- 5 U.S. Railroad retirement survivor pension
- 6 Worker's compensation survivor pension
- 7 Black Lung survivor pension
- 8 Regular payments from estates or trusts
- 9 Regular payments from annuities or paid-up insurance policies
- 10 Other type of survivor benefits
- 11 None of the above

[Observe: Did P read all the options or just the first few?]

[Observe: Did P who did not have any disability income find/use the "none" option?]

Probe 1: Were any of the response options confusing or unclear?

[If selected Other] Probe 2: Please explain the other benefit.

Q58b. Who received the (^FILL FROM Q58a)?

Select all that apply.

<List of household members who are ages 15 and over>

Public Assistance (Source)

Q59A88. Which types of cash assistance, if any, did (^anyone in this household/you) receive in 2023?

Select all that apply.

- 1 (^State Program Name)/Temporary Assistance to Needy Families (TANF)/welfare/Aid to Families
- 2 General assistance
- 3 Emergency assistance/short-term cash assistance
- 4 Diversion payments
- 5 Refugee Cash and Medical Assistance program
- 6 General Assistance from Bureau of Indian Affairs, or Tribal Administered General Assistance
- 7 Some other program
- 8 None of the above

[Observe: Did P read all the options or just the first few?]

[Observe: Did P who did not have any disability income find/use the “none” option?]

Probe 1: Were any of the response options confusing or unclear?

[If selected Other] Probe 2: Please explain the other program.

Q59A89. Which types of cash assistance, if any, did (^anyone in this household/you) receive on behalf of children in the household in 2023? Do not include Food Stamps (SNAP), SSI, Energy Assistance, WIC, School meals, Childcare, and Education Assistance.

Select all that apply.

- 1 TANF
- 2 General assistance
- 3 Emergency assistance/short-term cash assistance
- 4 Diversion payments
- 5 Refugee Cash and Medical Assistance program
- 6 General Assistance from Bureau of Indian Affairs, or Tribal Administered General Assistance
- 7 Some other program
- 8 None of the above

Probe 1: Was the “do not include” instruction helpful?

[If selected Other] Probe 2: Please explain the other program.

Q59b_88. Who received {fill type of cash assistance}?

Select all that apply.

<List of household members who are ages 15 and over>

Pensions (Source)

Q62Ar. Which types of pension income, if any, did (^anyone in this household/you) receive in 2023?

Do not include distributions or withdrawals from IRAs, 401(k)s, or similar accounts.

Select all that apply.

- 1 Company
- 2 Union
- 3 Federal government
- 4 State government
- 5 Local government
- 6 U.S. Military
- 7 U.S. Railroad retirement
- 8 Other type of pension
- 9 None of the above

[Observe: Did P read all of the options or just the first few?]

[Observe: Did P who did not have any disability income find/use the “none” option?]

Probe 1: Were any of the response options confusing or unclear?

[If selected Other] Probe 2: Please explain the other type of pension.

Q62b. Who received income from a (^FILL FROM Q62Ar) pension?

Select all that apply.

<List of household members who are ages 15 and over>

Annuities (Source)

Q96Ar. In 2023, did (^you/ anyone in this household) receive any income from an annuity?

- 1 Yes
 - 2 No
-

Q96Br. Who received annuity income?

Select all that apply.

<List of household members who are ages 15 and over>

INTERVIEWER: NOTE THAT RESPONSES TO THIS QUESTION WILL DETERMINE WHICH DOWNSTREAM QUESTIONS Ps WILL RECEIVE.

Retirement Accounts (Source)

Q97Ar. In 2023, which types of retirement accounts, if any, did (^you/anyone in this household) have that were designated specifically for retirement savings?

Select all that apply.

- 1 401(k)
- 2 403(b)
- 3 Roth IRA
- 4 Regular IRA
- 5 KEOGH plan
- 6 SEP plan (Simplified Employee Pension)
- 7 Other type of retirement account
- 8 None of the above

Probe 1: Was the end of the question, "...designated specifically for retirement savings", clear to you or not?

Probe 2: Were any of the response options confusing or unclear?

[If selected Other] Probe 3: Please explain the other type of retirement account.

Q97Br. Who had a (^FILL FROM Q97Ar)?

Select all that apply.

<List of household members who are ages 15 and over>

Q98Ar. Did (^you/NAME) withdraw any money or receive a distribution from (^your/their) (^FILL FROM Q97AR) in 2023, including any distributions (^you/they) may have been required to take?

- 1 Yes
 - 2 No
-

Employers Pension Plan

Q74a. Did any employer or union that (^name/you) worked for in 2023 offer a pension plan to any of its employees?

- 1 Yes
- 2 No

Probe 1: What do you think we mean by “pension plan”? Can you provide some examples? (is the participant including 401ks, etc.?)

[If Q74a=no] Probe 2: Do you feel that you can answer this question for all types of employees at your workplace (union, non-union, contractual, permanent, etc.)?

Q74a2. Were/was you/name eligible to participate in the pension plan?

- 1 Yes
- 2 No

Probe 1: Is everyone eligible or just certain employees?

Q74b: Did (^name/you) participate in the pension plan?

- 1 Yes
 - 2 No
-

Income-Earnings Accounts Outside of Retirement (Source)

Q99Ar. Besides retirement accounts, in 2023, which types of assets, if any, did (^you/anyone in this household) have that may have paid interest?

Select all that apply.

- 1 Interest-earning checking account
- 2 Savings account
- 3 CD (certificate of deposit)
- 4 Savings bond
- 5 Other savings or investments that pay interest
- 6 None of the above

Probe 1: Were any of the response options confusing or unclear?

[If selected Other] Probe 2: Please explain the other savings or investments that pay interest.

[If selected None] Probe 3: Do you have any bank accounts?

[If yes] - Probe 4: Do any of them earn interest, even if it's very low?

Q99Ba. Who had the (^FILL FROM Q99Ar)? For joint accounts, include each person.

Select all that apply.

<List of household members who are ages 15 and over>

Probe 1: Is the instruction about joint accounts clear?

[IF SOME HH MEMBERS LISTED BUT NOT ALL] - Probe 2: Were there other household members that you wanted to report who didn't appear on the list?

Q99Arf. In 2023, which types of assets did (^you/ anyone in this household) have that pay dividends?

Select all that apply.

- 1 Shares of stock in corporations
- 2 Mutual funds
- 3 Other savings or investments that pay dividends
- 4 None of the above

Probe 1: How confident are you in your understanding of dividends? What about interest? Do you feel these are the same or not?

Probe 2: Were any of the response options confusing or unclear?

Probe 3: How confident were you in your responses for others in the household?

[If selected Other] - Probe 4: Could you tell me why you selected "Other savings or investments that pay dividends"?

Q99Bf. Who had (^FILL FROM Q99Arf)? For joint accounts, include each person.

Select all that apply.

<List of household members who are ages 15 and over>

[If not asked previously]: Probe 1: Is the instruction about joint accounts clear?

CAPGDIS. Did (^you/NAME) receive any capital gains from (^your/their) (^FILL FROM Q99Arf) in 2023?

- 1 Yes
- 2 No

Probe 1: How confident are you in your understanding of capital gains?

Probe 2: Is this something you knew (whether you had cap gains or not) for this account?

Property Income (Source)

Q65A2. Which types of income, if any, did (^name/you) receive in 2023?

Select all that apply.

- 1 Royalties
- 2 Rent
- 3 Income from roomers or boarders (exclude amounts paid by relatives)
- 4 Income from estates or trusts (exclude estates or trusts already reported)
- 5 None of the above

Probe 1: Were any of the response options confusing or unclear?

Probe 2: Did you read the instructions in parentheses? Were they helpful?

Q65b. (royalties, rent, roomers, estate). Who received the (^FILL FROM Q65A2)? For joint ownership, include each person.

Select all that apply.

<List of household members who are ages 15 and over>

Probe 1: Is the instruction about joint ownership clear?

Probe 2: Did you want to report anyone not listed?

Education Assistance (Source)

Q66a. In 2023, did (^you/anyone in this household) attend school beyond the high school level including a college, university, vocational, business, or trade school?

- 1 Yes
- 2 No

Probe 1: Was the language “beyond the high school level” clear to you?

NQ66bd. Which types of educational assistance, if any, did (^anyone in this household/you) receive for tuition, fees, books, or living expenses in 2023?

Do not include VA educational benefits.

Select all that apply.

- 1 Pell Grant
- 2 Assistance from a welfare or social service office
- 3 Other government assistance
- 4 Scholarships, grants, etc.
- 5 Other assistance (employers, friends, etc.)
- 6 None of the above

Probe 1: Were any of the response options confusing or unclear?

[If selected “Other govt” or “Other assistance”] Probe 2: Please explain why you selected [Other government assistance] [Other assistance]?

Q66c. Who received the (^FILL FROM Q66b)?

Select all that apply.

<List of household members who are ages 15 and over>

Child Support (Source)

Q70a. In 2023, did (^you/anyone in this household) receive any child support payments?

- 1 Yes
 - 2 No
-

Q70b. Who received these child support payments?

Select all that apply.

<List of household members who are ages 15 and over>

Regular Financial Assistance (Source)

Q72a. In 2023, did (^you/anyone in this household) receive (^any other/any) regular financial assistance from friends or relatives not living in this household?

Do not include amounts that must be paid back.

- 1 Yes
- 2 No

[Observe: Did P read the “Do not include” instruction and follow it?] Probe 1: Did you see the instruction in italics? Did you take that into consideration when responding to this question?

Q72b. Who received this regular financial assistance?

<List of household members who are ages 15 and over>

Other Money Income (Source)

Q73A1R. Which types of other income, if any, did (^anyone in the household/you) receive in 2023?

Select all that apply.

- 1 Income from Alaska Permanent Fund
- 2 Income from foster child care
- 3 Income from alimony
- 4 Income from jury duty
- 5 Income from armed forces reserves
- 6 Income from severance pay
- 7 Income from hobbies
- 8 Income from other sources
- 9 None

Probe 1: Were any of the response options confusing or unclear?

Probe 2: What does “hobbies” mean to you?

[If selected Other] – Probe 3: Please explain the income from other sources.

Q73A1b. Who received (^FILL FROM Q73A1R)?

Select all that apply.

<List of household members who are ages 15 and over>

Income Amounts

New unemployment amount question (Q59 series):

[Universe: anyone selected in Q51A1b; loop through Q59 for each person selected in Q51A1b]

Q59amt. Default screen: Enter the amount you received each month from {unemployment fill} in 2023.

	Number of payments	Amount Total
(^unemployment source fill from Q51A1)	_____	\$____.00

[] I want to report yearly or in a different way.

Q59_alt. Alternative screen: Enter the amount you received from {unemployment fill} in 2023.

	Amount Total	Choose Frequency	Number of payments
(^unemployment source fill from Q51A1)	\$____.00	____(drop down)	_____

[INTERVIEWER – WE WILL USE THE SAME PROBES FOR ALL INCOME AMOUNT QUESTIONS. THESE ARE DISPLAYED UNDER EACH INCOME CATEGORY. ASK AS NECESSARY UNLESS YOU HAVE ALREADY ASKED THE PROBES AND KNOW THE RESPONSES. THESE ARE MORE LIKE USABILITY PROBES. WE PROBED ON COMPREHENSION IN THE EARLIER SECTION.]

[Observe: Did P report amounts for the right periodicity (e.g. month)?] Probe 1: Just to confirm, you selected [\$] per [Week/Month/Year], is that correct?

[Observe: Where did P struggle with the data entry, especially the check box and follow-up question with the grid.] Probe 2: Did you have any challenges completing this grid? Explain.

Probe 3: Would you have preferred to be asked how you want to report the amounts (bi-weekly, monthly, yearly) first?

Probe 4: Was it clear what the checkbox was there for?

Probe 5: Did you find the format of this question(s) easy to understand? Would you change anything to make it easier? **[Ask this especially if they received the grid]**

Probe 6: Was there some amount you wanted to include and then didn't? What was it?

Probe 7: Did seeing the total amount help you catch errors?

[If Yes] Probe 8: Was this total meaningful to you?

(Note: Does participant have a sense of what the total is to judge if there is an error?)

New workers compensation (Q52 series):**(Universe: loop through this question for anyone selected in Q52Ab)****Q52amt. Enter the amount of state worker's compensation (^name/you) received in 2023.**

	amount	payments
Worker's compensation	\$____.00	_____

[Observe: Did P report amounts for the right periodicity (e.g. month)?] Probe 1: Just to confirm, you selected [\$] per [Week/Month/Year], is that correct?

[Observe: Where did P struggle with the data entry, especially the check box and follow-up question with the grid.] Probe 2: Did you have any challenges completing this grid? Explain.

Probe 3: Would you have preferred to be asked how you want to report the amounts (bi-weekly, monthly, yearly) first?

Probe 4: Did you find the format of this question(s) easy to understand? Would you change anything to make it easier? **[Ask this especially if they received the grid]**

Probe 5: Was there some amount you wanted to include and then didn't? What was it?

Probe 6: Did seeing the total amount help you catch errors?

[If Yes] Probe 7: Was this total meaningful to you?

(Note: Does participant have a sense of what the total is to judge if there is an error?)

New Social Security (Q56 series):**(Universe: loop for anyone selected in Q56b)****Q56amt. Default screen: Enter the amount of Social Security received each month and the number of payments in 2023.**

	amount	Number of payments	Total
Social Security	\$____.00	_____	_____

[] I want to report yearly or in a different way.

Q56amt_alt. Alternative screen: For {Name}, enter the amount of Social Security received each month and the number of payments in 2023.

	amount	per	Number of payments	Total
Social Security	\$____.00	____(drop down)	_____	_____

[Observe: Did P report amounts for the right periodicity (e.g. month)?] Probe 1: Just to confirm, you selected [\$] per [Week/Month/Year], is that correct?

[Observe: Where did P struggle with the data entry, especially the check box and follow-up question with the grid.] Probe 2: Did you have any challenges completing this grid? Explain.

Probe 3: Was it clear what the checkbox was there for?

Probe 4: Did you find the format of this question(s) easy to understand? Would you change anything to make it easier? **[Ask this especially if they received the grid]**

Probe 5: Was there some amount you wanted to include and then didn't? What was it?

Probe 6: Did seeing the total amount help you catch errors?

[If Yes] Probe 7: Was this total meaningful to you?

(Note: Does participant have a sense of what the total is to judge if there is an error?)

New Social Security Disability (Q562 series):

(Universe: SSR = 2)

Q562. Default screen: For {name fill}, enter the amount of Social Security Disability received each month and the number of payments in 2023.

	amount	Number of payments	Total
For: {fill name}			
Social Security Disability	\$____.00	_____	_____

[] I want to report yearly or in a different way.

Q562_alt. Alternative screen: For {name fill}, enter the amount of Social Security Disability received each month and the number of payments in 2023.

	amount	Frequency	Number of payments	Total
Social Security Disability	\$____.00	____(drop down)	_____	_____

[Observe: Did P report amounts for the right periodicity (e.g. month)?] Probe 1: Just to confirm, you selected [\$] per [Week/Month/Year], is that correct?

[Observe: Where did P struggle with the data entry, especially the check box and follow-up question with the grid.] Probe 2: Did you have any challenges completing this grid? Explain.

Probe 3: Would you have preferred to be asked how you want to report the amounts (bi-weekly, monthly, yearly) first?

Probe 4: Was it clear what the checkbox was there for?

Probe 5: Did you find the format of this question(s) easy to understand? Would you change anything to make it easier? **[Ask this especially if they received the grid]**

Probe 6: Was there some amount you wanted to include and then didn't? What was it?

Probe 7: Did seeing the total amount help you catch errors?

[If Yes] Probe 8: Was this total meaningful to you?

(Note: Does participant have a sense of what the total is to judge if there is an error?)

(Universe: If valid entry provided for either Q562 or Q562_alt)

Q562d3. Is this \$(total amount from Q562d) before or after any monthly Medicare deductions?

- 1 After deductions
- 2 Before deductions

[Observe: Do they know if they have a deduction? What do they choose if they don't know?]

[If P says they definitely “don’t have a deduction”] [Observe: What do they choose? Before or after?]

Probe 1: How long have you been on Soc Security Disability?

Probe 2: Do you expect to get Medicare deductions in the future, or have you had them in the past?

(Universe: If Q56d3 = 1 or 2)

Q562md. How much were (name’s/your) monthly Medicare deductions? Include Medicare Advantage, Part B, and Part D premiums.

\$(text).00

Probe 1: Do you know what your deduction is for (e.g., Medicare Part B)?

Q558. In 2023, did (name/you) receive an initial Social Security Disability payment that was larger than the usual payment that we haven’t accounted for yet?

Sometimes the initial payment is larger to make up for the delay in receiving the first payment.

- 1 Yes
- 2 No

Q559. How much was that initial disability payment?

\$(text).00

Probe 1: Did you already factor this into your previous answer, when reporting the monthly payments?

(Yes) If so, how? (If needed: ...by adding additional payments or by increasing the amount per month?)

Social Security for Children (Q56i series)

(Universe: adult chosen as a recipient for a child)

Q56i. Default screen: For {name fill}, enter the amount of Social Security payments received each month for all children in this household and the number of payments in 2023.

	Amount each month	Number of payments	Total
Social Security for children	\$.____.00	_____	_____

[] I want to report yearly or in a different way.

Q56i_alt. Alternative screen: Enter the amount of Social Security payments for all children in this household (^name/you) received in 2023.

	Amount	per	Number of payments	Total
Social Security for children	\$.____.00	____(drop down)	_____	_____

[Observe: Did P report amounts for the right periodicity (e.g. month)?] Probe 1: Just to confirm, you selected [\$] per [Week/Month/Year], is that correct?

[Observe: Where did P struggle with the data entry, especially the check box and follow-up question with the grid.] Probe 2: Did you have any challenges completing this grid? Explain.

Probe 3: Would you have preferred to be asked how you want to report the amounts (bi-weekly, monthly, yearly) first?

Probe 4: Was it clear what the checkbox was there for?

Probe 5: Did you find the format of this question(s) easy to understand? Would you change anything to make it easier? **[Ask this especially if they received the grid]**

Probe 6: Was there some amount you wanted to include and then didn't? What was it?

Probe 7: Did seeing the total amount help you catch errors?

[If Yes] Probe 8: Was this total meaningful to you?

(Note: Does participant have a sense of what the total is to judge if there is an error?)

Supplemental Security Income (SSI) (Q57c series):

(Universe: Anyone indicated in Q57b)

Q57c. Default screen: For {name fill}, enter the amount of Supplemental Security Income received each month and the number of payments in 2023.

	Amount	Number of payments	Total
For: {fill name}			
Supplemental Security Income	\$____.00	_____	_____

[] I want to report yearly or in a different way.

Q57c_alt. Alternative screen: Enter the amount of Supplemental Security Income (^name/you) received in 2023.

	Amount	Frequently	Number of payments	Total
Supplemental Security Income	\$____.00	____(drop down)	_____	_____

Total Supplemental Security Income in 2023: _____

If the total is not correct, please make corrections above.

[Observe: Did P report amounts for the right periodicity (e.g. month)?] Probe 1: Just to confirm, you selected [\$] per [Week/Month/Year], is that correct?

[Observe: Where did P struggle with the data entry, especially the check box and follow-up question with the grid.] Probe 2: Did you have any challenges completing this grid? Explain.

Probe 3: Would you have preferred to be asked how you want to report the amounts (bi-weekly, monthly, yearly) first?

Probe 4: Was it clear what the checkbox was there for?

Probe 5: Did you find the format of this question(s) easy to understand? Would you change anything to make it easier? **[Ask this especially if they received the grid]**

Probe 6: Was there some amount you wanted to include and then didn't? What was it?

Probe 7: Did seeing the total amount help you catch errors?

[If Yes] Probe 8: Was this total meaningful to you?

(Note: Does participant have a sense of what the total is to judge if there is an error?)

Supplemental Security Income for Children (Q57i series)

(Universe: anyone listed in Q57e)

Q57i. Enter the amount of Supplemental Security Income (^name/you) received on behalf of children in 2023.

	amount	Number of payments	Total
Supplemental Security Income	\$____.00	_____	_____

[Observe: Did P report amounts for the right periodicity (e.g. month)?] Probe 1: Just to confirm, you selected [\$] per [Week/Month/Year], is that correct?

[Observe: Where did P struggle with the data entry, especially the check box and follow-up question with the grid.] Probe 2: Did you have any challenges completing this grid? Explain.

Probe 3: Would you have preferred to be asked how you want to report the amounts (bi-weekly, monthly, yearly) first?

Probe 4: Did you find the format of this question(s) easy to understand? Would you change anything to make it easier? **[Ask this especially if they received the grid]**

Probe 5: Was there some amount you wanted to include and then didn't? What was it?

Probe 6: Did seeing the total amount help you catch errors?

[If Yes] Probe 7: Was this total meaningful to you?

(Note: Does participant have a sense of what the total is to judge if there is an error?)

Disability Income (Q61e series)

(Universe: Q61c = 1-10)

Q61e. Default screen: For {name fill}, enter the amount of disability income each month and the number of payments in 2023.

	amount	Number of payments	Total
(^Disability Income Source fill from Q61c)	\$____.00	_____	_____

[] I want to report yearly or in a different way.

Q61e_alt. Alternative screen: For {name fill}, enter the amount of disability income each month and the number of payments in 2023.

	amount	Frequency	Number of payments	Total
(^Disability Income Source fill from Q61c)	\$____.00	____(drop down)	_____	_____

[Observe: Did P report amounts for the right periodicity (e.g. month)?] Probe 1: Just to confirm, you selected [\$] per [Week/Month/Year], is that correct?

[Observe: Where did P struggle with the data entry, especially the check box and follow-up question with the grid.] Probe 2: Did you have any challenges completing this grid? Explain.

Probe 3: Would you have preferred to be asked how you want to report the amounts (bi-weekly, monthly, yearly) first?

Probe 4: Was it clear what the checkbox was there for?

Probe 5: Did you find the format of this question(s) easy to understand? Would you change anything to make it easier? **[Ask this especially if they received the grid]**

Probe 6: Was there some amount you wanted to include and then didn't? What was it?

Probe 7: Did seeing the total amount help you catch errors?

[If Yes] Probe 8: Was this total meaningful to you?

(Note: Does participant have a sense of what the total is to judge if there is an error?)

Veterans Payments (Q60V series)

(Universe: anyone selected in Q60b_88)

Q60V. Default screen: For {name fill}, enter the amount of veterans payments received each month and the number of payments in 2023.

	amount	Number of payments	Total
(^Veterans Payments source fill from Q60ABB)	\$____.00	_____	_____

[] I want to report yearly or in a different way.

Q60V_alt. Alternative screen: Enter the amount of Veterans Payments (^name/you) received in 2023.

	amount	Frequency	Number of payments	Total
(^Veterans Payments source fill from NQ##)	\$____.00	____(drop down)	_____	_____

[Observe: Did P report amounts for the right periodicity (e.g. month)?] Probe 1: Just to confirm, you selected [\$] per [Week/Month/Year], is that correct?

[Observe: Where did P struggle with the data entry, especially the check box and follow-up question with the grid.] Probe 2: Did you have any challenges completing this grid? Explain.

Probe 3: Would you have preferred to be asked how you want to report the amounts (bi-weekly, monthly, yearly) first?

Probe 4: Was it clear what the checkbox was there for?

Probe 5: Did you find the format of this question(s) easy to understand? Would you change anything to make it easier? **[Ask this especially if they received the grid]**

Probe 6: Was there some amount you wanted to include and then didn't? What was it?

Probe 7: Did seeing the total amount help you catch errors?

[If Yes] Probe 8: Was this total meaningful to you?

(Note: Does participant have a sense of what the total is to judge if there is an error?)

Survivor Benefits (Q58E1 series)

(Universe: anyone selected in Q58b)

Q58E1. For {name fill}, enter the amount of {fill Survivor Benefits} received and the number of payments in 2023.

	amount	Frequency	Number of payments	Total
(^Survivor Benefits source fill from Q58A)	\$____.00	____(drop down)	_____	_____

[Observe: Did P report amounts for the right periodicity (e.g. month)?] Probe 1: Just to confirm, you selected [\$] per [Week/Month/Year], is that correct?

[Observe: Where did P struggle with the data entry, especially the check box and follow-up question with the grid.] Probe 2: Did you have any challenges completing this grid? Explain.

Probe 3: Would you have preferred to be asked how you want to report the amounts (bi-weekly, monthly, yearly) first?

Probe 4: Did you find the format of this question(s) easy to understand? Would you change anything to make it easier? **[Ask this especially if they received the grid]**

Probe 5: Was there some amount you wanted to include and then didn't? What was it?

Probe 6: Did seeing the total amount help you catch errors?

[If Yes] Probe 7: Was this total meaningful to you?

(Note: Does participant have a sense of what the total is to judge if there is an error?)

Public Assistance (Q59e series):

(Universe: anyone selected in Q59b_88)

Q59e. Default screen: For {name fill}, enter the amount of {cash assistance} received each month and the number of payments in 2023.

	amount	Number of payments	Total
(^Public Assistance source fill from Q59A88)	\$____.00	_____	_____

Q59e_alt. Alternative screen: Enter the amount of {cash assistance} (^name/you) received and the number of payments in 2023.

	amount	Frequency	Number of payments	Total
(^Public Assistance source fill from NQ# #)	\$____.00	____(drop down)	_____	_____

[Observe: Did P report amounts for the right periodicity (e.g. month)?] Probe 1: Just to confirm, you selected [\$] per [Week/Month/Year], is that correct?

[Observe: Where did P struggle with the data entry, especially the check box and follow-up question with the grid.] Probe 2: Did you have any challenges completing this grid? Explain.

Probe 3: Would you have preferred to be asked how you want to report the amounts (bi-weekly, monthly, yearly) first?

Probe 4: Was it clear what the checkbox was there for?

Probe 5: Did you find the format of this question(s) easy to understand? Would you change anything to make it easier? **[Ask this especially if they received the grid]**

Probe 6: Was there some amount you wanted to include and then didn't? What was it?

Probe 7: Did seeing the total amount help you catch errors?

[If Yes] Probe 8: Was this total meaningful to you?

(Note: Does participant have a sense of what the total is to judge if there is an error?)

Pensions (Q62E1 series)

(Universe: anyone selected in Q62B)

Q62E1. Default screen: For {name fill}, enter the amount of pension income received each month and the number of payments in 2023.

	amount	Number of payments	Total
(^Pensions source fill from NQ##)	\$____.00	_____	_____

[] I want to report yearly or in a different way.

Q62E1_alt. Alternative screen: Enter the amount of pension income (^name/you) received in 2023.

	amount	Frequency	Number of payments	Total
(^Pensions source fill from NQ##)	\$____.00	____(drop down)	_____	_____

[Observe: Did P report amounts for the right periodicity (e.g. month)?] Probe 1: Just to confirm, you selected [\$] per [Week/Month/Year], is that correct?

[Observe: Where did P struggle with the data entry, especially the check box and follow-up question with the grid.] Probe 2: Did you have any challenges completing this grid? Explain.

Probe 3: Would you have preferred to be asked how you want to report the amounts (bi-weekly, monthly, yearly) first?

Probe 4: Was it clear what the checkbox was there for?

Probe 5: Did you find the format of this question(s) easy to understand? Would you change anything to make it easier? **[Ask this especially if they received the grid]**

Probe 6: Was there some amount you wanted to include and then didn't? What was it?

Probe 7: Did seeing the total amount help you catch errors?

[If Yes] Probe 8: Was this total meaningful to you?

(Note: Does participant have a sense of what the total is to judge if there is an error?)

Annuities (ANNNEW1 series)

(Universe: anyone indicated in Q96Br)

ANNNEW1. Enter the total amount of annuity income (^name/you) received in 2023.

amount	Frequency	Number of	
\$____.00	____(drop down)	payments	Total
		_____	_____

[Observe: Did P report amounts for the right periodicity (e.g. month)?] Probe 1: Just to confirm, you selected [\$] per [Week/Month/Year], is that correct?

[Observe: Where did P struggle with the data entry, especially the check box and follow-up question with the grid.] Probe 2: Did you have any challenges completing this grid? Explain.

Probe 3: Would you have preferred to be asked how you want to report the amounts (bi-weekly, monthly, yearly) first?

Probe 4: Did you find the format of this question(s) easy to understand? Would you change anything to make it easier? **[Ask this especially if they received the grid]**

Probe 5: Was there some amount you wanted to include and then didn't? What was it?

Probe 6: Did seeing the total amount help you catch errors?

[If Yes] Probe 7: Was this total meaningful to you?

(Note: Does participant have a sense of what the total is to judge if there is an error?)

Withdrawals/Distributions from retirement plan (DISTNEW1 series)

(Universe: Anyone indicated in Q97Br)

DISTNEW. Default screen: Enter the total amount withdrawn or distributed from (^name's/your) {retirement account} in 2023.

	amount
(^retirement source fill from Q97Ar)	\$____.00

[] I want to report monthly or in a different way.

DISTNEW_alt. Alternative periodicity screen: Enter the total amount withdrawn or distributed from (^name's/your) {retirement account} in 2023.

	amount	Frequency	Number of	Total
(^retirement source fill from Q97Ar)	\$____.00	____(drop down)	_____	_____

[Observe: Did P report amounts for the right periodicity (e.g. month)?] Probe 1: Just to confirm, you selected [\$] per [Week/Month/Year], is that correct?

[Observe: Where did P struggle with the data entry, especially the check box and follow-up question with the grid.] Probe 2: Did you have any challenges completing this grid? Explain.

Probe 3: Would you have preferred to be asked how you want to report the amounts (bi-weekly, monthly, yearly) first?

Probe 4: Was it clear what the checkbox was there for?

Probe 5: Did you find the format of this question(s) easy to understand? Would you change anything to make it easier? **[Ask this especially if they received the grid]**

Probe 6: Was there some amount you wanted to include and then didn't? What was it?

Probe 7: Did seeing the total amount help you catch errors?

[If Yes] Probe 8: Was this total meaningful to you?

(Note: Does participant have a sense of what the total is to judge if there is an error?)

(Universe: Anyone indicated in Q97Br)

ROLLA. Did (^you/name) re-invest or "roll over" any of the money into an IRA or some other kind of retirement plan?

- 1 Yes
- 2 No

Probe 1: Can you explain what roll over means?

(Universe: ROLLA = 1)

ROLLAMTA. How much did (^you/name) re-invest or "roll over" into an IRA or some other kind of retirement plan in 2023?

[INTERVIEWER: KNOWN PROGRAMMING ISSUE THAT THIS QUESTION IS STILL ASKED WHEN ROLLA=NO]

(Universe: ROLLA = 2)

ROLLB. (^Do/Does) (^you/name) plan to re-invest or roll over any of the money?

- 1 Yes
- 2 No

ROLLAMTB. How much (^do/does) (^you/name) plan to re-invest or "roll over" into an IRA or some other kind of retirement plan?

Interest/Dividends on retirement accounts (RETIRENEW series)

(UNIVERSE: ANYONE INDICATED IN Q97BR)

RETIRENEW1. Default screen: For {name fill}, enter the total amount of interest or dividends received from {retirement account} in 2023, including small amounts reinvested or credited to the account.

	amount	Number of payments	Total
(^retirement source fill from Q97Ar)	\$____.00	_____	_____

[] I want to report monthly or in a different way

RETIRENEW_alt. Alternative screen: For {name fill}, enter the total amount of interest or dividends received from {retirement account} in 2023, including small amounts reinvested or credited to the account.

	amount	Frequency	Number of payments	Total
(^retirement source fill from Q97Ar)	\$____.00	_____	_____	_____

[INTERVIEWER: THERE IS A KNOWN PROGRAMMING ISSUE. QUESTIONS ARE STILL COMING ON PATH FOR PEOPLE WHO RESPOND TO THE INITIAL DISCRETE AMOUNT QUESTION WITH "I WANT TO REPORT ANOTHER WAY" AND THEN COMPLETE THE GRID ON THE "ALT" QUESTION. IT SHOULD ONLY COME ON PATH FOR PEOPLE WHO SKIP BOTH OF THESE QUESTIONS.]

[LET THE P SKIP RETIRENEW1 OR ALT. THERE IS A FOLLOW-UP QUESTION – RETIRENEW2]

[If provide an answer:] Probe 1: Did this amount include general account growth or appreciation in value?

(Universe: RETIRENEW1 = SKIP)

RETIRENEW2: The Census Bureau can estimate the amount earned in this account based on the size of the account. How much money was in (name's/your)?

\$(text).00

Contributions to Retirement Accounts (CONTRIB series)

(Universe: anyone indicated in Q97Br)

CONTRIB1. Earlier you said that (^you/name) (^have/has) a retirement account, such as a 401(k), 403(b), IRA, or other account designed specifically for retirement savings. Did (^you/they) contribute any money to (^your/their) plan(s), for example, through payroll deductions? Do not include amounts reinvested or "rolled over" from other retirement accounts.

- 1 Yes
 - 2 No
-

(Universe: CONTRIB1 = 1)

CONTRIB2. What is the easiest way for you to tell us (^your/ name's) contribution to their retirement account in 2023?

- 1 Percent of earnings
 - 2 Annual dollar amount
-

(Universe: CONTRIB2 = 1)

CONTRIB3a. What percent of (^your/their) earnings did (^you/they) contribute to (^your/their) account(s) in 2023?

(Universe: CONTRIB2 = 2)

CONTRIB3b. How much did (you/they) contribute to (your/their) account(s) in 2023?

Interest/Dividends on non-retirement accounts (Q63/NONRETIRENEW series)

(Universe: anyone indicated in Q99Ba)

Q63cp. Default screen: Enter the amount (^name/you) received in interests and dividends in 2023 from {fill}, including small amounts reinvested or credited to the account.

For a joint account, split the amount in half for each person.

amount
 (^fill from Q99AR
 or Q99BR) \$____.00

[] I want to report monthly or in a different way.

[LET THE R SKIP 63CP OR ALT. THERE IS A FOLLOW UP QUESTION]

[If provide an answer:] Probe1: Did this amount include general account growth / appreciation in value?

Q63cp_alt. Alternative screen: Enter the amount (^name/you) received in interests and dividends in 2023 from {fill}, including small amounts reinvested or credited to the account.

For a joint account, split the amount in half for each person.

	amount	Frequency	Number of payments	Total
(^fill from Q99AR or Q99BR)	\$____.00	____(drop down)	_____	_____

[LET THE R SKIP 63CP OR ALT. THERE IS A FOLLOW UP QUESTION]

[If provide an answer]: Probe 1: Did this amount include general account growth / appreciation in value?

(Universe: Q99Ara = 1 and Q63cp = SKIP OR Q63cp_alt = SKIP)

NONRETIRENEW12. The Census Bureau can estimate the amount earned in this account based on the size of the account. How much money did (you/name) have in checking accounts at the end of 2023?

\$[text].00

Property Income (Q65 series)

Universe: Q65A2 = 1 AND anyone indicated in Q65b

Q65c. Default screen: Enter the total amount (^name/you) received for rental income during 2023, after expenses. If there was a loss, enter the amount of that loss and select "Loss."

	amount	
Rental income	\$____.00	☐ Loss

[OBSERVE: DOES PARTICIPANT UNDERSTAND THE INSTRUCTION ABOUT THE LOSS BUTTON AND USE IT CORRECTLY] Probe 1: What do you think the loss button is used for?

Q65d. Default screen: Enter the total amount (^name/you) received in 2023.

For joint ownership, split the amount in half for each person.

	amount	Number of payments	Total
(^fill from Q65A2)	\$____.00	_____	_____

[] I want to report monthly or in a different way.

Q65d_alt -- Alternative periodicity screen: Enter) the amount (^name/you) received in 2023. For joint ownership, split the amount in half for each person.

	amount	Frequency	Number of payments	Total
(^fill from Q65A2)	\$____.00	____(drop down)	_____	_____

[Observe: Did participants report amounts for the right periodicity (e.g. month)?]

Probe 1: Just to confirm, you selected [\$] per [Week/Month/Year], is that correct?

[Observe: Where did participants struggle with the data entry, especially the check box and follow-up question with the grid.] Probe 2: Did you have any challenges completing this grid? Explain.

Probe 3: Would you have preferred to be asked how you want to report the amounts (bi-weekly, monthly, yearly) first?

Probe 4: Was it clear what the checkbox was there for?

Probe 5: Did you find the format of this question(s) easy to understand? Would you change anything to make it easier? **[Ask this especially if they received the grid]**

Probe 6: Was there some amount you wanted to include and then didn't? What was it?

Probe 7: Did seeing the total amount help you catch errors?

[If Yes] Probe 8: Was this total meaningful to you?

[NOTE: DOES PARTICIPANT HAVE A SENSE OF WHAT THE TOTAL IS TO JUDGE IF THERE IS AN ERROR?]

Educational Assistance

(UNIVERSE: NQ66BD = 1-5)

NQ669D. Default screen: Enter the total amount of educational assistance (^name/you) received in 2023.

	amount	Amount each month	Total
(^fill from NQ66bd)	\$____.00	_____	_____

[] I want to report yearly or in a different way.

NQ669G. Alternative screen: Enter the total amount of educational assistance (^name/you) received in 2023.

	amount	Frequency	Number of payments	Total
(^Fill from NQ66bd)	\$____.00	____(drop down)	_____	_____

[Observe: Did participants report amounts for the right periodicity (e.g. month)?]

Probe 1: Just to confirm, you selected [\$] per [Week/Month/Year], is that correct?

[Observe: Where did participants struggle with the data entry, especially the check box and follow-up question with the grid.] Probe 2: Did you have any challenges completing this grid? Explain.

Probe 3: Would you have preferred to be asked how you want to report the amounts (bi-weekly, monthly, yearly) first?

Probe 4: Was it clear what the checkbox was there for?

Probe 5: Did you find the format of this question(s) easy to understand? Would you change anything to make it easier? **[Ask this especially if they received the grid]**

Probe 6: Was there some amount you wanted to include and then didn't? What was it?

Probe 7: Did seeing the total amount help you catch errors?

[If Yes] Probe 8: Was this total meaningful to you?

[NOTE: DOES PARTICIPANT HAVE A SENSE OF WHAT THE TOTAL IS TO JUDGE IF THERE IS AN ERROR?]

Child Support

(Universe: anyone selected in Q70b)

Q70cp. Enter the amount of child support payments (^name/you) received in 2023.

amount	Frequency	Number of	Total
\$____.00	____(drop down)	_____	_____

[Observe: Did participants report amounts for the right periodicity (e.g. month)?]

Probe 1: Just to confirm, you selected [\$] per [Week/Month/Year], is that correct?

[Observe: Where did participants struggle with the data entry, especially the check box and follow-up question with the grid.] Probe 2: Did you have any challenges completing this grid? Explain.

Probe 3: Would you have preferred to be asked how you want to report the amounts (bi-weekly, monthly, yearly) first?

Probe 4: Did you find the format of this question(s) easy to understand? Would you change anything to make it easier? **[Ask this especially if they received the grid]**

Probe 5: Was there some amount you wanted to include and then didn't? What was it?

Probe 6: Did seeing the total amount help you catch errors?

[If Yes] Probe 7: Was this total meaningful to you?

[NOTE: DOES PARTICIPANT HAVE A SENSE OF WHAT THE TOTAL IS TO JUDGE IF THERE IS AN ERROR?]

Regular Financial Assistance:

(UNIVERSE: ANYONE SELECTED IN Q72B)

Q72cp. Enter the amount of regular financial assistance (^name/you) received from friends or relatives during 2023.

amount	Freq	Number of	Total
\$____.00	____(drop down)	_____	_____

[Observe: Did participants report amounts for the right periodicity (e.g. month)?]

Probe 1: Just to confirm, you selected [\$] per [Week/Month/Year], is that correct?

[Observe: Where did participants struggle with the data entry, especially the check box and follow-up question with the grid.] Probe 2: Did you have any

challenges completing this grid? Explain.

Probe 3: Would you have preferred to be asked how you want to report the amounts (bi-weekly, monthly, yearly) first?

Probe 4: Did you find the format of this question(s) easy to understand? Would you change anything to make it easier? **[Ask this especially if they received the grid]**

Probe 5: Was there some amount you wanted to include and then didn't? What was it?

Probe 6: Did seeing the total amount help you catch errors?

[If Yes] Probe 7: Was this total meaningful to you?

[NOTE: DOES PARTICIPANT HAVE A SENSE OF WHAT THE TOTAL IS TO JUDGE IF THERE IS AN ERROR?]

Other Money Income. (Universe: anyone selected in Q73A1b)

Q731P. Enter the amount of other income (^name/you) received in 2023.

	amount	per	Number of
(^source fill Q731Arc1)	\$____.00	____(drop down)	payments

[Observe: Did participants report amounts for the right periodicity (e.g. month)?]

Probe 1: Just to confirm, you selected [\$] per [Week/Month/Year], is that correct?

[Observe: Where did participants struggle with the data entry, especially the check box and follow-up question with the grid.] Probe 2: Did you have any

challenges completing this grid? Explain.

Probe 3: Would you have preferred to be asked how you want to report the amounts (bi-weekly, monthly, yearly) first?

Probe 4: Did you find the format of this question(s) easy to understand? Would you change anything to make it easier? **[Ask this especially if they received the grid]**

Probe 5: Was there some amount you wanted to include and then didn't? What was it?

Probe 6: Did seeing the total amount help you catch errors?

[If Yes] Probe 7: Was this total meaningful to you?

[NOTE: DOES PARTICIPANT HAVE A SENSE OF WHAT THE TOTAL IS TO JUDGE IF THERE IS AN ERROR?]

Poverty

Housing

MORT_YN. Which of these loans do you have on this property?

Select all that apply.

- 1- Mortgage or similar
- 2- Second Mortgage
- 3- Home Equity Loan
- 4- None

Probe 1: Are any of these terms confusing or unclear? If so – which ones?

Probe 2: Can you tell me the difference between home equity loans and mortgages?

NUMROOMS. How many separate bedrooms do your living quarters contain?

Count as bedrooms those rooms you would list if these living quarters were for sale or rent. If this is an efficiency/studio apartment, enter 0.

[Text entry, whole digits]

[Observe: Did the R read the instructions and count rooms correctly?]

Probe 1: Did you see the instructions on what to count as you determined your response?

[Observe: Did the P struggle with the term “living quarters” or defining where they live?] Probe 1: Did you have any challenges in determining what was meant by “living quarters”?

Food Assistance

SNAP_YN. At any time during 2023, even for one month, did (you/anyone in this household) receive benefits from SNAP (the Supplemental Nutritional Assistance Program), the Food Stamp program, (state program fill/blank) or use a SNAP or food stamp benefit card?

Do not include WIC.

1- Yes

2- No

[DO NOT DRAW EXTRA ATTENTION TO THE WIC INSTRUCTION BECAUSE WE WANT TO KNOW IN THE NEXT QUESTION IF THEY REMEMBER NOT TO INCLUDE IT.]

[BEFORE MOVING TO NEXT QUESTION: IF **P DID RECEIVE SNAP IN 2023** AND THEY INCORRECTLY SELECTED NO, ASK P TO CHANGE THEIR ANSWER SO THEY RECEIVE THE FOLLOW-UP QUESTIONS.]

[Observe: Did they notice the “even for one month” instruction?] Probe 1: When you read the question, did you notice the instruction to count even for one month?

[Observe only: Did they notice the WIC instruction and follow it?]

Probe 2: Have you heard of all of these programs? Are some of these the same programs to you but with different names?

[If No] – Probe3: Did you receive any help buying food, that you can think of, in 2023?

SNAP_ROST. Who received [(state program fill) benefits,] or foods stamps at any time in 2023?

Select all that Apply.

[Names from household roster]

Probe 1: The previous question noted an instruction not to include WIC. Did you remember that when answering?

Probe 2: Is there anyone in the household who you are not sure about?

SNAP_AMT. What was the value of SNAP [,(state program fill) benefits,] or food stamps received in 2023 for the entire household?

Amount	Frequency	Number of payments	Total
\$[text].00		_____	_____

[] Don't know

[Observe: Did P have any trouble with the frequency of payment drop down? For example, month, year?] Probe 1: Did you have any difficulty completing the grid?

[If more than one person on benefits] – Probe 2: Did you add the benefits for all household members together?

Probe 3: You have a SNAP card, right? Do you know what benefits are loaded onto that card?

[IF Yes:] – Probe 4: Do you know the separate amounts for each?

[Do not probe for specific amounts, just if they know them]

Probe 5: Do you get other benefits like P-EBT or Summer EBT or TANF? If yes, did you include these in the total?

SNAP_FREQ. How many monthly SNAP[, state program fill,] or food stamp payments were received in 2023?

(Amount fill from SNAP_AMT) for ____ (text box 2 digits <13) months

Probe 1: Did you have any trouble figuring out how many months?

Probe 2: Does showing this question on the same screen help? Or is it confusing/cluttered?

SNAP_CHK. Your total SNAP[, state program fill,] or food stamp payments was \$[fill from SNAP_AMT * SNAP_FREQ]. Does that look right to you?

1 Yes

2 No, I need to correct something.

Probe 1: What did you think of this question?

[LOOK FOR COMMENTS LIKE "REDUNDANT", "UNNECESSARY", "ANNOYING", "INSULTING", ETC. PROBE MORE IF NECESSARY.]

Probe 2: Does showing this question on the same screen help? Or is it confusing/cluttered?

Probe 3: Is seeing the amount for the whole year meaningful to you? Do you think of your benefits this way?

[If SNAP_CHK=No] Probe 4: Do you know what went wrong in the previous questions that resulted in the amount being incorrect?

SNAP_RNG. If you don't know the exact value, please estimate.

What was the value of SNAP [,(state program fill) benefits.,] or food stamps received in 2023 for the entire household?

- 1 \$0 to \$999
- 2 \$1,000 to \$2,999
- 3 \$3,000 or more

Probe 1: Is seeing the amount for the whole year meaningful to you?

Probe 2: Do you think of your benefits this way?

SNAP_RNG2. Was it...?

- 1 \$0 to \$99
- 2 \$100 to \$499
- 3 \$500 or more

Probe 1: What did you think of this question?

[LOOK FOR COMMENTS LIKE "REDUNDANT" OR "TOO DIFFICULT TO NARROW DOWN", ETC. PROBE MORE IF NECESSARY.]

School Meals

SMEAL_YN. During 2023, did any of the children in this household usually eat a complete breakfast and/or lunch provided by the school?

- 1 Yes
- 2 No

[If No] Probe 1: Please describe what your children do for breakfast and lunch on school days. Tell me, do they pack, buy something, or does the school provide free food?

Probe 2: Did you notice the word "complete" in the question? Did the inclusion of "complete" change your answer to the question?

Probe 3: What does "provided by" mean to you?

Probe 4: Does provided mean the same as prepared?

[INTERVIEWER: WE WANT TO UNDERSTAND IF PROVIDED IMPLIES "FREE".]

SMEAL_ROST. For each child, please indicate which school-provided meals they usually ate in 2023.

Select all that apply.

Child	Breakfast	Lunch	None
[Child 1]	☐	☐	☐
[Child 2]	☐	☐	☐
[Child N]	☐	☐	☐

[Observe: Did they use the None option or leave it blank?]

[Observe: Did the participant have any difficulty with the grid format?] Probe 1: Any challenges in completing this grid?

[If not discussed in previous question:] Probe1: How did you determine which meals each child ate?

[If P selects nothing or all are marked "None"] – Probe 2: Were you unsure how to answer the previous question or was it confusing? [GO BACK A SCREEN IF NEEDED]

SUBMEAL_YN. During 2023, did [any of these children/this child] receive free or reduced price lunch?

- 1- Yes
- 2- No

[If yes] Probe 1: Did you have difficulty deciding what meals were free/reduced?

Probe 2: Did you count meals where everyone gets free food, without having to apply for it (not need based)?

Probe 3: Were you thrown off by the phrase "reduced price"? Would "free or reduced price school meals" make more sense?

[IF CHILD EATS BOTH BREAKFAST AND LUNCH] Probe 4: Did you think of both breakfast and lunch? Do we need to specify both meals in the question?

SUBMEAL_ROST. For each child, please indicate which school-provided meals were free or reduced price in 2023.

Select all that apply.

Child	Breakfast	Lunch	None
[Child 1]	☐	☐	☐
[Child 2]	☐	☐	☐
[Child N]	☐	☐	☐

[Observe: Did they use the None option or leave it blank?]

[Observe: Did P have any difficulty with the grid format?] Probe 1: Any challenges in completing this grid?

[Observe: Did P realize that this is a different question from before? Or did they feel that they had already answered this?] Probe 2: Did you feel like this question is redundant with what you answered earlier?

[If P selects nothing or all are marked "None"] – Probe 3: Did you need to make a change with the previous question? [GO BACK A SCREEN IF NEEDED]

Non-Cash Benefits

NCREC. At any time during 2023, even for one month, did (you/anyone in this household) receive any of the following?

Non-Cash Benefit	Yes	No
WIC	☐	☐
Energy Assistance	☐	☐
Heating or Cooling Assistance	☐	☐
Rental Assistance/Section 8 Voucher	☐	☐
Public Housing	☐	☐
Internet or Broadband Assistance	☐	☐

[Observe: Did P have any difficulty with the grid format?] Probe 1: Any challenges answering the question?

[Observe: Did they use the No option or leave it blank?]

Probe 2: Did you have any difficulties answering this question? Can you tell me which programs you have?

Probe 3: Did you receive any other assistance that you don't see in this list?

WIC_ROST. Who were the WIC benefits for?

Select all that apply.

Roster names (children under 6, women between 15 and 45)

[If more than one person to choose from] – Probe 1: How did you decide who counts as receiving the benefits? Was it the child who qualifies for the benefits? Or the adult who gets the money?

WIC_MNTH. For how many months was WIC received in 2023?

[Name] _____
[Name] _____

[Observe: Did P have any difficulty with the grid format?] Probe 1: Any challenges answering the question?

[IF more than one HH member] Probe 2: Any trouble answering for other members of the household?

ENG_ASST. During 2023, how much [fill from NCREC--energy assistance/heating or cooling assistance/energy, heating, and cooling assistance] was received for the entire year?

\$(text).00
[] Don't know

Probe 1: Please explain what energy benefits you receive.

Probe 2: This question asks you to add up your benefits for the entire year. Were you able to do that?

Probe 3: Is it easier to enter this monthly or some other way?

ENG_RNG. If you don't know the exact value, please estimate.

During 2023, how much energy assistance was received for the entire year?

- 1 \$0 to \$999
- 2 \$1,000 to \$2,999
- 3 \$3,000 or more

Probe 1: Do you remember which energy benefits are being asked about? Or should "heating and cooling" be added to the question?

ENG_RNG2. Was it...?

- 1 \$0 to \$99
- 2 \$100 to \$499
- 3 \$500 or more

Probe 1: What did you think of this question?

[LOOKING FOR COMMENTS LIKE "REDUNDANT" OR "TOO DIFFICULT TO NARROW DOWN", ETC. PROBE IF NECESSARY.]

Child Care

CHCARE_PAID. Which type(s) of paid care were used for [CHILD] in 2023?

Select all that apply.

- 1- Child care center/preschool/nursery school
- 2- Home-based child care provider/paid care in provider's home
- 3- Paid care inside of your home (e.g., nanny/babysitter)
- 4- Paid care with family, friends, or neighbors
- 5- Before and/or after-school care
- 6- Summer camps
- 7- Other
- 8- None, did not pay for child care

[Observe: Did the P notice that this is only paid care? Are they trying to report unpaid care?]

[If P answered "other"], Probe 1: Please explain why you answered "Other".

Probe 2: Are we missing any other types of paid care?

[IF MORE THAN ONE SELECTED] Probe 3: Did you select one option for each type of care, or did you select 2 options for the same care?

CHCARE_UNPAID. Which types of free child care were used for [CHILD] in 2023?

Select all that apply

- 1- Care by a parent/guardian at home
- 2- Head Start
- 3- Pre-Kindergarten
- 4- Free care with family, friends, or neighbors
- 5- Fully-subsidized child care through subsidy or voucher
- 6- Other
- 7- None

[Observe: Did the P notice that this is unpaid care? Did it feel like the same question?] Probe 1: What do you think the difference is between this question and the previous question?

Probe 2: Please explain the first option about care by a parent or guardian. Did this make sense to you?

[If P answered "Other"], Probe 3: Please explain why you answered "Other".

[If P answered "None"], Probe 4: Please explain why you answered "None".

[If P answered "Family, friends, neighbors"] Probe 5: Was this in your home or outside of your home?

Probe 6: Are we missing any other types of free care?

Probe 7: Is "free" the same as "unpaid" to you? Do you have a preference for which word should be used in this question?

Probe 8: Do you have any childcare arrangements that don't cost money but aren't entirely free? In other words, you pay the care giver in some other way, like doing something for them or reducing their rent?

[If yes]: Probe 9: Did you include those when answering this question?

CHCARE_MAIN. What was the main type of child care received by [CHILD] in 2023?

Due to programming issues, this will list all options in CHCARE_PAID and CHCARE_UNPAID

Probe 1: How did you decide on the "main" type of care? Were any of the types of care used equally?

CHCARE_AMT. Across all childcare, how much was paid for each child in 2023?

	Amount	Frequency	Number of Payments	Total
[Child]				
[Child]				

[Observe: Did the P have trouble with the drop downs or the grid?]

Probe 1: Would there be an easier way for you to report this?

[If answered \$0] – Probe 2: Why did you answer \$0?

[INTERVIEWER: TRY TO UNDERSTAND WHAT WENT WRONG IN THE PREVIOUS QUESTION ABOUT PAID CARE.]

Probe 2: If we only asked you to think about care needed while at work, in training or school, or while looking for work, would that change the amounts you reported?

[If yes] Probe 3: What would the new amount be?

CHCARE_SUB. Was/were the child's/children's care fully or partially covered by a voucher or child care subsidy?

Child	Yes	No
[Child 1]	☐	☐
[Child 2]	☐	☐
[Child N]	☐	☐

[Observe: Did P have any trouble with the grid? Or are they used to it by now?]

Probe 1: Any challenges completing this question?

Probe 2: Do you know what a voucher or subsidy is?

CHCARE_PROB. Did [you / anyone in this household] have problems obtaining child care that prevented them from working more hours in 2023?

- 1- Yes
- 2- No

Probe 1: What situations did you think of when answering this question?

Probe 2: Did you think of infrequent situations (like your child or babysitter was sick), or chronic problems (like not being able to find after-school care), or both?

Probe 3: Did you count using paid time off (vacation or sick time) when answering this question?

CHCARE_PROBTIME. How much time were you and others in your household not able to work due to problems obtaining child care in 2023?

[text] [Periodicity dropdown—hours, days, weeks]

[Observe: Did the R have any trouble with the drop down?] Probe 1: What did you think of using the dropdown menu?

Probe 2: How did you arrive at this answer?

CHCARE_ADAPT. During 2023, did you [or anyone in the household] take any of the actions below in order to care for your [child/children] because child care was closed, unavailable, or unaffordable, or you were concerned for your [child's/children's] safety in care?

Select all that apply.

- 1- Took unpaid leave
- 2- Used vacation, sick days, or other paid leave
- 3- Cut your work hours
- 4- Quit a job
- 5- Were fired from a job
- 6- Did not look for a job
- 7- Supervised one or more children while working
- 8- Other (specify)
- 9- None of the above

[Observe: Did P read all the responses?] Probe 1: Did you read through all of the responses or skim over them?

[Observe: The “fired from a job” option is not an action the participant can take. It’s done to them. Does the R trip over this option?]

Probe 2: Which of the childcare problems listed after “because” (like childcare was closed) happened to you in 2023?

Probe 3: Were you thinking of any other childcare problems when you answered this question?

Probe 4: Did you select any of the answers even though it was not the result of a childcare problem? For example, you supervised a child while working because you didn’t feel you needed childcare.

Child Support

AWAY_KIDS. Did (you/anyone in this household) have any children living elsewhere with their other parent or guardian during 2023?

Adult	Yes	No
[Adult 1]	☐	☐
[Adult 2]	☐	☐
[Adult N]	☐	☐

[Observe: Did P have any trouble with the grid?] Probe 1: Any challenges completing this question?

Probe 2: Are any children under 18 living outside the home with someone other than their parent or guardian?

CHSUP_ROST. In 2023, did (you/anyone in this household) pay any child support for children living elsewhere?

Adult	Yes	No
[Adult 1]	☐	☐
[Adult 2]	☐	☐
[Adult N]	☐	☐

[If “Yes” to any Adult] – Probe1: Is (adult) paying child support? For example, through garnished wages, sending a check to the other parent, pays for activities, etc.

CHSUP_AMT. How much child support was paid in 2023?

[Adult 1] \$[text].00
 [Adult 2] \$[text].00
 [Adult N] \$[text].00

Probe 1: Did you think about informal child support like paying for activities, summer camp, school supplies, school tuition, etc.?

[End of instrument]

Thank you, those are all the questions that I have. Do you have any other thoughts or comments that I did not cover, that you would like to share now?

[TURN OFF THE RECORDER]

[PROVIDE P INFORMATION ON RECEIVING \$40 INCENTIVE – SEND OUT INCENTIVE EMAIL AND UPDATE CASE IN TRACKER TO “COMPLETE”]

[This page intentionally left blank]

Appendix F. Programming Issues from Income and Health Insurance

Income Questions with Programming Issues					
Question number	Question stem (or topic)	Known Issue Before Interviews	Type of issue	Issue detail	Estimated Number of Participants Affected
All	All	Yes	Format	Question names must be displayed for the interviewer to follow probes and note where problems occur. We have no way of moving their location.	30
All	All	Yes	Navigation	You cannot back up past the beginning of a loop (i.e., when there is no back button available). This is a Qualtrics limitation.	30
All	All	Yes	Navigation	Backing up and changing answers may cause glitches in the instrument. There's not a fix for this without restarting the whole instrument. Hopefully this is only a worry when interviewers are doing their training.	30
Multiple	Questions that end in _alt where a respondent indicated that they'd like to report X income a different way	Yes	Format	The spec requested a total box for the questions that give an option to report differently. These weren't originally added to the qualtrics, and then other functionality issues took precedence over adding them in. Will include for Round 2 when question stems and flow are refined, which may give better data	4
Employer's pension block	Questions about if employer offered pension plan, whether P eligible and participated in it	Yes	Loop	Due to programming difficulties for the other people in the HH, we're only going to ask this set of questions to the Respondent.	21
ROLLAMT questions	Amount P/HH member plans to re-invest or roll over	Yes	Routing/ logic	Still come on path for people who said no to ROLLA. Should only get this if they have rolled money over	2

Income Questions with Programming Issues					
Question number	Question stem (or topic)	Known Issue Before Interviews	Type of issue	Issue detail	Estimated Number of Participants Affected
RETIRENEW series and NONRETIRENEW series	Estimate amount earned in retirement or checking accounts	Yes	Routing/ logic	Questions are still coming on path for people who respond to the initial discrete amount question with "I want to report another way" and then complete the grid on the "alt" question. It should only come on path for people who skip both of these questions.	2
Q41	In the [fill # week/weeks form Q33] that you/ ^name worked, how many hours did you / they usually work per week?	Yes	Fill and wording	(you and other HH members) With adding the checkbox for "all weeks in 2023" in Q33, the fill and the question stem don't perfectly flow and are a little awkward. It's more important to us to test having that checkbox in Q33, and hopefully won't trip up respondents significantly in Q41 for those who select "all weeks"	23
Q47e1c	Were/Was you/ ^name the owner of {employer name from Q47a}?	No	Routing/ logic	Should have been asked to all Q47e1=5, but was asked to no participants. We did have 2 that answered Q47e1=5, but they did not receive Q47e1c.	2
Q47e1_combined (named "Q481_combined" in the report)	Which one of the following best describes {Employer Name from Q47a}?	No	Routing/ logic	Did not appear for 6 participants when it should have shown	6
Q47d1	What were your/their most important activities or duties?	No	Routing/ logic	Did not present to 4 participants that we believe it should have presented for. Need to confirm this is programmed correctly.	4
Q4788	Counting all locations where {Name's employer} operates, what was the total number of employees in 2023?	Yes	Fill	Qualtrics was giving us issues with implementing the EMPLOYER NAME fill for 4788. As a work-around, we're implementing NAME's employer, just for this test	25

Income Questions with Programming Issues					
Question number	Question stem (or topic)	Known Issue Before Interviews	Type of issue	Issue detail	Estimated Number of Participants Affected
Q48_per	Enter the amount (^name/you) received, before taxes and other deductions, from this employer in 2023.	No	Routing/ logic and question labeling	Occasionally Q48_per is presented first, before Q48_amount. When this occurs, although question says Q48_per, the question is set up to only report an annual amount. When checkbox is selected, are then shown grid with dropdown options, but question is labeled Q48b_amount, which is incorrect since Q48b_amount is label for question asked of only people indicated being self-employed (see screenshots for reference).	5
Q57d	Is there anyone in this household, who we have not already counted, who received Supplemental Security Income in 2023 on behalf of any children in this household?	No	Routing/ logic	Presented to at least 2 participants with no children in the household but did not present to all participants. Not sure what the error is here.	9
Q61c	In 2023, which sources of income, if any, did (^you/name) receive due to a disability or health problem?	No	Routing/ logic	should have been asked of all participants who answered Q59Ar = 1 or Q60A = 1. It was only asked of one participant, but the reason why this participant was routed to the question is unclear. The programming needs to be reviewed and updated.	8
Q59A88	Which types of cash assistance, if any, did (^anyone in this household/you) receive in 2023?	No	Routing/ logic	May have been a programming error. Seems like it should have been asked to all participants, but was only asked to 21.	9
Q98Ar	Did (^you/NAME) withdraw any money or receive a distribution from (^your/their) (^FILL FROM Q97AR) in 2023, including any distributions (^you/they) may have been required to take?	No	Routing/ logic	should be asked to all respondents who answered Q97Ar = 1-7, regardless of household size. It seems as though people who were in single person households were skipped over Q98Ar when it should have been asked.	13

Income Questions with Programming Issues					
Question number	Question stem (or topic)	Known Issue Before Interviews	Type of issue	Issue detail	Estimated Number of Participants Affected
Q99Bf	Who had (^FILL FROM Q99Arf)? For joint accounts, include each person.	No	Routing/ logic	There may have been a programming error experienced with P2285, who selected both P1 and P2 at Q99Bf but was only asked about P2 for CAPGDIS.	1
DISTNEW	Enter the total amount withdrawn or distributed from (^name's/your) {retirement account} in 2023.	No	Routing/ logic	Presented to one participant incorrectly. Skip patterns should be reviewed.	1
ROLLB	(^Do/Does) (^you/name) plan to re-invest or roll over any of the money?	No	Routing/ logic	Presented to one participant (P2734) incorrectly. Unclear why.	1
Q731P	Enter the amount of other income (^name/you) received in 2023.	No	Routing/ logic	P2417 was not presented Q731P (other income) but did report self in 73A1B.	1
SNAP_FREQ & SNAP_CHK	How many monthly SNAP[, state program fill,] or food stamp payments were received in 2023? / Your total SNAP[, state program fill,] or food stamp payments was \$[fill from SNAP_AMT * SNAP_FREQ]. Does that look right to you?	No	Routing/ logic	We had 3 participants (P2332, P2464, P2512) who answered 'monthly' on SNAP_AMT but were not presented SNAP_FREQ or SNAP_CHK.	3
WIC_MNTH	For how many months was WIC received in 2023?	No	Routing/ logic	We believe this should have been asked for P2332, who receives WIC and selected a child on WIC_ROST. Unclear why this was not presented to respondent. Confirm programming is working correctly.	1
SMEAL_YN	During 2023, did any of the children in this household usually eat a complete breakfast and/or lunch provided by the school?	No	Routing/ logic	The universe for SMEAL_YN is supposed to be people with households with children 5-18, but a participant in a household with only children under 5 was presented this question.	1

Income Questions with Programming Issues					
Question number	Question stem (or topic)	Known Issue Before Interviews	Type of issue	Issue detail	Estimated Number of Participants Affected
SUBMEAL_YN	During 2023, did [any of these children/this child] receive free or reduced price lunch?	No	Routing/ logic	The universe for SUBMEAL_YN is supposed to be people who said "yes" to SMEAL_YN, but everyone who was presented SMEAL_YN (regardless of how they answered) were also presented SUBMEAL_YN	4
SUBMEAL_ROST	For each child, please indicate which school-provided meals were free or reduced price in 2023.	No	Routing/ logic	The two participants who did not check any meals (P2369 and P2332) were not able to check any meals because they do not have school-age children;	2
ENG_RNG and ENG_RNG2	During 2023, how much energy assistance was received for the entire year? / Was it...?	No	Routing/ logic	ENG_RNG and ENG_RNG2 are supposed to be for people who skip ENG_ASST. P2512 answered ENG_ASST but was also presented both of these to answer.	1
Chcare_main	What was the main type of child care received by [CHILD] in 2023?	Yes	Response option display	Our intention was to display only those options selected in chcare_paid and chcare_unpaid. However, due to programming limitations we had to just display both lists again on the chcare_main screen	5
CHCARE_AMT	Across all childcare, how much was paid for each child in 2023?	No	Routing/ logic	This question was being shown to participants who selected "none, did not pay for childcare" in CHCARE_PAID.	2
AWAY_KIDS	Did (you/anyone in this household) have any children living elsewhere with their other parent or guardian during 2023?	No	Wording	In program this question was displayed as "Did (you/anyone in this household) have any children living elsewhere with their other parent during 2023?" instead of Did (you/anyone in this household) have any children living elsewhere with their other parent or guardian during 2023?	26

Health Insurance Questions with Programming Issues				
Question number	Question stem (or topic)	Known Issue Before Interviews	Type of issue	Issue detail
Q2	-	Yes	Wording	State program name (CAIDNAME) fill has been difficult to program. For states that do not have a unique state program name, it just reads as the two-letter state abbreviation and medicaid. Example: "FL medicaid". We can change the text to something else, but cannot remove it entirely.
Qs 2, 13, 28	-	Yes	Response option display	Expandable options on the list of insurances still have checkboxes. We're unable to remove them for this test. We did make them unclickable so that they don't interfere with later fills, but our intention is to only have them as a list in the final version.
Q12	-	Yes	Response option display	The list of insurances doesn't always display choices from the funnel. It will display the "other type of insurance" for anyone who selected "something else" or "I don't know" on the questions entering the funnel.
Qs 17, 22d, 25a, 31a	Whose name was your [^health insurance type] policy in? (who was the policyholder?)	No	Response option function	Response options for this question listed the household roster that participants inputted in the beginning of the survey. However, there was no option to select a non-household member policyholder. Participants whose policyholders were non-household members selected themselves as the policyholder and noted concern over the inaccurate responses.
MOOP	-	Yes	Loop	Limiting MOOP questions to R and 1 other HH member in order to save time on interview

Health Insurance Questions with Programming Issues				
Question number	Question stem (or topic)	Known Issue Before Interviews	Type of issue	Issue detail
Qs 32, 35, 38:	-	No	Routing/ logic	When participants do not enter a numeric response and instead write in the numeric field a textual response (e.g. P2279: "I'm not sure"; P2265: "Not sure – Paid by parent"), they are not shown the follow up questions asking them to select a range (Q33, Q35, Q38 respectively). Thus, the information that would be collected in Q33, 34, 36, 37, and 39 are skipped out.

[This page intentionally left blank]

Appendix G. Recommended Question Order

Below you will find our overall recommendations for question order for the Income questions. This suggested order takes into account best practices in survey methodology, such as reducing respondent burden by grouping similar concepts together. We believe prioritizing income types that are more common will improve the survey experience for respondents. These question order changes should be tested in the second round of cognitive interviewing to ensure intended improvements to the survey experience. Before testing, a final specification listing all questions will be helpful to list out all transition text and introductions, as well as review question wording in order. For example, if CONTRIB1 is moved up in the survey, we may delete the transition text currently included. For now, we have listed in the table below where we believe section transitions will help improve the flow of the items and can assist with reviewing a full document with all questions before testing commences.

The table below includes placeholders for section introductions that should be specified when the final question order is confirmed. These transitions could be included on the following question itself, and not necessarily a new survey page. These transitions should help the flow of the survey and improve respondent experiences. Two of the questions about housing, MORT_YN and NUMROOM, do not fit well with the other topics in this section. We are unsure what introductory questions are included in the administration of ASEC. If other housing questions are asked, such as confirmation of the respondent's address, then these questions should be placed with related questions about housing. As detailed in the findings about these questions, they currently do not have enough context and could benefit from reordering with relevant housing questions. If there are no other housing questions included in ASEC, then we recommend adding a section introduction before and after these two questions to provide a better transition.

Questions that are starred in this table (*) are those that did not exist in the first round of cognitive testing. Questions with strike through are items that we recommend removing from the instrument, see **Section 5** and **Section 6** for question-specific findings supporting these deletions.

Proposed Re-Order	Original Order	Q Name	Topic	Description
0		Intro*		Introduction to the survey with instructions
1	1	Resname		R name
2	2	live_1 - live_8		R address
3	3	Tenure		Living quarters
4	4	popcount	Household Roster	Household size
5	5	name roster	Household Roster	HH names
6	6	age	Household Roster	HH age
7	7	sex	Household Roster	HH sex
8	8	Q29a	Employment	Did you work - y/n
9	9	Q29b	Employment	Temp, part-time, seasonal work - y/n
10	10	Q30	Employment	Looking for job or layoff - y/n
11	11	Q31	Employment	How long looking for work/layoff - num of weeks
12	12	Q32	Employment	Main reason for not working
13	13	Q33	Employment	How many weeks worked
14	14	Q35	Employment	Worked less b/c layoff or lost job - y/n
15	15	Q36	Employment	How many weeks layoff/looking for work
16	16	Q37	Employment	How long looking for work - num of weeks
17	17	Q38	Employment	Main reason not looking for work
18	18	Q39	Employment	How many employers
19	19	Q41	Employment	Hours worked per week
20	20	Q43	Employment	Worked less than 35hrs - y/n
21	21	Q44	Employment	How many weeks less than 35hrs
22	22	Q45	Employment	Reason worked less than 35hrs
23	23	Q45a	Employment	Why unable to work full time
24	24	Q47a	Employment	Employer name
25	33	Q47c	Employment	Type of work/main occupation - OE
26	34	Q47d1	Employment	Important activities/duties

Proposed Re-Order	Original Order	Q Name	Topic	Description
	25	Q47e1	Employment	Employer description – condensed
	26	Q47e1a	Employment	Gov't employer type
	27	Q47e1b	Employment	Employer incorporated – y/n
	28	Q47e1c	Employment	Owner of employer – y/n
27	29	Q47e1_combined	Employment	Employer description - combined
28	30	Q4788	Employment	Number of employees
29	31	Q47b	Employment	Industry of employer - OE
30	32	Q47b1	Employment	Manufacturing/retail/wholesale
31	80	Q74a	Income Sources - Employer's Pension	Employer offer pension plan - y/n
32	81	Q74a2	Income Sources - Employer's Pension	Eligible for pension plan - y/n
33	82	Q74b	Income Sources - Employer's Pension	Participate in pension plan - y/n
HEALTH INSURANCE QUESTIONS (MOOP AND ROYA) – no order changes				
34		Section intro*		Transition to sources and amounts of income
35	35	Q48a_source	Earned Income	Type of income
36	37	Q48_per	Earned Income	Income amount - alternate periodicity
37	38	Q48b_amount	Earned Income	Self employed income
38	73	Q62Ar	Income Sources - Pension	Types of income
39	74	Q62b	Income Sources - Pension	Who received pension
40	39	Q51A1	Income Sources - Unemployment	Unemployment benefits
41	40	Q51A1b	Income Sources - Unemployment	Who received unemployment
42	41	Q52A	Income Sources - Worker's comp	Worker's comp
43	42	Q52Ab	Income Sources - Worker's comp	Who received worker's comp
44	77	Q97Ar	Income Sources - Retirement	Type of retirement account
45	78	Q97Br	Income Sources - Retirement	Who had retirement account
46	79	Q98Ar	Income Sources - Retirement	Withdraw from retirement account - y/n
47		Section intro*		
48	43	Q56a	Income Sources - Social security	Social security - y/n
49	44	Q56b	Income Sources - Social security	Who received social security
50	45	SSR	Income Sources - Social security	Reason of social security

Proposed Re-Order	Original Order	Q Name	Topic	Description
51	46	SSCR	Income Sources - Social security	Reason child getting social security
52	47	Q56g	Income Sources - Social security	Who received SS on behalf child
53	49	Q56f	Income Sources - Social security	Social security on behalf of child - y/n (not already counted)
54	50	CSS	Income Sources - Social security	Which child received social security
55	52	CRSS	Income Sources - Social security	Reason child getting social security
56	51	Q56g2	Income Sources - Social security	Who received SS on behalf of child
57	53	Q57a	Income Sources - SSI	Supplemental security income (SSI) - y/n
58	54	Q57b	Income Sources - SSI	Who received SSI
59	55	SSIR	Income Sources - SSI	Reason receiving SSI
60	56	Q57d	Income Sources - SSI	SSI on behalf of child - y/n (not already counted)
61	59	CSSI	Income Sources - SSI	Which child received SSI
62	57	Q57e	Income Sources - SSI	Who received SSI on behalf of child
63	58	RSSI	Income Sources - SSI	Reason receiving SSI on behalf of child
64	60	Q59AR	Income Sources - Disability	Disability - y/n
65	61	Q59b	Income Sources - Disability	Who had disability
66	62	Q60a	Income Sources - Disability	Retired/left job for health reason - y/n
67	63	Q60b	Income Sources - Disability	Who retired/left job in 2023
68	64	Q61c	Income Sources - Disability	Sources of disability income
69		Section intro*		
70	95	Q72a	Income Sources - Regular Financial Assistance	Assistance from friends/family - y/n
71	96	Q72b	Income Sources - Regular Financial Assistance	Who received assistance from friends/family
72		Section intro*		
73	70	Q59A88	Income Sources - Public Assistance	Types of cash assistance
74	71	Q59A89	Income Sources - Public Assistance	Types of cash assistance received on behalf of child
75	72	Q59b_88	Income Sources - Public Assistance	Who received cash assistance
76		Section intro*		

Proposed Re-Order	Original Order	Q Name	Topic	Description
77	83	Q99Ar	Income Sources - Income Earning Accounts	Types of assets
78	84	Q99Ba	Income Sources - Income Earning Accounts	Who had assets
79	85	Q99Arf	Income Sources - Income Earning Accounts	Types of assets that pay dividends
80	86	Q99Bf	Income Sources - Income Earning Accounts	Who had dividends account
81	87	CAPGDIS	Income Sources - Income Earning Accounts	Received capital gains - y/n
82	75	Q96Ar	Income Sources - Annuity	Received income from annuity - y/n
83	76	Q96Br	Income Sources - Annuity	Who received annuity
84		Section intro*		Intro to other types of income with language such as “less common forms of income”, reiterate request to not double report.
85	65	Q60A88	Income Sources - Veterans	Source of VA payments
86	66	Q60b_88	Income Sources - Veterans	Who received VA payments
87	67	Q60D88	Income Sources - Veterans	Annual income VA questionnaire - y/n
88	68	Q58a	Income Sources - Survivor Benefits	Types of survivor benefits
89	69	Q58b	Income Sources - Survivor Benefits	Who received survivor benefits
90	90	Q66a	Income Sources – Education Assistance	Attend school beyond HS - y/n
91	91	NQ66bd	Income Sources – Education Assistance	Types of educational assistance
92	92	Q66c	Income Sources – Education Assistance	Who received educational assistance
93	93	Q70a	Income Sources - Child Support	Received child support payments - y/n
94	94	Q70b	Income Sources - Child Support	Who received child support
95	88	Q65A2	Income Sources - Property	Types of property income
96	89	Q65b	Income Sources - Property	Who received property income
97	97	Q73A1R	Income Sources - Other Money Income	Type of other income received

Proposed Re-Order	Original Order	Q Name	Topic	Description
98	98	Q73A1b	Income Sources - Other Money Income	Who received other income
99		Section intro*		
100	123	Q62E1_alt	Income Amounts - Pensions	Alt way to report pension income
101	100	Q59_alt	Income Amounts - Unemployment	Alt way to report unemployment
102	101	Q52amt	Income Amounts - Worker's comp	Amount from worker's comp
103	134	CONTRIB1	Income Amounts - Retirement	Contributed to retirement account- y/n
104	135	CONTRIB2	Income Amounts - Retirement	Percent of earnings vs. Annual dollar amount
105	136	CONTRIB3a	Income Amounts - Retirement	Percent of earning contributed
106	137	CONTRIB3b	Income Amounts - Retirement	Annual amount contributed
107	126	DISTNEW_alt	Income Amounts - Retirement	Alt way to report retirement withdrawals
108	127	ROLLA	Income Amounts - Retirement	Re-invest/roll over money - y/n
109	128	ROLLAMTA	Income Amounts - Retirement	Amount rolled over
110	129	ROLLB	Income Amounts - Retirement	Plan to reinvest/roll over money - y/n
111	130	ROLLAMTB	Income Amounts - Retirement	How much plan to roll over
	132	RETIRENEW_alt	Income Amounts - retirement	Alt way to report interest/dividend retirement income
112	133	RETIRENEW2	Income Amounts - Retirement	Census can estimate interest earned on retirement account
113		Section intro*		
114	103	Q56amt_alt	Income Amounts - Social security	Alt way to report social security
115	111	Q56i_alt	Income Amounts - Social security	Alt way to report social security on behalf of a child
116	105	Q562_alt	Income Amounts - Social security	Alt way to report social security disability
117	106	Q562d3	Income Amounts - Social security	Before or after Medicare deductions
118	107	Q562md	Income Amounts - Social security	How much Medicare deductions
119	108	Q558	Income Amounts - Social security	Initial disability larger than usual payment - y/n
120	109	Q559	Income Amounts - Social security	How much initial disability payment
121	113	Q57c_alt	Income Amounts - SSI	Alt way to report SSI
122	113	Q57c_ALT	Income Amounts - SSI	Amount SSI received monthly
123	114	Q57i	Income Amounts - SSI	Amount SSI for child - annual

Proposed Re-Order	Original Order	Q Name	Topic	Description
124	116	Q61e_alt	Income Amounts - Disability	Alt way to report disability income
125		Section intro*		
126	147	Q72cp	Income Amounts - Regular Financial Assistance	Regular financial assistance amount - annual
127		Section intro*		
128	121	Q59e_alt	Income Amounts - Public Assistance	Alt way to report public assistance income
129		Section intro*		
	139	Q63cp_alt	Income Amounts - income earning accounts	Alt way to report interests/dividends (non retirement)
130	140	NONRETIRENEW12	Income Amounts - Income Earning Accounts	Census can estimate interest earned in non-retirement
131	124	ANNNEW1	Income Amounts- Annuity	Annuity income - annual
132		Section intro*		Intro to other types of income with language such as “less common forms of income”, reiterate request to not double report.
133	118	Q60V_alt	Income Amounts - Veterans	Alt way to report VA income
134	119	Q58E1	Income Amounts - Survivor Benefits	Amount survivor benefits - annual
135	145	NQ669G	Income Amounts - Education Assistance	Alt way to report education assistance
136	146	Q70cp	Income Amounts - Child Support	Child support amount - annual
137	141	Q65c	Income Amounts - Property	Amount from rental income - annual
138	143	Q65d_alt	Income Amounts - Property	Alt way to report property income
139	148	Q731P	Income Amounts - Other Money	Other money income amount - annual
140		Section intro*		
141	149	MORT_YN	Housing	Loans on property
142	150	NUMROOM	Housing	Num of bedrooms
143		Section intro*		
144	151	SNAP_YN	Food Assistance	Received snap - y/n
145	152	SNAP_ROST	Food Assistance	Who received SNAP
146	153	SNAP_AMT	Food Assistance	Value of SNAP - annual for entire HH

Proposed Re-Order	Original Order	Q Name	Topic	Description
147	154	SNAP_FREQ	Food Assistance	How many monthly SNAP payments received
148	155	SNAP_CHK	Food Assistance	SNAP amount correct - y/n
149	156	SNAP_RNG	Food Assistance	Estimated value of SNAP
150	157	SNAP_RNG2	Food Assistance	Estimated value of SNAP
151	162	NCREC	Non-Cash Benefits	Types of non-cash benefits received
152	163	WIC_ROST	Non-Cash Benefits	Who received WIC'
153	164	WIC_MNTH	Non-Cash Benefits	How many months received WIC
154	165	ENG_ASST	Non-Cash Benefits	Annual energy assistance amount
155	166	ENG_RNG	Non-Cash Benefits	Energy assistance estimate
156	167	ENG_RNG2	Non-Cash Benefits	Energy assistance estimate
157		Section intro*		
158	168	CHCARE_PAID	Child care	Type of paid child care used
159	169	CHCARE_UNPAID	Child care	Type of unpaid child care used
160	170	CHCARE_MAIN	Child care	Main type of child care used
161	171	CHCARE_AMT	Child care	Amount spent on child care
162	172	CHCARE_SUB	Child care	Child care covered by voucher/subsidy - y/n
163	173	CHCARE_PROB	Child care	Problems finding child care - y/n
164	174	CHCARE_PROBTIME	Child care	Time not able to work b/c didn't have child care
165	175	CHCARE_ADAPT	Child care	Actions taken when couldn't find child care
166	176	AWAY_KIDS	Child Support	Any kids living elsewhere - y/n
167	177	CHSUP_ROST	Child Support	Pay child support - y/n
168	178	CHSUP_AMT	Child Support	Child support amount paid - annual
169	158	SMEAL_YN	School Meals	Eat school lunch - y/n
170	159	SMEAL_ROST	School Meals	Which meals school-provided
171	160	SUBMEAL_YN	School Meals	Free/reduced lunch - y/n
172	161	SUBMEAL_ROST	School Meals	Which meals free/reduced
	99	Q59amt	Income Amounts – unemployment	Amount unemployment received monthly
	125	DISTNEW	Income Amounts – retirement	Amount withdrawn from retirement account – annual
	131	RETIRENEW1	Income Amounts – retirement	Amount from interests/dividends from retirement – annual

Proposed Re-Order	Original Order	Q Name	Topic	Description
	138	Q63ep	Income Amounts—income earning accounts	Amount from interests/dividends (non-retirement)
	117	Q60V	Income Amounts—Veteran's	Amount of VA income—monthly
	142	Q65d	Income Amounts—property	Amount from property income—annual
	144	NQ669D	Income Amounts—education assistance	Amount education assistance—monthly
	102	Q56amt	Income Amounts—social security	Amount from social security monthly
	104	Q562	Income Amounts—social security	Amount from social security disability
	110	Q56i	Income Amounts—social security	Amount social security on behalf of a child
	115	Q61e	Income Amounts—disability	Amount of disability income monthly
	120	Q59e	Income Amounts—public assistance	Amount public assistance—monthly
	122	Q62E1	Income Amounts—pensions	Amount pensions—monthly
*These items are new and did not exist in the instrument tested in round one of cognitive interviews. These transition statements could be added to the beginning of a survey question and not a stand alone screen.				